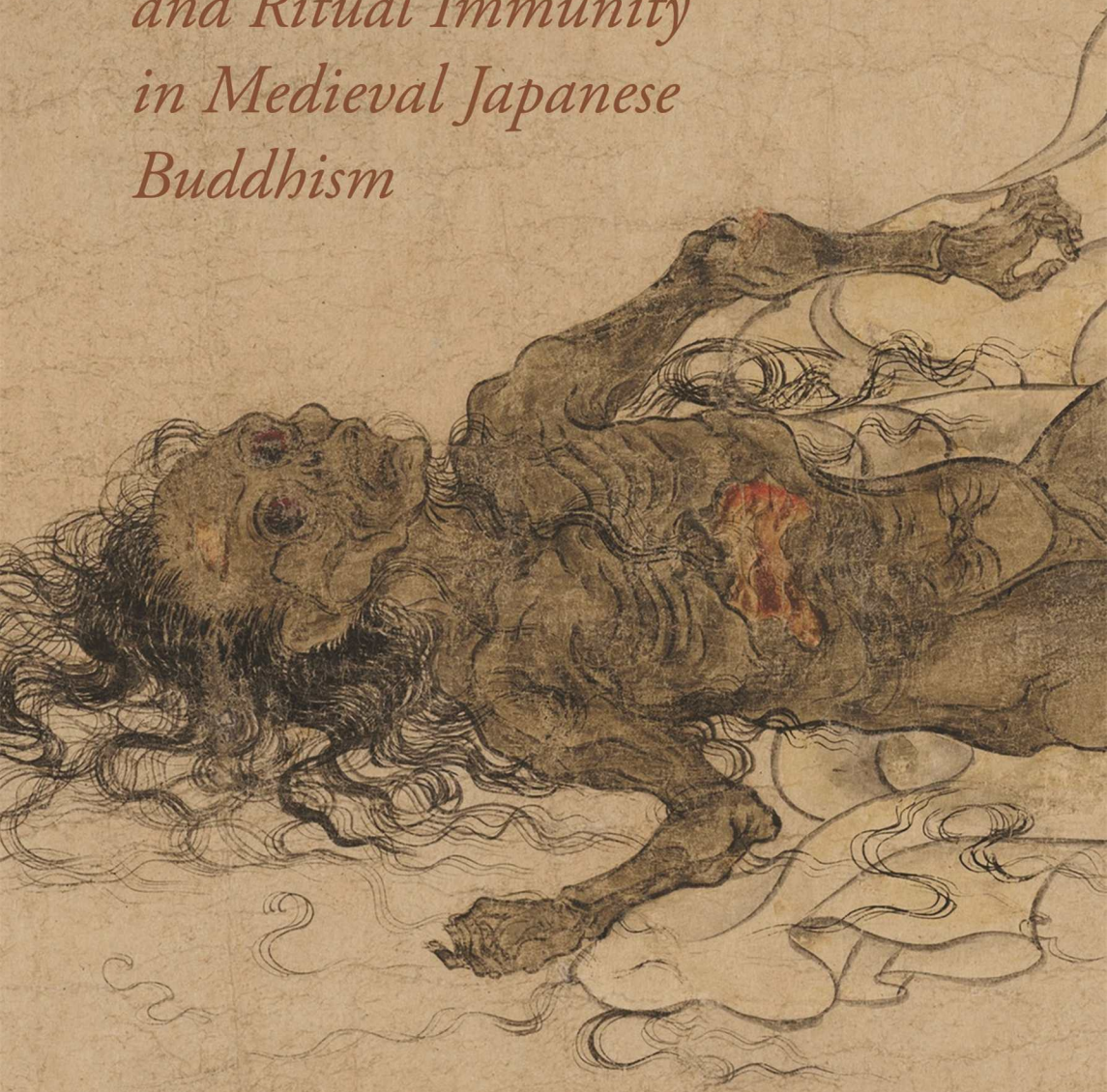


# CADAVEROUS

*Postmortem Contagion  
and Ritual Immunity  
in Medieval Japanese  
Buddhism*



ANDREW MACOMBER



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POSTMORTEM CONTAGION AND RITUAL IMMUNITY  
IN MEDIEVAL JAPANESE BUDDHISM

Andrew Macomber



University of Hawai'i Press

HONOLULU

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This book is dedicated to the memory of my teacher,  
Peter N. Gregory (1945–2025).

羯諦羯諦  
波羅羯諦  
波羅僧羯諦  
菩提薩婆訶





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## ABBREVIATIONS AND CONVENTIONS



|                        |                                                  |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| DNK                    | <i>Dai Nihon kokiroku</i>                        |
| DNBZ                   | <i>Dai Nihon bukkyō zensho</i>                   |
| <i>Essential Notes</i> | <i>Denshibyō kanjin shō narabini sōbyō chihō</i> |
| KT                     | <i>Shintei zōho kokushi taikai</i>               |
| NKBT                   | <i>Nihon koten bungaku taikai</i>                |
| NST                    | <i>Nihon shisō taikai</i>                        |
| SNKBT                  | <i>Shin Nihon koten bungaku taikai</i>           |
| SNKBZ                  | <i>Shinpen Nihon koten bungaku zenshū</i>        |
| T                      | <i>Taishō shinshū daizōkyō</i>                   |
| TIZS                   | <i>Tōyō igaku zenpon sōsho</i>                   |
| ZGR                    | <i>Zoku gunsho ruijū</i>                         |
| ZST                    | <i>Zōho shiryō taisei</i>                        |

Throughout this book, references to diary entries begin with the year according to Japanese era names, followed by the approximate year in the Western calendar in parentheses, the month and day according to the original source, and then citation information (volume and page number). Citations from the Taishō canon, marked with the abbreviation T, include volume, Taishō number, page, register, and line numbers, in that order. For premodern names, text titles, and terms, traditional characters have been converted to modern simplified characters, according to the current system in Japan. Names are written surname followed by personal name. For transcription of Chinese terms, I follow the pinyin system. Unless otherwise indicated, all translations of original sources and Japanese scholarship are my own.





# Introduction



IN 1175, COURTIER NAKAYAMA NO TADACHIKA 中山忠親 (1131–1195) announced the arrival of a new disease.<sup>1</sup> As Tadachika correctly observed, in the late twelfth century, the aristocracy of Heiankyō (today’s Kyoto) had an outbreak on their hands of a menacing disease with which they were woefully unfamiliar. Had the affliction been caused by resentful spirits of the dead, there would have been no need for Tadachika’s declaration, nor cause for alarm, since diseases caused by spirits were well known among aristocrats, who also knew precisely what to do when such spirits made their appearance. What undoubtedly captured Tadachika’s anxious attention—what made the affliction anomalous—was the unusual manner in which the disease was bound to death. Not only was the illness causing victims to emaciate gradually, leaving them for dead in a ghastly, cadaverous state; most unusual of all was that the disease was *caused* by corpses, hence the name they gave it: “corpse-vector disease” (*denshibyō* 伝屍病).

As Tadachika and his peers struggled to make sense of the new affliction, Buddhist monks at the temple Onjōji 園城寺, just a half-day’s walk over the mountains east of Heiankyō, rummaged through the manuscripts of their library. These monks, who belonged to the Jimon 寺門 lineage of the Tendai 天台 school, pored over all kinds of texts—writings on meditation and healing written by their Chinese forebears, esoteric Buddhist ritual texts, Chinese medical literature, and even a rare scripture attributed to Laozi, the figurehead of Daoism. What energized these monks was an almost feverish impulse for ritual design: They sought to craft a ritual that would eliminate the corpse-driven disease making living corpses of their elite patrons. Synthesizing a wide range of medical knowledge with ritual techniques and therapeutic modalities, Jimon monks finally drafted a pair of liturgical manuscripts. By the early 1170s, the monks had completed what was, at the time, the only comprehensive solution proposed to subjugate the pathogens behind corpse-vector disease. They called it the Ritual of Shōmen Kongō for Expelling Demons and Māras (hereafter, the Ritual for Expelling Demons).

The Ritual for Expelling Demons stood apart from other Buddhist rituals for healing of the early medieval period in its pathological focus and therapeutic design.<sup>2</sup> Until the late twelfth century, much Buddhist ritual healing had been aimed at treating diseases caused by the resentful spirits of deceased members of the aristocracy—the immaterial dead. With the Ritual for Expelling Demons, Jimon monks were setting the target of their ritual healing on a new and different pathological problem: a disease caused by corpses—the material dead.

Until this time, most Buddhist rituals for healing constituted a kind of therapy at a distance, or remote healing. Because monks invoked the miraculous powers of Buddhist deities, unseen agents unburdened by the ordinary constraints of space and time, healing rites could be performed at a distance from the ailing patients and still be expected to have therapeutic effects. In the Ritual for Expelling Demons, however, Jimon monks broke this convention by prescribing, as the rite's primary healing modality, moxibustion (*kyū* 灸), a form of cautery derived from Chinese medicine in which a healer burns the patient's skin directly with dried mugwort. In centering their rite around moxibustion, not only were the monks diverging from the tried-and-true traditions of remote healing—traditions they helped establish—they were also suggesting that the eradication of this novel disease demanded no less than scorching the very flesh of their aristocratic and imperial patients. An approach more aggressive and violent than had ever been the case for Buddhist healing rites in Japan, the decision to incorporate cautery is especially curious given that the rite was ostensibly meant to heal patients rather than harm them.

This book examines the history of the Ritual for Expelling Demons in terms of its curious departures from established forms of Buddhist ritual healing in early medieval Japan. It asks three core questions: Why was it monks of the Jimon lineage, and not another monastic community, who designed this ritual? Why did Jimon monks aim their ritual at a disease caused by corpses, of all things? Why did they deem it necessary to engage the physical body of the patient and to do so in a way that would leave their patients burned and scarred?

Exploring these questions about the origins, conception, and design of a highly innovative and audacious healing ritual illuminates more than the story of a single therapeutic practice. The unusual changes to focus and practice reflected in this ritual speak to broader transformations in early medieval Japan, in both the imagination of disease and the creation of healing rituals. Two main areas of change concern us. The first pertains to the changing ways that notions of disease were shaped by the imagination of death. In early medieval Japan, death was never simply the terminus of disease; it was also imagined to cause it. Why and how did variants of death come to be imagined as pathogenic in early medieval Japan? Throughout, I analyze varied entanglements of death and disease, which I call postmortem contagion. The second main area of concern

pertains to the complex processes through which healing rituals were designed in early medieval Japan. I conceptualize these processes in terms of what I call ritual immunity.

## RITUAL IMMUNITY

The Ritual for Expelling Demons was created at a turning point in the history of disease in premodern Japan. According to William Wayne Farris, if the years 750 to 1050 marked Japan's "age of plagues," the years 1050 to 1260, during which time the Jimon ritual was created, marked a transitional period that saw the "declining importance of disease." During the age of plagues, epidemics—smallpox, measles, mumps, influenza, dysentery—occurred on the archipelago at a frequency of approximately one every 2.9 years in the 700s and one every 3.8 years in the "poorly documented" 900s. After 1050, the number of disease outbreaks dropped to one outbreak every 4.2 years—still staggering by today's standards but a significant decrease nonetheless. Farris attributes this decline to the fact that the killer diseases of the "age of plagues" had become endemic in the Japanese population by this time. Owing to the traumatic onslaught of epidemics in earlier centuries, the archipelago's inhabitants had come to build biological resistance in the form of immunity.<sup>3</sup>

The timing of this decline is ironic, as Farris notes, since 1052 was understood in Japan to be the beginning of the age of the Final Dharma (*mappō* 末法).<sup>4</sup> As described in Chinese Buddhist sutras known in Japan, the Final Dharma, imagined to begin thousands of years after the *parinirvāṇa* of Śākyamuni Buddha, was an apocalyptic epoch during which the world enters a long and protracted decline, eventually leading to extinction, until the appearance of the next buddha.<sup>5</sup> The soteriological consequences of this age are well known. As the Buddha declares in the *Great Compassion Sutra* (*Dabei jing* 大悲經), when the dharma enters the final phase, monks and nuns will break the precepts, people will slander the true teachings, and lives will become shorter, provoking great trepidation and chaos across society.<sup>6</sup> Myriad calamities will befall those who live in this corrupt age, including famines, droughts, floods, pirates, swarms of locusts, and roaming hordes of demons seeking to "destroy the sinners."<sup>7</sup>

In Japan, besides concerns about soteriology, disasters, and demonic forces, the consequences of the Final Dharma were also understood in terms of disease outbreaks. There were good reasons for this, as Mimi Yiengpruksawan has noted. A number of major disease outbreaks occurred between 995 and 1030, making the conditions "ripe for millenarian thinking," and good reason to re-place the date of the beginning of the Final Dharma—which in earlier centuries had been placed in 552—in 1052.<sup>8</sup> Linking disease outbreaks with the Final Dharma was also likely spurred by a dramatic increase in the mid-Heian

period of a bewildering array of afflictions attributed to resentful spirits returning from beyond the grave to exact revenge on their mortal enemies, a topic I consider in detail in chapters 2 and 3.

In Japan, Buddhists thus came to see the Final Age as a terrifying double feature: murderous demons and raging disease. In *Record of Nourishing Life by Drinking Tea* (*Kissa yōjōki* 喫茶養生記), the monk Yōsai 榮西 (1141–1215) made the situation clear enough. Although he was influenced by his experiences in Song China, he wrote *Record of Nourishing Life by Drinking Tea* with the goal of shedding light on the pathological conditions of the Japanese archipelago as he saw them. For Yōsai, the Final Age was defined not only by monastic communities “violating proper deportment,” or by monks, nuns, and laypersons failing to live “in accord with the teachings of the Buddha,” but also by a pandemonium of pestilential proportions: “In these times there will be demons and spirits (*kimi mōryō* 鬼魅魍魎),” he wrote, “who will send the realm into chaos and antagonize the people, creating manifold diseases for which no medical treatment exists, of which medical knowledge proves ignorant, against which medical formulas provide no salvation. There will be no way to save those who suffer long of this exhaustion in the extreme.”<sup>9</sup>

Linking the Final Age to disease against which dreadfully little could be done was not a perception limited to monks, who were direct students of the apocalyptic discourses transmitted to Japan by way of Chinese Buddhist scriptures. Similar articulations of epochal distress are found in the writings of courtiers, the patrons and recipients of Buddhist ritual therapy during this ruinous age. For example, in 1106, when resentful spirits assailed Emperor Horikawa 堀河 (1079–1107) with disease, the exorcisms performed by priests failed one after another, forcing a political shutdown. Diarist Fujiwara no Tadazane 藤原忠実 (1078–1162) lamented that when it comes to such illnesses, “nothing can be done in the Final Age.”<sup>10</sup> Tragically, Tadazane was not wrong, at least in this case. Not long after, Horikawa’s ghost affliction sent him to the grave.

We are left with a curious and apparent contradiction. On one hand, by the early medieval period, the Japanese had enhanced their biological immunity and thus their overall resistance to epidemic diseases. On the other hand, widespread doom and gloom over the Final Dharma suggests that many felt they had just entered an unprecedented age of disease proliferation, an epoch of diseases carried by malicious spirits and demons. Among the takeaways we can glean from this contradiction, one is particularly important for this book: We would be mistaken to assume that the ebbs and flows of biological immunity alone tell the whole story of medical history in early medieval Japan. Biological immunity sheds little light on how disease was imagined in this period. Perceptions and representations of disease were consequential, shaping material practices, personal experiences of illness, and social relationships configured by illness,

morality, and therapy. Biological immunity also tells us little of direct relevance about Buddhist ritual healing, which, as the prevalence of Final Dharma discourse suggests, arguably exerted the most exhaustive and sustained influence on such developments in medical history in this period.

The gap between biological “realities,” on the one hand, and the disease imaginary, on the other, prompts a reconsideration of how we define immunity in any account of disease and therapy in history. Medical history in the West, which has considered immunity largely in terms of the modern biomedical field of immunology, has tended to spotlight Edward Jenner’s (1749–1823) development of smallpox vaccination in the 1790s. As renowned scholar of Chinese medicine Joseph Needham (1900–1995) wrote, “It will be generally allowed that the inoculation for the smallpox was the beginning of all immunology, one of the greatest and most beneficent departments of modern medical science.”<sup>11</sup> Although there is no doubt that immunology as we know it grows more or less directly from Jenner’s innovation and developments in the experimental sciences of Europe in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, this discovery is not the only way to understand immunity and the question of immunity’s “origins.” Needham, for example, offered an alternative origin story for immunology: the development of smallpox variolation in China, an innovation he traced as far back as the Song period (960–1279).

Needham also suggested that any origin of immunology as such must be located in a wider and older range of human attempts to engage and overcome disease. Although smallpox inoculation in China predates and thus anticipates the establishment of immunology as a field of scientific research in the West, the innovation had much earlier roots, born as it was within an “ambiance of Taoist religion, magic and medicine.”<sup>12</sup> As an example, Needham describes a cave-temple near Dunhuang in west China where slips of yellow paper were pasted on the cave walls, each marking the “gate” of a named disease—cholera, chickenpox, whooping cough, smallpox. Needham speculates that children would have been passed through each gate in a ritual of circumambulation. The symbolic exposure would provide a booster to the otherwise vulnerable child, enabling them to overcome the real disease when it inevitably came. In this ritual, Needham proposes, the seeds were sown for the kind of immunitary thinking that eventually made the Daoist innovation of the smallpox inoculation possible. What is important here is not the historical, geographical, or religious specificity of Needham’s convenient example, for countless cases can be found in other times and places. What matters is that even the better known and widely celebrated discoveries of immunology and the smallpox inoculation were emanations of broader and more varied histories of the human imagination of diseases and our complex responses to them, both defensive and therapeutic.

We need not limit our analytical experiments with the insightful concept of immunity to its technical meanings in the biological sciences or to the discovery of a specific medical intervention. The research of many thinkers across numerous disciplines—including Roberto Esposito, Donna Haraway, Jacques Derrida, Peter Sloterdijk, Nik Brown, and Emily Martin—demonstrates that notions of immunity are interwoven into and variably inspire human culture, language, and politics in ways that exceed what the disciplines of the medical sciences have staked out as the purview of immunology.<sup>13</sup> As a field of metaphors, images, and models for capturing, making sense of, and organizing reality, immunity has shaped the human imagination of disease and defilement, somatic and material practices of hygiene and therapy, notions of self and other, and social and moral relations between individuals and communities. Although much of the research conducted by the scholars noted above has focused understandably on the mutations and consequences of immunitary thinking since the formal development of immunology in the nineteenth century, Needham's example of ritual vaccination in a Dunhuang cave-temple alone makes abundantly clear that the immunitary imaginary has operated wherever and whenever humans have found themselves grappling with threats to the integrity of their bodies, minds, and kin, even in the absence of a single theoretical term that might correspond precisely to our "immunity."

One of the most vocal proponents of thinking culture through the lens of immunity has been the German philosopher Peter Sloterdijk. In *You Must Change Your Life*, one of several works in which he brings the notion of immunity to cultural analysis, Sloterdijk builds on the work of Ilya Mechnikov and Paul Ehrlich to define immune systems as "embodied expectations of injury and the corresponding programs of protection and repair." Seen from the perspective of immunity, he writes, "life itself appears as a dynamics of integration that is equipped with auto-therapeutic or 'endo-clinical' competencies and refers to a species-specific space of surprise." For Sloterdijk, "surprise" here names the encounter of an individual organism with threat, irritation, invasion. The immune system, which remains attuned to potential surprises, "has an equally innate and—in higher organisms—adaptively acquired responsibility for the injuries and invasions it regularly encounters in its permanently allocated environment or conquered surroundings."<sup>14</sup> In an enlarged conception of immunity, "environment" need not simply denote a physical space inhabited by biological organisms but may encompass those fields scholars call "contexts," the social, cultural, and historical conditions that shape human activity, including the domains we identify as medicine, ritual, and religion.

Sloterdijk argues that in addition to the biological immune system, humans have at least two other complementary systems of immunity, which "developed for the pre-emptive processing of injuries": the social and the symbolic. Of the

first, which he calls socio-immunological methods, he includes “especially legal and solidaristic ones, but also the military ones by which people resolve their confrontations with distant and foreign aggressors and insulting or harmful neighbours.” The second refers to “the symbolic or psycho-immunological practices on which humans have always relied to cope—with varying successes—with their vulnerability through fate, including mortality, in the form of imaginary anticipations and mental armour.” The second, symbolic type of immunity gives rise to what Sloterdijk calls anthropotechnics, those “methods of mental and physical practising by which humans from the most diverse cultures have attempted to optimize their cosmic and immunological status in the face of vague risks of living and acute uncertainties of death.”<sup>15</sup>

Sloterdijk encourages us to view immunity not in the restricted sense of biological operations but as a wide array of schemes and strategies for imagining and engaging with threatening agents in an uncertain world. His expanded view of immunity enables us, I believe, to better understand the imagination of surprising encounters with disease and the measures conceived and launched to reduce the perceived harms of such encounters in early medieval Japan. After all, many felt at certain times that they were prevailing therapeutically over the threats that populated the apocalyptic time and place they inhabited—even without what biomedicine would today recognize narrowly as efficacious forms of inoculation or treatment. More than anything, it was the ritual performed by Buddhist monks that most consistently gave them that sense of therapeutic success.

For example, courtiers often couched their celebration of the efficacy of Buddhist ritual therapies within the socio-symbolic framework of the Final Dharma. In 1098, after the high abbot of the Tendai school, Ninkaku 仁覚 (1045–1102), performed an exorcism ritual for Princess Tokushi 篤子内親王 (1060–1114), then suffering from an illness caused by an evil spirit, Fujiwara no Munetada 藤原宗忠 (1062–1141) noted, “Although we are in the Final Age, the miraculous efficacy of the Buddha Dharma has here been made manifest!”<sup>16</sup> Munetada made a similar comment in 1095 after the young Princess Teishi 媞子内親王 (Ikuhōmon’in 郁芳門院, 1076–1096) rallied after ritual treatment at the temple Hosshōji 法勝寺: “Last year when the Retired Emperor [Shirakawa 白河天皇, 1053–1129] was suffering from malarial fever he was cured in this hall; now the Imperial Lady has had her evil *qi* cured there as well. Before and now, such miraculous efficacy has manifested. Although it is indeed the age of the Final Dharma, the sun of the Buddha has returned!”<sup>17</sup>

I adopt Sloterdijk’s expanded notion of immunity to think through the evolutions and mutations of Buddhist ritual healing in early medieval Japan. Building on Sloterdijk’s identification of the social and symbolic immune systems besides the biological, I study Buddhist ritual healing from the perspective

of a fourth type, what I call “ritual immunity.” Ritual immunity refers to the creative, experimental, and above all messy processes by which healing rituals come into being. I draw attention to how healing rituals were conceived, designed, and performed as epistemological and practical responses to the emergence of new diseases and the pathogenic agents imagined to cause them. From the lens of ritual immunity I ask: How did monks in early medieval Japan craft and use ritual techniques, technologies, and knowledge to protect their patrons from pathogenic threats and treat their diseases?

Whereas Sloterdijk analytically distinguishes between social and symbolic immune systems, I see these two fields of expanded immunity as closely intertwined in the epistemological and performative dimensions of ritual immunity in early medieval Japan. As I show, Buddhist ritual healing often functioned as the interface between the social and the symbolic. For example, the performative manipulation and interpretation of symbols, signs, and somatic states, by which exorcisms such as those noted already made possible the interpretation of therapeutic success (efficacy as the “return” of the “Buddha’s sun”), were inextricably tied to and set against the shared feeling of collective distress and moral corruption articulated in the idea of the Final Age.

It was also, of course, through healing rituals that Buddhist monks forged close alliances with, and earned the patronage of, courtiers and emperors, the patients they addressed in symbolic and performative ways in their healing rites. I view social alliances facilitated by ritual healing as “immunitary relations,” a term I borrow from Nik Brown. In medieval Japan, courtiers and emperors outsourced their biological, psychological, and moral care to (that is, put their literal lives in the hands of) Buddhist monks, who worked vigorously to safeguard those lives through ritual design and performance. This also meant that the success of the monks and their monastic communities depended on their relations with patrons. Because this was as much a matter of safety for Buddhist communities, rather than simply cultural capital abstractly defined, the immunitary significance of these relations went both ways.

The notion of ritual immunity, I argue, is especially illuminating for thinking about ritual healing in early medieval Japan. Traditional medical historiography on this period has left a yawning gap between the completion of the *Ishinpō* 医心方 by Tanba no Yasuyori 丹波康頼 (912–995) in 984 and the compilation of the *Notes of a Simple Physician* (*Ton’ishō* 頓医抄) and *Myriad Relief Prescriptions* (*Man’anpō* 万安方) by Kajiwarā Shōzen 梶原性全 (1265–1337) in the early fourteenth century, with little research focused on medical history in the years between 1000 and 1300. This is problematic not just because it suggests the most important datum in medical history is the compilation of extensive medical treatises. It also regrettably conveys the mistaken impression that 1000–1300 marked a quiet period for the immunitary imagination. Nothing could be



further from the truth. This period marked the height of anxieties about the Final Dharma, which was perceived in terms of its unprecedented pestilential density; it was also a heyday for the creation of Buddhist rituals against disease. In other words, the period that marks the beginning of the “decline of disease” in Japan in fact marks an explosion of immunitary activity and innovation in the field of ritual healing. The Ritual for Expelling Demons constitutes one remarkable product of these developments in the late twelfth century and offers an illuminating case of the dynamics of ritual immunity in early medieval Japan.

## EXPERIMENTS IN EFFICACY

As a branch lineage of the Tendai school, Jimon monks crafted their rituals largely by building on the corpus of ritual scriptures associated with what scholars call esoteric Buddhism or tantric Buddhism (*mikkyō* 密教). Esoteric Buddhism is difficult to define, but it can be understood as a complex religious and ritual culture that grew out of protracted interactions between Mahāyāna Buddhism and the diverse religious system of medieval South and Central Asia that scholars have broadly referred to as “tantra.” Rather than a discrete collection of doctrines or beliefs, tantra is best seen, to borrow the words of Robert Sharf, as “a body of technological expertise comprised of certain powerful tools—mantras, *mudrās*, icons, altars, esoteric implements including ceremonial weapons, and so on—and the arcane procedural knowledge necessary to wield them.”<sup>18</sup> This body of ritual expertise was incorporated into Mahāyāna Buddhism, which to some extent included similar practices, such as the worship of Buddhist deities, *dhāraṇī*, and demonology. Once integrated into Mahāyāna Buddhism, tantric ritual techniques, technologies, and objects could be used to invoke and interact with the buddhas, bodhisattvas, and a host of other deities and demons the “Great Vehicle” had co-opted at different stages of its evolution. The use of tantric techniques to invoke these deities, esoteric Buddhist scriptures claimed, give initiated monks access to magical powers, supernormal capabilities, and competencies that could be channeled and directed toward realizing soteriological and this-worldly goals.

The resulting synthesis, tied together with such incredible claims of ritual efficacy, was transmitted via Central Asia to Tang China in the form of written scripts for ritual performances that were translated into Chinese in great numbers. Soon after, monks crafted “apocryphal” esoteric scriptures—or in Michel Strickmann’s words, “original Chinese Buddhist scriptures”—to better tailor the once-foreign ritual system to serve the concerns of its new Chinese audience.<sup>19</sup> Emperors, aristocrats, generals, and other elites sought to take advantage of the wide-ranging potencies and transformative potentials promised by the foreign scriptures. The same pattern of adoption was repeated not long after

by sovereigns and powerful families in Japan, when the esoteric Buddhist corpus was transmitted to the archipelago in the Nara (710–784) and early Heian periods.

What drew many to the esoteric corpus, monk and sovereign alike, were the astonishing claims the scriptures made about the immunitary potential of esoteric rites, that is, their therapeutic efficacy.<sup>20</sup> When esoteric scriptures mention specific diseases for which the ritual is addressed, these lists often continue on and on, as Ryūichi Abé notes of a typical example, “as if to include every imaginable illness.”<sup>21</sup> As the Buddha remarks to Ānanda in one such sutra, “this *dhāraṇī*, if chanted, can eliminate indigestion, diarrhea, *vāta*, *pitta*, and *śleṣman*, sores, fistulae, urinary ailments, respiratory ailments, cough, oppressive cold or heat, headache, and backache. Possession by ghosts and demons all will be cured.” Lest any reader take this list to be insufficiently comprehensive, the Buddha ends by declaring, “I, with my Buddha-eye, can see all the obstacles facing other people, gods, demons, Brahmas, renunciates, and Brahmins.” In other words, the prescribed *dhāraṇī*, guided and empowered by the omniscient eye of the Buddha, can do vastly more than the human authors of these scriptures had the time, energy, or imagination to enumerate.<sup>22</sup>

In early medieval Japan, monks of esoteric Buddhist lineages could not simply rest their laurels on such claims of direct ritual access to universal, nonspecific therapeutic efficacy. Patronage of such rites and the monks who performed them by laypersons was not automatic. Esoteric Buddhist monks had to become active participants in what Alan Strathern has called “an economy of ritual efficacy.”<sup>23</sup> In his analysis of Christianity and certain forms of Buddhism, Strathern asserts that even religions with a decidedly transcendentalist orientation must gain traction in culture and society through immanent ways, on the ground. In early medieval Japan, it was not enough for esoteric monks to merely claim access to limitless therapeutic powers. Much energy had to be spent to convince patrons and earn their trust, primarily by demonstrating that rites did what monks claimed, that they indeed had efficacy and were appropriately suited to the therapeutic task at hand. Monks thus had a difficult task on their hands: the project of translating the transcendent, universal efficacy of miraculous deities into concrete therapeutic benefits for their patients in convincing and compelling ways. Ritual was the obvious medium for this translation from claim to concrete demonstration, but as we might imagine, this task did not always go so well—and that matters because the monks of any esoteric lineage were not the only ones promoting their healing services to courtiers and emperors in early medieval Japan.

The religiomedical marketplace of early medieval Japan was a crowded space, featuring numerous types of healers of sometimes overlapping but mostly distinct epistemological and technical systems.<sup>24</sup> One type was the yin-yang

master (*onmyōji* 陰陽師). As specialists of traditions of divination and the manipulation of cosmic forces based on knowledge from the continent, yin-yang masters performed divination on aristocratic and imperial patients to diagnose disease and the intervention of the gods and other unseen forces and agencies. They also offered forms of purification that sometimes functioned therapeutically.<sup>25</sup> Another active healer on the scene was the court physician (*kusushi/ishi* 医師, *ike* 医家). Operating largely from the corpus of Chinese medical literature, court physicians were divided primarily into two lineages in the Heian period: the Wake 和気 and Tanba 丹波 families. Physicians performed all the major functions as healers: They diagnosed illness and treated patients with medicines (herbal, aromatic, and sometimes animal), moxibustion, needling, hot water therapy, and more.

I would be remiss not to mention in this economy of ritual efficacy patients themselves, some of whom eagerly consumed medical knowledge and engaged in autotherapeutic activities. In fact, in the diaries of courtiers we find the most extensive form of autopathography that existed in medieval Japan. By enhancing their immunity through informed endeavors of self-care, such patients rendered themselves less reliant on the services of yin-yang masters, physicians, and Buddhist healers. Although I use the term “patient” throughout this book as a shorthand, we must not forget that they were active agents in their therapy and shaped the dynamics of the ritual healing they received from others. Indeed, as I discuss shortly, it was often the judgments and decisions made by patients that most immediately affected the healing and therapeutic activities of the specialists they employed, specialists who were no doubt hoping to be compensated and summoned again in the future.

The greatest competition in this economy for esoteric monks of any lineage were those of rival monastic lineages. Jimon monks, the authors of the Ritual for Expelling Demons, found themselves in frequent competition with monks of Shingon 真言 lineages, who were based at the temples Tōji 東寺 and Nin-naji 仁和寺, both of which were in Heiankyō and its environs. The main rival of Jimon monks was also their perennial political nemesis, the Sanmon 山門 branch of the Tendai school, which was based at the temple Enryakuji 延暦寺 on Mt. Hiei 比叡山. In addition, over the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, other types of Buddhist healers began appearing around the sickbeds of patients, summoned by courtiers, warriors, and emperors alike. Foremost among these were the *hijiri* 聖, a loosely defined category of monks who were often ambulatory and reclusive and operated outside monastic institutions.<sup>26</sup>

In this milieu of fervent competition between Buddhist healers, a distinct advantage was secured not only by the circulation of secret ritual transmissions but also by access to Chinese medical literature. Although the Chinese medical corpus formed the basis of medical practice conducted by court physician

lineages, they could not claim a monopoly on that knowledge, for medical texts were often transmitted to and preserved in Buddhist temples.<sup>27</sup> A case in point is Ninnaji, an imperially sponsored temple that became home to generations of dharma princes (*hosshin'ō* 法親王), many of whom, like Kakushō Hoss-hinō 覺性法親王 (1129–1169), performed healing rites. Such connections to the court afforded Ninnaji manuscripts of the *Huangdi neijing Taisu* 黃帝內經太素 and *Mingtang* 明堂, and at least five fascicles of the *Ishinpō*, which Tanba no Yasuyori compiled by collecting and editing passages almost entirely from Chinese medical texts.<sup>28</sup> As I discuss in chapter 4, another fascicle of the *Ishinpō*, preserved at the temple Kongōji 金剛寺, may have been available to Jimon monks. In any case they possessed some edition of the primary model and source for the *Ishinpō*, the Tang-period *Arcane Essentials from the Imperial Library* (*Waitai miyao fang* 外台秘要方), on which they drew in writing about corpse-vector disease. In some cases, it is evident that monks acquired medical documents and knowledge directly while abroad in China, a privilege that does not seem to have been shared by court physicians in any substantial way. The Tendai monk Yōsai, for example, was able to make use of the *Taiping yulan* 太平御覽 and the late eleventh-century *Zhenglei bencao* 証類本草 when compiling *Record of Nourishing Life by Drinking Tea*, two works he likely acquired in China.<sup>29</sup> Likewise, the Jimon monk Jōjin 成尋 (1011–1081) sent from across the sea numerous works of medical import to Onjōji's Tōin library.

Because the economy of ritual efficacy in early medieval Japan was a competitive field—at any time a patron could replace one healer with another—it was essential for healers to establish and demonstrate their relevance and efficacy, and to do so continually. We must not forget that rituals are not immune to failure, as much scholarship has recently shown.<sup>30</sup> I develop a slightly different emphasis on this issue. To paraphrase a quote often attributed to Buckminster Fuller: “There are no failures in ritual healing, only experiments.” In early medieval Japan, competition between healers, shifting political relations and alliances, the possibility of failure but also of (perceived) success, and the exceedingly high stakes of grappling with disease and demons during the age of the Final Dharma all conspired to spur energetic experimentation in the field of ritual. If the vast number of liturgical manuscripts that have and continue to be discovered in libraries and temples like Kanazawa Bunko 金沢文庫, Shinpukuji 真福寺, Eizan Bunko 叡山文庫, and Onjōji tells us anything at all, they reveal that monks spent countless hours of their day-to-day lives as ritual designers, tweekers, and transcribers, that the monastic lineages to which they belonged were no less than ritual laboratories. When they were not poring over prescriptive ritual texts or creating new rituals, they were making house calls to ailing patients or conducting a rite in-house, performing therapeutic experiments that sometimes succeeded and sometimes failed. Depending on the results, they were

called back or replaced with another specialist. To reiterate: Esoteric monks did not merely hang their hat on some notion of the universal efficacy of their rites, despite what authoritative scriptures might encourage us to believe. Rather, they continually researched, designed, and ran ritual experiments aimed at achieving real and tangible results for their patients.

I agree with David Harley that it is unproductive to reduce the study of medicine to an analysis of social or political interests alone, for that tells us little about how the cognitive content of a given healing practice was linked to its perceived success, failure, and later adoption or alteration. We stand to learn much more when we admit that practices involving the body, including many rituals, must prove persuasive.<sup>31</sup> Indeed, experiments with ritual healing in early medieval Japan were often clearly motivated by a desire to make the ritual convincing to patrons and patients. One strategy monks adopted was to align their rituals in design, content, and symbol with mental models held by their patients about disease, the body, healing, and efficacy. This strategy was critical in the therapeutic milieu of early medieval Japan, when, as noted, many patients consumed and produced medical knowledge and engaged in self-diagnosis and self-therapy. Patients cared immensely about how the ritual they sponsored would turn out, which makes good sense, given that their lives depended on it, and so did the health of their family and the longer success of their lineage. Learned and shrewd, patients routinely scrutinized their healer, the methods they used, the therapeutic process, and the results. The results of any particular performance of ritual healing were always open to interpretation, manipulation, and counterclaims. Thus, aiming to guide the interpretations brought to therapy in directions that would prove favorable, esoteric monks did not simply force on their patients prepackaged claims culled from esoteric scriptures about universal efficacy; instead, they strategically designed the elements of their healing rituals to attune more precisely to the lifeworlds of their patients. To understand how and why esoteric monks designed healing rites in particular ways, it is necessary to consider how their patients understood matters of body, disease, pathogens, therapy, and efficacy.

Esoteric monks did not lean totally into the worldviews of their patients when designing their ritual programs. Because these monks were students and specialists of esoteric liturgical literature, Mahāyāna Buddhist scriptures, writings of Chinese Buddhist masters, and Chinese medicine, they had their own, arguably more sophisticated concepts of the dynamics at play in diagnosis and treatment. As I demonstrate in my analysis of the Ritual for Expelling Demons, monks sought equally to convince themselves of the validity of their healing programs—by making those programs more valid, consistent, and coherent. We have little reason not to assume that, to the extent possible, monks made sincere efforts to create healing programs that made sense in their own mental

frameworks. The extensive research they conducted on these matters is sufficient evidence for this fact. Their positions at temples, which were located at some remove from the court, allowed them to perform research without being excessively influenced by the dynamics of court life. At their temples, monks availed themselves of libraries stocked with manuscripts from the liturgical and medical canons. What they did not have on hand could sometimes be acquired by making a request to a branch temple in the lineage, through a relationship with an aristocrat (who had their own libraries), or, in rare cases, a pilgrimage to China. Throughout this book, I stress that monks were motivated not just by their “interest” in earning the patronage of their patients. As ritual healers, monks were also scholars and ritual practitioners wrestling with thorny pathological puzzles. There can be little doubt that they were concerned for the well-being of their patients (in many cases, members of their own family) and for themselves (monks were not automatically immune to the diseases that afflicted their patients).

Ritual healing had to be more than cognitively convincing to its creators and recipients; it also had to be compelling in affective, aesthetic, and embodied ways. Above all, ritual efficacy was about demonstration: The effects of ritual on body and health had to be made manifest. This dynamic is always at play in rituals whose results matter, for two reasons. First, therapeutic rituals aim to do no less than heal. Second, ritual effects are typically unseen during and immediately after the performance. Rituals with demonstrative efficacy—which could somehow demonstrate that they were working quickly and in a tangible and ideally felt sense—had a clear advantage in the economy of ritual efficacy. The legibility of efficacy in turn reflected the perception of the healer’s therapeutic prowess, which in turn encouraged greater trust in the healer, more compensation, and more invitations to the sickbeds of elite patients.

The importance of legibility to the medieval Japanese notion of ritual efficacy is on full display in the premodern Japanese term we can translate as “efficacy,” both ritual and therapeutic: *gen* 驗. *Gen* was the most used character to describe efficacy in sources from the Heian and Kamakura periods.<sup>32</sup> It was used, for example, when a medical procedure or ritual “had efficacy” (*gen ari* 有驗) or had “no efficacy” (*gen nashi* 無驗). These sources also frequently note the “influence of efficacy” (*genki* 驗氣), a term that is homophonous with *genki* 減氣, referring to a “decrease of the influence” of disease. Historical sources also speak of the “virtue” or “power” of efficacy (*gentoku* 驗德), comparable to the curative “virtues” of a medicine.

*Gen* and related terms were often used when an effect of ritual or therapy was seen, felt, or experienced and thus verified. *Gen* was used when the patient responded in some obvious way, appearing to have gotten better as a result of intervention—a return of the appetite, perhaps, or of mobility in the limbs,

body temperature, speech, normal bowel movements, or consciousness—or when the patient directly described themselves as feeling better in some way (whether or not this was actually the case in a biological sense). The etymology for *gen* as it was understood in ancient and early medieval Japan reflected a similar constellation of meanings. In the *Newly Compiled Mirror of Characters* (*Shinsen jikyō* 新撰字鏡, ca. 898–901), a twelve-volume dictionary, the meanings for *gen* are given as *chō* 徴 (credible evidence, proof, to establish as true), *shō* 証/證 (to clarify a matter, sign, indication, disease symptom), and *kō* 効 (efficacy, as in the efficacy of medicine; symbol, sign, proof).<sup>33</sup> The *Collection of Notes on Names and Meanings* (*Ruijū myōgi shō* 類聚名義抄, ca. 1000) reads *gen* as *shirushi* シルシ, meaning sign or token.<sup>34</sup> *Shirushi* was a common gloss for the character *gen* in Buddhist didactic tales and court literature.<sup>35</sup> The sense of *gen* as sign and symptom here is critical because it means that efficacy was fundamentally a semiotic affair, involving signs of the body or performance to be read, and thus always a matter of interpretation. It was the healer's job to craft rituals in a way that would predispose patients, patrons, and onlookers to certain interpretations, namely, those that leaned toward reading the ritual as exhibiting the desired *gen*. Because priests often shared these notions of *gen*, we have little reason to automatically assume their interpretative work in ritual necessarily constituted a kind of crass manipulation, a view that reflects entrenched assumptions about historical actors engaged in religious and medical activities rather than an adequate understanding of emic discourses on efficacy.

There is a clear parallel between the meanings of *gen* as they pertained to ritual and therapeutic efficacy and the use of the character *gen* to name the genre of *genki* 験記, the “records of miraculous events.”<sup>36</sup> In medieval Japan, many works were produced in this genre, including textual and visual/textual narratives (*e* 絵/*emaki* 絵巻). Famous examples include the *Miraculous Records of the Lotus Sutra* (*Hokke genki* 法華験記) and the *Illustrated Miracles of the Kasuga Deity* (*Kasuga gongen genki e* 春日権現験記絵). Narratives of this genre centered on occasions when the miraculous influence of powerful scriptures or the otherwise invisible gods or buddhas demonstrated some tangible effect on the world and in the lives of the devoted, often in response to ritual practices or displays of meritorious action. The genre of miraculous records speaks to the same imagined dynamic of efficacy when the term *gen* articulates the effects of healing practices. That is, *gen* is about the manifestation of effects and influences that are ordinarily invisible or occulted. Therefore, the difficult challenge that ritual healers faced when working against disease and disease agents in the economy of efficacy in early medieval Japan was to make the effects of ritual healing tangible and legible to themselves and their patients in ways that paralleled the incredible manifestations of the buddhas and gods.

It is significant that *gen* formed the centerpiece of competition between Buddhist monks. These battles, which are frequently staged in tale literature, constituted a clash of magical powers between monks, always involving ritual techniques, including many of the same spells, gestures, and implements used in healing scenarios. These competitions have been referred to as *gen-kurabe* 験競べ, the “comparing of efficacy.” These clashes usually end with a clear winner and loser, the latter often shown to be a charlatan or a novice on the gradient of ritual skill. Although *gen-kurabe* was a conceit of tale literature, it reflects the real-life competitions between monks and other healers that constituted the economy of ritual efficacy in early medieval Japan. Actual occasions of monks competing occurred around the sickbeds of patients, since courtiers summoned multiple practitioners around the same time, giving them quick access to a “second opinion.” The winners and losers would be decided by patients and concerned family members, who were constantly evaluating how things were going and if positive effects were manifesting, whether that be in the condition of the patient, something in the ritual, or a dream somebody had later. They would make judgments of a consequential nature—in their diary accounts of the event, records that were passed down to their offspring; in their choices about compensation; and in their decisions about whom to invite back and how frequently.

The term *gen* also figures in the historical term *genza* 験者 (alt. *genja*), which literally means “efficacious one.” Without precedent in earlier Chinese sources, *genza* first appeared in sources from the mid-Heian period and came to refer to monks who had magical powers acquired through ritual practice. Although in tale literature the *genza* often figure in stories depicting almost violent exchanges with similar monks—such as the *gen-kurabe*—the word most typically referred to monks who performed ritual healing and were known for demonstrating efficacy in that field. As I discuss in detail in chapter 2, the *genza* were often associated with the “possession rite,” a ritual that developed in the late tenth century as an exorcistic therapy against diseases caused by resentful spirits. In chapter 3, we shall see that it was the monks of the Jimon lineage, from which the Ritual for Expelling Demons emerged, who acquired a special reputation in the field of ritual healing and the possession rite as *genza* in the latter half of the Heian period.

As “efficacious ones,” esoteric monks of the Jimon lineage crafted rituals capable of demonstrating healing efficacy through iterative cycles of research, experimentation, and performance in the competitive milieu that defined therapeutic culture in the early medieval period. In chapters 5 and 6, I reveal the importance of research in the process by which Jimon monks identified and described the pathogenic agents they came to imagine as the malicious agents behind corpse-vector disease. It is evident that they were helped in that work by



the lineage's accumulation of centuries of experimental ritual practice against diseases caused by immaterial spirits, a topic explored in chapter 3. Moreover, these attempts to articulate the agents behind disease causation and spread were made in the context of ritual design. In other words, Jimon monks carried out this knowledge work in and through the compilation of prescriptive ritual texts, thus the epistemology of disease was always tied to ritual programs meant to demonstrate efficacy in performance. In turn, it is only possible to understand the ritual program that Jimon monks designed with reference to the knowledge they produced about the disease. When we turn to the therapeutic aspect of ritual design in chapter 7, we will see how Jimon monks sought to link their notions of disease and pathogens with ritual and medical practices. I examine how, through these practices, Jimon monks sought to bring to ritual healing an innovation that would heighten the tangibility of ritual efficacy: the direct incorporation of the patient's felt experience into ritual performance.

## DEMONS AND THE METAPERSONS OF DISEASE

Viewing ritual healing through the lens of immunity brings into sharp relief the agencies that cause disease. An integral function of biological immune systems is to prime the organism for the potential appearance in the environment—and invasion into the organism's body—of threats and pathogens like viruses, bacteria, and parasites. Immunity is thus an operation of anticipation, a forecast of foreign others that at any given moment may be unseen to the naked eye (if not the all-seeing eye of the Buddha). Key to this operation is an ongoing mechanism of boundary work. Through complex biological and cognitive work, the host is constantly demarcating and thus policing the barriers between the self (the internal somatic field to be protected) and others (alien threats to the somatic field from without).<sup>37</sup> This boundary work facilitates the identification of threats and the creation of a kind of tactical immunological memory. It makes possible, to borrow the words of Donna Haraway, “a plan for meaningful action to construct and maintain the boundaries for what may count as self and other,” and a range of defense mechanisms for disarming and defanging external threats.<sup>38</sup>

It is no coincidence that operations of a similar nature have been noted for forms of thinking we would readily characterize as “religious.” Sloterdijk provocatively sees the basic operations of immunity, namely, the detection of and engagement with perceived threats, as procedures that shape important (but certainly not all) aspects of religious thought and action. The immune system is primed “to work out a *modus vivendi* with foreign and invisible powers—and, in so far as these can bring death, ‘higher’ and ‘supernatural’ ones—this is a preliminary stage to the behaviour one is accustomed to terming religious or spiritual in human contexts.”<sup>39</sup>

Seeking to bring a recognition of the operation of these immunitary tendencies into conversation with the study of ritual healing, I refer to the “foreign and invisible powers” that were imagined to cause disease in early medieval Japan as “metapersons.” I draw on the work of Alan Strathern, who defines metapersons as those beings who have “agency and motivation just as people have, but [who] are not present to the senses in the way that ordinary people are, and [who] usually possess a greater range of powers to effect their will.”<sup>40</sup> The term captures the cast of characters familiar to religion and ritual practices: ghosts, spirits, demons, ancestors, gods, and so on. Metapersons populate all societies. Even societies that have undergone modernization and now enshrine positivism, Strathern insists, have yet to succeed in completely exorcising an awareness of such invisible agencies. One need only recall germs, an entity that links the premodern to the modern, and religious to secular beliefs, in places like the United States. As Nancy Tomes writes in her book *The Gospel of Germs*, “By virtue of their religious heritage . . . ordinary Americans had been conditioned to believe in an ‘invisible world’ dominated by unseen forces that held the power of life and death.”<sup>41</sup> Because awareness of metapersons seems to be a feature of evolved human cognition, metapersons cannot be fully sanitized or scrubbed away. This is why, Strathern notes, “when cognitive scientists refer to ‘religion’ this [awareness of metapersons] is normally what they mean.”<sup>42</sup>

Much ritual activity, throughout the world and specifically in premodern Japan, is aimed directly at establishing with metapersons what T. M. Luhmann calls “parasocial relationships.” In her book *How God Becomes Real*, she explains:

A relationship with a god or spirit is a parasocial relationship, like relationships with all invisible others. One cannot have an ordinary face-to-face relationship with invisible others; they have no faces. A god is not of course thought to be a fictional character by persons of faith. Nonetheless, the relationship is parasocial because its content occurs largely inside the person’s head, using his or her imagination, and what must be imagined about the god emerges from the rich stories in which that god is embedded.<sup>43</sup>

I am similarly concerned with how Buddhist monks in early medieval Japan used ritual as a means of forming parasocial relationships with metapersons. The use of narrative played an important role in this process, but because my concern is ritual, I also highlight how monks related to metapersons through ritual knowledge, design, and performance.

I use the term “metaperson” primarily with reference to the disease-causing agencies and threats that were engaged and captured in processes of ritual

immunity. This means I am mostly concerned with the beings who inhabit the more threatening end of the metapersonal spectrum. Patterns of cognitive bias suggest that humans in general may actually have a preference for the shadowy side of invisible others. Although countless rituals obviously invoke and instantiate gods and demons, the high and the low, the beneficent and the harmful, scholars of cognitive science and religion have pointed to a gravitational pull in the human mind and religion toward those agencies perceived as evil or dangerous. Some have even proposed the existence of a kind of built-in mechanism they call (somewhat dramatically) the “hyperactive agency detector device.”<sup>44</sup> Agential thinking, it has been pointed out, tends to kick in when we think something is wrong, not when things are going right. In *God Is Watching You*, Dominic Johnson points out that people are more likely to attribute outside agency to a situation in which they are experiencing an unpleasant event. He also discusses the pervasive tendency of humans to change their behavior in the presence of eyes. “When we are watched we behave differently,” he writes, and this goes far in accounting for the near-ubiquitous notion of the “evil eye” in cultures throughout the world.<sup>45</sup> In Johnson’s research, the existence of this tendency supports one of his broader arguments about religion: that the idea of what makes us fundamentally human is the constant sense we cannot shake off of being ceaselessly watched by gods, spirits, or other agents. For my purposes, it is notable that this unshakable sense represents an inverse of protective immunitary boundary work, which can be understood as the habitual activity of keeping a watchful eye trained on that which watches us back (recalling again the Buddha’s omniscient eyes).

Focusing on the darker spectrum of metapersons is eminently justified when examining the rituals of esoteric Buddhism in medieval Japan. As Michel Strickmann, Bernard Faure, and Iyanaga Nobumi have demonstrated, one feature of esoteric Buddhism that exerted an outsized effect on Japan was its robust demonology.<sup>46</sup> Esoteric scriptures imported from the continent, and those produced anew in medieval Japan, were replete with detailed descriptions of pathogenic and harmful agencies and irritants: demon kings, lesser demons, and wrathful gods; ghosts and spirits; body worms, venomous snakes, shape-shifting foxes, and demonic cats; meddling *māras*, anthropophagous *yakṣas* and *raṁṣas*, and *vetāla* zombies; vaguely defined “nonhumans,” and so on. Yet as Faure has thoroughly shown, the demonic population and its specificity quickly complicates any interpretative approaches of a reductive sort, including the cognitive and psychological approaches. The richness and diversity of the demonic in medieval Japan cannot be adequately digested by invoking either primeval fears or cognitive biases. For one thing, the population of dangerous entities never stopped growing and mutating over the medieval period. With demons, “there was always a remainder,” as Faure puts it, and “the fight between good and evil continued to rage.”<sup>47</sup>

What fed these processes was not only a fear of the unknown but also the tireless production of mythological and demonological discourses by Buddhist monks. In this book, I want to spotlight another major driver behind the ever-energized production of demonological discourse: the unending encounters with “surprises” of the pathological sort, that is, the unexpected appearance from beyond the horizons of the known of new and strange diseases that challenged and disrupted existing conceptual frameworks about disease, the body, and the integrity of the self. As provocations to the immune systems of both aristocratic patients and monk healers, these anomalous pathological situations inspired new attempts to make sense of and catalog pathogenic influences and metapersons. Demonology in medieval Japan was not simply an abstract intellectual field but what Bruno Latour has called “empirical metaphysics,” that is, knowledge generated in response to the eruption of “controversies over agencies,” vexing agencies that “ceaselessly populate the world with new drives and, as ceaselessly, contest the existence of others.”<sup>48</sup> Such controversies were also key components of ritual immunity in early medieval Japan, not least because these surprise-driven dynamics of knowledge production played out through and incited the production of rituals meant to defang and squash such physically threatening and cognitively confounding entities.

But esoteric monks were not interested in engaging with all manner of demonic and pathogenic agencies for the sake of comprehensiveness, nor could they secure total control over the ungovernable contingences that shaped the processes of ritual immunity, even if their knowledge work and practices had the largest impact on the imagination of disease, the body, and therapy. Monks and their patients alike came to be implicated by processes of ritual immunity that were preoccupied with disease-causing metapersons and agencies. One pathogenic “surprise” monks repeatedly found themselves facing were variants of “postmortem contagion,” disease entities intertwined with death. Indeed, what made the Jimon Ritual for Expelling Demons so innovative for its time was its focus on diseases caused by a new form of postmortem contagion: corpses, the material dead.

## POSTMORTEM CONTAGION AND CORPSE-VECTOR DISEASE

Throughout history, the corpse has figured into accounts of disease and epidemics. Human cultures have frequently assumed a necessary relationship between corpses and disease outbreaks. Indeed, there is something seemingly intuitive about attributing to decaying flesh an irreducible inauspiciousness, apprehensions about contamination, and with these, the potential for pathological influence on our living bodies. As Christos Lynteris and Nicholas H. A. Evans note,

“For more than two-and-a-half millennia both medical and lay accounts of epidemics have set the human corpse at the center of their attention, generating one of the most pervasive tropes and topoi of what Priscilla Wald has aptly termed ‘outbreak narratives.’”<sup>49</sup>

The central place of the corpse in such accounts is not, as we might expect, the consequence of some indisputable bacteriological reality. Although dead bodies do contribute to the spread of disease in certain scenarios, the place they hold in historical accounts of disease and epidemics is often oversized and mythic. Moreover, as Lynteris and Evans point out, the precise ways the corpse comes to be framed in societies as a pathogenic or epidemic danger, and the various medical, religious, and cultural conditions that invite and shape such framings, are far from universal. The corpse has not signified the same thing everywhere and at all times, nor has it always been linked to contagion and disease.

In this regard, premodern Japan offers an interesting case study of the history of the imagination of corpse–disease relations. Historians and scholars of religion have long assumed, for example, that in premodern Japan, contact with the dead was believed to cause disease.<sup>50</sup> They have drawn attention particularly to a special pollution imagined to emanate from the dead, known as “defilement” (*kegare* 穢れ), which they assumed was pathogenic. It has been assumed that illness itself constituted a form of defilement and was thus similar to the nature of the corpse.

Neither the thesis that people believed that death defilement causes disease nor the idea that illness constituted defilement has been demonstrated or extensively studied. Despite human intuition and scholarly assumptions, there has been a curious dearth of historical research on the relationship between corpses and disease. This is true even for the academic field of medical history in Japan (*igakushi* 医学史), an unusual oversight given the history of that field. Medical history arose in Japan during the nation’s moment of “hygienic modernity” in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. Across political, scientific, and popular spheres, alarms were raised over the concern that corpses spread disease and policies must be implemented to prevent such postmortem transmissions. For example, one argument made for the practice of cremation during the Meiji period (1868–1912) was that corpses facilitate the spread of epidemics, thus it is imperative to reduce them by fire to inert ash and bone. Such arguments about cremation dovetailed with local traditions, practiced since at least the late Edo period (1603–1868), in which the deceased bodies of people with tuberculosis, leprosy, and cholera were cremated to prevent disease transmission.<sup>51</sup> In the Meiji period, these arguments received new support from modern science and hygiene, and they came to be folded into larger constructions of national identity. Ruth Rogaski writes, “All preventive practices advocated within this new *eisei* [hygiene], from abstinence from alcohol to the burning

of corpses, claimed to be based on universal truths emerging from laboratory experiments in chemistry, physiology, and the new science of bacteriology. At the same time, *eisei* implied that national survival was the ultimate purpose of disease prevention.”<sup>52</sup>

We now know that corpses only contribute to the spread of disease in a limited way, but this was not known in the early twentieth century, when the opposite view had become the prevailing scientific orthodoxy. Strangely, the subject of corpses is completely absent from Fujikawa Yū's *History of Disease in Japan* (*Nihon shippei shi* 日本疾病史), published in 1912, just a year after the end of the Meiji period. Nor does the pathogenic corpse figure into the work of Hattori Toshirō, who was otherwise highly critical in his assessment of the hygiene (or lack thereof) of the Heian aristocracy in his landmark study, *Research on the History of Medicine in the Heian Period* (*Heian jidai igakushi no kenkyū* 平安時代医学史の研究, 1955). In Hattori's long descriptions of the toxic lifestyle of aristocrats, their poor dietary choices, the lack of air flow in their dark mansions, the damaging effects of their cosmetics, and so on, we might expect at least a passing mention of the proliferation of corpses that characterized the Heian period. Yet in the work of these medical historians, corpses are primarily the effects of disease, since epidemics produce corpses on a large scale; the possibility that they might have been the cause of disease is not considered.<sup>53</sup>

This book explores a topic that has fallen between the cracks of medical history: the question of how corpses came to shape the imagination of disease. The primary case study is the emergence of corpse-vector disease in the late twelfth century. The approach adopted here is not to examine the corpse's pathogenic tendencies in isolation, as from a bacteriological perspective. Rather, I aim to place the corpse in a wider array of narratives, concepts, and practices in which disease and contagion were linked to death in premodern Japan. I propose the category of postmortem contagion, which I borrow from the insightful work of Lynteris and Evans on corpses and epidemics. In this book, postmortem contagion refers to the various ways that death and death-generated entities were imagined to influence humans through persistent varieties of transmission and infection, including invasion, possession, pollution, and disease.

Corpse-vector disease, the pathological focus of the Ritual for Expelling Demons, was a concept that originated in Chinese medicine and was transmitted to Japan through Chinese medical texts.<sup>54</sup> However, it emerged as an operational category on the ground at the intersection of several varieties of postmortem contagion in early medieval Japan. Perhaps the most pervasive type of postmortem contagion was what I call “spirit disease,” known in Heian-period Japan as *jake* 邪気 (alt. *jaki*), or “evil *qi*.” An affliction provoked by ghosts of an immaterial form, spirit disease was the predominant pathological trope by which courtiers and emperors linked disease to the dead. The key issue

with spirit disease, I argue in chapter 2, was that of resentment and tense moral relations between the living and the dead.

A second key aspect of postmortem contagion I examine pertains to the proliferation of corpses in the Heian period, focusing on 1170–1220. During this height of the population of cadavers, courtiers faced an epidemic of decaying and foul-smelling bodies in the streets and alleys of the capital of Heiankyō and, owing to pervasive fears about the ritual pollution that emanated from corpses, the problem of death defilement. As I show in chapter 5, unlike spirit disease, death defilement was an amoral contagion that sparked anxiety and controversy on a daily basis, turning life in the capital into one of constant stress and vigilance. As a disease caused by corpses but configured by moral concerns as well, corpse-vector disease represented a new form of postmortem contagion that was linked to, yet diverged from, the imagination of spirit disease and death defilement.

The relationships between material death, disease, and contagion were thus variably imagined in early medieval Japan. In examining these imaginations, I draw special attention to metapersons, those unseen entities that Buddhist monks sought to understand with ritual knowledge and influence with ritual action. The category of postmortem contagion is populated with such metapersons as spirits, worms, corpses, various forms of corpse influence, death defilement, and demons. Against the resentful spirits that constituted and provoked evil *qi*, Buddhists innovated a new ritual focused on spirit possession. The creation of the possession rite forms the backdrop for the development that interests us most: the Jimon ritual against corpse-vector disease. Jimon monks imagined corpse-vector disease and its relation to death, contagion, and disease in terms of several distinct but related metapersons: corpse influence, demons, *māras*, and “corpse-worms.” In chapter 6, I discuss how they constructed such metapersons by drawing on various streams of knowledge: Daoist and Buddhist scriptures, the writings of their Chinese patriarchs, esoteric Buddhist ritual texts, and Chinese medicine. Their construction of the agencies behind corpse-vector disease serves as an example of the processes of knowledge production by which corpses come to be seen as etiological. For the Ritual for Expelling Demons, it also reveals how the construction of death-related metapersons was informed by the logics of ritual immunity: the varied attempts to transform and eradicate agents of affliction through ritual experimentation, research, and practice.

## THE JIMON LINEAGE AND THE RITUAL FOR EXPELLING DEMONS

The monks who designed the Ritual for Expelling Demons belonged to the Jimon lineage, one of the two branches of the Tendai school.<sup>55</sup> The Tendai

school was established in 804 by Saichō 最澄 (767–822). Until the mid-Heian period, the school primarily grew at Enryakuji, a temple complex on Mt. Hiei where, decades before, Saichō had built a modest temple dedicated to the Medicine Buddha (Yakushi Nyorai 薬師如来).<sup>56</sup> Inspired by Chinese Tiantai, which was organized around the thought of Zhiyi 智顗 (538–597), Saichō centered his school on the *Lotus Sutra* (*Hokkekyō* 法華經), a foundational Mahāyāna scripture. Later in life, Saichō became interested in the teachings of esoteric Buddhism, which was the focal point of his contemporary Kūkai 空海 (774–835), later seen as the founder of the Shingon school. Thereafter, although monks on Mt. Hiei would continue to study so-called exoteric doctrines (*kengyō* 顯教), that is, prominent Mahāyāna teachings like the *Lotus Sutra*, “Pure Land” thought, and the bodhisattva precepts, Saichō’s disciples, most notably Ennin 円仁 (794–864) and Enchin 円珍 (814–891), came to engage extensively with esoteric teachings and rituals. Their engagements marked the beginnings of what came to be called Taimitsu 台密, Tendai-style esotericism.

It was not long before numerous lineages and factions formed within the Tendai school atop Mt. Hiei. The two most prominent branches were the Sanmon (Mountain Gate), which looked to Ennin as its patriarch, and the Jimon (Temple Gate), which revered Enchin. As chapter 1 details, the Jimon branch became a wholly separate monastic community in the mid-tenth century, when its members descended Mt. Hiei and reestablished themselves at Onjōji. Also called Miidera 三井寺, the name by which it is popularly known today, Onjōji was a temple of imperial origins that was adopted and revamped by Enchin. Although the temple complex was much larger in premodern times, it was located mostly where it still stands today, in the city of Ōtsu in Shiga prefecture, not far from the foothills of Mt. Hiei in what was then the province of Ōmi 近江. The temple is set against Mt. Nagara 長等山 in the west and looks toward Lake Biwa 琵琶湖 in the east.

It is widely acknowledged that Jimon monks made sizable contributions to Japanese Buddhism and culture in the Heian and Kamakura periods, the time frame that concerns us in this book. The wide-ranging influence of the Jimon lineage can be discerned in the fields of doctrinal exegesis, monastic debates, the interpretation of the precepts, esoteric rituals, Pure Land thought and practice, *kami* cults, and more generally, in art, architecture, literature, poetry, and politics. A common refrain one often hears in the field of Japanese Buddhism is that tragically few historical documents have survived for Onjōji and the Jimon community, limiting the extent to which those contributions can be adequately elucidated. Indeed, the number of extant manuscripts that attest to the activities of Jimon monks in early medieval Japan pale in comparison to those that survived at Sanmon-Tendai and Shingon temples. For good reason, the blame for this dearth of extant documents is sometimes linked to the fires



of monastic rivalry, for the halls of Onjōji were burned down many times in the early medieval period, often at the hands of Sanmon monks, their cousins in the Tendai school.

However, this long-standing narrative about the historiographical limitations of tracing the rich history of Onjōji and the Jimon lineage warrants considerable nuance for two main reasons. First, recent years have seen the publication of new major studies and historical documents. Tachi Ryūshi's monumental study on Kōin 公胤 (1145–1216), Matsumoto Ikuyo's research on the *Record of Treasured Secrets* (*Hōhiki* 宝秘記) by Keihan 慶範 (1155–1221), Edward Drott's exploration of the old man deity at Onjōji, and Sujung Kim's book on the cult of Shinra Myōjin 神羅明神 shed new light on the social, ritual, mythical, and political world of the Jimon community.<sup>57</sup> These scholars have shown that the Jimon community was in no way isolated as a result of its split from the Sanmon branch. It remained connected—to other monastic lineages and institutions, to the court, to occupational fishing groups around Lake Biwa, and to communities tracing their lineage to the Korean peninsula. These studies have also benefited from, and thus help us contextualize, historical documents that have been published in the *Onjōji monjo* 園城寺文書 series. Another series, *Onjōji no butsuzō* 園城寺仏像, has made it possible to examine the vast array of Buddhist icons that have survived at Onjōji from the early Heian to Edo periods. This book is indebted to these new studies and historical materials.<sup>58</sup>

Second, it must be acknowledged that, to date, scholars have not taken full advantage of the Jimon documents that have survived. This point was recently made by Nakagawa Jinki, who encourages scholars to put aside the pessimistic refrain about manuscript scarcity and to look anew at what does exist, which in his case are surviving records of dharma assemblies (*hōe* 法会).<sup>59</sup> The scholars noted above exemplify the proactive and creative approach Nakagawa promotes. I bring the same attitude to a sorely neglected body of Jimon liturgical literature, the manuscripts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons, the diachronic and synchronic analysis of which constitutes the core focus of this book. These manuscripts have received occasional attention, first by medical historians and *kōshin* investigators and only secondarily by scholars of Japanese Buddhism. No study to date has tried to situate their conception, creation, and transmission in the Jimon lineage. My argument is that it is necessary to situate the Ritual for Expelling Demons and its manuscripts in the history of the Jimon lineage to understand them adequately, since Jimon monks were the authors and editors of those manuscripts, work they conducted using textual resources on site at Onjōji. I also contend that these manuscripts help us shed light on a major consistent feature of the Jimon community: the influential role that its monks played for centuries as exorcists, ghostbusters, demon slayers, and therapeutic pyrotechnicians—that is, as ritual healers.

One critical point must be clarified at the outset. At present, there is no known surviving document, whether a diary entry or a mention in a liturgical anthology, indicating that Jimon monks performed the Ritual for Expelling Demons on an ailing person at a particular place and time. Such lack of performance record might come as a shock to some readers, but it is not a major concern for the methodological approach of this book for the following reasons. First, it is my view that we have sufficient evidence to speculate they probably did perform it. The episodic histories in chapters 1 and 3 demonstrate that Jimon monks were performing healing rites for elite patients with significant frequency, a fact that can be stated with confidence despite the limitations of outside observer accounts (i.e., diaries written by courtiers and other documentary evidence). Relatedly, the Ritual for Expelling Demons presumes an audience, specifically aristocratic patients, with whom Jimon monks had been engaged for centuries. It seems unlikely that the monks would have passed up the opportunity to impress this audience with their highly unusual rite, one that also resonated with current trends in the therapeutic culture of the day and responded directly to a new disease that was afflicting notable members of that audience.

Second, prescriptive though they may be, ritual documents emanate from and thus come to encompass the lifeworlds of those who produced them, the anxieties and hopes they held, and the longer histories of practice in which they were embedded. Healing rituals in particular reveal how their producers imagined disease, the body, and efficacy and how they imagined they might transform those dimensions of human existence by implementing social, material, and symbolic actions by way of ritual performance. To use an analogy, it would be a mistake for a scholar of medieval Japan to minimize the value of a narrative—say, of the genre of didactic explanatory tales or *setsuwa*—in reconstructing the emic world that produced it simply because no record had been found of it having been preached at a particular temple. Conversely, when skillfully and creatively analyzed, such a tale might be used to reconstruct aspects of the otherwise inaccessible contexts of performance—to say nothing of the other features of the living, enfleshed world that gave it life.<sup>60</sup> Like narrative, prescriptive rituals are products of the collective imagination, one that emerges in interaction with the actors and elements of social, material, biological, and performative milieus. Rituals often filter those complex dynamics into their own structuring narrative, even if only the basic conceit of the heroic healer who wields ritual action to conquer the demonic villain. My starting point here is curiosity at the fact that Jimon monks conceived of the Ritual for Expelling Demons at all—and creatively designed it as they did, focused on the strange affliction of corpse-vector disease and moxibustion. I also believe that the Jimon ritual has much to reveal about broader changes in the imagination of disease and therapy in early medieval Japan.

## CHAPTER OVERVIEWS

Chapter 1 begins with an episodic sociomedical history of the Jimon lineage. It focuses on the therapeutic ritual services Jimon monks provided during the Heian and early Kamakura periods for aristocratic and imperial patients, including altar rituals invoking deities such as Fudō Myōō, the Five Wisdom Kings, and Senju Kannon. Providing these therapeutic services, I argue, enabled Jimon monks to amplify their relevance among important patrons during a time of existential crisis for the community. Through healing rituals, Jimon monks forged “immunitary relations” with patients, ties characterized by therapeutic interdependence.

Chapter 2 brings the reader into the mansions and lifeworld of those who sponsored healing rites, aristocrats living in Heiankyō in the Heian period. From the late tenth century on, aristocrats increasingly came to be afflicted by a disease they attributed to unseen spirits. I show that these “evil influences” (*jake*) were homegrown, born of the culture of resentment that prevailed in court life and growing anxieties about one’s postmortem fate. Seeking relief from the psycho-spectral irritants that haunted their mansions, minds, and bodies, courtiers called on Buddhist monks belonging to esoteric lineages. I examine how monks responded to the problem of spirit disease by creating a new ritual: the possession rite. Although this ritual often proved to be successful, I demonstrate that it came into being through a complicated process of accident, experiment, and adaptation. Monks relied on the trusted techniques of their esoteric liturgical tradition but also diverged from them. These divergences were motivated by a creative attempt to better align the efficacy of ritual healing with a disease whose pathology was specific to the dynamics of the lifeworld of their patients at court.

Lingering in the aristocratic mansion, chapter 3 zooms in on how Jimon monks pioneered and practiced the possession rite from the mid-Heian to the early Kamakura period. I show how monks like Yokei, Kanju, Shin’yo, Gyōson, and others performed the rite compellingly and thereby solidified the reputation of Jimon monks in the eyes of their patients as effective ghostbusters—or, to use the historical term, *genza*, “efficacious ones” known for ritual prowess over disease-causing spirits. The chapter ends with an analysis of a “performance” of the possession rite by Keisei, a key contributor to the project of copying, editing, and transmitting the liturgical texts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons.

Part II turns to the emergence of a wholly different kind of post-mortem contagion—corpse-vector disease—and the Jimon ritual response to it. In chapter 4, I introduce the manuscripts, the monks who produced them, and the basics of the ritual. Chapter 5 is set at the porous boundaries between the aristocratic mansion and the urban environment of Heiankyō, in which

corpse-vector disease came into being. I suggest that the emergence of this disease reflected a new imagination of contagion and the permeability of boundaries. With corpse-vector disease, contagious influences that populated the streets of Heiankyō were imagined as pouring into the lifeworld of aristocrats and emperors—and into their bodies—as a pathological influx. Setting the stage for this development was the unprecedented proliferation of corpses in the capital from 1170 to 1220, which brought increasing fears about the defilement (*kegare*) imagined to emanate from corpses. Examining historical records alongside passages from the texts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons, I show how this amoral notion of defiled contagion converged with the Buddhist moral notion of karmic impurity, creating the conditions for imagining diseases of the body that originated not from spirits but from the material dead and eventually the pathologization of death defilement.

Chapters 6 and 7 shift from the capital of Heiankyō back to Onjōji, where Jimon monks from the 1170s to the early 1220s were trying to work out how they should understand this postmortem contagion and what they should do to heal their ailing patients. I examine the content of the manuscripts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons. My analysis is thus synchronic, but the manuscripts came into being over multiple generations of Jimon monks. I aim to reconstruct the processes of knowledge production, research, and practice-oriented logics that enabled Jimon monks to craft and refine their ritual response over time.

Chapter 6 considers the epistemological dimensions of the ritual texts. I examine how Jimon monks imagined and produced the pathogenic metapersons behind the etiology and pathology of corpse-vector disease. In their writings, Jimon monks identified three types of pathogens: demons, *māras*, and corpse-worms. Although in the conceptual frameworks of the various ritual and medical literature these three represented different and distinct categories of metapersonal agency, I demonstrate that Jimon monks selected them as the agents of corpse-vector disease because they blurred the boundaries between self and other. The epistemological work and research in which the monks engaged was aimed at showing how these agents caused disease in the body by hijacking the victim's agency, thus influencing the victim's karma and creating the conditions for the generation of the corpse-vector disease contagion.

Chapter 7 turns to the treatment program Jimon monks created. Unlike spirit disease, the pathogenic metapersons of corpse-vector disease could not be transferred to a spirit medium or managed through diplomatic communication. The ways the metapersons of corpse-vector disease blurred the boundaries between patient and disease agent demanded, I argue, a different therapeutic program altogether. In the Ritual for Expelling Demons, Jimon monks sought to solve this problem by prescribing direct physical contact with the patient's body, as this had become the site of pathological entanglement. In so doing,

Jimon monks departed from mainstream ritual healing, including the possession rite they pioneered, which for the most part was imagined working remotely, at a distance. The therapy they promoted, to be conducted in the context of the *goma* fire ceremony, was moxibustion, a form of cautery in which the healer burned processed mugwort on the patient's body. I contend that the monks chose moxibustion deliberately to literalize the violent efficacy that was long associated with the fire of the *goma* ceremony.

In the epilogue, I reflect on the afterlife of the Ritual for Expelling Demons as its manuscripts were transmitted within and beyond Heiankyō and Onjōji. The composition of new ritual and medical texts focusing on Shōmen Kongō, Buddhist forms of moxibustion, the “Three Corpse-Worms,” and corpse-vector disease demonstrates just how innovative and consequential the Ritual for Expelling Demons turned out to be. These snapshots of the reverberations the Jimon rite set in motion—each representing new chapters in a much longer story of how the processes and practices of ritual immunity were activated against disease-causing corpses and other forms of postmortem contagion in medieval Japan—lay out the agenda for future studies.



# PART I

## Spirit Disease





# CHAPTER 1

## Ritual Healing in the Jimon Lineage



IN 998, EMINENT COURTIER FUJIWARA NO YUKINARI 藤原行成 (972–1027) had a brush with death. In the seventh month of the year, during an illness, Yukinari suddenly lost consciousness. In his diary he recounted the dream he subsequently had, a nightmare that showed him the horrifying manner by which the pathogen was wreaking havoc on his body. He saw a shadowy figure of commanding presence yanking out the guts from his belly through a hole that had been opened some two inches below his navel.

Almost by instinct, those around Yukinari who now feared for his life sent word to Kanju 観修 (945–1008), a monk of the Jimon lineage of the Tendai school. After arriving at Yukinari's mansion from his temple Gedatsuji, Kanju administered the Buddhist precepts to his unconscious patient. The monk may have assumed Yukinari was teetering on the verge of death, as bestowing precepts was sometimes carried out as a last-minute measure to improve a dying person's chances for a better rebirth. Yet the ceremony proved to be restorative: Kanju's booster of merit therapeutically jolted Yukinari out of his feverish nightmare. In his diary Yukinari noted that Kanju's ceremonial treatment altered the course of his dream vision. When nearly every inch of his bowels had been extracted, he saw three written characters—"Fu Dō Son" 不動尊, the "Venerable Fudō"—enter his abdomen. To Yukinari, this was a miraculous sign that his ailing body was being literally pieced back together with the help of the esoteric deity Fudō Myōō. He wrapped up his diary entry by praising Kanju's efficacy as "indisputably manifest": The monk, Yukinari seemed to imply, was no less than a living incarnation of Fudō himself.<sup>1</sup>

This chapter examines the role Jimon monks played for elite patrons in the Heian period as ritual healers. The role was not acquired overnight, nor was it an inevitable extension of their identity as Buddhist monastics versed in esoteric ritual practices. As I show, Jimon monks energetically worked to create the role of healer as they sought to make themselves relevant and therapeutically essential to the lives and lineages of aristocrats and emperors. Examining the role these monks played as healers demonstrates that the Jimon lineage was never

a stable group whose existence can be taken for granted, defined, as we might imagine, simply by a confluence of social ties and shared monastic interests. The lineage is better seen as a community of individual actors whose collective identity as a monastic community came into being through historical processes and practices that involved interactions with other coeval communities, including competing monastic lineages and the community that coalesced around the emperor, regents, and important figures in the Heian court.<sup>2</sup> Performing rituals for healing, I argue, played an especially important role in the process by which Jimon monks effectively brought their lineage and its distinctive ritual signature into being.

As previous research on monastic factionalism has shown, the Jimon lineage was shaped by centuries of controversy and conflict. Much of this conflict was a direct consequence of the schism that erupted in the tenth century between the Jimon lineage and its sibling branch in the Tendai school, the Sanmon lineage. By threat of arson and violence, Jimon monks were forced to evacuate the monastic headquarters of Tendai on Mt. Hiei and reestablish themselves elsewhere. They did so first and foremost at the temple Onjōji and second at satellite temples around the capital of Heiankyō. In some respects, this disruption was a blessing in disguise, for it ultimately gave Jimon monks greater proximity to their ailing and sometimes unconscious patrons, courtiers and emperors who increasingly sought ritual assistance against disease, epidemics, and dangerous childbirth—and by extension the nightmarish demons and spirits seeking to dismember their bodies from the inside out. By helping their patrons survive various pathogenic threats through ritual healing, the Jimon lineage sought to safeguard its own survival against sectarian threat. Driven by ritual practices, this process generated what can be called immunitary relations, webs of therapeutic interdependence that linked the lives and lineages of Jimon priests to those of their elite patients.

## THE JIMON LINEAGE: CONFLICT AND RITUAL

The Jimon lineage came into being as a discrete monastic community in the Heian period in large part through a series of disputes and internecine conflict with the Sanmon lineage. As scholars such as Paul Groner and Neil McMullin have shown, this was the consequence of increasing factionalism on Mt. Hiei in the tenth century.<sup>3</sup> At the outset, it should be noted that factionalism on the mountain was only a minor issue during the time of Enchin, the patriarch to whom members of the Jimon lineage traced their line. Born in Sanuki 讃岐 (today's Kagawa prefecture) in 814, Enchin began his studies on Mt. Hiei in 828. From 853 to 858, he completed a pilgrimage to Tang China, which included visits to Guoqingsi 国清寺, the home temple of the Chinese Tiantai school,

and Chang'an 長安, where his uncle Kūkai had received esoteric scriptures and teachings fifty years earlier. Enchin brought back to Japan and his Tendai school many sacred writings, the majority of which were esoteric ritual texts. Already by his time in the early Heian period—thanks in no small part to Kūkai's earlier compelling arguments for their efficacy—the value of such scriptures had grown substantially, and emperors and courtiers increasingly turned to esoteric rituals for treating illness, longevity, protection of the state, safe childbirth, and other boons promised in ritual scriptures.<sup>4</sup>

When he returned to Japan in 859, Enchin refurbished Onjōji, a temple in the province of Ōmi, today's Ōtsu city in the prefecture of Shiga. Originally established in the late Nara period as a family temple for the Ōtomo clan, under Enchin's auspices Onjōji became an "affiliated cloister of the Tendai school" (Tendai *betsuin* 天台別院) and eventually the base for his lineage of Tendai students. At Onjōji, Enchin stored many of the sacred writings he imported from China in a newly built library called the Tang Hall (Tōin 唐院). A large portion of this library was later transferred to the Thousand Arm Hall (Senjuin 千手院), also known as the Sannōin 山王院, in the Nishidani area of Mt. Hiei, the home of Enryakuji, the headquarters of the Tendai school since its founding by Saichō.<sup>5</sup> This Thousand Arm Hall also doubled as Enchin's abode on Mt. Hiei during his tenure as the fifth abbot (*zasu* 座主) of the Tendai school, which lasted as long as twenty-three years (868–891). Following Enchin's passing in this hall in 891, and over the next hundred years or so, the Thousand Arm Hall and its library was the home base for Jimon monks.<sup>6</sup>

Owing in part to Enchin's extensive tenure as abbot, Jimon monks came to hold considerable institutional sway on Mt. Hiei, even more so than members of the Sanmon lineage, who traced their line back to Ennin. By the late ninth and early tenth centuries, monks who became the abbots of Onjōji were nearly guaranteed to become abbots of the Tendai school. This is because the system of promotion that operated on Mt. Hiei favored monks who served as abbots of branch temples in the Tendai school, and Enchin's Onjōji had become one of those, thanks to the efforts of Enchin and his immediate disciples. Abbots of the Tendai school wielded tremendous authority, exerting control over pedagogical matters such as the curriculum of study and practice on the mountain and over administrative affairs, including matters surrounding the ordination of new monks.<sup>7</sup>

The Sanmon equivalent of the Jimon Onjōji was Hosshōji 法性寺, a Fujiwara clan temple in the capital of Heiankyō. As Paul Groner has explained, abbacy at Hosshōji occasionally functioned as a gateway to abbacy of the Tendai school.<sup>8</sup> During the ninth century, several Sanmon monks who were abbots of Hosshōji went on to become abbots of the Tendai school, including the ritual powerhouse Son'i 尊意 (866–940). For esteemed Sanmon monks, Hosshōji

became a springboard to the highest seat of the Tendai institution. The temple's links to Tendai and the Sanmon branch were strong from the time of its founding. Hosshōji was originally established by Fujiwara no Tadahira 藤原忠平 (880–949), a politician for whom Son'i performed many rites.<sup>9</sup> It later came to be associated with the court lineage of Fujiwara no Morosuke 藤原師輔 (908–960), Tadahira's son. Morosuke and his lineage maintained close ties with monks of the Sanmon branch, including its most prominent figure in the mid-Heian period, Ryōgen 良源 (912–985). Hosshōji held ordination privileges; it was sanctioned by the court to designate four monks as “esoteric masters” (*ajari* 阿闍梨). Since designation as esoteric master was one of the prerequisites to promotion to abbot of the Tendai school, guarding this privilege was a vital priority for the Sanmon branch.<sup>10</sup>

Thus, Sanmon monks were furious when in 981 the court made the controversial decision to appoint as Hosshōji's abbot Yokei 余慶 (919–991)—a Jimon monk who had been elevated to abbot of Onjōji only two years earlier. Yokei's appointment as abbot of Hosshōji was tantamount to a seizure of the Sanmon lineage's main pathway to any significant institutional control over the Tendai school. Sanmon monks immediately protested the court's decision. When the court refused to listen, nearly two hundred Sanmon monks marched to Heiankyō and threatened violence. The court cowered and retracted its decision; Yokei was forced to vacate his newly appointed seat at Hosshōji. From this point, the relationship between Sanmon and Jimon monks on Mt. Hiei deteriorated. As Groner writes, “After the incidents surrounding Yokei's appointment as abbot of Hosshōji, rumors began on Mount Hiei that Ennin's faction was planning to burn some of the major buildings controlled by the monks of Enchin's faction, including the library that contained the texts that Enchin brought to Japan at the Senjuin [Thousand Arm Hall] on Mount Hiei, as well as the Kannon'in and the Ichijōji at the foot of Mount Hiei,” two temples associated with the Jimon branch.<sup>11</sup> Another disturbing rumor held that Sanmon monks had plans to assassinate five distinguished Jimon monks, including Yokei.

Faced with the threat of being quite literally smoked out of their home and murdered by their monastic brothers, Jimon monks soon began their exodus from Mt. Hiei. They established a new home base at Onjōji, where they replanted the Tōin library of sacred writings along with a statue of Enchin (known as the Chūson Daishizō 中尊大師像).<sup>12</sup> Other Jimon monks took up residence at temples scattered around the outskirts of the capital and in the western foothills of Mt. Hiei. Yokei led hundreds of monks to Daiunji 大雲寺, a temple in Iwakura 岩倉 (today's northern Kyoto); Kanju, Yokei's student and the monk who treated Yukinari, led some thirty monks to Gedatsuji 解脱寺, also located in Iwakura; Bokusan 穆算 (944–1008) took up residence at Ichijōji 一乗寺;

Shōsan 勝算 (939–1011) at Shūgakuin 修学院; and Myōchō 明肇 (946–1014) at Fumonji 普門寺.<sup>13</sup>

Forced by controversy, conflict, and chaos to reconsolidate in these ways, the Jimon lineage as a discrete monastic community was thus baptized by fire. At the same time, the evacuation of the monks from Mt. Hiei was not without certain positive consequences. The escape enabled Jimon monks to secure a key spatial advantage over most Enryakuji Sanmon monks. Having moved to temples around the capital of Heiankyō, Jimon monks now had easier access to the court, the palace, and courtier residences. In fact, the temples where they reestablished themselves reflected the close ties they had already cultivated with patrons. For example, Daiunji was constructed as a vow temple of the courtier Fujiwara no Fuminori 文範 (909–996), who was also the father of the Jimon monk Myōchō. In 985, Senior Grand Empress Shōshi 昌子 (950–999) established at Daiunji the Kannon'in 観音院, thus demonstrating she was not only a patron of the Jimon lineage but actively facilitated its reestablishment during this time of turmoil.<sup>14</sup> It is noteworthy that Fuminori's retainer was also the father of Kanju, the monk who took up residence at Gedatsuji. Gedatsuji, in turn, was a vow temple of Fujiwara no Senshi 詮子 (Higashi Sanjō-in 東三条院, 962–1002?), the daughter of Fujiwara no Kaneie 兼家 (929–990), the older sister of Michinaga 道長 (966–1028), and mother to Emperor Ichijō 一条天皇 (980–1011).<sup>15</sup> One important consequence of the Jimon exodus was that it brought members of the lineage physically closer to the court than they had been at Enryakuji or Onjōji, an advantageous reduction of distance reinforced by close social ties to important people of court society.

Jimon monks also sought to collapse the distance between themselves and their patrons even further by providing ritual services. As Lucia Dolce has pointed out, rituals dedicated to deities and performed for practical benefits "functioned as the socio-political interface of the Tantric lineages" with patrons.<sup>16</sup> As members of a lineage for which esotericism (tantrism) was central, Jimon monks performed all manner of ritual for their clients, but they arguably forged their signature in the realm of health care: rituals to empower and protect the body, treat illness, eradicate pathogens, and for safe childbirth.<sup>17</sup> Although they were by no means the only monastic community to provide such services, Jimon monks made special efforts to deliver tangible experiences of health, healing, and disease elimination. Accordingly, courtiers and emperors often remarked on the comfort that rituals performed by Jimon brought them in times of illness and the efficacy of their rites against the specific pathology of resentful spirits. Despite widespread belief that they were living during the end of days, there was a renewed feeling that these rites provided a world that was cohesive, ordered, and animated with the salubrious power of buddhas, bodhisattvas, and other benevolent deities. Jimon monks forged immunity

relations with patients, a web in which the bodies and diseases of courtiers and emperors became irrevocably tethered to monks and their rites.<sup>18</sup> By protecting their patrons, Jimon monks were working to secure the protection of their own lineage, which was frequently under threat.

Because the rich history of the Jimon lineage and its ritual activities cannot be condensed into a single chapter, I adopt an episodic approach organized by three major time periods and focus on only a dozen or so key members of the Jimon community. I begin with Enchin. Although we cannot say that the Jimon lineage had emerged in his time, Enchin nonetheless established foundations for ritual healing to which his descendants retroactively looked for inspiration. The second period of focus is the “Era of Regents” (Sekkan-ki 摂関期; mid-tenth to the mid-eleventh century), which began around the time the Jimon and Sanmon branches split. In this otherwise tumultuous time, Jimon monks used ritual healing and their new strategic placements around the capital to forge relationships with patrons at court. The third period corresponds to the “Era of Abdicated Sovereigns” (Insei-ki 院政期; late eleventh through late twelfth centuries), a time of changing political configurations when Jimon monks had to make and remake their ritual healing to maintain their relevance. Given the relative paucity of extant Jimon sources, my analysis of their ritual healing in these eras is necessarily uneven. To paint a fuller picture, I rely on diaries, typically written by courtiers during the period in question, as well as tales (*setsuwa*) and records (*denki*). Although the tales and records were compiled later, they nonetheless reflect the transmission of stories about the Jimon lineage and its monks, which were rooted in their historical activities.

## RITUAL HEALING IN THE TIME OF ENCHIN

Long before the split between the Jimon and Sanmon branches, early Tendai monks played important official roles at court as ritual healers. Soon after Saichō established the school in 804, Tendai monks came to occupy posts in the office of the “ten meditation masters in imperial service” (*naigubu jūzenji* 内供奉十禪師)—the emperor’s personal healers.<sup>19</sup> Saichō was appointed to the role in 797. Ennin, one of Saichō’s most distinguished students, later revered as the patriarch of the Sanmon branch, was appointed to the position in 848.<sup>20</sup> Ennin’s appointment no doubt related to the therapeutic services he provided for Emperor Ninmyō 仁明天皇 (810–850). For Ninmyō, he performed what is considered the first esoteric ritual in Japan centered around the “Seven Medicine Buddhas” (Shichibutsu Yakushi 七仏薬師). Ennin performed the ritual in front of an image of the buddhas he hung on a bamboo screen that was part of a fixture enclosing the emperor at the Seiryōden 清涼殿, the emperor’s private

residence.<sup>21</sup> Ennin's ritual, performed close to his august patient, reflects the trust that emperors placed in Tendai ritual healers from an early date.

Another important Tendai monk in this early period was Enchin, who was later revered as the patriarch of the Jimon lineage. Enchin was appointed to the position of "meditation master" in 850. Like Ennin before him, Enchin is known to have provided similar services to emperors, such as Seiwa 清和天皇 (850–880). Other aspects of his career reflect an abiding interest in esoteric rituals capable of transforming the body and exerting therapeutic effects. During his sojourn in Tang China, Enchin traveled to numerous temples and accumulated a veritable library of liturgical scriptures, many of which contain scripts for healing rituals that were accompanied by claims of comprehensive therapeutic efficacy.

Enchin was not merely a courier of ritual documents from abroad, for he also personally engaged with these practices and apparently ran his own experiments in the field of ritual transformation. One of the earliest extant documents detailing engagement with the body through "empowerment" (*kaji* 加持; Skt. *adhiṣṭhāna*) prayers in Japan is in Enchin's own hand. A single sheet of paper, the *Contemplation of Nyoirin [Kannon's] Mind-Within-Mind Mantra* (*Nyoirin shinchūshin shingon kan* 如意輪心中心真言觀) has survived to the present day in the cavity of an icon of Enchin enshrined at Gedatsuji, a branch temple of Onjōji in Iwakura that came to be occupied by Jimon monks led by Kanju around the year 1000, after the migration of Jimon monks from Mt. Hiei. The manuscript outlines a ritual program that pairs seven precise locations on the human body (the crown, forehead, two eyes, mouth, heart, two spleens, navel) with Siddham characters (*shittan bonji* 悉曇梵字). The practitioner is instructed to visualize these seven characters morphing into gold, emanating from the mouth of the bodhisattva Nyoirin Kannon 如意輪觀音, and entering the practitioner's own heart. The resulting boundaryless illumination equips the practitioner with "all knowledge" and the "three illuminations" (*sanmyō* 三明): heavenly vision, past life knowledge, and the extinguishing of afflictions.<sup>22</sup> We can reasonably assume that Enchin would have used this ritual sequence not only to empower himself, a means to booster the effects of his ritual healing, but also to empower imperial patients, who would have certainly welcomed such illuminating supplementation.

As the lineage began to solidify over the tenth and eleventh centuries, Jimon monks continued to draw on Enchin's example and provide therapeutic services for emperors. During the reigns of Emperors Daigo 醍醐 (r. 897–930) and Suzaku 朱雀 (r. 930–946), select individuals from Tōji and Enryakuji were employed as "protector monks" (*gojisō* 護持僧), ritual specialists who provided therapeutic and body-protection services for the "jeweled body" (*gyokutai* 玉体) of the emperor and members of the imperial family. While the emperor slept,

protector monks stayed up through the night in the Futama 二間, a room located immediately next to the emperor's sleeping quarters in the Seiryōden. They chanted mantras, recited sutras, and performed altar rites. Onjōji monks eventually were employed as “night-duty monks” (*yoi no sō* 夜居の僧), as such protector monks were also known, beginning with Kanju, who served Emperors Kazan 花山 (r. 984–986) and Ichijō (r. 986–1011).<sup>23</sup> By the reigns of Shirakawa and Horikawa, protector monks from Onjōji slightly outnumbered monks from Enryakuji and Tōji.<sup>24</sup>

With the increasing privatization of such ritual services in the early Heian period, esoteric monks also came to provide these services to courtiers. In their services to emperors and courtiers, Jimon monks performed the ritual of “empowerment,” which functioned to heal ailing bodies and preemptively fortify the body (*goshin* 護身) of patrons against pathogenic dangers.<sup>25</sup> They also used several more complicated rituals in which they invoked the power of unseen deities through a ritual altar, a topic I explore in more depth next, using three main examples: rituals surrounding the Five Wisdom Kings, Fudō Myōō, and the Senju Kannon.

## MANDALIC THERAPY: THE FIVE ALTAR RITE AND RITES TO FUDŌ MYŌŌ

During the Heian period, Jimon monks who saw themselves as heirs to Enchin's lineage made a name for themselves as healers by performing esoteric Buddhist rituals known as “altar rites” (*danhō*; alt. *danpō* 壇法), often referred to more simply as “rituals” (*shuhō* 修法). The term points to the most basic feature of these rites: invoking a buddha, bodhisattva, or other Buddhist deity, designated as the rite's primary object of worship (*honzon* 本尊), on an altar. Although there existed a great variety of altar rituals, each with complex procedures comprising multiple sequences, certain features were shared. One was that the officiating priest made offerings to the object of worship. Another was the priest's use of the “three mysteries” (*sanmitsu* 三密) of “body, speech, and mind”—the ritual techniques of the mudras, mantras, and visualization. The kind of offerings presented and the specific forms of the three mysteries techniques depended on the deity toward which the rite was addressed, the objective of the rite, and the style and teachings of the esoteric lineage of the priest.

One of the most important types of altar rituals was the *goma* 護摩 (Skt. *homa*) or “fire ceremony.” The fire ceremony was distinguished by the use of an altar equipped with a hearth in the center to be used for creating a ritual fire. Into this hearth the priest tossed certain kinds of wood (*goma-gi* 護摩木) and material offerings to the deity. The importance of the fire ceremony to esoteric Buddhism and to the trans-religious system of tantra more generally cannot be



overstated. As Richard Payne writes, “If there is any one element that comes close to being the defining characteristic of tantra, it is *homa* (*goma*), a votive ritual in which offerings are made to a deity by burning them ritually.”<sup>26</sup> In Japan, the fire ceremony was often performed specifically for wrathful deities, such as Fudō Myōō 不動明王 (Skt. Acala Vidyārāja), the Five Wisdom Kings (Godai Myōō 五大明王, a set that featured Fudō at the center), and Aizen Myōō 愛染明王. In practice in Japan, it was arguably most closely associated with the objectives of subjugation (*chōbuku* 調伏; Skt. *ābhicaraka*)—the quelling of enemies, demons, and disease—and for averting calamities (*sokusai* 息災; Skt. *śāntika*).

Scholars have identified two basic stages of the fire ceremony, and these correspond to the two ways the priest was seen to derive magical power and efficacy through the rite. In the first, which perhaps represents an older layer inherited from earlier Vedic ritual, the priest invites a deity into the space of the altar as a guest. Acting as host, the priest entertains the deity with ritual offerings and secures the deity’s superhuman assistance. In the second stage, guest and host become one: The priest uses the techniques of the three mysteries to merge with the deity, a process of ontological identification referred to as “becoming a buddha in this very body” (*sokushin jōbutsu* 即身成仏) or “self entering, entering self” (*nyūga ga’nyū* 入我我入). Michel Strickmann dubbed this second stage “auto-possession”: By performing ritual techniques, the priest induces the deity’s possession of himself, enabling him to incorporate the deity’s superhuman powers into his own body.<sup>27</sup> Divinely possessed, the priest can channel this power for healing, subjugating enemies, and other this-worldly purposes.

One illustrative example of an altar rite performed as a fire ceremony is the Five Altar Rite (Godanhō 五壇法). The Five Altar Rite became explosively popular in the mid-Heian period, right when the Jimon lineage began finding its footing as an independent community. The Five Altar Rite was an elaborate ceremony featuring five altars, which enshrined the Five Wisdom Kings, which in turn corresponded to one of the five directions in physical space. One standard configuration of the ritual’s spatialized format in Heian Japan was provided by the highly prolific translator of esoteric scriptures into Chinese in China, Amoghavajra (Ch. Bukong 不空, 705–774): Fudō Myōō was to be enshrined in the center altar, Gōzanze Myōō 降三世明王 (Skt. Trailokyavijaya) in the east, Gundari Myōō 軍荼利明王 (Skt. Kuṇḍalin) in the south, Daiitoku Myōō 大威德明王 (Skt. Yamāntaka) in the west, and Kongō Yasha 金剛夜叉 (Skt. Vajrayakṣa) in the north.<sup>28</sup> As with any series of five in the context of esoteric Buddhist ritual discourse, the Five Wisdom Kings in the four cardinal directions and the center collectively represented the space of the mandala (*mandara* 曼荼羅), those cosmograms of the universe and pantheon that were used for many purposes in esoteric Buddhist practice. During the mid-Heian period, emperors

and high-ranking courtiers, enticed by the possibility of having transformative mandalic energies at their disposal, frequently sponsored the Five Altar Rite for eliminating epidemics, subjugating disease agents, treating disease, extending life, and safe childbirth.<sup>29</sup>

Scholars have often associated the Five Altar Rite in this period with the rivals of the Jimon lineage, the Sanmon branch, and for good reason. In the thirteenth-century *Notes on A, Sa, and Ba* (*Asabashō* 阿娑縛抄), Shōchō 承澄 (1205–1282), a Sanmon monk, gives two first historical instances of the rite, both of which point to the Sanmon branch. One record notes that the first performance took place in 940 at Hosshōji, a temple under the authority of Sanmon monks, who used it as a springboard of promotion to the abbacy of the Tendai school. The Five Altar Rite was used on that occasion for military purposes, to subjugate uprisings in the “east and west.”<sup>30</sup> A different record of the Tendai school indicates that the rite was performed by the Sanmon monks Son’i, then abbot of Tendai, and his successor Gikai 義海 (871–946).<sup>31</sup> An alternative account in the *Notes on A, Sa, and Ba* indicates that the first performance took place in 961 on Mt. Hiei, when it was led by the monk Gikei 喜慶 (dates unknown). The account notes that Gikei conducted the altar dedicated to Fudō, which, as the central altar in the configuration of the Five Wisdom Kings, was always seen to be the most important and thus typically managed by the highest-ranking monk involved.<sup>32</sup>

Not long after these initial performances, the Five Altar Rite was used to treat the illnesses of sovereigns. The first known performance for this purpose took place in 967. The top Sanmon monks performed the rite for Emperor Reizei 冷泉天皇 (950–1011), who was overwhelmed with madness. It was performed again by Sanmon monks in 981, this time to treat the illness of Emperor En’yū 円融天皇 (959–991).<sup>33</sup> In both cases, the central and most important altar was managed by Ryōgen 良源 (912–985), the towering abbot of the Tendai school known for restoring Enryakuji in a number of ways, including by leading the reconstruction of the temple complex after a devastating fire in 966. Ryōgen was also remembered for his conflicts with the Jimon lineage.

Neither Ryōgen nor the Sanmon branch monopolized the Five Altar Rite. Jimon monks also performed it and related rituals dedicated to Fudō. Jimon monks would have traced their ties to Fudō back to Enchin. They would have known well that their patriarch was visited by a gold manifestation of Fudō while meditating in a rock cave in 838, and that Enchin ordered artisans to craft his vision into an icon.<sup>34</sup> Later, Fudō protected his boat when he traveled to China and on another occasion miraculously appeared at Enchin’s pillow when the monk was lying sick in bed, reflecting the god’s therapeutic presence.<sup>35</sup> Enchin’s tutelary Fudō became the basis for the famous painting of “Yellow Fudō,” which was probably commissioned by Enchin in 891 and has survived at

Onjōji.<sup>36</sup> Another legend, likely dating to the twelfth century, tells how Enchin transformed his own body into the Yellow Fudō to heal the regent Fujiwara no Mototsune 藤原基経 (836–891), then a child suffering from malarial fever (*gyakubyō* 瘧病).<sup>37</sup>

One early example of a Jimon monk using the Five Altar Rite is Yokei. In fact, Yokei likely participated in the Five Altar Rite performed by Ryōgen in 981 for treating Emperor En'yū, when he may have managed the northern altar dedicated to Kongō Yasha.<sup>38</sup> The timing of this event is significant. As noted, it was also in 981 that Yokei was appointed abbot of Hosshōji, the decisive event that occasioned the split between the Sanmon and Jimon branches. Yokei was thus often remembered as Ryōgen's direct rival. Although he did not manage the central altar in the Five Altar Rite for Emperor En'yū, later stories recalled his pivotal role performing this ritual for the emperor's treatment.<sup>39</sup> For example, in one story in *Tales of Times Now Past* (*Konjaku monogatari shū* 今昔物語集), Yokei is one of two named monks who conducts the ritual for the ailing Emperor En'yū. The story contrasts the Five Altar Rite conducted by Yokei and four other monks with a separate ritual performed by a lone monk, who is eventually exposed as worshipping *tengu* 天狗, mountain-dwelling goblins or spirits who often figure in Buddhist tales of the early medieval period as mischievous disrupters of authentic Buddhist practice.<sup>40</sup> The contrast conveys the impression that Yokei was associated with the orthodox practice of the Five Altar Rite. Historically speaking, that Yokei would have performed the rite with some frequency is also substantiated by the existence of the Hall of the Five Wisdom Kings at Daiunji, the temple to which Yokei led hundreds of monks after leaving Mt. Hiei.<sup>41</sup>

Historical sources demonstrate that Yokei was also frequently employed by emperors to subjugate disease through the single-altar version of the rite dedicated to Fudō.<sup>42</sup> For example, Yokei was summoned to the imperial palace to perform the Fudō subjugation rite for ailing emperors at least twice in 982 and once in 985. On two of those occasions, he performed the rite at the Jijūden 仁寿殿, a building in the imperial palace that was designated specifically for Buddhist rituals and other ceremonies to be performed on behalf of the emperor.<sup>43</sup>

It is thus not surprising that authors of tales compiled over later centuries described Yokei as having intimate connections with Fudō, including the idea that he could use ritual techniques to ontologically merge with and become identical to Fudō, recalling the core esoteric notion that monks "become buddhas" during ritual performances. One story tells of how Yokei comes to the aid of Kūya 空也 (903–972), a wandering ascetic, who finds himself in need of emergency treatment for an arm injury. One version notes that while Yokei performed a magical chiropractic technique on Kūya, black smoke streamed out from his head, suggesting that the ritual magic is working so well that he is

on the verge of bursting into flames.<sup>44</sup> The image of a smoking ritualist, which became a trope in tales about ritually powerful Buddhist monks, plays on the conventional image of Fudō, a wrathful deity who is almost invariably depicted as engulfed in a mandorla of flames over which he exerts ritual control. Sure enough, another version of the story describes Yokei's therapy as "the medicine of the Wisdom King for the illness of Mida," identifying the patient Kūya with Amida Nyorai and the healer Yokei with Fudō.<sup>45</sup> In a related story, a *tengu* from China who wants to challenge eminent monks in Japan encounters Yokei on a mountain path from the Thousand Arm Hall. Readers learn the arrogant *tengu* runs and hides when he sees that Yokei, his first challenger, is immersed in a blanket of flames that burn high above his palanquin.<sup>46</sup> This imaginary blurring of Yokei with Fudō was no doubt a consequence of his memorable performances of rites to Fudō and the Five Wisdom Kings during his lifetime.

After Yokei, Shin'yo, one of Kanju's disciples, took up the mantle of the Five Altar Rite. In one especially dynamic example, he participated in the rite to combat an epidemic in 1012. As usual, the rite was performed by five monks; in this case, all were close in age but hailed from different monastic lineages: Saishin 済信 (954–1030) performed the rite at the center of Heiankyō at the Shingon'in 真言院 (which had a privileged location in the imperial palace); Ningai 仁海 (951–1046) at Tōji at the southern gate of the city; Seiten (alt. Jōten) 成典 (958–1044) at Ninnaji in the northwest of the city; and Ingen 院源 (951–1028) at Enryakuji atop Mt. Hiei in the northeast. Shin'yo performed the rite at his home base of Onjōji in the neighboring Ōmi province to the east.<sup>47</sup>

What this example reveals is how the mandalic, spatial dimension of the Five Altar Rite had implications for its specific therapeutic application in mid-Heian Japan. As Elizabeth ten Grotenhuis and Pamela Winfield have pointed out, esoteric Buddhist mandalas were modeled after the design of capital cities in medieval China that, centered around emperors divinely appointed by heaven, functioned as cosmograms in their own right.<sup>48</sup> Because the design of Chinese capitals such as Chang'an 長安 served as templates for the capitals of Heijōkyō 平城京 (Nara) and Heiankyō in Japan, it was perhaps inevitable that geopolitical spaces in Japan came to be inscribed with mandalic significance as well. For this reason, the Five Altar Rite, invoking the mandalic imagination of an integrated and spiritually charged physical space, came to be used against the species of pathogenic phenomenon that tended to cover broad spaces in short spans of time: epidemics. Just as emperors routinely stationed monks at different sites around the physical space of the capital and had them recite sutras in times of epidemics to protect the city's inhabitants, so did emperors order esoteric monks to perform the Five Altar Rite against widespread disease outbreaks.<sup>49</sup>

At the same time, mandalas are arranged as spatial hierarchies. In the Five Altar Rite, Fudō occupies the central and most important position, reflecting

his identity as the wrathful incarnation body of Dainichi Nyorai 大日如来 (Skt. Mahāvairocana), the cosmic buddha who preaches the esoteric sutras. Thus Shin'yo arguably occupied a less privileged position in the ritual configuration. However, Shin'yo would build his reputation for wisdom king rites and ascend the mandalic hierarchy through impressive performances. In 1012, accompanied by another Jimon monk, Monkō 文慶 (966–1046), Shin'yo performed the rite at Hosshōji for seven consecutive days.<sup>50</sup> In 1016, he performed a Fudō ritual in the imperial palace, which may have been the Five Altar Rite, considering that he was accompanied by fifteen attendant monks.<sup>51</sup> In 1022, when Emperor Go-Ichijō 後一条天皇 (1008–1036) was ill, Shin'yo performed a Fudō rite in the palace library.<sup>52</sup> By 1026, Shin'yo developed a reputation for his tireless and unusual performance of the Five Altar Rite. In the fifth month of that year, four Jimon monks led by Shin'yo, along with one Sanmon monk, were summoned to perform the Five Altar Rite for the ailing Emperor Go-Ichijō—the very ritual that, performed on the occasion of his birth, brought him safely into the world some eighteen years before.<sup>53</sup> The record on the later event in 1026 makes a point of noting that even after the four other monks had finished the concluding vow, thus formally marking the ceremony's close, Shin'yo did not put down his proverbial *vajra* and stop the ritual but kept going. In his diary entry about this event, Fujiwara no Sanesuke 実資 (957–1046) wonders why: “Was Shin'yo on the central altar? Was his efficacy (*gentoku* 験徳) different from the others?”<sup>54</sup> Sanesuke's suspicions were confirmed several days later when the following message arrived from Emperor Go-Ichijō: “High Bishop Shin'yo was efficacious during the rites for the emperor's illness. Therefore, he orders you [Sanesuke] to bestow upon Shin'yo seventy households.”<sup>55</sup> This handsome reward matches the palpable efficacy Shin'yo was seen bringing to the Five Altar Rite, a direct consequence of his unusual efforts.

Besides these performances for emperors, Shin'yo also used the Five Altar Rite to strengthen his connections with Michinaga, the most powerful patron of his time. Michinaga had likely heard about Shin'yo's ritual reputation. He had the chance to witness the power of Shin'yo's ritual magic up close in 1012, when Shin'yo performed empowerment for the Grand Empress, Michinaga's oldest daughter, Shōshi 彰子 (988–1074), who was then tormented by a toothache caused by swelling. When Shōshi healed almost instantaneously from Shin'yo's rite, Michinaga remarked, “The efficacy (*gentoku*) was incredible. I've never seen anything like it!”<sup>56</sup>

Michinaga soon called on Shin'yo's expertise with the Five Altar Rite to help him with his own pathological concerns and those of his other children. In 1006, Michinaga had rebuilt the Hall of the Five Wisdom Kings at Hosshōji. The hall came to possess two interrelated functions: It was a site for Michinaga's periodic reclusions and a venue for the performance of the Five Altar Rite.

Michinaga made sure Jimon monks played important roles at this hall from its founding. For example, Kanju, Shin'yo's teacher, was one of five monks who performed the "eye-opening ceremony" (*kaigen kuyō* 開眼供養) for the icons of the Five Wisdom Kings when the reconstruction was completed.<sup>57</sup> The icon of Fudō that was originally one of the Five Wisdom Kings installed at Michinaga's hall—whose eyes were opened by Kanju—still survives to this day.<sup>58</sup>

It is perhaps no coincidence that a nearly identical icon of Fudō dating to the same decade has survived at Onjōji (see figure 1). Completed in 1014, the icon was the project of Ryōkai 良海 (dates unknown), son of Fujiwara no Kintō 藤原公任 (966–1041) and brother to two monks who belonged to Onjōji. He was closely linked to Michinaga through his younger sister, who was married to Michinaga's second son, Fujiwara no Norimichi 藤原教通 (996–1075).<sup>59</sup>

It is not surprising that Jimon monks were called back to Hosshōji to perform rituals in front of Fudō and the other wisdom kings. In 1018, Shin'yo led a Five Altar Rite at the hall when Michinaga, suffering from chest illness, developed an intense fever.<sup>60</sup> Indeed, just a few days before, after Michinaga had isolated himself in the hall, he invited Shin'yo to perform rituals to improve his karmic merit.<sup>61</sup> Again in 1020, when Michinaga's son Yorimichi was ill, he summoned Shin'yo to perform the Five Altar Rite in the same venue. Shin'yo

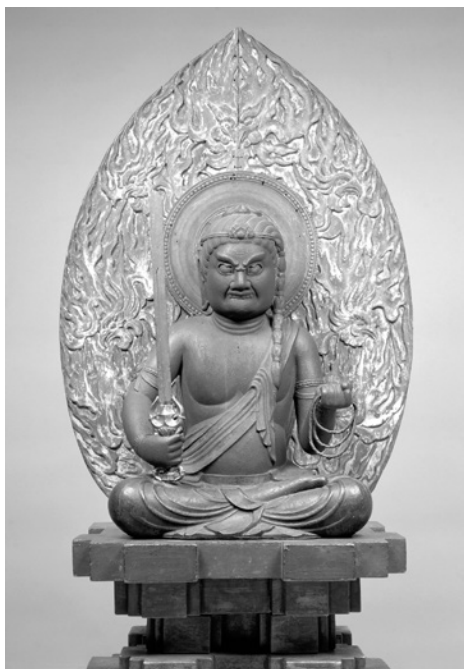


Figure 1. Fudō Myōō. 1014. By Jōchū 盛忠 (dates unknown). Transmitted at Kangakuin 勧学院, Onjōji. Nara National Museum. Courtesy of Miidera and Fuke Shungen.

performed the rite with Myōson 明尊 (971–1063), another Jimon monk and a student of Kanju, and they were successful, for as the diary entry indicates, the spirits were “subjugated of themselves.”<sup>62</sup>

Jimon monks also designed new therapeutic rituals focused on Fudō. As we will see in later chapters, Fudō was assigned a major role in the Ritual for Expelling Demons that Jimon monks crafted in the late twelfth century, even as that rite was nominally and performatively centered around a different and lesser-known wrathful deity, Shōmen Kongō. Around the same time, Jimon monks also drew on continental scriptures focused on Fudō to create another new ritual, “Expelling the Great Death Ritual” (Jo daishi hō 除大死法).<sup>63</sup> Numerous references to the ritual are found in the *Record of Treasured Secrets*, Keihan’s compilation of the teachings of his master, Shin’en 真円 (1116–1204).<sup>64</sup> The Expelling the Great Death Ritual was aimed at quelling epidemics of contagious diseases that threatened to bring about “the calamity of mass death” (*daishi-nan* 大死難), recalling the use of the Five Altar Rite against epidemics.

## ARMS AND EYES FOR EVERY EVIL: SENJU KANNON

While in his *Notes on A, Sa, and Ba* Shōchō linked the Five Altar Rite with the Sanmon branch, he was under the impression that one key altar rite more closely related to the Jimon branch: the rite to Senju Kannon 千手觀音, an esoteric manifestation of the bodhisattva Kannon (Skt. Avalokiteśvara) with “a thousand arms” (*senju*).<sup>65</sup> Although we know rites to Senju Kannon were performed by monks of all lineages, Shōchō’s perception is telling. He wrote, “The Senju Rite is venerable. It was transmitted by both Jikaku (Ennin) and Chishō (Enchin), but Miidera keeps it as an utmost secret.”<sup>66</sup> This observation suggests that Senju Kannon was important in the Tendai school since its early days, going back to both Ennin and Enchin. His comment also reveals the perception that, at least by his day in the early Kamakura period, Senju Kannon and the esoteric ritual dedicated to this bodhisattva was closely associated with the followers of Enchin, the Jimon lineage at Miidera (Onjōji). As I demonstrate here, Jimon monks turned to the divine powers of this thousand-armed bodhisattva to enhance the therapeutic services they offered to courtiers, emperors, and empresses, thereby crafting a unique ritual signature in the eyes of elite patrons and their monastic peers.

As with many esoteric deities, Senju Kannon was already worshipped during the Nara period. Esoteric sutras devoted to Senju Kannon not only made their way to the archipelago at this time but also received substantial attention from major monks and the sovereigns who backed them.<sup>67</sup> In 741, Genbō 玄昉 (d. 746), a scholar-priest of the Hossō 法相 school who had imported some five thousand Buddhist texts to Japan from China in 734, saw to the production of

a thousand copies of Senju Kannon's key scripture, the *Thousand Arm Sutra*.<sup>68</sup> Genbō's large-scale transcription project was meant to return the favor Emperor Shōmu 聖武天皇 (701–756) bestowed on him in 739, the transcription of a different esoteric sutra, which was intended to treat the priest of an illness he suffered.<sup>69</sup> In 755, Queen Consort Kōmyō 光明皇后 (701–760) ordered the construction of a large sculpture of Senju Kannon for the Lecture Hall at Tōdaiji.<sup>70</sup> In 758, Jikun 慈訓 (691–777), who was one of Shōmu's personal healers, led a large-scale sutra transcription to pray for the recovery of the ailing Kōmyō, for which one thousand copies of the *Thousand Arm Sutra* were made.<sup>71</sup>

Belief in Senju Kannon's healing powers may have also spread on a more popular level, as several Buddhist didactic tales (*setsuwa* 説話) from the early Heian period suggest. One tale from the ninth-century collection *Nihon kan-reiroku* 日本感靈録 describes a blind novice whose eyesight is miraculously restored after he diligently praises Senju Kannon and recites his *dhāraṇī* while on pilgrimage at Tsubosakadera 壺阪寺.<sup>72</sup> Another tale in a roughly contemporaneous collection, the *Record of Miraculous Events in Japan* (*Nihon ryōiki* 日本靈異記), tells again of a blind man's restored vision, this time after the man contemplates one of Senju Kannon's thousand arms, the one holding the light-emitting "sun jewel" (*nichimanishu* 日摩尼手).<sup>73</sup>

In the Tendai school, worship of Senju Kannon began on Mt. Hiei with the founder of the school and its head temple, Enryakuji. Saichō is said to have carved his own icon of Senju Kannon, measuring five *shaku* 尺 (approximately 152 centimeters) in height.<sup>74</sup> Saichō's purported icon (no longer extant) may have served as the basis for a second Senju Kannon icon crafted at Enryakuji, also measuring five *shaku*. This icon, which is identified as a statue that survives today at Enryakuji and is designated as a National Treasure, dates to Saichō's time in the late eighth century.<sup>75</sup> Historical records indicate that this icon came to be installed at the Thousand Arm Hall, also known as the Sannōin, one of the halls Saichō established in the Nishidani area of Mt. Hiei.<sup>76</sup>

Location may have played a role in the establishment of the hall and selection of its deity. Scholars have linked the worship of Senju Kannon in the early Heian period to natural water sources, the most famous case being Kiyomizudera 清水寺, the "Pure Water Temple."<sup>77</sup> Likewise, not far from the Thousand Arm Hall on Mt. Hiei, one finds a natural spring, which served historically as a well from which monks drew water to be offered to the temple's many deities. According to the *Records of Onjōji* (*Onjōji denki* 園城寺伝記, ca. after 1343), the discovery of this well goes back to Enchin. During a pilgrimage to the mountains of Kumano 熊野, Enchin encountered a deity who entrusted him with a servant named Water Youth. When Enchin returned to Mt. Hiei, he had the youth use a *vajra*, the metal instrument monks employ during esoteric rites, to dig a well.<sup>78</sup> The story links the unearthing of the site's



natural water source, and by extension Senju Kannon, with the patriarch of the Jimon lineage.

As the legend suggests, the Thousand Arm Hall became the abode of Enchin. As a result, it also became the home base for the Jimon community on Mt. Hiei.<sup>79</sup> As noted already, the building was also known as the “Tang Hall” (Tōin) because it housed the sacred writings Enchin brought back from China. After the split between the Sanmon and Jimon branches and the evacuation of Jimon monks from Mt. Hiei in the tenth century, Enchin’s Tōin and its library were reestablished at Onjōji. As we might expect, the monks also brought the cult of Senju Kannon with them.

A perusal of the sacred works in the Tōin library demonstrates that Enchin showed great interest in the bodhisattva with whom he lived on Mt. Hiei. One of his catalogs of imported works (*shōrai mokuroku* 請來目) mentions at least three scriptures about this bodhisattva: *Ritual Recitations of the Thousand-Armed, Thousand-Eyed [Avalokiteśvara] from the Diamond Pinnacle Yoga [Scripture]* (*Jin’gangding youjia Qianshou qianyan niansong fa* 金剛頂瑜伽千手千眼念誦法), *Dhāraṇī of the Great Compassionate Thousand-Armed, Thousand-Eyed Avalokiteśvara* (*Qianshou qianyan Guanzizai dabeixin tuoluoni* 千手千眼觀自在大悲心陀羅尼), and *Scripture of the Dhāraṇī Spells of the Thousand-Eyed, Thousand-Armed Guanshiyin Bodhisattva* (*Qianyan qianbi Guanshiyin pusa tuoluoni shenshou jing* 千眼千臂觀世音菩薩陀羅尼神呪經下卷, lower volume).<sup>80</sup> Enchin also wrote the *Secret Record of the Thousand Arm Sutra* (*Senju kyō jutsu hiki* 千手經述秘記), a brief commentary on what became the most popular Senju Kannon scripture in Japan, the *Thousand Arm Sutra* (*Senjukyō* 千手經), the full title of which was *Sutra on the Dhāraṇī of the Vast, Complete, and Unobstructed Great Compassion of the Bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara with a Thousand Arms and a Thousand Eyes* (*Qianshou qianyan Guanshiyin pusa guangda yuanman wuai dabeixin tuoluoni jing* 千手千眼觀世音菩薩廣大圓滿無礙大悲心陀羅尼經, T 1060).<sup>81</sup> Onjōji records also describe how Enchin received from Faquan 法全 (fl. 800–870), one of his teachers in esotericism in Chang’an, “mudras and spells of the thousand eyes and thousand arms.”<sup>82</sup> In this way, Enchin’s relationship with the esoteric bodhisattva spanned geographic, domestic, ritual, and doctrinal dimensions.

After Enchin’s time, Senju Kannon remained important in the budding Jimon lineage. A second early icon, dating to the latter half of the ninth or first half of the tenth century, attests to this fact (see figure 2). Now preserved at Onjōji, the icon is said to have originally come from Nyoiji 如意寺, where it presided over the temple as its chief deity. One legend holds that Nyoiji was founded by no less than Enchin himself. Another attributes the founding to Yokei, who reached an agreement with the mountain deity to share the land.<sup>83</sup> The earliest historical record for the temple dates to 983, when Yokei was active,

but that record only describes a memorial rite held there for Taira no Tokimochi 平時望 (877–938), a prominent member of the Taira 平 clan. The record demonstrates that Nyoiji began as a clan temple for the Taira, but links with the Jimon lineage began to form during the late Heian period, if not earlier, owing perhaps initially to reasons of geographic proximity. Nyoiji was located on a mountain pass known as Nyoigoe 如意越え that connects Ōmi, where Onjōji was located, to Higashiyama, the eastern side of Heiankyō. When Jimon monks relocated their base from Enryakuji to Onjōji in the late tenth century, they increasingly commuted to the court by way of the Nyoigoe road, a convenient passage into the city.<sup>84</sup> These commutes undoubtedly became more common as patronage from courtiers grew in this period, one consequence of the healing services Jimon monks offered. In turn, courtiers traveled to Onjōji on occasion to receive ritual services directly at the temple.<sup>85</sup>

Over time, Onjōji fully absorbed Nyoiji into its administrative fold as an official branch temple, a process that was complete by the time of Keihan and his disciple En'i 円意 (1172–1252) in the early Kamakura period. Tachi Ryūshi speculates that Nyoiji was even used as a substitute venue when various halls at Onjōji were burned down by Enryakuji monks in 1214. In 1217, Keihan, a descendant of the Taira clan, the son of Taira no Chikanori 平親範 (1137–1220),



Figure 2. Senju Kannon. Late ninth or early tenth century. Transmitted at Nyoiji, Onjōji. Courtesy of Miidera and Fuke Shungen.

performed consecration (*kanjō* 灌頂) rites at Nyoiji, likely under the protective gaze of the chief deity, Senju Kannon. Thus, as Onjōji absorbed Nyoiji, it also absorbed its central icon, a bodhisattva with which Jimon lineage monks were already familiar.

In earlier centuries, the first Jimon monk after Enchin to build a notable track record for performing healing rituals dedicated to Senju Kannon was Kanju. Extant records place the beginnings of this association in the eighth month of 999, when Senior Grand Empress Shōshi became ill. Kanju was summoned to perform empowerment for her.<sup>86</sup> In the eleventh month of the same year—just two days after Jimon monk Shōsan performed the “possession rite” for her—Kanju carried out a ritual addressed to Senju Kannon.<sup>87</sup> It is not surprising that Shōshi turned to Jimon monks for healing, nor that the ritual Kanju performed would have involved Senju Kannon. After all, in 985 Shōshi had established Kannon’in, a hall dedicated to the bodhisattva, built on the grounds of Daiunji. As noted earlier, Shōshi’s Kannon’in was where Yokei resided, along with “hundreds” of other Jimon monks, following the community’s migration from Mt. Hiei. The Kannon’in enshrined icons of the Six Kannon (Roku Kannon 六観音), a set of six incarnations of the bodhisattva, which often included Senju Kannon.<sup>88</sup>

The Senju Kannon ritual for healing soon helped Kanju soar to the heights of official clerical positions. Just four months after performing the Senju Kannon rite for Shōshi, in the third month of 1000, Kanju performed the rite for Fujiwara no Senshi. As the daughter of Kaneie, an older sister of Michinaga, and mother to Emperor Ichijō, Senshi was a person of far-reaching political influence.<sup>89</sup> Three days after performing the Senju Kannon rite for Senshi’s treatment, Kanju was promoted from the position of supernumerary archbishop (*gon no sōjō* 権僧正) to archbishop (*sōjō* 僧正).<sup>90</sup> An additional promotion graced him in the next month, when he became chief administrator (*hōmu* 法務), a post that was typically occupied by the presiding archbishop.<sup>91</sup> In a record made on the day these promotions were celebrated, the diarist Yukinari—a patient of Kanju, as we saw at the start of the chapter—notes that Kanju was compensated with nearly one thousand kilos of rice for the ritual he performed to treat Senshi.<sup>92</sup> By the early months of 1000, Kanju had become one of the most powerful monks in his time, an achievement that owed much to his performance of the Senju Kannon ritual for healing. These rituals also strengthened his bond with Senshi. After the tumultuous split of the Jimon and Sanmon branches, Kanju and thirty other Jimon monks set up shop anew at Gedatsuji, a monastery originally established by Senshi as a nation-protecting temple.<sup>93</sup> After he was promoted to grand archbishop (*daisōjō* 大僧正) in 1002, Kanju was chosen to lead the consecration ceremony for a new hall there. To the extent that Jimon monks boosted the lives of their patrons, therefore, they became more intertwined in their patrons’ lives,

thus expanding their own influence and authority and safeguarding themselves from threats from competing monastic lineages.

## GO-SHIRAKAWA: JIMON HEALING FOR A DEVOUT PATIENT

Jimon monks continued to perform rituals for Senju Kannon for healing purposes during the Era of Abdicated Sovereigns, as we discuss in more detail in chapter 3. Here I consider important developments that took place in the mid- to late twelfth century, the period that roughly overlaps with the Jimon creation of the Ritual for Expelling Demons in the 1170s. Evidence of Senju Kannon-oriented therapy in this period appears, for example, in the *Record of Treasured Secrets*, compiled by Keihan. Keihan notes the example of Gyōkei 行慶 (1101–1165), one of the disciples of the monk Gyōson 行尊 (1055–1135). On one occasion, Gyōkei performed a Senju Kannon ritual for Emperor Toba 鳥羽天皇 (1103–1156), which proved to be efficacious in a memorable way: His illness was cured in precisely seven days.<sup>94</sup> Owing no doubt to therapeutic feats like this, Gyōkei was appointed as protector monk for Emperor Konoe 近衛天皇 (1139–1155) and eventually promoted to abbot of Onjōji.

Surviving evidence from this period shows that Jimon monks possessed textual resources to support such rituals to Senju Kannon. This is confirmed by one extant manuscript of the *Sutra on Mixing Medicines and Healing Illness by the Thousand-Armed, Thousand-Eyed Avalokiteśvara* (*Qianshou qianyan guanshiyin pusa zhibing heyao jing* 千手千眼觀世音菩薩治病合藥經, ca. 650–660).<sup>95</sup> As the title suggests, the sutra is focused squarely on therapeutic themes. Intriguingly, the manuscript was preserved in the Kissuizō 吉水藏 library of Shōren'in 青蓮院. Although Shōren'in was managed by Sanmon monks, most notably its third abbot, Jien 慈円 (1155–1225), this particular manuscript contains a colophon, dating to 1132, indicating that it belonged to a monk of Miidera, that is, Onjōji.<sup>96</sup> Thus, even Sanmon monks looking to study the therapeutic powers of Senju Kannon drew on the resources gathered by Jimon monks. As discussed later, the *Sutra on Mixing Medicines and Healing Illness by the Thousand-Armed, Thousand-Eyed Avalokiteśvara* became a key text for the Ritual for Expelling Demons manuscripts.

To examine how the Jimon cult of Senju Kannon strengthened ties with powerful patrons, I turn to a particular case, that of Retired Emperor Go-Shirakawa 後白河 (1129–1192). The links between Go-Shirakawa, monks of the Jimon lineage, and the healing services these monks provided through the ritual mediation of Senju Kannon are complex and deserve close study. The starting point in tracing these links is the year 1164, when Go-Shirakawa completed what was undoubtedly the most monumental display of devotion to Senju Kannon

in his era: building the temple hall Rengeōin 蓮華王院, better known today as Sanjūsangendō 三十三間堂. With financial backing from Taira no Kiyomori 平清盛 (1118–1181), Go-Shirakawa constructed Rengeōin on the grounds of his palace as cloistered emperor, Hōjūjidono 法住寺殿.<sup>97</sup> The name of the hall, Rengeōin, or “Lotus Flower King,” was taken from one appellation for Senju Kannon.<sup>98</sup> As with the Thousand Arm Hall on Mt. Hiei, Senju Kannon was enshrined as the chief deity of Rengeōin. In the hall, Go-Shirakawa installed no fewer than one thousand statues of the bodhisattva, all of which were carved to be “life-sized” (*tōshin* 等身).<sup>99</sup>

Why was Go-Shirakawa willing to spare no expense in this incredible display of devotion to Senju Kannon? In a foundational essay on Buddhist icons, Mimi Yiengpruksawan suggests that Go-Shirakawa’s Rengeōin ought to be seen alongside several projects led by powerful figures in the late Heian period that shared the same purpose: weaponizing Buddhist icons against disease epidemics.<sup>100</sup> Indeed, as Yiengpruksawan points out, an epidemic of *akamogasa* or “red pox” (often understood by medical historians to be measles) spread across the realm in 1163, the year before Rengeōin’s completion.<sup>101</sup> This timing—especially when considered with many similar examples of aristocrats and emperors commissioning icons during times of epidemics and disease in the late Heian period—strongly suggests that Go-Shirakawa sought to counter malign and multitudinous pathological forces through his excessive reproduction of Senju Kannon icons at Rengeōin.

If countering epidemics was one of Go-Shirakawa’s goals, the same might have been true for Shōsenjudō 小千手堂, the “Small Thousand Arm Hall,” another building Go-Shirakawa constructed on the grounds of his palace Hōjūjidono. Shōsenjudō’s construction, which took place in the fourth month of 1176, was consecrated with a recitation of the *Thousand Arm Sutra*, another Senju Kannon scripture imported by Enchin that, as we shall see, was heavily preoccupied with countering pathological forces.<sup>102</sup> The consecration ceremony was likely led by Jimon monk Kenkaku 賢覚 (d. 1178).<sup>103</sup> Like Rengeōin, the Shōsenjudō was said to house icons of the Twenty-Eight Attendants (Nijūhachibushū 二十八部集) and one thousand statues of Senju Kannon. As the name of the hall hints, these icons may have been miniature compared with the full-body statues enshrined in Rengeōin. Indeed, one source describes the central icon of the hall as three *shaku* (roughly 90 centimeters).<sup>104</sup> Differences in scale aside, the purpose for their creation appears to have been the same. Like Rengeōin, the construction of Shōsenjudō in 1176 was preceded by an epidemic in the previous year.<sup>105</sup> Go-Shirakawa thus built at least two halls enshrining a thousand icons of Senju Kannon, and we can cautiously conclude in both cases that these projects were at least partly aimed at combating disease epidemics, destructive forces he would have seen as a threat to his sovereignty and the realm.

Go-Shirakawa's perception of Senju Kannon's distinctive efficacy against plagues was rooted in a broader imagination of epidemics as an unsettling game of numbers. In the discussion on the mandalic configuration of the Five Wisdom Kings against epidemics, I noted the perception of epidemics as a singular phenomenon, with one outbreak defined by its wide stretch across a defined space. In Heian Japan, epidemics were also seen in terms of a multiplicity of pathogenic agents: the epidemic as a swarm of pathogens. According to one old image in Japan, epidemic deities (*ekishin* 疫神) were imagined to ride on flower blossoms in the spring, the season for new growth, including noxious and pestilential influences that spawned epidemics. These flower-riding plague deities were broadcast by the wind, it was thought, thereby spreading epidemics through the archipelago.<sup>106</sup> In another image, operative since at least the Nara period, plague deities were imagined to travel through the islands at great speeds atop horses, a cultic development linked closely to the influx of beliefs surrounding horse-riding deities brought to Japan by immigrants from the Korean peninsula.<sup>107</sup>

What continued to be unsettling about epidemics for those in early medieval Japan was how the legion of pathogenic agents could be everywhere at once and yet nowhere to be seen, and how there exists at least one pathogenic demon for every potential human victim. To fight the menacing combination of spectrality and multiplicity that epidemics embodied, few deities could be imagined as surpassing Senju Kannon. After all, the bodhisattva not only had one thousand arms but—as a quick glance at the bodhisattva's sutras reveals—all one thousand hands were imagined to contain an eyeball and hold a ritual implement. Many of those implements were weapons (dharma wheels, jeweled swords, axes, bows, arrows, *vajras*, lassos) or objects of intimidation (skulls, bells, mirrors, fly whisks). Thus, Senju Kannon was imagined as somatically equipped with two interrelated powers: The bodhisattva was both able to see the myriad of invisible threats, with his thousand eyes, and repel them through martial counterforce.<sup>108</sup> Although Senju Kannon's thousand arms and eyes represent a hyperbolic imagination of salvific power, these features offered believers like Go-Shirakawa a powerful image of perfect immunological alignment against the inherently hyperbolic threat of disease spectrality and multiplicity represented by demon-driven epidemics.

The perception that Senju Kannon was the right deity for the extraordinary task of pacifying epidemics was fostered by esoteric scriptures imported into Japan, some of which became the basis for ritual practices that emerged during Go-Shirakawa's time and before. A focus on epidemics is evident, for example, in the *Thousand Arm Sutra*, the scripture Gyōkei recited to treat Toba, which was also recited when Kenkaku officiated the consecration of Go-Shirakawa's Shōsenjudō. A key passage reads, "When evil dragons and epidemic deities

circulate poisonous *qi* and fever-disease threatens to bring one's life to an end, concentrate on reciting the Great Compassion spell and you will eliminate epidemic diseases and extend your lifespan."<sup>109</sup> The elimination of epidemics is mentioned as a boon of worshipping Senju Kannon in other scriptures as well, including the *Scripture of the Dhāraṇī Spells of the Thousand-Eyed, Thousand-Armed Guanshiyin Bodhisattva*, imported to Japan by Enchin.<sup>110</sup>

Another scripture popular in this period that outlined Kannon's capabilities against epidemics was the *Sutra on the Dhāraṇī for Summoning the Bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara to Eradicate Toxic Harms* (*Qing Guanshiyin pusa xiaofu duhai tuolunizhou jing* 請觀世音菩薩消伏毒害陀羅尼呪經). It tells the miraculous story of a village saved by an epidemic when the villagers offer to Kannon a "willow twig and pure water." Early in the twelfth century, this scripture was chanted at least twice for treating the illness of Emperor Horikawa 堀河 (1079–1107), whose treatment I consider in more detail in chapter 3. Thereafter, the scripture became the liturgy for an esoteric fire ceremony (*goma*) against epidemics. The earliest performance of this rite for that purpose can be traced back to 1156.<sup>111</sup> Moreover, according to Hayami Tasuku, this "Willow Kannon Rite" became the basis for the Willow Branch Empowerment (Yanagi no O-kaji 柳のお加持), a ceremony still performed at Sanjūsangendō (Rengeōin) today on the fifteenth day of the first month of the new year to ward off illnesses, especially headaches.

The history of the Willow Kannon Rite in the twelfth century is typically associated with the Anō lineage, which belonged to the Sanmon branch. Jimon monks of the period were also aware of this scripture and its ritual uses. In fact, according to one teaching passed down in the Shingon lineage at Anshōji 安祥寺, the Willow Kannon Rite was originally imported to Japan by Enchin.<sup>112</sup> At Onjōji, Jimon monks may have associated the ritual most closely with a different scripture, namely, the *Secret Ritual Sutra of Avalokiteśvara Bodhisattva with a Thousand Glowing Eyes* (*Qianguangyan Guanzizai pusa mimi fa jing* 千光眼觀自在菩薩秘密法經, T 1065).

Jimon monks discerned important links between Willow Kannon and Senju Kannon. Indeed, in the *Secret Ritual Sutra of Avalokiteśvara Bodhisattva with a Thousand Glowing Eyes* they adopted, the Willow Kannon, who appears as "Medicine King, Observer Without Obstructions" (Yakuō Kanjizai 藥王觀自在), is an incarnation of a particular hand of Senju Kannon, namely, the one holding a willow twig. The section pertaining to this incarnation directly concerns illness: "If you wish to rid your body of any kind of illness, you must perform the Willow Branch Medicine Ritual."<sup>113</sup> In the *Record of Treasured Secrets*, the Jimon monk Keihan, a contemporary of Go-Shirakawa, transcribed a note from his master Shin'en about the "small spell of Senju," which derives from the same scripture.<sup>114</sup> Later in the text, Keihan quotes his master's mention of the "mantra of the willow hand of Senju" in the context of a question about

spells for treating “stone dripping illness” (*sekirinbyō* 石淋病).<sup>115</sup> In these ways, Jimon monks not only transmitted knowledge about the Willow Kannon Rite but also explicitly connected this particular epidemic-quelling incarnation of the bodhisattva to Senju Kannon. Thus, healing rites performed at Rengeōin, whether directed to Willow Kannon or Senju Kannon, may well have been shaped by Jimon influence.

Indeed, Jimon monks did much to bolster the cult of Senju Kannon during the twelfth century, the effects of which Go-Shirakawa sought and experienced. They also brought the bodhisattva to Go-Shirakawa in several direct ways. For one thing, they may have been the first to educate him on the bodhisattva’s therapeutic powers. Go-Shirakawa’s earnest interest in Senju Kannon is said to have begun in 1145, when Go-Shirakawa was nineteen years old. According to an entry in *Notes on Turning the Dharma Wheel* (*Tenpōrinshō* 転法輪鈔), after Go-Shirakawa lost his mother, Taikenmon’in 待賢門院 (1101–1145), the Jimon monk Dōkaku 道覚 (dates unknown) gave him an image of Senju Kannon with the Twenty-Eight Attendants.<sup>116</sup> Dōkaku informed him that the image was the chief personal icon of Ryūmyō 隆明 (alt. Ryūmei, 1019–1104). Also an eminent Jimon monk, Ryūmyō was abbot of Onjōji (beginning in 1098) and was employed as protector monk (*gojisō*) for Shirakawa and his son Horikawa.<sup>117</sup> *Notes on Turning the Dharma Wheel* reports that henceforth, on the eighteenth day of every month (the anniversary of his mother’s death), Go-Shirakawa never failed to recite the *dhāraṇī* from the *Thousand Arm Sutra* one thousand times.<sup>118</sup>

These facts underscore the pivotal role Jimon monks played in introducing the cult of this bodhisattva to Go-Shirakawa, thus planting the seeds for his later construction of thousands of Senju Kannon statues at Rengeōin. But as we might expect, a recurring thematic linking Go-Shirakawa, the Jimon lineage, and Senju Kannon was healing. This theme, along with these links, emerges in vivid ways when we consider the twelfth-century history of another temple, Kokawadera 粉河寺, in the province of Kii (today’s Wakayama prefecture). One convincing theory among scholars holds that Go-Shirakawa was the one who commissioned the *Illustrated Origins of Kokawa Temple* (*Kokawadera engi emaki* 粉河寺縁起絵巻), a twelfth-century scroll that narrates the origins of the temple. The second half of the narrative describes the miraculous cure of the daughter of a wealthy man in the Kokawa area. According to the narrative, the daughter’s illness was chronic and resisted all treatments. One day, a young ascetic wearing a white robe appeared as if from nowhere and successfully treated her illness in only seven days; his method: the *dhāraṇī* of Senju Kannon.

This story, and the temple whose founding it narrates, links Go-Shirakawa with Jimon monks and their healing practices in several ways. In the illustrated scroll, one scene depicts the conversion of the wealthy man’s family after his daughter’s unusual cure. The family gathers around a newly carved statue of



Senju Kannon, the statue that would become the central icon of Kokawadera, crafted in appreciation for the bodhisattva's therapeutic assistance. The artist deliberately chose to depict several pieces of wood to the left of the statue from the viewer's perspective. One edition of the temple's founding legends suggests that this is wood that was left over from carving the Kokawadera Senju Kannon statue. It also indicates that the leftover wood was thereafter used to carve the central icon of the Small Thousand Arm Hall, the Shōsenjudō.

The origin narrative also contains a note indicating that the officiant monk for the consecration of the Shōsenjudō was Kenkaku. This is not surprising given that the "young ascetic" who uses the *Thousand Arm Sutra* to treat the wealthy man's daughter in the narrative closely mirrors the monk-healer type that Go-Shirakawa would have certainly associated with the Jimon lineage. As we have seen, Jimon monks used the *Thousand Arm Sutra* to treat emperors, often in very idiosyncratic and memorable ways. We might recall how, in the case of Toba, Go-Shirakawa's father, Gyōkei was said to have treated him with the *dhāraṇī* in "only seven days"—precisely the amount of time it takes the mysterious young ascetic to treat the ailing daughter in the Kokawadera narrative.

It makes sense that for Go-Shirakawa, the white-robed ascetic of the narrative would represent a Jimon monk, considering the history of the temple Kokawadera. Since at least the time of Gyōson in the early twelfth century, Kokawadera was fully under the administrative fold of the Jimon lineage. Eventually it came under the control of Shōgoin 聖護院, a branch temple of Onjōji that oversaw guided pilgrimages to the mountains of Kumano and the development of institutionalized mountain asceticism later known as Shugendō 修験道, the "way of cultivating efficacy." It is thus reasonable to speculate that the white-robed ascetic who appears in the Kokawadera narrative as a healer invoking the powers of Senju Kannon may well have been Go-Shirakawa's image of Jimon monks—the ones who first introduced him to Senju Kannon and whose reputation with ritual healing would have been well known to him.

Still other robust ties between Go-Shirakawa, the Jimon lineage, and Senju Kannon become apparent when we consider Go-Shirakawa's pilgrimages to the mountains of Kumano. Not far from Kokawadera in the Kii province, Kumano was famous for its three shrines (Hongū 本宮, Shingū 新宮, and Nachi 那智). Dedicated to local *kami*, these sites also incorporated and were surrounded by buildings to Buddhist deities. Many sites on the Kumano mountain pilgrimage were devoted to the different manifestations of Kannon, including Senju Kannon. Over the twelfth century, emperors, consorts, and aristocrats undertook pilgrimages from the Heiankyō capital to the Kumano mountains.<sup>119</sup> For his part, Go-Shirakawa took as many as thirty-four pilgrimages in the latter half of his life, making the trek at a rate of nearly once a year.

As was the case for those elite pilgrims before and after him, Go-Shirakawa was led on these trips by tour guides (*sendatsu* 先達), Buddhist monks who guided patrons through the physical terrain of the mountains and provided around-the-clock spiritual navigation, helping them make prayers, recite sutras, and interact with the buddhas, bodhisattvas, and gods in the mountain's many shrines and temples.

In the twelfth century, the administration of the Kumano pilgrimage routes was largely overseen by *sendatsu* who were also the principal abbots of Onjōji.<sup>120</sup> Historical sources suggest this may have begun with Zōyo 増誉 (1032–1116), the protector monk of Shirakawa who established the Jimon branch temple Shōgoin. Shirakawa appointed Zōyo as the first administrator of the Kumano pilgrimage (Kumano *sanzan kengyō* 熊野三山検校) and eventually as abbot of Onjōji.<sup>121</sup> I return to other Jimon monks involved with the pilgrimage in chapter 3. Here, one guide of the mid- to late twelfth century is of special importance to my study of the links between Go-Shirakawa, Senju Kannon, and healing: the Jimon monk Kakusan 覚讃 (dates unknown).

Kakusan led at least twenty pilgrimages and was at one point appointed as supervisor of the pilgrimage system. In 1162, Kakusan led Go-Shirakawa on what was the latter's second pilgrimage, a trip that strengthened Go-Shirakawa's relationship with Senju Kannon. As Go-Shirakawa wrote of the pilgrimage, "I secluded myself for three days at each of the three shrines of the Hongū, Shingū, and Nachi, during which time I performed the summary recitation of the [*Thousand Arm Sutra*] a total of one thousand times."<sup>122</sup> During a visit to the Shingū Shrine on the night of the twelfth day of the second month, while other pilgrims dozed off, Go-Shirakawa stayed up all night reciting the *Thousand Arm Sutra*. As dawn approached, he was moved by emotion and produced an *imayō* 今様 verse:

Surpassing the vows of the myriad other buddhas,  
the vow of the Thousand-Armed One is most dependable.  
It preaches that even withering plants and trees might suddenly bloom  
with flowers and bear fruit.<sup>123</sup>

At this exact time, Kakusan, likewise forgoing sleep to perform a ceremony under a pine tree nearby, heard the voice of a *kami* speak out, "Now is the time for our hearts to melt!"<sup>124</sup> Kakusan and Go-Shirakawa interpreted this unexpected message from above as a sign that the shrine's deities had responded positively to Go-Shirakawa's offering of verse in praise of Senju Kannon.

Go-Shirakawa's *imayō* was most certainly a reference to the healing powers of Senju Kannon's *dhāraṇī*. His abbreviated recitations of the sutra on this trip notwithstanding, Go-Shirakawa had certainly read the sutra thousands of times

by the time he took his second pilgrimage to Kumano. He of all laypersons would have known that the original passage from the *Thousand Arm Sutra* went like this:

This *dhāraṇī* immensely benefits sentient beings of the Three Worlds. If treated with this *dhāraṇī*, all who experience an abundance of bodily suffering will be cured. This great divine spell enchants parched and withered trees and once again they produce branches, stems, flowers, and fruits. How much more so for beings endowed with sentience and consciousness! If the diseases on their bodies are treated with this, it is certain that no place (on their body) will fail to be cured!<sup>125</sup>

Juxtaposing this original passage from the sutra with Go-Shirakawa's verse suggests that the botanical metaphors of the latter were also likely charged with therapeutic themes. In Go-Shirakawa's experience, the withering decline of his aging and ailing body has been miraculously reversed through a rejuvenation prompted by an esoteric spell dedicated to Senju Kannon.<sup>126</sup> In an age when much poetry and literature was, as William LaFleur put it, "shot through and through" with the motif of the irreversible impermanence of life (*mujo* 無常), in his personal moment of connection with a familiar bodhisattva, Go-Shirakawa is jolted with a taste of the impossible, a confirmation of the revitalization of his very health—one subsequently echoed by Kakusan's encounter with the mysterious voice from above.<sup>127</sup> We should not fail to recall how the notion of efficacy in early medieval Japan, expressed with the term *gen*, referred to both curative powers and the miracles of gods.

Go-Shirakawa's miraculous experience influenced a second incredible event that occurred soon after the pilgrimage ended, during the sixth month of the same year. As we learn from another record in *Notes on Turning the Dharma Wheel*, one day after Kakusan performed the concluding vow to a ritual involving the *Thousand Arm Sutra*, he had a dream in which Go-Shirakawa appeared wearing a white robe. Kakusan interpreted the appearance of his patron in a white robe as an incarnation of Senju Kannon.<sup>128</sup> The event directly recalls the white-robed healer-ascetic written into the *Illustrated Origins of Kokawadera*. Just as the healer-ascetic in the *Illustrated Origins of Kokawadera* likely represented for Go-Shirakawa a Jimon healer-monk who doubled as an incarnation of Senju Kannon, Go-Shirakawa appears as an incarnation of the same bodhisattva who, on another register of symbolism, refers again to the white-robed ascetic of Kokawadera.

Finally, just as Jimon monks had done for Toba and other sovereigns, Jimon monks drew on the powers of Senju Kannon to provide ritual healing directly for Go-Shirakawa and his family in practice. In 1165, the Jimon monk

Kakukan was called in to treat Go-Shirakawa's first son, Nijō. Because that case is considered in depth in chapter 5, here I note only examples that involve rituals Go-Shirakawa sponsored at his Rengeōin hall dedicated to Senju Kannon. In 1176, Go-Shirakawa's consort (*nyōgo* 女御) Taira no Shigeko 平滋子 (also known as Kenshunmon'in 建春門院, 1142–1176)—who had accompanied Go-Shirakawa on at least four pilgrimages to Kumano<sup>129</sup>—became ill with a swelling (*nikimi* 二禁).<sup>130</sup> In addition to calling in court physicians to perform moxibustion and sponsoring Buddhist rituals for healing, Go-Shirakawa commissioned an altar rite dedicated to Senju Kannon at Rengeōin. The ritual was elaborate and involved as many as thirty altars, ten each operated by monks from Tōji, Enryakuji, and Onjōji. For the chief officiant of the ritual, Go-Shirakawa chose none other than Kakusan. Who better to lead the healing rite for his ailing consort than the Jimon monk who validated the retired emperor's spiritual resonance with Senju Kannon at Kumano, and who just a decade before even dreamed of the retired emperor himself as an incarnation of the bodhisattva?<sup>131</sup>

Kenshunmon'in did not survive this bout with illness, but Go-Shirakawa's faith in Senju Kannon and Jimon monks did not waiver. Toward the end of 1191, Go-Shirakawa had become severely ill. To eliminate his illness—and certainly to avoid a wicked death and extend his life, other boons the *Thousand Arm Sutra* promised devout readers—he commissioned the same thirty-altar Senju Kannon ritual at Rengeōin. A lengthy record of the rite appears in Keihan's *Record of Treasured Secrets* and in the later *Continued Lamp Record of Miidera* (*Mii zoku tōki* 三井続燈記, 1483), attesting to its importance for the Jimon lineage in Go-Shirakawa's time and thereafter.<sup>132</sup> The records indicate that the ceremony lasted about two weeks. As in previous cases, Senju Kannon's *dhāraṇī* was the centerpiece. More than twelve Jimon monks conducted altars on the right and left sides, including Kōin and Keihan. As with the earlier ritual for Go-Shirakawa's consort, the prominent role of managing the center altar was assigned to a Jimon monk. Although the records do not provide a name, they identify the monk as belonging to Shōgoin, which was a branch temple of the Jimon lineage connected with the Kumano pilgrimage. The employment of a Shōgoin monk may relate to the fact that around this time, Go-Shirakawa's son Jōe 静恵 (1164–1203) had officially entered Shōgoin. Moreover, Jōe had previously studied under Kakuchū 覚忠 (1118–1177), a Jimon monk under whom Go-Shirakawa took the precepts.<sup>133</sup> It is also significant that the first “attendant monk” to be listed in the records as serving the center altar is Kakukan 覚寛 (dates unknown), an important Jimon monk we meet in chapter 5. Finally, even after this Senju Kannon rite ended, Jimon monks carried on with therapeutic services for their venerable patron and patient. For example, on the seventeenth day of the first month, Jimon monks offered a copy of the *Vimalakīrti Sutra*

(*Yuimakyō* 維摩經) to the gods at the shrine Iwashimizu Hachimangū 石清水八幡宮 to pray for Go-Shirakawa's recovery.<sup>134</sup>

Faced with threats of violence from monks of the Sanmon branch, their monastic cousins in the Tendai school, in the late tenth century monks of the Jimon lineage had little choice but to descend Mt. Hiei. From their former base on Mt. Hiei, the Senjuin—the “Hall of the Thousand Arms”—to the temple Onjōji, Jimon monks replanted Enchin's archive of sacred works, the Tōin library, which comprised a vast collection of esoteric liturgical writings. Prominent members of the lineage like Yokei and Kanju laid new foundations for their community at temples in the north of the capital Heiankyō.

From these positions of proximity to the capital, Jimon monks ramped up their ritual services for elite patrons, with much energy directed toward esoteric rites with therapeutic efficacy. Tailoring esoteric rituals like empowerment and altar rites to effectively respond to the hopes and fears of their patrons—plagued as these courtiers and emperors were by all manner of diseases and epidemics—was essential if Jimon monks were to survive this tumultuous period. As we saw in this chapter, it was through ritual services that Jimon monks sought to convince their patrons of the distinctive advantages of patronizing their monastic community. Because they frequently succeeded or were perceived as succeeding, Jimon monks continued to perform healing rituals throughout the Heian period for elite patrons, from Michinaga to Go-Shirakawa.

The healing rituals examined here, especially the altar rites addressed to the esoteric deities Fudō Myōō, the Five Wisdom Kings, and Senju Kannon, were seen as effective for treating manifold illnesses and afflictions. However, from the mid-tenth century on, emperors and aristocrats increasingly found themselves panic-stricken in the face of a new disease, one that was so peculiarly vexatious that it sometimes resisted esoteric altar rites, even those that invoked the most powerful deities. What made this new affliction so difficult to manage was its source: This disease came from beyond the grave.

## CHAPTER 2

### Evil Dead in the Aristocratic Mansion



Immune systems in general constitute embodiments of expectations of injury. At the biological level, these show up in the capacity to build antibodies; at the juridical level, in the form of procedures to compensate for injustice; at the religious level, in the shape of chaos-overcoming rituals that show people how they can carry on when things no longer work according to human estimates.

—Peter Sloterdijk

ON A HOT DAY IN THE CAPITAL OF HEIANKYŌ AROUND THE YEAR 1000, court lady Sei Shōnagon chanced upon a Buddhist exorcism at the home of a well-to-do aristocrat. Although there was no ailing patient to be seen, the presence of a finely dressed priest and the entrance of a girl Sei took to be a spirit medium made it obvious that somebody in the household was sick; the cause: a resentful spirit. Together with others drawn to the ceremony that had begun to unfold, Sei watched as the priest intoned the “Thousand-Armed Kannon” spell and transferred the spirit who was causing all the trouble into the body of the young medium. The medium trembled, groaned, and fell into a trance: The ritual was working. The priest compelled the spirit to speak its “reasons” (*kotowari*)—what grudges had compelled it to afflict the patient?—and then “pardoned” it (*yurushitsu*), bringing the rite to an end. A high-ranking woman of the household thanked the priest for his therapeutic services (the patient had rallied) and requested that he return the next day. In Sei’s words, the priest “took his leave with an air of such dignity that everyone felt the Buddha himself had appeared on earth.”<sup>1</sup>

It would be difficult to find a firsthand account that better illustrates how aristocrats of the Heian period (794–1185) saw the possession rite, the healing ritual against diseases caused by spirits of the dead. During the possession rite, a priest used ritual techniques to transfer an offending spirit from the body of the ailing patient into the body of a medium, enabling communication with the otherwise unseen pathogenic ghost. Once the priest had determined why the

spirit was afflicting the patient, he sent it away. Curiously, the patient appears to have had little to no involvement in the ritual's procedures. By all accounts, this hardly mattered. The priest's impressive performance, the convulsions of the possessed medium, the dialogue between priest and spirit—all were taken to indicate one thing: The rite was clearly “working.” Indeed, the performance Sei observes ends with celebration, gratitude, and an earnest plea that the priest come back and do it again tomorrow.

As a historical witness of trends in Buddhist ritual healing during the Heian period, Sei's account lends the impression that by 1000 or so, not only had the Buddhist possession rite become a routine affair in aristocratic mansions but the aristocrats who sponsored it were confident in its therapeutic efficacy against spirit disease. Indeed, a survey of the most prominent literary works in this period, including the *Tale of Genji* (*Genji monogatari* 源氏物語, ca. 1001–1005) and *A Tale of Flowering Fortunes* (*Eiga monogatari* 栄花物語, ca. 1028), features episode after episode of eminent priests grappling with pathogenic spirits by way of the possession rite—often coming away victorious. But this rite and its perceived successes were no figments of literary imagination. Observed accounts of real performances of the possession rite also fill the pages of diaries written in the Heian period by courtiers who, their lives and those of loved ones saved by the rite, praised and handsomely paid the priests who performed it. How did the possession rite rise to such prominence in Heian Japan? In other words, why was it seen as efficacious?

For many scholars of Buddhism in Japan's Heian period, the possession rite is no longer the bizarre or inexplicable phenomenon it once was. Scholars have come a long way from early interpretations of the rite as representing a divergence on the part of priests from “proper” Buddhist doctrine and an accommodation of Japanese shamanism, Shinto, or superstition. Much recent research has demonstrated that the possession rite was rooted in rituals of esoteric Buddhism, the scriptures for which were initially imported to Japan in the late eighth and early ninth centuries. In the centuries before the possession rite, esoteric rituals had become firmly established in Japan as powerful healing technologies. The scriptures that prescribed them came stamped with the claim that such rituals could heal all those in need, extend life spans indefinitely, and eliminate virtually every disease imaginable. There is no question that esoteric rituals and these incredible claims to universal efficacy were the substrate from which the possession rite grew in the tenth century.

At the same time, reducing the development of the possession rite in Heian Japan to the reception of esoteric scriptures would adopt a rather static view of what was a complex and dynamic innovation. In this chapter, I examine the possession rite as a product of what I call ritual immunity. Ritual immunity refers to the messy and experimental processes of ritual creation, design, and

performance aimed at engaging pathogenic metapersons, unseen entities that threaten the integrity of body, mind, and community. I view the possession rite as a creative ritual response to a pathological problem that was native to the concerns of aristocratic society of Heian Japan yet new in its time: spirit disease.

I begin by discussing the appearance of spirit disease in the mid-tenth to early eleventh centuries. After describing its characteristics and symptoms, I show that the emergence of the disease in this time was spurred by growing anxieties surrounding postmortem existence and invisible spectral threats. What drove the dead to afflict the living with somatic violence in the form of disease was resentment toward those who had mistreated them in past lives. Spirit disease was never simply an illness of a person's body or mind; it was also a social affliction animated by the imagination of injustice in the stressed lifeworld of the Heian court. Then I examine the possession rite. As Sei Shōnagon's report vividly illustrates, the possession rite turned out to be an unusually successful experiment in the laboratory of ritual immunity. The second half of the chapter shows why that was the case, focusing on notions of therapeutic efficacy that were embedded in and enacted through the rite.

## SPIRIT DISEASE

### PSYCHO-SPECTRAL IRRITANTS AT COURT

Historical and literary sources suggest that disease-inducing spirit irruptions became a pervasive problem for the first time in the mid-Heian period, beginning around the mid- to late tenth century, and remained for many centuries.<sup>2</sup> As Hattori Toshirō declared in his pioneering study on Heian-period medical history, no other etiology provoked as much fear in Heian aristocrats as did pathogenic spirits.<sup>3</sup> As a consensus of scholars has confirmed in recent decades, a staggering amount of daily afflictions were blamed on ghosts.<sup>4</sup> Already around 1000, Sei Shōnagon had good reason to count *mononoke*—alongside “foot *qi*” and “chest affliction”—as one of the three most common ailments in court society.<sup>5</sup>

Spirit disease and the multifaceted afflictions it caused were subjects that courtiers discussed frequently over letters, via messengers they sent to and from the court, in their diaries, and when they ran into each other on the streets of Heiankyō and by its rivers.<sup>6</sup> In the *Shōyūki* 小右記 (Diary of the Ononomiya Minister of the Right), the diary of Fujiwara no Sanesuke covering 982 to 1032, there are more than seventy entries directly pertaining to spirit disease and its treatment. Extant entries surely represent only the tip of the iceberg, especially since matters surrounding spirit disease were inherently sensitive, revolving around illness, death, loss of autonomy, and, as we shall see, inauspicious affairs



about court lineages spoken by the unwelcomed dead. Because encounters with pathogenic spirits were so common in daily life, the topic figures prominently in the fictional and semi-fictional literature produced in this period by court women. As Doris Borgen has shown extensively, spirit disease is a salient narrative trope in the *Tale of Genji*, in which it is cast by author Murasaki Shikibu 紫式部 (973?–1014?) as a chaos-inducing force that not only afflicts but even kills major characters.<sup>7</sup> Watanabe Takeshi has also highlighted the importance of spirit disease in *A Tale of Flowering Fortunes*, a semi-fictional account of the rise of Fujiwara no Michinaga in court politics.<sup>8</sup>

In literary sources such as the *Tale of Genji* and *A Tale of Flowering Fortunes*, the term used for spirit disease was *mononoke* (もののけ or 物気). In her discussion of the historical etymology of *mononoke*, Borgen notes that *mono* was “not the tangible ‘thing’ it means in modern Japanese but its very opposite in ancient usage: something unspecifiable, without a clear form, and therefore extraordinary, strange, to be feared as an outside force.”<sup>9</sup> In early sources such as the Nara-period poetry anthology *Collection of Myriad Leaves* (*Man’yōshū* 万葉集, ca. 759), *mono* appears as a gloss for the character *ki/oni* 鬼 (Ch. *gui*). As was common in the context of medieval China as well, in the early Japanese context, the character *ki* most typically named harmful beings such as ghosts and spirits who bring disease or inflict suffering, often by possessing a living person, as was imagined to be the case with *mononoke*.<sup>10</sup>

The second character in the term *mononoke*, *ke* (also read *ki*; Ch. *qi*; hereafter, *qi*), sometimes translated “influence” or “pneuma,” had manifold meanings. In the context of Chinese medicine, which drew from broader strands of natural and political thought that developed as early as the Warring States period (475–221 BCE), *qi* referred to dynamic agents of influence that flowed in bodies and the outside world and was capable of crossing the barriers between body and environment in various ontological guises—climatic, elemental, pestilential, somatic, and psychological.<sup>11</sup> In the Japanese context, where Chinese conceptions were absorbed in idiosyncratic ways, *qi* was likewise understood as a kind of unseen material or influence that accumulates and diminishes in quantity and moves around or within bodies and the surrounding environment. In Japan, *qi* was seen to exert negative influence by assuming deleterious and pathological forms. For example, one theory of epidemics held that they were caused by the *qi* that emanated from *kami* (the gods).<sup>12</sup> A related notion appears in one story in the *Record of Miraculous Events in Japan*, in which an *oni*—in this case, a messenger of King Yama (Enmaō 閻魔王), the sovereign of hell—tells a person whose time has not yet come that he ought not approach, for the *qi* that emanates from the messenger’s body will surely make the man sick. (King Yama’s messengers were never inclined to increase their own workload.)<sup>13</sup> Thus, the term *mononoke*, referring to spirits of the departed, also referred to an

influence that emanated from the bodies of spirits as well as gods and demons, an influence that was seen as pathogenic.

The term *mononoke* also appears to some degree in diaries (*nikki* 日記) written in Sino-Japanese (*kanbun* 漢文) by male courtiers, as do similar terms such as *reiki* 靈氣 (spirit influence) and *reibutsu* 靈物 (spirit thing). More commonly, diarists used the term “evil *qi*” (*jake* 邪氣; also, *jarei* 邪靈 or *jar-eiki* 邪靈氣).<sup>14</sup> Like *mononoke*, this term also refers to an “influence” (*qi*) but specifies that the influence is *ja*: perverse, deviant, evil. The term derives from Chinese medicine where, read *xieqi*, it historically expressed two different disease etiologies. The first held that diseases are caused by ghosts who haunt or curse the living, a process imagined as an invasion of the physical body. The second etiology, which was adopted in particular in the medical thought of the Yellow Emperor corpus of the Han dynasty (202 BCE–220 CE), held similarly that disease is caused by an invasion of pathogens into the body, but saw those pathogens as nonanthropomorphic forms of *qi* operative in the external environment, most notably wind, cold, heat, and dampness.<sup>15</sup> Paul Unschuld sees the historical appearance of the second etiology as a major turn in Chinese medicine toward a view of disease that was more naturalistic and less demonological.<sup>16</sup> Medical texts of the Sui (581–618) and Tang (618–907) periods routinely blur the distinction between the etiological perspectives, as is evident in such works as the *Treatise on the Origins and Symptoms of Diseases* (*Zhubing yuanhou lun* 諸病源候論, 610; hereafter, *Disease Origins*), a text that exerted substantial influence on Japanese medical thought in the Heian period.<sup>17</sup> As a result, both etiological senses of evil *qi* were known in Heian Japan, at least among educated court physicians and Buddhist monks who read medical literature. The fact remains that the operative, everyday meaning of evil *qi* in Japanese aristocratic society was always much closer to the first of the medical etiologies: Courtiers saw evil *qi* as spirits of deceased individuals who had pathogenic agency. Rather than a nebulous influence of the natural environment, evil *qi* spirits were motivated metapersons.

What kinds of symptoms were attributed to evil *qi* in Heian Japan? One constellation of symptoms was psychological: Evil *qi* spirits frequently produced in victims psychological disturbances and anomalous behavior. Diary entries describe how those possessed by spirits became nervous; had difficulty responding to questions; spoke or wrote unintelligible or “mad” words; lost the ability to speak altogether; exhibited random outbursts of singing, yelling, and crying; and made unusual requests that could have only come from alien agencies.<sup>18</sup>

There was often a concern in these and similar cases that the agency of the victim had been hijacked by a spectral intruder. Nowhere is this aspect of spirit disease more striking than in cases involving premature tonsure, that is, when somebody took the Buddhist precepts before it was socially acceptable to do so.

Such was suspected in 982 when Princess Sonshi 尊子内親王 (966–985) lopped off her hair in secret, without informing even her closest attendants. Malign spirits were at work, it was rumored, and surely it was no help that her father was Reizei, a former emperor who many suspected had likewise lost his mind to ghosts.<sup>19</sup> In another record dated 986 in *A Tale of Flowering Fortunes*, Emperor Ichijō's "disturbing" interest in Buddhist sermons, his frequent mutterings of a desire to cast aside his family and material possessions, and his intention to leave the secular world are attributed to the workings of a ghost—in fact, the same spirit then thought to be haunting Reizei.<sup>20</sup> Likewise, in 998 Michinaga, then suffering from a suspicious lower back ailment, declared his desire to take the tonsure and promptly exit politics, and the emperor—for whom Michinaga's departure would have had destructive consequences—immediately concluded that a spirit must be twisting his thoughts.<sup>21</sup>

The affliction of evil *qi* was far from merely mental. Diaries attest that it was associated with disease localized in the eyes and in the lower back; with the presence of "warm *qi*" (*unke* 温気), fevers, and chills in the body; with difficulty eating and drinking, as well as abdominal blockage and constipation; and even spitting up blood.<sup>22</sup> Somatic symptoms of evil *qi* had a discernible character. They were often characterized by sudden onset and refused to dissipate.<sup>23</sup> Evil *qi* afflictions were often confused with, combined with, or said to cause other patently physical diseases, including epidemics (*ekibyō* 疫病, *ekike* 疫気, *jigyō* 時行),<sup>24</sup> malarial fever (*gyakubyō*), chest affliction, warm disease (*unbyō* 温病), "free-flux" illness (*ribyō* 痢病; abdominal pain and excessive defecation), "measles" (*akamogasa* 赤疱瘡), wind disease (*fūbyō* 風病), wind *qi* (*fūke* 風気), wind fever (*fūnetsu* 風熱), and a condition—used as a category by yin-yang masters in their divinatory diagnoses—in which the body is said to be "difficult to treat" by disposition.<sup>25</sup> Evil *qi* was associated with other harmful influences thought to cause illness and death, such as curses (*tatari* 祟) from gods like the Stove God (Kamado no kami 竈神).<sup>26</sup> It often assailed women during pregnancy, labor, and the postpartum period, times of immense uncertainty and—all too frequently—death.<sup>27</sup> Finally, evil *qi* could become so severe as to render the patient unconscious and even bring death, much like the episodes Murasaki Shikibu dramatized in the *Tale of Genji*.<sup>28</sup>

The precise relationship between evil *qi* and these other diseases and conditions was often left unexplained and untheorized in historical sources. Even so, courtiers understood evil *qi* to be much more than a disruption of the victim's psyche or personality. Indeed, from the mid- to late tenth century, evil *qi* and other associated terms for spirit disease came to name the causes and manifestations of a staggering variety of psychological and physiological symptoms.

At the same time, recognition of the various body-and-mind symptoms of evil *qi* fails to grasp the fuller significance of the phenomenon and its wider

range of deleterious effects. In fact, the pathological influence of evil *qi* was never limited to the bodies or minds of individual patients. When we turn to consider where this affliction came from and what it was “made of”—resentment turned pathogen—it becomes clear that evil *qi* named not only an affliction suffered by directly ailing victims but also an interpersonal sickness that implicated the malign spirit and reverberated in relationships between lineage groups at court.

### VENGEFUL SPIRITS

As the indeterminate and vague term *mono* in *mononoke* suggests, the identities of spirits labeled as such or with similar terms like evil *qi* were often obscure and elusive. Sometimes a diagnosis revealed that the spirit was in fact a *kami*, such as those worshipped at the Kifune 貴布禰社 or Inari 稻荷 Shrines, a deity of the home such as the Earth God (Dokujin 土公神) or the Stove God, a Buddhist deity like Shōten 聖天 or the astral god Myōken 妙見, or even the spirit of a tree.<sup>29</sup> Most often, however, evil *qi* was linked to spirits of deceased humans. For the rest of the chapter, I focus primarily on evil *qi* as human spirits. I consider three strands that fed into the rise of the phenomenon of evil *qi* in the mid-Heian period: an older notion of “vengeful spirits,” new anxieties about postmortem existence, and a growing imagination of pathogenic resentment as a violent threat. Examining these strands allows us to grasp the affliction’s wider pathological profile, which is key for understanding the ritual that was created to manage it.

First, the notion of evil *qi* drew on earlier beliefs tethering death to disease, seen most vividly in the notion of vengeful spirits (*onryō* 怨霊). These were wrathful ghosts of court nobles of the early Heian period (late eighth and early ninth centuries) whose lives were tragically cut short by political rivals. Accused of plotting against the state and political peers, these nobles were arrested and then executed, driven to suicide by poison, or left to die in exile or en route to places of exile. Because their deaths were followed shortly after by disaster or disease (or rumors of such), their living political rivals concluded that their spirits had returned from the grave to exact revenge. It was to placate such vengeful spirits that the Assembly for the Venerable Spirits (Goryō-e 御霊会) was first performed in 863.<sup>30</sup> One key impetus for the ceremony was an outbreak of “coughing sickness” earlier in the same year, a disaster attributed to the angry dead.

These occasional appearances of vengeful spirits taught the ruling aristocracy that, depending on the manner of passing, the dead may return to afflict the living with disease. The association of death and disease is an aspect of belief in vengeful spirits that courtiers would also appreciate when evil *qi* began to appear in the late tenth century. For this reason, modern scholars have also

sometimes conflated evil *qi* and vengeful spirits. This is not without some historical justification. Indeed, one later Buddhist commentary from the Kamakura period defines “external evil *qi*” explicitly as “vengeful spirits and the like who curse (the living).”<sup>31</sup>

The notion of evil *qi* was undoubtedly shaped by belief in vengeful spirits, but these spectral phenomena differ in important ways. As Yamada Yūji has shown, the people who became vengeful spirits after death were all major figures at court whose deaths were well known.<sup>32</sup> This made their posthumous identification in connection with disease and disaster relatively straightforward. Moreover, the calamities they brought were large in scope, affecting not only the tiny population of elite aristocratic society but also the broader populace in and around Heiankyō. In contrast, although some emperors and key political players returned from their graves as evil *qi* spirits, it was not always the case that the spirits belonged to persons of major political significance. Nor were the deaths of those who became evil *qi* necessarily tragic or violent. Very often, the identity of the evil *qi* remained obscure, resisting all efforts at unmasking.<sup>33</sup> Finally, the field of paranormal-pathological activity in which evil *qi* operated never reached the level of sweeping calamity that was attributed to vengeful spirits; evil *qi* exerted their harm in the small and insular world of court society. Whereas vengeful spirits showed up sporadically to generate catastrophes like epidemics, evil *qi* haunted the aristocracy with a wide range of afflictions on an almost daily basis.<sup>34</sup>

#### POSTMORTEM ANXIETIES

Besides belief in vengeful spirits, a second strand that fed into the rise of evil *qi* were anxieties about postmortem existence that arose in the tenth and eleventh centuries. One stemmed from a fear of falling into hell and returning to the world of the living as an unwittingly antagonistic spirit. Two examples illustrate this anxiety.<sup>35</sup> The first example appears in a *fujumon* 諷誦文, a liturgical script read aloud by a priest in a ritual for cultivating merit and sending it to the deceased. Dated 1060, the script was composed by Retired Emperor Uda and addressed to the spirit of Minamoto no Tōru 源融 (822–895). After Tōru’s death, Uda had come to live in Tōru’s old mansion, Kawara no In, and eventually Tōru began haunting the place. The script notes that ten days before Uda’s service for Tōru, his spirit possessed a female household servant. Using the servant’s voice, Tōru’s spirit reported he was being severely punished in hell—his body was placed on the forest of swords, his bones crushed by an iron mallet, and other tortures. This was retribution, he declared, for the prior karma of killing sentient beings. Most noteworthy here, the spirit indicated that because his body remains saturated with karmic sin, his present disposition is

inherently violent. Thus, he found himself bringing harm to the living, including Uda, despite having no intention of doing so.<sup>36</sup>

Another example comes from the slightly earlier collection *Records of the Miracles of the Lotus Sutra in Japan* (*Dai Nihonkoku Hokekyō genki* 大日本国法華経験記), compiled during the Chōkyū 長久 era (1040–1044) by the Sanmon monk Chingen 鎮源 (dates unknown), who resided at the Shuryōgon'in 首楞嚴院 in the Yokawa 横川 precinct of Mt. Hiei. In this story, a man who has fallen into the hell of ceaseless torture returns to his wife in the wretched body of a snake. He says: "I am your husband. Though I have no mind to harm you, the suffering of my body causes me to possess and afflict you. When I was alive, I took pleasure in many evils. I was cruel with animals and took objects of the Buddha as my own. At no point did I fail to do evil, nor did I perform a single hair of good."<sup>37</sup> Thus, in this example and that of the ghost of Tōru, the spirits are unwittingly driven by their karma: Although neither wishes to do harm, their karma, combined with their present suffering in the hells, drives them to malicious actions against the innocent, even those they love.

These episodes speak to anxieties about the loss of self-autonomy imagined to attend death and karmic accumulation, anxieties that would have resonated with another postmortem anxiety that was growing in the same period: failure to achieve rebirth in the Pure Land. The ideal of rebirth in the paradisiacal Pure Land presided over by Amida Buddha became mainstream across aristocratic society in the late tenth century. Three main factors drove this trend: Genshin's 源信 (942–1017) 985 compilation of *Essentials of Rebirth* (*Ōjō yōshū* 往生要集), the creation of a new hagiographical genre of exemplary rebirth narratives (*ōjōden* 往生伝), and the formation of communities dedicated to the practice of deathbed rituals aimed at securing rebirth.<sup>38</sup> In *Essentials of Rebirth*, Genshin taught readers to "shun this defiled world" (*onri edo* 厭離穢土) and "aspire to the Pure Land" (*gongu jōdo* 欣求淨土).<sup>39</sup> But he also wrote graphically about the hells into which one might fall if rebirth should somehow fail. Inevitably, anxieties sprouted up around the possibility of rebirth failure, especially as people hopelessly compared themselves with the exemplary models described in the hagiographies and encountered difficulties when trying to perform the deathbed ritual according to ritual prescriptions. As Jacqueline Stone has shown, many things could go wrong for the Pure Land aspirant in the weeks, days, and even seconds before death: distractions, lingering attachments, demonic interference, insufficient merit, karma so heavy one could not slip out from under it.<sup>40</sup>

It is not hard to imagine that the increase of anxieties around failure to be reborn in the Pure Land would have contributed to the sense that evil *qi* spirits were being generated as often as people were failing to achieve favorable rebirth. The idea that failed rebirth might directly contribute to the proliferation of troubled, pathogenic spirits is vividly illustrated in a late eleventh-century liturgy

titled *Opening Pronouncement for the Goma Ceremony* (*Goma hyōbyaku* 護摩表白; 1058) preserved at Kōsanji 高山寺. This text constitutes the dedicatory prayer that was to be read on the occasion of a *goma* fire ceremony. The prayer indicates that the ailing sponsor suspects that wicked spirits (*akuryō* 悪霊) and evil *qi* are to blame for his present illness. The prayer he hopes will be realized through the fire ceremony is one that any courtier aware of the postmortem consequences of failed rebirth might reasonably make: May these “evil spirits and evil *qi* now arouse *bodhicitta*, believe and receive the Dharma, discard their evil karmic bodies, and quickly attain rebirth in the Pure Land.”<sup>41</sup> In other words, the sponsor prays that the spirits who menace him are cleared of their own karma and pass successfully and immediately to the Pure Land—to the mind of any Heian courtier, a sure way of getting menacing spirits off your back.

The spirit of one person even made this kind of request himself. The spirit of the monk Gashō 賀静 (887–967), who had died with the displeasure of failing to be promoted as abbot of the Tendai school, came back to haunt Emperor Sanjō, contributing to the latter’s chronic eye affliction. On one occasion in 1015, the spirit requested that a repentance ritual (*senbō* 懺法) structured as a fire ceremony and dedicated to Amida Nyorai be performed in the hall where he used to reside on Mt. Hiei.<sup>42</sup> In his petition from beyond the grave, Gashō begged for a mitigation of his karma (by way of repentance) and admission to the Pure Land (by way of invoking Amida). Seen inversely, his request defines the phenomenon of evil *qi* rather concisely as a combination of bad karma and unfavorable rebirth. The impossible dream of the Pure Land for the dead had spawned new nightmares for the living.

#### PATHOGENIC RESENTMENT

A third strand that fed into the rise of evil *qi* in the mid-Heian period was the culture of resentment that social and political dynamics engendered. This culture of resentment, and its influence on anxieties surrounding violence and disease, most directly shaped the imagination of evil *qi* as an almost ceaseless daily threat.

The stage for growing resentment across the aristocracy was set by socio-political developments since the early Heian period. In the late ninth and early tenth centuries, court lineages belonging to the northern branch of the Fujiwara family had successfully pushed out competing clans from central positions of power. Thereafter, competition at court became mostly an insular battle between lineages of the northern branch. At all levels of the nobility, individuals competed for higher rank, esteemed offices, and cultural prestige; at the highest level, they battled for the reins of imperial control. The Fujiwara power game for sovereignty was largely played through heredity and marriage politics. Prominent

men in the family wed their daughters to emperors. Once a male heir to the throne was born, the grandfather could exert control from behind the scenes—hence the scholarly designation for this period, the Era of Regents. Michinaga, both fortuitous and strategic, represents the pinnacle of this strategy, having successfully wed three of his daughters to emperors, a tactic that earned him a level of political authority unheard of for anyone outside of the imperial bloodline.

Such struggles for political power, dependent on the manipulation of interpersonal relationships and uncontrollable biological processes (childbirth, disease, death), inevitably created constant stress conditions for the aristocratic community. So did the fact that the losers of this political game were not banished from court entirely but continued to coexist in tense relationships with the winners, creating a community in which volatile affects and animosities were prone to linger. As a result, the social lifeworld of the Heian court was trafficked by hostility, envy, and resentment, entities that, it turned out, refused to confine themselves to individual psyches as internal thoughts and feelings.

We might expect that, with the engines of resentment running so hot, the “good people” of the Heian nobility would have made frequent recourse to physical attacks and murderous plots. To a certain extent, the historical record does not disappoint: Some courtiers were indeed jumped by rivals, and heads did roll (literally) from time to time.<sup>43</sup> On the whole, however, overt physical aggression at court was rare. Compared with preceding centuries, violence overall had decreased. This decrease mirrored changes from above in the legal system. Capital punishment was virtually nonexistent by the early Heian period. The last major execution took place in 810 and none occurred until 1156, when the rise of the warrior class began to place new stress on the nobility. As legal historian Rikō Mitsuo has argued, executions likely stopped after 810 because of fears about vengeful spirits.<sup>44</sup> Indeed, we must remember that those people of earlier centuries whose spirits returned for revenge were often victims of unjust and fatal punishments. Learning from the disastrous consequences of such acts, reasonable courtiers in the early Heian period surely concluded that the murder of one’s peers for political ends would only put a target on their own backs, increasing the likelihood of violent revenge from beyond the grave. One overall effect of the general aversion to violence in this time was that rivals continued to inhabit the social sphere of the court: Losers lived on with their resentments as participants in court life while winners, continuing to wield their privileged political power from above, feared what such resentment might incite from below, from their less successful peers.

In an era when physical violence was socially suppressed, the disenfranchised instead sought power and revenge through means that were more clandestine, magical, and sinister. Shigeta Shin’ichi observes that there was more cursing during the Era of Regents than in any other era in Japanese history. Many aristocrats



turned to monks for Buddhist-style cursing, which took the form of altar rites to “subjugate” enemies, despite the Council of State’s 901 ban of the private sponsorship of Buddhist rites for such purposes. Some courtiers in the mid-Heian period performed the cursing themselves, but most sought professional assistance from yin-yang masters, especially the nonofficial masters known for donning the physical appearance of Buddhist monks (*hōshi onmyōji* 法師陰陽師).

Surveying even a small sample of cases that occurred during 995 to 1030 reveals that cursing was both common and varied in applied practice.<sup>45</sup> Some buried talismans or other cursing paraphernalia (*enmotsu* 厭物) in the garden of their target’s mansion or in the hallowed ground of *kami* shrines.<sup>46</sup> It often became known that a curse had been sown in the soil when somebody stumbled upon these dreadful objects by chance; in one case, these items were found at the mansion of an already sick individual and were no doubt interpreted as the cause of the illness.<sup>47</sup> One suspicious person threw hexing materials into the well of their target’s mansion, presumably to prevent later discovery but also because the well was an integral organ of the body of households and thus a natural target for ritual poisoning.<sup>48</sup> One year, Minister of the Left Akimitsu 顯光 (944–1021) offered his beloved daughter’s hair to the gods in exchange for assistance cursing Sanesuke, who was then senior council of the Council of State and quickly ascending the ranks of court hierarchy.<sup>49</sup> The next year, rumors spread that Akimitsu’s daughter herself prayed to the god of Kifune to curse Michinaga, the chancellor of the Council of State.<sup>50</sup> Six years later, an “evil woman” went so far as to steal the physical icon that housed the *kami* of Kifune Shrine to use it for ritual maledictions of an unknown enterprise.<sup>51</sup>

Nervous courtiers who had attained some degree of enviable power sought to protect themselves from cursing by turning to the same professionals who provided cursing services. They employed priests to perform altar rituals, as Sanesuke did in 1025, when he had the Enryakuji monk (and his son) Ryōen 良円 (983–1050) perform a seven-day subjugation rite dedicated to Daiitoku Myōō 大威徳明王 to protect his daughter, Chifuru 千古, whose sickness it was suspected was caused by cursing.<sup>52</sup> In 1027, he had Ryōen perform the same ritual for as many as two weeks, after experiencing a nightmare suggesting that he was being targeted.<sup>53</sup> Some had yin-yang masters perform purification, as Sanesuke also did following his bad dream.<sup>54</sup> Others brought the legal system down on the cursers. Offenders were arrested, interrogated, and imprisoned. In 1000, those charged with cursing were denied amnesty, and at least one folk yin-yang master accused of the crime died in captivity.<sup>55</sup> Thus, from the perspective of those in positions of power at court, the relative absence of violence did not spell immunity from injurious attacks. They knew violence could come just as easily from the shadows in the form of ritual cursing carried out or paid for by a disgruntled colleague at court.

Of special note, the violent threat of cursing was often understood as etiological; in other words, cursing made people sick. The imagined etiological dimension of cursing is reflected in a passage of *A Tale of Flowering Fortunes* in which Michinaga summons two yin-yang masters to diagnose Yorimichi's illness. The two practitioners, depicted as skilled in the arts of curse prevention, propose three possibilities: *mononoke*, the *qi* of *kami*, and cursing.<sup>56</sup> The fact that cursing was seen to be a cause of disease, at least in the eyes of the yin-yang masters who were often tasked with making such determinations, is verified in one treatise that can be definitively attributed to the master of much later fame, Abe no Haruaki (Seimei) 安倍晴明 (921–1005). Fascicle 27 of his *Abbreviated Essentials of Divination* (*Senji ryakketsu* 占事略決) of 979, which contains instructions for diagnosing disease, mentions cursing performed by human actors (*juso* 呪詛).<sup>57</sup>

The culture of resentment spawned even stranger things. Courtiers began to speak of a disembodied psychic entity known as “wicked thoughts” (*akunen* 悪念).<sup>58</sup> When Sanesuke had Ryōen perform the Daiitoku Myōō subjugation rite against cursing, his intention was also to dispel this entity. By “wicked thoughts,” he was not referring to, say, the immoral thoughts of his own mind; rather, he had come to imagine that wicked thoughts were an influence in the world that was potentially coming to harm him. Two years earlier, he sponsored a similar rite for his daughter, and it was to protect her from the harm such a thing might bring. In his diary, Sanesuke notes explicitly that the rite was performed to combat three entities: cursing, evil *qi*, and wicked thoughts. The precise character of these wicked thoughts is not spelled out in historical sources. Shigeta speculates that wicked thoughts were probably not dissimilar from the “living spirits” (*ikiryō* 生霊) of the famous possession episodes in the *Tale of Genji*: malicious thoughts that detach from the disturbed individual who generates them and take the form of a pathological influence targeting the object of the person's antagonism.

We can appreciate at least three important similarities between wicked thoughts, evil *qi*, and cursing: First, as implied by the term, wicked thoughts were likewise animated by resentment and other hostile affects. Second, in all three cases, the true identity of the agent behind the malicious influence (whether the disturbed mind thinking the wicked thoughts, the deceased person whose spirit roams, or the conjurer of the maledictions) was obscure, concealed in the dark shadows of uncertainty, gossip, and anxiety. Third, wicked thoughts, evil *qi*, and cursing were all seen to inflict violence in a specific, sinister way: They induced disease in the body of their victims.

Considering these facts, it is fair to say that in the Heian period, resentment went viral. Courtiers were plagued daily by several species of pathogenic resentment. Each threat was imagined as a stealthy psycho-spectral irritant capable

of generating disease in targeted victims. Although they all emerged from the same rotten substrate of jealousy, hostility, and competition, none were as pervasive and damaging as evil *qi*. And none provoked as urgent and innovative a response from Buddhist healers.

## THE POSSESSION RITE

### COMING TO TERMS WITH THE DEAD

Faced with a diagnosis of evil *qi*, courtiers sought therapeutic assistance almost exclusively from the healing powers of Buddhist practitioners, institutions, and techniques.<sup>59</sup> Some ailing courtiers were sequestered at temples, where they could benefit from ritual services closer to the salubrious powers imagined to radiate from the icons of buddhas, bodhisattvas, and wisdom kings.<sup>60</sup> Others hired priests to chant scriptures such as the *Lotus Sutra*, the *Great Perfection of Wisdom Sūtra* (*Daihannya kyō* 大般若經), and the *Peacock Sutra* (*Kujaku kyō* 孔雀經).<sup>61</sup> Still others sponsored more elaborate performances of altar rituals, including the Five Altar Rite, the “roasting mustard seeds” ritual dedicated to Fudō Myōō (*keshiyaki* 芥子焼), the Seven Buddhas Yakushi Rite, and the Sonjōō 尊星王 Rite.<sup>62</sup>

Already by the late tenth century, a new ritual had emerged as the go-to solution for the problem of spirit disease. It may have developed in light of perceived limitations of received rituals and techniques, including sutra recitation and altar rites, against the vexatious pathology of spirit disease. This would explain a remark made in the early twelfth century by Emperor Horikawa when he overheard monks chanting sutras to treat his spirit disease: “That will do no good now. Just transfer this evil spirit from me.”<sup>63</sup> Horikawa’s (to us) unexpected directive to his priestly caretakers to forget the holy scriptures and initiate what he called a “transfer” suggests that by the early twelfth century, courtiers had come to place faith in a different kind of healing ritual when afflicted with spirit disease. Documentary evidence reveals that confidence in this new ritual was already firmly in place by the early eleventh century.

In his request, Horikawa was referring to a basic feature of the new ritual: the transfer of the disease-causing spirit from the patient’s body to the body of a spirit medium. Besides “transfer,” the rite has been referred to by many terms in historical sources and by modern scholars. Scholars sometimes refer to the ritual as “possession prayers” (*yorigitō* 憑祈祷), a phrase that derives from the Shugendō practice of later periods and, more commonly in recent years, “medium empowerment” (*yorimashi kaji*). In diaries, the ritual is most commonly referred to simply as “empowerment” (*kaji*), implying its continuity with the earlier Buddhist ritual techniques known by that name. For convenience,

I refer to the practice simply as the “possession rite.” Although it was occasionally performed with altar rituals, sutra recitation, and other practices, the possession rite was mostly recognized and performed as a discrete practice. Among the various forms of ritual healing that Buddhist priests used against spirit disease from the late tenth century on, the possession rite quickly became the most sought after by patrons.

Courtier accounts in diaries make clear that when they found themselves haunted by disease-inducing ghosts, they knew invariably who they were going to call: the *genza* (alt. *genja*).<sup>64</sup> Literally “an efficacious one,” *genza* were Buddhist monks seen to have wonder-working capabilities they cultivated through ritual practice and austerities. Most frequently in the Heian period, *genza* were employed as therapeutic ghostbusters, a service they offered by performing the possession rite. Scholars previously assumed *genza* were monks of low social status, but we now know that *genza* were no different from monks who performed elaborate altar rites; they hailed from major elite monasteries and were members of esoteric lineages.

One way to understand the possession rite is to compare it with altar rituals, from which it differs in setting, procedures, and ritual actors. Altar rituals could be performed at monasteries or in mansions; it was easier to do so at the former, since monasteries were already equipped with altars enshrining the buddhas and deities on whom the priest called. When the altar ritual involved only a single altar, priests usually performed these rituals alone, with some logistical assistance from attendant monks (*hansō* 半僧). To perform the possession rite, the *genza* priest invariably made a house call. That is, he left the monastery—usually located at some distance from the main living quarters of the capital—and went to the mansion where the afflicted patient resided. In this respect, the possession rite was closer to empowerment rites, which were typically performed near the patient.

At the mansion, the *genza* priest was joined by a medium, who was already at the mansion or arrived separately.<sup>65</sup> As we will see, the medium played a far more pivotal role in the possession rite than did attendant monks in altar rites. Some documentary sources refer to the medium as a *yorimashi*, a term that conveys the sense that it is their body that the spirit will “possess and reside” in. Most records of the possession rite in diaries refer to mediums simply as “girl/woman” (*onna* 女), “lady-in-waiting” (*nyōbō* 女房), or “person” (*hito* 人).<sup>66</sup> As these terms suggest, the medium was typically female, and she was often a lady-in-waiting or lower-ranking servant. Unlike priests, mediums were not ritualists by profession but were retainers and attendants of the mansion of a higher-ranking aristocrat, and thus would have known the afflicted patient and family intimately. For the duration of the ritual, the priest sat in the same room with the medium, and both were surrounded by concerned family members and

curious onlookers. The patient would not be visible in the immediate vicinity but would be resting on the other side of a folding screen or curtains of state (*kichō* 几帳) or in another section of the mansion altogether.

The *genza* priest typically began the possession rite by “empowering” the body of the medium using the familiar “three mysteries” of esoteric empowerment (*kaji*)—incantations, hand gestures, and visualization. Ritual manuals indicate that the priest used these techniques in part to project into the medium’s body a minor god known as the Dharma Protector (Gohō 護法), a deified incarnation of the Buddhist teachings. One purpose of this initial transfer of a beneficent metaperson may have been to fortify the medium’s body in preparation for the next step, which entailed some degree of danger. In this key step, the priest transferred the spirit from the body of the patient to the body of the medium. Contrary to what we might expect, the immediate presence of the patient’s body does not appear to have been necessary for transporting the spirit. Indeed, this is the last we hear about the patient, if we hear about them at all, until a family member checks on their condition later to see whether the ritual is working. The priest then “spellbinds” (*jubaku* 呪縛) the spirit in the body of the medium. Transformed into a containment unit for the spirit, the medium’s body becomes the spotlight for all subsequent ritual activity.

If all has gone well, the transfer of the spirit to the body of the medium will have opened a channel of communication: The *genza* priest can talk with the offending spirit, to whom the medium has lent her voice. The priest then begins to interrogate the captured spirit, endeavoring to discern its identity and compel it to acknowledge the harm it brings to the victim. The spirit is encouraged to air its grievances while the priest tries to convert the spirit to the righteous path using Buddhist teachings. In practice, communication often fell through. Some spirits resisted the interrogation and refused to announce their names; sometimes there were multiple spirits possessing the medium and the priest was unable to parse individual identities from the cacophony of phantom voices. In any case, after some time, the priest transitioned into the final phase of the ritual, the “subjugation” that expels the spirit from the body of the medium. At the end of the rite, a family member checks on the condition of the patient, which will hopefully signify that the ritual has done some good. The sponsors then compensate—and often celebrate—the *genza* priest for his therapeutic services.

#### RITUAL EFFICACY: FOUR ANGLES

How was the possession rite imagined to work against spirit disease? In particular, how did it address the resentment that animated malign spirits? We can identify four aspects of the rite’s mechanics that contributed to its therapeutic efficacy: transfer, subjugation, communication, and conversion. Before

examining these in turn, it is crucial to understand that the therapeutic addressee of the possession rite was not limited to a single patient. All parties involved would have agreed that the rite is performed to treat the patient presently afflicted with spirit disease, the “patient proper,” whose affliction occasioned the ritual. But as we shall see, the possession rite was also performed to engage two other “patients,” or “metapatients,” we might call them. The first was not an individual person but the family lineage to which the patient belonged. The second was the perpetrator, the resentful spirit who brought the disease. As I will argue, it was only because the possession rite addressed and treated both the patient’s lineage and the disease agent as metapatients—in addition to the patient proper—that the rite was seen to be efficacious for the multifaceted pathology that spirit disease represented.

One of the most common features of the possession rite that directly addressed the patient’s immediate suffering was the transfer. The first task to which the *genza* priest applied himself was extracting the offending spirit from the patient’s body and transferring it to the medium’s body. Although it is arguably the case that the priest performed the spirit relocation to set up operations of greater therapeutic significance, numerous diary entries indicate that simply by extracting the spirit from the patient’s body, the patient experienced immediate relief from their symptoms—precisely what Horikawa was seeking in the above example.<sup>67</sup> Prescriptive ritual scripts for the possession rite likewise show that priests probably shared this notion. One passage in the “Procedures for Efficacious Ones” (*Genza sahō* 験者作法) in the *Collection of Ritual Procedures* (*Sahō shū* 作法集) by Seigen 成賢 (1162–1231) reads, “If the demon is successfully transferred into the body of the youth (i.e., the medium), the patient should finally attain some relief.”<sup>68</sup>

We can understand this sense of relief as the inverse of one aspect of spirit disease etiology, namely, that symptoms begin when the spirit invades the patient’s body. It is only logical that symptoms abate when the priest disjoins the spectral parasite from its host through the ritual surgery of the transfer. Sure enough, in practice, the effects of the transfer on the patient’s condition often proved to be immediately noticeable. In one early example from 1015, Emperor Sanjō was stricken with an eye affliction caused by the spirit of his deceased father, former Emperor Reizei. In his diary, Sanesuke reported, “While the spirit was transferred [from Sanjō’s body and into the medium], the emperor’s eyes became clear.”<sup>69</sup>

The relief that spirit transfer brought to the patient lasted only as long as the state of separation continued; in other words, the transfer was not seen to remedy the underlying problem. One component of the possession rite meant to bring more permanent relief was the technique priests used to formally conclude the performance: subjugation. Subjugation was expected to occur when

the priest “dropped” (*otosu* 落とす) the offending spirit, seeking to expel it from the body of the medium (or sometimes the patient). The term used for this act in diaries, “subjugation” (*chōbuku*), derived from the name of one type of fire ceremony commonly performed by esoteric priests for subduing and expelling enemies, demons, and other hostile entities. Because of the inherently aggressive nature of the technique, in the possession rite it was usually performed only when the spirits were safely transferred out of the ailing patient’s body and into a medium, thus mitigating any potential iatrogenic harm to the patient.<sup>70</sup>

In practice, the subjugation component of the possession rite sometimes unexpectedly provoked the spirits into talking.<sup>71</sup> But as we might expect of the rite’s concluding act and from the original esoteric notion of subjugation, it sometimes led to what was perceived as a cure.<sup>72</sup> As with ritual transfer, in some cases the efficacy of this cure was empirically verifiable to onlookers. For example, in one account Sanesuke described how the voices of evil *qi* spirits became audible in the act of being subjugated.<sup>73</sup> The voices of subjugated spirits undoubtedly flowed from the mouth of the medium, as the exorcism passage in the *Pillow Book* suggests: “While well aware that this suffering is the spirit’s and not the girl’s own, nevertheless those who know her are filled with pity to witness her fearful lamenting and wailing, and they sit beside her and attempt to keep her clothing straight as she writhes there.”<sup>74</sup>

At the same time, the possession rite was not just a form of metaphysical kinesthetics, concerned with ritually moving pathogenic entities between bodies or dislodging them entirely. A third source of the rite’s efficacy drew from prompting meaningful interaction with the spirit, a process made possible once the spirit had been transferred to the medium and thereby had a human voice. We have seen already how disease-causing spirits constituted what I call metapersons, those unseen agents who have certain human-like motivations and behaviors. In the possession rite, priests and participants sought to engage with these spirits not in terms of the fuller biography of the person to whom the spirit once belonged; rather, they zeroed in on those factors seen to animate the spirit’s pathogenic activities, most importantly their perceived resentments and personal karmic history. In so doing, the possession rite sought to bring therapeutic attention and resolution to the situation, effects that were imagined in multiple ways.

At a most basic level, the communication component of the possession rite was aimed at identifying the offending spirit. By identifying the spirit, two related matters could be raised for all involved: the harms the spirit was bringing to the patient, and the grievances held by the spirit. We can take as an example a case from 1020, when Emperor Go-Ichijō was ill and the possession rite was most likely used to identify the offending spirit, in this case the late Prince Atsuyasu 敦康 (999–1018?), the first son of Emperor Ichijō.<sup>75</sup> Once the

spirit was identified as Atsuyasu, the reasons for his return as an evil dead would not have been difficult to reconstruct. Two years before his passing in 1018, Atsuyasu was a top candidate for the next crown prince, a position that would be chosen by his father, Emperor Ichijō, on the occasion of his abdication of the throne to Emperor Sanjō. But Ichijō, motivated by apprehensions over Michinaga's influence, decided to pass over his first son and chose Go-Ichijō, the son of Michinaga's daughter Shōshi and Michinaga's preferred candidate. Therefore, the identification of Atsuyasu's spirit through the possession rite implicitly acknowledged his anger at having been denied the succession for which he had aspired.

A similar case occurred in 1025, when the daughter of Tadanobu 齊信 (967–1035) was doubly afflicted with measles (*akamogasa*) and the resentful spirit of Sanenobu 誠信 (964–1001), Tadanobu's late older brother. Sanenobu's death was certainly not one of those auspicious passages a Heian courtier might have read about in Pure Land rebirth hagiographies. When alive, Sanenobu had long sought the position of middle counselor (*chūnagon* 中納言) but in the end was surpassed by Tadanobu, on whom had fallen the grace of Michinaga's support. The result, as later sources make clear, was a "resentful death" (*uramijini* 恨死).<sup>76</sup> As in the case of Atsuyasu, discerning Sanenobu's pathological spirit through the possession rite occasioned an implicit acknowledgment of the fact that he had been tragically wronged. In a social environment where the topic of Sanenobu's unfair displacement would have been unmentionable in everyday conversation—still more of Michinaga's sweeping reach over courtly affairs—the possession rite played a key function by bringing Sanenobu's resentment into the light.

Such cases have sometimes motivated scholars to entertain comparisons between the possession rite and modern psychoanalysis or psychotherapy.<sup>77</sup> In both practices, the comparison suggests, people work through repressed and unresolved dilemmas, usually with origins in interpersonal conflicts, with the assistance of a specialist, a priest in one case being not so different from a psychotherapist in the other. When examining the possession rite in Heian Japan, we must keep in mind that the individual afflicted with spirit disease (the patient proper) did not typically participate in any respect in the ritual communications between the spirit and the priest. Unlike modern talk therapy, in which the isolated psyche of the patient becomes the locus of treatment, the communicative aspect of the possession rite operated with a wider lens. The possession rite drew attention to lineage-wide issues, with the spotlight often trained on the tensions between the lineage and other rival lineages at court. Sanenobu's immediate target was Tadanobu's daughter, but this was likely because she was already ill with measles and thus defenseless. Correctly understood, the target of Sanenobu's affliction was fuzzier and wider in scope: his brother Tadanobu,



yes, but also the lineage he represented, whose continuation depended on the production of new descendants through his daughter, a reproductive process that Sanenobu's spirit, driven by postmortem animosity, was now threatening to disrupt.

For the possession rite to be efficacious, it had to address and treat lineages as patients. This is precisely what it often did. In particular, the possession rite provided the occasion and raw material with which living members of lineages could create various kinds of potent, compelling, and sometimes comforting webs of meaning. Information gleaned from the evil dead allowed them to uncover the cause of an otherwise mysterious affliction, account for the broader failures of their lineage in the political sphere, rationalize the fortunes of their rivals, and obliquely condemn those rivals. In some cases, this information even allowed them to acknowledge the suffering of karmically wayward spirits and address the spirit's suffering in therapeutic ways.

Several of these dynamics are illustrated in the complex case of the return of the spirit of Fujiwara no Morosuke 師輔 (908–960) and his spectral attack on the pregnant Seishi 姪子 (972–1025)—once again, a vulnerable target. This case makes for productive analysis because the words from Morosuke's spirit during the ritual in 993 still survive, albeit through several layers of mediation. The following monologue of Morosuke's spirit appears in a written entry of Sanesuke's diary, the *Shōyūki*. There, Sanesuke is reporting what he heard from Kanju, the Jimon monk who performed the ritual that prompted the spirit's appearance. The words that Kanju heard were those of Morosuke's spirit, voiced by a medium:

I am the spirit of Minister Kujō. While alive, I turned to Buddhist ceremonies and followed external [magic] techniques to earnestly realize my wish for the flourishing of my descendants, and that wish was realized. My wish for the ruin of the offspring of Grand Minister Ononomiya [Saneyori] was exceedingly deep, and I hoped to put an end to his descendants through the techniques of yin and yang. I anticipated the [magical techniques] would work for sixty years, and they have indeed proven effective. Now, owing to my wish to destroy others, I am suffering greatly. I do not anticipate I'll escape this suffering. When a descendant of Grand Minister Ononomiya is to give birth, I will go there without fail to hinder the birth, thus remaining faithful to the vows I made when I was alive. Not much time remains of the sixty-year [period during which the magic I performed is to remain effective]. The external techniques I conducted at that time have only two years of effectiveness remaining. It will be impossible for me to reinitiate those hindering techniques. But Kōi [Seishi] now

shows signs of pregnancy. Thus, I come to make her suffer. My purpose is to terminate these other lineages.<sup>78</sup>

The first thing we must notice is that Morosuke's words, vocalized in an exchange occasioned by the possession rite, are of a liminal and parasocial nature. The Morosuke who speaks here as spirit is not identical to the Morosuke who died some thirty-three years before this event. For one thing, we can reasonably assume that the living Morosuke never would have confessed to cursing, in the eyes of his peers a morally repugnant activity and one that would have gotten him thrown in jail if caught. Yet Morosuke-the-spirit is all too ready to air his dirty laundry before an audience of members of two lineages that were his rivals at court, those of Saneyori 実頼 (900–960), whom Morosuke's spirit explicitly names, and those of Moromasa 師尹 (920–969), the grandfather of the victim, the pregnant Seishi. Indeed, everyone involved with this performance and its recording belonged to or was affiliated with Morosuke's rival lineages. A priest employed by Seishi's family, presumably by her father, Naritoki 濟時 (941–995), elicited Morosuke's monologue; the monologue was delivered through the mouth of a medium, probably a woman who was employed by Seishi's lineage and likely served Seishi directly. The rite probably took place in Naritoki's mansion, with none of Morosuke's descendants in attendance. Finally, it was transcribed by Sanesuke, the grandson of "Grand Minister Ononomiya" (i.e., Saneyori). Both Saneyori (Morosuke's half-brother) and Moromasa (Morosuke's full brother and the grandfather of Naritoki) were the heads of lineages the living Morosuke had viewed as his rivals.

Although the patient proper in this case is the pregnant Seishi, the therapeutic addressees of the monologue are the lineages of Moromasa and Saneyori. In particular, the monologue delivered by the parasocially conjured and constrained spirit of Morosuke enables these two lineages to construct various levels of meaning and thereby gain a degree of certainty during what was undoubtedly a very volatile moment.

First, Morosuke's monologue functions to acknowledge that Morosuke is presently suffering for his karmic sins. Although not stated directly, we can infer from the earlier discussion of courtiers who became evil *qi* unwittingly after falling into hells that Morosuke ended up there as well, hence his postmortem transformation into a disease-causing spirit. From one perspective, we might read this acknowledgment of his postmortem suffering as a gesture of compassion extended by members of his rival lineages. Indeed, the stories of those who unwittingly became evil *qi* described these figures in ways that might evoke some degree of pity in readers, since the spirits came to inflict harm on the living without intending to do so. In Morosuke's case, compassion is clearly replaced by condemnation. Through the words of the medium, Morosuke's spirit is made

to confess his karmic crimes (selfish concern for his own lineage, malicious wishing, and using Buddhist and non-Buddhist magic to curse his rivals). His own confession leaves little doubt that his present suffering in hell is the result of his own criminal intentions and actions, his personal karmic history as it was inscribed into the memory of his rival lineages at court. Moreover, the violence that he inflicts on Seishi as disease is framed as the continuation of those crimes, which not even his death could extinguish. By his own account—as it is channeled through the words of a medium—Morosuke is made a villain, concerned not for the well-being of those he afflicts but only (and still rather selfishly) that his maledictions will soon reach their expiration date.

For the members of Morosuke's rival lineages, his confession provides knowledge that is not quite comforting. They discover, after all, they are haunted by a spirit still running hot on a corrupt karmic engine, malediction expiration dates notwithstanding. At least the ritual elucidation brings cognitive closure to certain mysteries of urgent concern for these lineages. For one thing, Morosuke's confession provides a compelling explanation for Seishi's illness, a great concern given that she is in a vulnerable state due to her pregnancy. The rite also helps these lineages piece together an account for the recent failures they experienced in court politics and life, failures for which blame can be shifted onto Morosuke, an object of shared antagonism.

Historical facts support the possibility that Saneyori's and Moromasa's descendants would have seen things like this. Although Morosuke was not without his own setbacks in life, his line was by far the most successful of those implicated here. In recent years, his son Kaneie had dominated court politics as regent, chancellor, and minister of the right. This set the stage for Kaneie's own son, Michinaga, to extend the political monopoly even further. Thus, the members of these lineages would have had good reason to feel resentment toward Morosuke's line—and to suspect that malicious activities were behind their own failures to secure comparable fortunes. In this way, communication between spirit and priest that possession rite performances were meant to occasion allowed for the living to validate their resentments and confirm their suspicions. In this case, it also seems to have provided an opportunity for two court lineages of the Fujiwara family to come together in solidarity against a third, more successful line.<sup>79</sup>

What the possession rite has elucidated in the case of Morosuke's spirit amounts to an indictment, and there is no indication that members of his rival lineages sought to appease his spirit by cultivating and transferring merit, repentance-by-proxy, prayers for a better rebirth, or posthumous investiture of title or rank. In other cases, the possession rite provided a framework for more diplomatic interactions. In these cases, concerned and implicated patrons used the possession rite to establish a *modus vivendi* with the offending spirit,

often by giving the spirit some honor, position, or project they sought while they were alive. In these cases, the afflicted lineage continued to operate as a patient, but it is also clear that another “patient” was also being addressed: the disease-causing spirit.

The spirit of the priest Gashō illustrates how such exchanges worked to bring therapeutic resolution to spirit disease.<sup>80</sup> On the twenty-second day of the fifth month in 1015, Gashō’s spirit afflicted Emperor Sanjō, making Gashō one of several perpetrators (along with Fujiwara no Motokata) blamed for irritating the emperor’s eyes. Gashō’s spirit disclosed that his haunting had a purpose. He sought to receive the position of abbot of the Tendai school, the most powerful clerical office of the day and one that was denied to him before his death. Emperor Sanjō was inclined to hand it over, despite initial resistance from Michinaga, who pointed to a lack of precedent for such a posthumous investiture. The strongest resistance came two days later from Tendai’s present abbot, Keien 慶円 (alt. Kyōen, 944–1019), who was undoubtedly indignant at being dragged into the whole spectral soap opera. After being firmly denied by the sitting abbot, Gashō’s spirit modified his request from abbot to archbishop (*sōjō*), whereupon a resolution came into the picture: The court posthumously awarded him that position in the next month.

Emperor Sanjō no doubt believed his investiture of Gashō’s spirit would help cure his eyes. The posthumous conferral of rank, title, and office to quell disaster and disease was a tradition that went back to rituals for pacifying vengeful spirits since the early Heian period.<sup>81</sup> In addition to healing, this example reveals how the possession rite occasionally functioned as an intervention in court politics, specifically by allowing politics to carry on after relevant parties had left the realm of the living. Monks and courtiers did not necessarily see eye to eye in this regard. Commenting on Keien’s refusal to posthumously grant Gashō the position of abbot to save the emperor’s eyes, Sanesuke wrote: “Even if the request was granted, it would cause no trouble for the abbot. It’s not that they would unseat a living person from the position and give it to the dead. What worries him?” After noting that precedent did exist for such procedures (perhaps a dig at Michinaga), Sanesuke remarked, “It seems that monks do not understand the affairs of the court.”<sup>82</sup> He seems to be articulating one view of the possession rite that his peers at court likely shared on occasion: When it comes to resentful spirits, Buddhist monks may prompt the conversation—but it is those at court who finish it.

From this perspective, the possession rite as a vehicle of communication constituted a curious interface. As a ritual orchestrated by Buddhist monks, it was situated beyond the routine ceremonial affairs of Heian politics. Precisely because it operated just outside conventional politics—often in the mansions of aristocrats, rather than in the imperial palace—it provided a medium for

elucidating a host of resentments and animosities otherwise disallowed by court customs and those in power who controlled such customs, Michinaga being a recurrent example. The useful liminality of the possession rite's communicative function was paralleled by the parasocial interface it established between the living and the dead and between patients and metapathents.

That said, the efficacy of the possession rite was, to be sure, variably understood, and one aspect of that efficacy was more firmly planted in the purview of Buddhist monks: the spirit's conversion. In one segment of the possession rite, priests would preach to the spirit, hoping to guide it back to the righteous path. That the spirit needed conversion was clear from one meaning of the term "evil *qi*" (*jake*), the most frequently used term for spirit disease. Although as we noted "evil *qi*" derived from Chinese medicine, in Japan it was interpreted through a Buddhist lens. The *ja* or "deviance" of *jake* referred to the erroneous, false, and heretical. Hence, to a Buddhist priest, the *qi* of such spirits was misaligned karmically: Their present maligned nature was the consequence of the morally deviant behavior they engaged in over previous lifetimes, such as with Tōru's killing and Morosuke's cursing. Accordingly, therapeutic logic necessitated that the priest get the twisted spirit straightened out.

That priests in Heian Japan assumed this role of karmic chiropractors is made explicit in the following passage from the "Procedures for the Efficacious Ones." We read the priest's script of the mini-sermon by which he addressed, and thereby sought to realign, the gremlin's moral deviance. It starts with a short preface that clarifies the sermon's purpose:

To every member of the sagely assembly of the esoteric gods, please assist my spellwork! When I extricate the disease from this sick person and they attain relief thereby, I eliminate the karma of the [offending] spirit-demon [*ryōki* 靈鬼] and cause them to gain a mind of compassion. I castigate the demon by saying: "It's because of your attachments that you restlessly wander around the unfavorable paths of rebirth and use your suffering as justification to make others suffer. What merit, though, does it bring you to continually magnify the suffering of others? When will you find release? In fact, it's when you bring relief to another that the self finds relief. Bodhisattvas increase in happiness by taking on the suffering of others. Your ceaseless anguish is thus simply a consequence of how things work. I have begun to see this myself. The wellspring of great suffering derives from causing others to suffer. I reprimand you, but it's because I take pity on the person who now suffers this affliction and not, demon, because I hate you. Therefore, I assume the authority of the Buddha-Dharma to bring release to the sick one as well as to you demon, with the goal of leading you to the correct view."<sup>83</sup>

If the priest is healing the ailing patient here, the patient is not in the direct pathway of therapeutic action. Rather, the priest heals the patient through a program of propaganda aimed at the disease-causing entity. The priest seeks to convince the miserable wraith that a superior existence in the transmigratory system of rebirths is one without karmic inflammation, one without attachments and ill will toward others. The “correct view” (*shōken* 正見) to which the priest seeks to lead the demon is precisely the opposite of the demon’s maligned and perverse perspective, what in many Buddhist contexts would be called *jaken* 邪見 (mistaken or wicked view), using the same character *ja* used in *jake*. By incorporating a segment of preaching, the possession rite functioned as a remedy for the moral waywardness of warped spirits.

The importance of conversion is also clear from the priest’s ritual deployment of a metaperson with righteous muscle: the Dharma Protector (Gohō). As noted already, before transferring the spirit into the body of the medium, the priest ritually injected the minor deity known as the Dharma Protector. One purpose of this injection was to protect and empower the body of the medium, since it would become host to a volatile and violent spirit. The terminology provides a clue as to why that would be the case. Just as the term “evil *qi*” marked the spirit’s malign karma, Gohō also evokes karma, but its eradication.<sup>84</sup> The Dharma Protector was seen as an incarnation of the dharma, the Buddhist teachings. Like Buddhists elsewhere in the world, monks in Japan were convinced there was no better medicine for the illness of karmic deviance than the dharma itself, so the ritual injection of the Dharma Protector would have been imagined as a booster of righteousness meant to counteract the rotten moral condition of the invasive spirit. From the perspective of Buddhist *genza*, the problem of spirit disease was best solved not by political procedures, as their noble patrons may have assumed, but by moral therapy conducted postmortem. Better late than never, the remedy of the dharma, whether preached by the priest or incarnated by a minor deity, was what pathogenic spirits needed.

#### THE ORIGINS OF THE POSSESSION RITE

Having described the possession rite and discussed how it was imagined to work on the spectral agents of evil *qi*, I take a step back to ask larger questions: How should we understand its creation in Heian Japan? Why did it come to assume a near dominant status as the primary healing ritual commissioned by courtiers against spirit disease? After considering received views on the origins of the possession rite in Heian Japan, I discuss the rite’s development in terms of ritual immunity, the messy and experimental processes by which healing rituals come into existence as responses to diseases and other threatening agents.

Broadly speaking, two divergent interpretations have been proposed to explain the origins of the possession rite. According to an older view, proposed by literary scholars like Ivan Morris, the possession rite represented a Buddhist ritual accommodation of indigenous beliefs and practices surrounding the *kami* of Japan—what is typically referred to as Shinto. In this view, since the foreign religion of Buddhism was fundamentally rational in its doctrines and did not originally contain “shamanistic” elements such as possession and exorcism, the appearance of those elements in Buddhist ritual in Japan must represent an assimilation on the part of the clergy to patently native ways of interacting with local gods and spirits.

This older view is not entirely without merit in at least one aspect: The possession rite displays similarities with medium-focused *kami* rites. Indeed, Tokunaga Seiko has recently demonstrated that the language used to describe aspects of the possession rite in diaries and stories parallels terminology describing possession by *kami* and the oracles delivered thereby.<sup>85</sup> For example, the verb *yoru* (to possess, come near, obey), which appears in one term for the possession rite “medium” (*yorimashi*), was often used to describe possession by *kami*. The same is true of *tsuku* 付く (to possess, attach, touch), a verb used to describe possession by evil *qi* that appears in *monotsuki* 物付き (another term for the possession rite’s medium in later sources); this term was sometimes written *taku* 託, which, in the context of *kami* rites, can refer to an oracle from a *kami*.<sup>86</sup> As noted above, *mononoke* sometimes turned out to be spirits not of recently departed humans but of *kami*, suggesting that both human spirits and *kami* fit equally into the category of *mono*, those vaguely defined unseen entities with deleterious *qi* influence.

Besides these terminological overlaps, cultic practices surrounding the *kami* provide little insight into the historical development of the possession rite in the late tenth century. Moreover, proponents of the older view brought to their perspective of the possession rite a normative and outdated understanding of Buddhism informed by Protestant idealizations. According to that understanding, Buddhism is an “enlightened” religion in a modern Western sense, eschewing magical and “superstitious” ideas and practices. It is clear to scholars now that this perspective is limited and warped. As the groundbreaking scholarship of Michel Strickmann has demonstrated, possession, exorcism, and demonology are not in any way alien to Buddhism, not least to esoteric Buddhism, the body of Buddhist ritual techniques that rose to prominence in Heian Japan.<sup>87</sup>

Strickmann argued that the development of the possession rite in Japan is best understood in light of the impact of esoteric Buddhism and its ritual scripts on Heian society. His view represents the second major interpretation of the origins of the possession rite in scholarship. “It may turn out, upon analysis,” he wrote, “that the wave of demonomania that swept over the Japanese aristocracy

[i.e., the proliferation of evil *qi* spirits] was to a large extent iatrogenic, produced by the monkish physicians themselves.”<sup>88</sup> In other words, by performing the possession rite on a regular basis for elite patrons—performances based on imported ritual scripts—Buddhist priests may have generated the pathological problem of spirit disease the rite was performed to treat.

The effect of esoteric Buddhism and its textual and ritual culture on the development of the possession rite in Heian Japan is undeniable. How to understand the broader impact of esoteric Buddhism on ritual healing in medieval Japan is an abiding concern of this book. But here I wish to stress that the development of the possession rite cannot be grasped only in terms of the influence of foreign ritual scripts on local therapeutic practice. Indeed, we have already seen how the notion of spirit disease—the target of the possession rite—was a home-grown product of the culture of resentment that Heian society spawned. If we are to come to terms with how the possession rite emerged as a response to the specific threat of postmortem resentment posed by spirit disease, we must acknowledge not only the influence of imported esoteric ritual scripts but also how monks in Japan modified those scripts to address issues on the ground, a project of translation and adaptation that necessarily involved much contingency, creativity, and experimentation.

#### DERIVATION, DIVERGENCE, AND EXPERIMENTS IN EXORCISM

One of the more thought-provoking theories of the origins of the possession rite to be advanced in recent years, one that we might take as a more productive starting point, was proposed by Ueno Katsuyuki. Ueno raised the intriguing possibility that the earliest cases of possession by spirits in the context of esoteric rituals may have been spontaneous, not intentional. During ritual performances to treat spirit possession, he speculates, even though no deliberate attempts were made by priests to induce possession in a medium, the malignant spirits may have made the leap from the ailing victim they were possessing to a member of the audience, gripping them with possession.

Some textual evidence suggests such happenings. According to one early story about Empress Samedono's 染殿皇后 (828–900) affliction in 899, the healing rite performed by a mountain ascetic summoned to treat her was interrupted when a female retainer in attendance suddenly broke out in disordered and mad speech, as if she was delivering words of the gods. In response, the ascetic spellbound the attendant, whereupon a fox (or its spirit) emerged from her robe, causing Samedono's condition to improve. This case is different from the typical pattern we have discussed, for it involved a fox spirit. However, it allows us to imagine how spontaneous possession of someone who was not the victim might have occurred and provides an early case in which a transfer of a



spirit from the victim's body to that of an attendant was observed to improve the victim's condition.<sup>89</sup>

At the same time, there are some issues with Ueno's hypothesis. First, it is difficult to accurately date the Somedono episode. More important, similar examples from the interim period before the development of the possession rite in the late tenth century have yet to be found. The only exception, a rather clear-cut case of spontaneous possession involving an unwitting medium, comes later in the period for an event dated 1015, from *A Tale of Flowering Fortunes*: "Michinaga prayed with frantic energy, the tears streaming from his eyes, and the possessing spirit fled to a nearby lady-in-waiting, someone who had never acted as a medium before."<sup>90</sup>

We can easily imagine how priests in such situations would have recognized the therapeutic potential of what were otherwise ritual accidents. Observing such unexpected leaps of the spirits, some priests may have had the composure to improvise, redirecting ritual action to the unprepared medium, which is just what seems to have happened for Empress Somedono. However the possession rite first came about, for possession to occur regularly and predictably, it seems evident that priests would have realized they needed to cultivate and master techniques for spirit conjuration and relocation. Such experiments, they must have reasoned, would allow them to gain the ability to artificially produce possessions on command and, to the extent possible, control them in a ritual setting and guide them toward therapeutic resolution.

As best as scholars have been able to determine, priests did commence such ritual experimentation, first by digging further into the textual archive of the ritual scripts they or their lineage forebears imported from China. As much recent scholarship has demonstrated, priests in Heian Japan discovered a set of ritual techniques in esoteric liturgical literature that promised them the possession-inducing abilities they sought: the techniques known as *abisha* 阿尾奢 (Ch. *aweishe*), a term that transliterates the Sanskrit *āveśa*, meaning "spirit possession."

The techniques of *āveśa*, which were described in numerous esoteric scriptures imported to Japan, clearly became ritual templates for priests in the Heian period. Two examples convey the basic procedures as they were known in Japan. One key source was the *Sūtra of the Questions of Subāhu* (*Supohu tongzi qingwen jing* 蘇婆呼童子請問經). This work's significance for the development of the possession rite in Japan is evident in the fact that it is mentioned by name in the "Procedures for Efficacious Ones," one of the only extant prescriptive sources on the possession rite produced in Japan.<sup>91</sup> The *Sūtra of the Questions of Subāhu* describes a ritual in which a priest is to select a young virgin boy or boys, purify them, have them sit in a mandala, and use various techniques to summon into their body the deity Bosina 鉢私那 (or Susina 速私那).<sup>92</sup> Once possession has

been secured, the priest can ask Bosina questions about “things past, present, and future, of profit and loss, of suffering and joy.”<sup>93</sup>

Similarly, the *Instantly Efficacious Āveśa Ritual Explained by Maheśvara* (*Suji liyan Moxishouluotian shuo aweishe fa* 速疾立驗魔醯首羅天說阿尾奢法, T 1277) contains a method for having Garuḍa, the messenger and mount of the god Maheśvara, possess children. The induced possession of “four or five virgin girls or boys of about seven or eight years of age” would allow the ritualist, through a series of questions, to “know future auspicious and inauspicious events, success and failure.”<sup>94</sup> From the possessed child the ritualist may also “learn of drought and inundations, aggression by neighboring states, rebellions by wicked persons, and all manner of good and evil portents.”

As these examples show, the *āveśa* rite prescribed in imported esoteric liturgical scriptures was similar to the possession rite practiced in Heian Japan in several ways. Both were esoteric ritual practices in which a child or young person serves as a medium into which the presence and voice of unseen spirit entities are conjured. As such, there can be little doubt that priests in Japan drew on *āveśa* prescriptions when they began to experiment with techniques for harnessing and controlling spontaneous possession by malign spirits. It is equally evident, however, that priests in Heian Japan did not merely perform *āveśa* procedures exactly as they were prescribed in imported ritual scripts. As we saw in chapter 1 with numerous examples from the Jimon lineage, monks in Heian Japan were not only ritual performers but also innovative ritual designers who made earnest efforts to tailor their rites to better respond to the afflictions plaguing their patients. We should not be surprised that the possession rite they developed over the late tenth and early eleventh centuries diverged in important ways from textual prescriptions of *āveśa*.

There were three primary areas of divergence. First, in esoteric liturgical texts, *āveśa* techniques are described as effective for facilitating possession in child mediums for the purpose of gaining knowledge about what is good and evil, auspicious and inauspicious; in other words, the function of *āveśa* was oracular or divinatory. In the possession rite in Heian Japan, by contrast, the ritualist facilitated possession of the medium for the purpose of engaging with—relocating, conversing with, appeasing, converting, subjugating, expelling—spirits who cause disease. It is true that when priests, patients, and other family members were able to communicate with spirits in the possession rite, they acquired useful knowledge. But the knowledge was not about the future so much as the past, the personal past of the malign spirit: their disappointments, unresolved grievances, traumatic death, and lingering karma. The purpose of acquiring such knowledge was above all therapeutic, the goal of the ritual being to cure the afflicted, whether that be the ailing patient proper, the afflicted lineage, or the karmically misaligned spirit.

The second way the possession rite diverged from *āveśa* pertains to the nature of the spirits conjured. Because the purpose of *āveśa* was to summon a god who will helpfully convey useful knowledge, summoning disease-causing agents or other threatening demons constituted at best an accident on the ritual job and at worst an immediate danger. It is telling that works such as the *Sūtra of the Questions of Subāhu* took pains to describe the differences between signs indicating that the desired deity (Bosina) possessed the child and those indicating the presence of a demon. A ritualist who has done their homework will know how to spot the unwelcomed presence of a demon in the body of the child medium: “In that case their eyes are red and rounded, like those of someone glaring in anger. The pupils of their eyes do not move around, and their mouths gape open in fright. In this case, too, they neither breathe in or out nor blink their eyes.”<sup>95</sup> In the context of *āveśa*, knowing these signs is critical because demonic entities pose a threat to the child medium, whose body has been purified and prepared to receive a benevolent god. Moreover, unwanted demons will fail to supply the desired information. In fact, given that priests might accidentally summon those obstacle-creating entities known as *māras*, the data coming through the possessed child would surely turn out to be disinformation meant to thwart the rite and its cure. In addition to tips for correctly discerning between possessing agents, esoteric scriptures provided fail-safe techniques for expelling any unwanted guests immediately. Ritualists who find themselves in this hazardous scenario, the *Sūtra of the Questions of Subāhu* admonishes, should “begin chanting auspicious verses, recite the mantra of the Impure Furious Vajra-Being (Ususama Myōō), or read out the *Great Dhāraṇī-Book Collection*.”<sup>96</sup> If these techniques fail, the ritualist should perform a fire ceremony dedicated to Kuṇḍalin.

Priests in Heian Japan were certainly aware of the potential hazards of soliciting an unwanted guest from the darkness. For this reason, the “Procedures for Efficacious Ones” produced in Japan encourages readers to consult the *Sūtra of the Questions of Subāhu* for information about the various types of spirits that might make their way, invited or not, into the medium’s body.<sup>97</sup> Yet these textual prescriptions and warnings differ markedly from the possession rite as it was actually practiced in the Heian period, the whole point of which was to summon a malign, demon-like spirit. Indeed, the possession rite assumes that if the patient’s condition is to improve at all, it is precisely such harmful metapersons that must be made manifest in the medium.

It is striking that these two ways the Heian-period possession rite diverged from esoteric liturgical prescriptions have been noted for rites of exorcism in China in nearly the same period. The Song period saw the rise in popularity of rites of exorcism involving child mediums. These rites were performed by esoteric Buddhist monks and Daoist exorcists known as Ritual Masters (*fashi* 法師).

Like the Heian possession rite, these rites can be formally traced back to precedents in esoteric liturgical texts, particularly the *āveśa* prescriptions. However, as Edward Davis has argued, whereas in *āveśa* “the function of the children was clearly mediumistic and oracular,” the Song rituals were focused squarely on exorcism and therapy. Unlike the earlier function of the medium in prescriptive esoteric texts, who “do not appear to have been acting as vehicles for demonic possession or as surrogates for a demoniac,” this was clearly their purpose in the exorcistic rites that exploded in popularity during the Song.<sup>98</sup>

This brings me to the third major divergence, which pertains to the medium. Ritual texts prescribing *āveśa* indicate that when selecting a medium, the ritualist ought to choose a child of seven or eight years of age, sometimes specifying that they should be virgins and boys. This was presumably because children lack a solidified identity and are uncontaminated by sexual impurities, thus they would most transparently reflect the presence of the induced god or spirit. The “Procedures of the Efficacious Ones,” written in Japan, repeats similar instructions, demonstrating the close relationship between this prescriptive text and its equally prescriptive inspirations in the esoteric ritual corpus. However, records from the Heian period reveal three important facts about who served as spirit medium in practice, pointing to notable differences from *āveśa* prescriptions. First, mediums were most often women. Second, insofar as it is possible to determine their ages, these women were typically older than the children prescribed in imported ritual texts. Third, these women possessed a social identity that was not based abstractly on age, gender, or sexual maturity: What defined their identity was that they belonged to the household of the aristocratic patient, sometimes as relatives but mostly as attendants or ladies-in-waiting.<sup>99</sup>

Women of such a profile becoming mediums in practice makes good sense, given that priests performed the possession rite in aristocratic mansions, where they were surrounded by a captive audience of household members and servants. If the possession rite originated with causes of spontaneous possession, as Ueno suggests, it would make sense that the most likely to be possessed would have been the women of the mansion, who routinely gathered to watch rituals unfold. Yet there is no indication from extant historical sources that priests were in any rush to replace these amateur (and at first probably unwitting) mediums with prepared or professional ones. Priests in Heian Japan were thus not strictly following *āveśa* prescriptions, which instruct the ritualist on how to prepare a fitting medium. This also meant that priests were not trying to capitalize on some of the obvious advantages that preparing mediums might bring, including the fact that prepped mediums could be made familiar with “successful” outcomes before actual performances; they could be trained in methods of communication and scripts that better aligned with the desired

ritual goals, such as diplomatic communication with spirits; and they would be more receptive to the priest's instructions.

By using unrehearsed mediums in the possession rite, priests risked leaving the door open to various unpredictable contingencies, accidents that might potentially compromise the success of therapeutic performance. But since priests continued to retain such unprepared mediums—and disregard instructions for *āveśa* in their ritual scripts—we can assume they recognized the unusual advantages of having this specific kind of medium participate in the rite for treating spirit disease. It is not difficult to understand why. After all, these mediums were embedded in aristocratic households. Bound by service and trust to those who employed them—often including the ailing individual—these mediums would have been regularly exposed to rumors about interlineage affairs, matters that would have been of direct relevance for interacting with spirits in the possession rite. For example, servants and retainers of the patient's household would know who at court had recently passed away and under what conditions, with which peer lineage relations were now tense or had been so in the recent past, what specific animosities and resentments might be directed at the household to which they belonged, and who was cursing whom.

Embedded mediums constituted key nodes in what Heather Blair has called the “relational agency” of aristocratic lineage networks in the Heian period. As she notes, “people of high rank and status commanded extensive networks of agents.”<sup>100</sup> It was through the “cooperation between high- and low-status partners” making up these networks that various activities of significance for the lineage were accomplished, including the management of estates, material exchanges with other members of the court, and of course ritual activities.<sup>101</sup> This cooperation in aristocratic households seems to have extended to the possession rites led by outside but sympathetic actors, Buddhist priests.

The incorporation of lineage-embedded women in the possession rite had two positive consequences for Buddhist ritual healing. First, by employing these women as mediums, priests could respond much more precisely to the pathological problem as their patrons and patients saw them, their mental model of disease. Spirit disease was primarily a matter of somatic violence wrought by spectral metapersons bearing specific resentments toward the patient's lineage. Embedded mediums clarified the precise nature of these resentments, not only because they manifested the spirit in their bodies but also because they had relevant social and spectral data as members of the network coalescing around their lineage and mansion. The possession rite could not prove successful in any meaningful way to elite patrons and patients without the collaborative relationships and affective resonance between high-ranking aristocrats and the lower-ranking women who participated as mediums, through which critical knowledge about court life could be captured and enacted in performances.

Thus, although the possession rite was undoubtedly an esoteric Buddhist ritual performed by a priest versed in esoteric scriptures, its success was highly dependent on the dynamics of relational agency that operated within and was specific to lineages of the nobility.

A second positive consequence is that the possession rite would have made the efficacy of esoteric ritual healing much more tangible and immediate for aristocratic patrons. Altar rites, such as those we described in chapter 1, were often performed on distant mountain temples, typically without an audience of patrons. Although letters could be sent to and from these temples—with reports of what sutras and spells were being chanted, what auspicious signs had manifested during the rite, and if the rite had successfully concluded—altar rituals performed from afar could not provide patrons with the opportunity to see in what ways or how the ritual was working. Confidence in ritual efficacy would have to depend on secondary information and trust in the ritualists, a quality that would have been fragile and unsteady. Above all, altar rites performed at a distance provided patrons with much less material for the meaning-making that was essential to see such practices as having tangible effects on the lineage and its members.

In contrast, because the possession rite incorporated a woman of the household as medium, the priest performed it for an immediate audience of patrons in their very mansion. There, the effects of the ritual were given expression of an especially captivating and enthralling sort. At the center of the performance was the body of the medium, whose trembling, groaning, and trances (which Sei Shōnagon describes well in her account) articulated the spirit's presence and the ritual's power. Through the possession rite, patrons and other household members could watch resentful spirits being subjugated by priests as a ritual process in real time, no longer an abstract ritual objective or invisible effect that had to be imagined. The efficacy of the possession rite would have displayed an immediacy that patrons would not necessarily have experienced to the same degree with altar rituals. Indeed, in the cases in which the possession rite prompted interactions and diplomacy with the spirit, the next steps of the therapeutic process were often entrusted to members of the patron's lineages, such as sponsoring additional rituals for the spirit or posthumously offering titles and positions. Thus, by diverging from esoteric ritual tradition, priests secured for ritual healing a reality it may not have had before in Japan.

I began this chapter with Sei Shōnagon's visit to an aristocratic mansion, where she happened upon a ritual exorcism led by a Buddhist priest. What she saw that day was the possession rite, which by that time had been formalized to a considerable degree. Indeed, Sei promptly recognized that the young girl brought

into the room would serve as spirit medium, suggesting this was not her first time witnessing a healing ritual against the evil dead.

As we have seen, the possession rite did not appear simply by virtue of the transmission of esoteric liturgical scripts from abroad. Instead, it was an innovative ritual that came into being through a complex process I examined in the framework of ritual immunity: a response by priests to a specific pathological problem, one that drew on relevant ritual resources, engaged metapersons seen to cause the disease, and was hammered out through a process of localizing liturgical practices while leaning into unpredictable developments on the ground. Although it is difficult to precisely reconstruct the initial development of the rite, there is no doubt that its creation became possible only when priests began to pay attention to the voices of resentful spirits afflicting their clients and formed a productive alliance with women of aristocratic households, those who proved capable of channeling those spirits in ritual performance.

Given the many ungovernable contingencies involved in this process of ritual adaption, experimentation, and performance, we should not forget to be astonished at how well the possession rite seemed to go in actual practice. As Sei's account suggests, once the priestly ghostbuster expelled the spirit and his job was done, he was celebrated and compensated, and all in attendance hoped he would return soon to reproduce the ritual's salubrious effects. It is true that performances of the possession rite did not always go as well as the one Sei described. But her account speaks to what was a frequent experience throughout the mid-Heian period. Because such ritual success was frequent, even routine, the possession rite undoubtedly also succeeded in inspiring among the aristocracy new confidence in the efficacy of esoteric rituals for healing. As we shall see in chapter 3, monks of the Jimon lineage played a major role in that process.

## CHAPTER 3

### The Ghostbusters of Onjōji



IN THE FIFTH MONTH OF 1239, ILLNESS CAME FOR KUJŌ MICHIIIE 九条道家 (1193–1252).<sup>1</sup> As chieftain of the prominent Kujō branch of the Fujiwara family, regent to the emperor, and father to the fourth shogun presiding over the warrior government in Kamakura, Michiie was a statesman of otherwise unparalleled political authority, but his luck was running out. Some years before, warriors had squashed his coup to reinstate the emperor. In the span of just two years, he lost his son and daughter. In 1239, while residing at Hosshōji, the Fujiwara clan temple he had big plans to revamp, Michiie found himself bedridden with an affliction caused by a dense swarm of disquieted spirits, reflecting, as one scholar put it, the “mandala of conflicts” that engulfed the embattled politician.<sup>2</sup>

Fortunately for Michiie, he was not left to fend for himself. To his aid came a monk of the Jimon lineage of the Tendai school. Keisei was Michiie’s older brother, a Kujō sibling who chose a career in the monastery rather than at court. Presumably in response to a letter for help, Keisei left his temple Hokkesanji 法華山寺 in the western outskirts of Heiankyō and arrived at Hosshōji. He used ritual techniques to incite the primary spirit afflicting Michiie to possess instead a twenty-one-year-old woman, the wife of one of Michiie’s retainers. From midnight until daybreak over several nights, Keisei tirelessly communicated with the spirit, probing the motivations of the ghosts afflicting his patient. On the third day, he brokered a deal. Keisei promised to cultivate some merit for the spirit provided it bless Michiie’s new monastery with protection that only a divine spirit can bestow. In the end, Michiie survived his illness and went on to build what became the great Zen temple Tōfukuji 東福寺 on the grounds of Hosshōji, the same Hosshōji that centuries before resounded with the commanding voice of Michinaga.

As the previous chapter demonstrated, long before Michiie’s time, the Heian aristocracy was plagued almost daily by spirit disease, a problem that called for no less than therapeutic ghostbusters. Popular and academic accounts have at times identified the “ghostbusters” of Heian Japan as the yin-yang masters (*onmyōji*), especially the figure who came to great notoriety in later history,



Abe no Haruaki (Seimei).<sup>3</sup> Some yin-yang masters were involved with managing pathogenic spirits, particularly when it came to diagnosing the disease through divination. However, therapeutic battles against the evil dead were fought most energetically by Buddhist monks, especially those who went by the title *genza*.

There has been some scholarly confusion as to the precise identity of these *genza*, the performers of the possession rite. Much research assumed that because they associated with professional spirit mediums, *genza* belonged to a lower social class, and thus ranked far below monks of elite monasteries such as Tōji, Enryakuji, and Onjōji. In turn, those scholars associated the elite monasteries and their monks with the performance of elaborate ceremonies such as altar rituals.

It is now clear that scholars conflated the *genza* of the Heian period, whose activities we glean primarily through diaries written by courtiers, with the *genza* of later periods, whose image comes primarily from later illustrated narrative sources, such as the Kamakura-period *Illustrated Miracles of the Kasuga Deity* from 1309. The *genza* depicted in these later sources seem to have been of lower social status and circulated not only in aristocratic spheres but also among the common people. These *genza* did associate with spirit mediums, who were also not always officially affiliated with elite institutions. Earlier research also worked with the false assumption that because the possession rite involved spirit possession and mediumship, it must have constituted a popular form of religion better suited for the lower classes, one that differs in character from the more complex ritual and doctrinal system of esoteric Buddhism at elite monasteries.<sup>4</sup>

In fact, as we have already seen, the possession rite derived in important ways from the complex ritual system of esoteric Buddhism. Moreover, newer research of courtier diaries has revealed that *genza* of the Heian and early Kamakura periods were high-ranking monks hailing from major elite monasteries. They were often the same monks who performed esoteric altar rituals. *Genza* were in fact known in every major monastic lineage. In the tumultuous Era of Regents, for example—when pathogenic spirits began haunting the living members of the court—*genza* from Shingon lineages included the monks Ningai 仁海 (951–1046), Jinkaku 深覚 (955–1043), and Saiku 済救 (dates unknown). The Sanmon branch boasted its own *genza*, including the monks Jinkō 尋光 (dates unknown), Genken 源賢 (977–1020), Eizō 叡増 (dates unknown), and Eikō 叡効 (dates unknown).

The most noteworthy constituent of *genza* were monks belonging to the Jimon lineage. Diary entries written from over the entire Heian period demonstrate that Jimon *genza* were the most numerous and performed the possession rite more frequently than monks of rival lineages. It also seems that they provided therapeutic services in the way of the possession rite to the highest-ranking patrons, including Senior Grand Empress Shōshi, Emperor Sanjō, Michinaga,

his son Yorimichi, Emperor Go-Ichijō, and Emperor Horikawa, among many others.<sup>5</sup> In the early Kamakura period, the Jimon monk Keisei was summoned to treat the great statesman Michiie, which was not simply a consequence of their blood relation, although that surely had something to do with it. Rather, Keisei's employment was also a recognition of the distinctive ritual signature Jimon monks had forged by that time in the field of therapeutic ghostbusting.

Following the roughly chronological and episodic approach adopted in chapter 1, here I discuss the ways Jimon *genza* developed and used the possession rite over the Heian period and in the process became the preeminent ghostbusters of the age. Recalling the notion of immunitary relations, I spotlight how Jimon monks used the possession rite against spirit disease to solidify their ties with important members of the aristocracy, thereby securing their external protection—by way of patronage—as they boosted the aristocracy's protection against the evil dead.

## ENCHIN AND EARLY EXPERIMENTS WITH INDUCED POSSESSION

To understand how Jimon monks came to acquire their reputation as *genza* and performers of the possession rite, it is necessary to trace the beginnings of the procedures for inducing spirit possession, or *āveśa*, in the reception of esoteric Buddhism in the early Heian period. One might be tempted to trace the beginnings of *āveśa* in Japan to Kūkai 空海 (774–835), the founder of the Shingon school. Indeed, Kūkai introduced to Japan key aspects of esoteric ritual practice that were linked to *āveśa* and to ritual healing, including the category of wrathful deities known as the wisdom kings (*myōō*) like Fudō, the practice of empowerment (*kaji*), which Kūkai applied in healing scenarios, and esoteric sutras that prescribed *āveśa* procedures.<sup>6</sup> Moreover, as Michel Strickmann points out, *āveśa* procedures were carried out by Huiguo 慧果 (746–806), Kūkai's teacher in China. Summoned before the emperor, Huiguo reportedly used ritual techniques that caused spirits to possess eight young boys, whereupon the children were able to answer the emperor's questions.<sup>7</sup>

Direct evidence that Kūkai performed *āveśa* in Japan, however, is still lacking. This has led other scholars to suggest that the roots of *āveśa* in Japan lie with the Tendai Sanmon monk Sōō 相応 (831–918), a disciple of Ennin who founded the temple Mudōji 無動寺 on Mt. Hiei. Sōō's hagiography, *Tendai nanzan Mudōji konryū oshō den* 天台南山無動寺建立和尚伝, mentions a case in 861 in which he reportedly uses incantations to cause the deity Matsuo Myōjin 松尾明神 to possess a youth and thereby receive divine oracles. Aside from the similarity to descriptions of *āveśa* in esoteric literature, the passage is significant because it constitutes the only known *setsuwa* tale to explicitly use the

Japanese transliteration for *āveśa*, *abisha*. However, as Ueno Katsuyuki points out, because this hagiography dates to the eleventh century—during which time the therapeutic form of *yorimashi kaji* was already well established—its reliability as a record of the earliest account of *āveśa* in Japan is tenuous.<sup>8</sup>

In fact, the earliest experiments with techniques of spirit possession in Heian Japan seem to have been conducted by the patriarch of the Jimon lineage, Enchin. The evidence, which survives in a manuscript in Enchin's own hand, is a work known as *Enchin's Questions* (*Enchin gimon* 円珍疑問), a more polished draft of an earlier text known as *Trivial Questions* (*Sasa gimon* 些々疑文). The work contains a letter along with a list of questions Enchin addressed to one of his esoteric mentors during his sojourn in Tang China, Zhihuilun 智恵輪 (Prajñacakra, ?–875/876). Enchin studied with Zhihuilun in 855 or 856, and he continued his exchanges with his teacher after he returned to Japan from China in 858, including Zhihuilun sending eight scriptures to Enchin in 861.<sup>9</sup> *Enchin's Questions*, which Enchin sent abroad in 882, reflects those ongoing exchanges.

One of the questions about which Enchin sought clarity pertained to *āveśa*, spirit possession. In the preface to the question, Enchin indicates that some of his disciples have been practicing the *āveśa* rite for invoking the deity Maheśvara (Makeishuraten 魔醯首羅天). This rite was prescribed in the *Instantly Efficacious Āveśa Ritual Explained by Maheśvara*, a scripture many Japanese monks picked up while abroad in China, including Kūkai, Ennin, Eun 恵運 (798–869), and Enchin.<sup>10</sup> Despite the scripture's promise of instantaneous efficacy, Enchin informs Zhihuilun in his letter that his disciples have yet to succeed in “accomplishing” (*jōju* 成就) the rite, suggesting that their experiments with inducing possession had not gone well. Enchin ends this section by requesting that his master convey a direct teaching about these techniques, one that would provide information beyond what he could find in liturgical scriptures.

As it turned out, no reply was received, since Zhihuilun was deceased by the time Enchin penned his letter. Nonetheless, the letter speaks to a pivotal early moment in the history of the possession rite in Japan. Enchin's struggle with sparking possession attests to the general difficulty that many Japanese students of esoteric Buddhism in his time faced: how to reconstruct embodied practices from prescriptive textual instructions alone. More simply, his letter betrays a discernible curiosity in the special ritual method of *āveśa* and its potentials, an interest the letter suggests was shared by his immediate disciples. Despite their failed attempts to induce possession, we have no reason to believe that the disciples stopped their ritual experiments at this point. Given the fact that a rite using similar techniques for inducing possession emerged in mid-Heian Japan, and that this ritual became closely associated with Jimon monks, the early experiments of Enchin and his disciples appear to have been consequential.

Enchin likely turned his followers on to the extraordinary powers of rituals for healing and bodily transformation. Some rituals could be used to treat patrons afflicted by pathogenic agents not wholly dissimilar to the spirits with which Jimon monks later grappled in the possession rite. One such student of the early Heian period was Zōmyō 増命 (843–927). Zōmyō became abbot of Onjōji in 899 and later served a sixteen-year tenure as abbot of the Tendai school from 906 to 922.<sup>11</sup> Zōmyō not only received advanced teachings in esoteric ritual practice directly from Enchin, he also offered to his late master the posthumous title “Chishō Daishi” 智証大師. Officially bestowed by Emperor Daigo in 927, this is the name by which descendants of Enchin’s lineage thereafter used in reverence.<sup>12</sup> There is no doubt that Zōmyō’s clerical authority in the Tendai school stemmed partly from his successes as a ritual healer. In one episode from the *Abbreviated Records of Japan* (*Fusō ryakki* 扶桑略記, after ca. 1094), Zōmyō treated the illness of Emperor Daigo, which was said to be malarial fever (*gyakubyō*), a disease frequently attributed to demons and one that, as noted in chapter 1, Enchin was also said to have treated by becoming the Yellow Fudō. After Zōmyō performed the ritual, another Jimon monk, Tan’yo 湛誉 (dates unknown), reportedly witnessed a demon fleeing under the emperor’s palace.<sup>13</sup> Although there is no mention of Zōmyō using a spirit medium here, he does seem to have been using subjugation techniques against pathogenic, spirit-like entities, thus anticipating key features of the possession rite that developed several decades later.

## THE ERA OF REGENTS: MAKING THE SPIRITS SPEAK

Ritual experimentation against the resentful dead gained new urgency for monks of the Jimon lineage in the mid- to late tenth century. Several factors made this so. For one, as discussed in chapter 2, this was when members of the Jimon lineage made their exodus from Mt. Hiei and began to grow new roots around the capital of Heiankyō. With their existence called into question, the stakes for strengthening ties with the court peaked. Jimon monks met this challenge through ritual creation and performance, no doubt supported by liturgy-based experiments that Enchin had initiated earlier. Moreover, this was the period in which an increase of resentment at court precipitated the rise of pathogenic psycho-spectral entities, afflicting members of the court with newfound apprehension and disease. In developing the possession rite, Jimon monks aimed to overcome the existential crisis they were facing as a monastic lineage by ritually countering a pathological problem threatening the lives of their patrons.

One early diary entry suggests that a nascent form of the possession rite was performed in 967 by Yokei, the monk at the center of the Hosshōji abbacy controversy that led to the Jimon–Sanmon split. The entry notes that Yokei

received compensation for performing “empowerment” that led to the “subjugation” of an evil spirit afflicting Emperor Reizei, who was then suffering from madness (*kyōki* 狂気).<sup>14</sup> Several of the basic elements of the possession rite are already discernible: Responding to an “evil *qi*” spirit (*jake*), Yokei used empowerment procedures that facilitated the spirit’s subjugation. That he was compensated suggests that Yokei was successful. It is notable that around the same time, Sanmon monks like Ryōgen had performed for Reizei’s affliction the Five Altar Rite in the palace.<sup>15</sup> This contrast anticipates a key characteristic of the possession rite: Successful performances could be achieved by a single monk working independently, in contrast to the team of five monks (plus many attendants) necessary for the Five Altar Rite. If a monk of one lineage could succeed where five of a competing lineage could not, the ritual technique that made such a feat possible would have been highly valued.

Earnest development of the possession rite appears to have begun with Yokei’s disciples and grand-disciples closer to the end of the tenth century. Three monks deserve special mention: Kanju, Shōsan, and Shin’yo. Kanju was Yokei’s disciple and served as the body-protecting monk for important figures like Yukinari and Michinaga.<sup>16</sup> Kanju’s claim to fame is that he may have been one of the first to compel spirits to speak during the possession rite. In 993, when he performed a healing ritual for the ailing and pregnant Seishi, the spirit of Morosuke appeared and spoke at length about cursing two rival lineages.<sup>17</sup> Kanju reported this information to Sanesuke, who transcribed the spirit’s haunting monologue in his diary—clearly an event of great interest. Coaxing the spectral visitor to speak became a key feature of the possession rite and in many cases was seen as integral to its diplomatic efficacy. Indeed, as noted in the discussion of this event in chapter 2, the induced possession of Morosuke’s spirit enabled two court lineages implicated by the event to gain critical information and confirm their suspicions. Here we can add that Jimon monks would have found the self-incriminating appearance of Morosuke as spirit-metaperson validating for their own purposes. After all, while alive, Morosuke was a close ally and supporter of Ryōgen, the rival of Yokei and the Jimon lineage.<sup>18</sup>

Kanju also demonstrated to patrons that his ritual prowess over spirit disease could prove useful for the emergency of difficult childbirth. Such was the case in 993, when Yukinari’s wife successfully gave birth to a boy but the afterbirth was prolonged, causing concern. Yukinari suspected the foul play of evil *qi*. Acting on instinct, he immediately went to fetch Kanju and brought the monk back to his wife’s villa. Kanju is said to have performed empowerment techniques against evil *qi*. Yukinari describes with astonishment how—in the span of a single recitation by Kanju—the afterbirth was brought to a smooth conclusion. In his palpable joy, Yukinari notes that even though evil spirits had come to hinder the afterbirth, threatening the life of his beloved wife, the “Buddha’s

power” proved to be “without limit,” a statement that implicitly praises Kanju’s divine skills against the evil dead.<sup>19</sup>

A noteworthy detail of this case is that Kanju is said to have performed the rite while standing up. Although it would have been typical for monks to sit on a mat while performing the possession rite, Kanju stood, almost certainly to avoid incurring pollution due to the childbirth, a severe source of ritual defilement (*kegare*). By coming to the aid of his patrons, Kanju not only risked defilement—something that not every member of the Buddhist clergy was willing to do—he also skillfully adjusted the performance so that its efficacy would not malfunction because of proximity to the pollution that all would have understood to permeate the scene of labor.

We can understand why Yukinari kept Kanju close at hand. The two even made house calls together. About an occasion in 1002, Yukinari wrote, “When I was going to see Tametaka, the former Grand Archbishop (Kanju) came. We went together in the same carriage to the palace (of Tametaka). When Kanju was performing empowerment, the evil *qi* was subjugated.”<sup>20</sup> In another case in 1003, it was Yukinari who was stricken with illness. At first, a yin-yang master by the name of Kamo no Mitsuyoshi 賀茂光榮 (dates unknown) performed purification for him, by which they seem to have discerned that they were dealing with the “influence” (*ke*) of an evil spirit. Yukinari had the eminent Sanmon monk Keien perform empowerment together with Seizen 聖全 (dates unknown). But in his diary, Yukinari makes a point of saying that his condition improved only that evening after he was empowered by Kanju. The experience prompted him to schedule an appointment with Kanju for an altar rite the next day, which was also to involve Myōchō, a Jimon monk associated with one of the four main Jimon temples around Heiankyō, Fumonji.<sup>21</sup> This example illustrates a broader pattern that we can assume was common in this period: When a monk of one lineage succeeded in the possession rite where others fell short, elite patrons were encouraged to rely on members of the successful lineage even more. To the extent that Kanju was effective, Jimon monks came to play a larger role in Yukinari’s life, in turn reducing the latter’s reliance on monks of competing lineages, as is suggested here with Sanmon monks.<sup>22</sup>

Given Kanju’s track record, it is not surprising that later writers would remember his triumphant performances of the possession rite—and that they would do so in narratives pitting Jimon monks against Sanmon monks as rival lineages in Tendai. The *Genkō-Era Annals of Buddhism* (*Genkō shakusho* 元亨釈書, 1322) tells of the Enryakuji monk Jitsuin 実因 (945–1000) who repeatedly requested the abbacy of Hosshōji. Deemed too small a vessel for the office, Jitsuin died without receiving the honor (much like Gashō in chapter 2) and returned from the grave to exact revenge on Emperor Ichijō. Kanju performed empowerment and moved the spirit to a medium, whereupon the spirit declared: “I

am Jitsuin. My resentment towards the emperor runs deep. But now that I have been bound by a wisdom king, I shall depart." The emperor's illness was healed.<sup>23</sup> Kanju is identified here as a living wisdom king, reflecting how contemporaries identified him with Fudō, as was the case with his frequent client, Yukinari, and his reputation as efficacious wielder of the possession rite against pathogenic resentment. The story also speaks obliquely to the fact that the possession rite not only implicated sick patients and their lineages but also functioned to stage competition between monks of the Jimon and Sanmon branches, a variant of the "efficacy competition" (*gen kurabe*) trope in tale literature. In this story, the Jimon monk Kanju is cast as the ghostbuster who repels a vengeful ghost hailing from the Sanmon lineage.

Another important Jimon *genza* in the mid-Heian period was Shōsan. A student of Yokei and two-time abbot of Onjōji, Shōsan lived at one of the four major Jimon temples in Heiankyō, Shūgakuin, after the Jimon migration from Mt. Hiei. He is mentioned in a case for the year 1000 when a former assistant handmaiden was possessed by evil *qi* and lunged at Michinaga with a "wrathful" expression, suggesting that Shōsan had been summoned by Michinaga to perform the rite.<sup>24</sup> On another occasion in 1000, Shōsan was slated to perform a ritual for Michinaga, who was then dealing with evil *qi* and possibly a curse from a rival. Although Shōsan was unable to participate and the order went to another monk, that he was selected first demonstrates Michinaga's preference for this Jimon monk.<sup>25</sup> Michinaga may well have known that in 999, Shōsan had successfully flushed evil spirits into the body of "one or two girls," whereupon the patient's condition improved. That this patient was no less than the Senior Grand Empress Shōshi, who maintained close ties with the Jimon lineage, is significant and surely contributed to enhancing Shōsan's reputation with courtier patrons such as Michinaga.<sup>26</sup>

By far the most impressive and renowned Jimon monk to wield the possession rite in this period was Shin'yo. Also known as Jissōbō 実相房, Shin'yo was a student of Kanju and Bokusan, and of Fukō 扶公 (dates unknown), a monk of Kōfukuji 興福寺 and his brother.<sup>27</sup> What set Shin'yo apart from other Jimon monks at the outset was that resentful spirits shaped his personal family history. His great-grandfather was Fujiwara no Tokihira 藤原時平 (845–903), the statesman who infamously ordered the exile of Sugawara no Michizane in 901.<sup>28</sup> Michizane's spirit became a vengeful spirit (*onryō*), indeed, the most famous of them all. In later sources such as the *Illustrated Legends of the Kitano Tenjin Shrine* (*Kitano tenjin engi emaki* 北野天神縁起絵巻), Michizane's spirit, afflicting Tokihira with disease, emerges out of Tokihira's ears in the form of two snakes when Jōzō 淨蔵 (891–964)—perhaps the first named *genza* in the historical record—performs healing empowerment.<sup>29</sup> Fear of resentful spirits thus ran in Shin'yo's family. Tokihira's second son, Fujiwara

no Akitada 藤原顕忠 (898–965), Shin'yo's grandfather, is said to have lived in a state of sleepless apprehension as a result, and some believed that was the cause of his decision to abandon all political ambition.

Unlike his grandfather, Shin'yo refused to cower in the face of the spectral history that haunted his family. Instead, building on his esoteric education in the Jimon lineage, he transformed himself into a commanding ritual specialist with the skills for managing resentful spirits, thereby creating a ritual signature that only increased the traction of the Jimon lineage among courtier patrons. From at least 1015 on, Shin'yo performed the possession rite successfully to treat numerous patients, many of whom were emperors. A devoted pupil of Kanju, Shin'yo seems to have picked up his teacher's ability to compel spirits to talk. For example, when Emperor Sanjō was afflicted by an eye disease in the fifth month of 1015, Shin'yo effectively prompted communication with two of his afflictors—the ghosts of Motokata and the Sanmon monk Gashō—by transferring them into the bodies of ladies-in-waiting.<sup>30</sup> Later that month, Shin'yo's ritual appears to have conjured the appearance of the deity Shōten 聖天 (alt. Shōden), who helpfully reported that the evil *qi* spirits afflicting Sanjō had been subjugated.<sup>31</sup> When Emperor Go-Ichijō was suffering from evil *qi* in 1020, Shin'yo drove the spirit out with empowerment.<sup>32</sup> He did so again for Go-Ichijō in 1022, flushing spirits into ladies-in-waiting, whereupon the emperor recuperated.<sup>33</sup>

Shin'yo also developed close relationships with high-ranking aristocrats. These associations were undoubtedly related to his Fujiwara pedigree, but they were also a consequence of his therapeutic successes. For example, in 1027 Sanesuke's wife suddenly lost consciousness due to spirit possession—with some morbidly speculating that she was already dead—and Shin'yo performed empowerment and brought her back to life.<sup>34</sup> His closest patron was undoubtedly Michinaga. By engaging with Michinaga, Shin'yo continued to cultivate a relationship that had been established earlier by Kanju and Shōsan. These Jimon monks may have in fact recommended Shin'yo to Michinaga, though as noted, Michinaga had already witnessed Shin'yo's ritual skills when he treated his daughter's toothache, at which time Michinaga applauded his ritual efficacy.<sup>35</sup> Records indicate that Shin'yo discussed evil spirits with Michinaga in 1015, suggesting he was already treating such illnesses for him by this time.<sup>36</sup> When Michinaga was plagued by evil *qi* in the fourth month of 1018, Shin'yo was called to Hosshōji, where Michinaga had sequestered himself, to perform an altar ritual; on the occasion, a scream, likely from the medium, suggested the presence of a resentful spirit.<sup>37</sup> Shin'yo seems to have remained at Michinaga's side at Hosshōji for several days, because just a few days later he participated in a Five Altar Rite there. The performance apparently did the job, for it provoked the appearance of a spirit identified as Michinaga's older brother, Michikane 道兼 (961–995).<sup>38</sup> As a consequence of these events (and undoubtedly many



others that were not recorded), the mere presence of Shin'yo at Michinaga's side became almost synonymous with the presence of pathogenic spirits. In 1023, when Michinaga was suffering from a fever and Shin'yo was performing empowerment, those around him immediately speculated that his symptoms were probably the work of evil spirits; after all, why else would this Jimon master be ministering to him?<sup>39</sup>

Shin'yo also extended the services of therapeutic possession and exorcism to Michinaga's children. When Michinaga's daughter Kenshi 妍子 (994–1027) was ill, Shin'yo transferred afflictive spirits out of her body, thereby jump-starting her appetite.<sup>40</sup> In 1020, Shin'yo and another Jimon monk, Myōson 明尊 (971–1063), performed a Five Altar Rite for Michinaga's son, Yorimichi, who was said to be suffering from malarial fever (*gyakubyō*). Although the entry for this event notes that empowerment was not used, it also says that the evil *qi* spirits were “subjugated of themselves.”<sup>41</sup> It is surely no coincidence that Myōson became the abbot of Yorimichi's Byōdōin 平等院 in Uji.<sup>42</sup> Michinaga's descendants of even later generations also remembered Shin'yo as Yorimichi's healer, as we see in one story in the *Stories of Lord Fuke* (*Fukego* 富家語), written by Tadazane, Michinaga's great-great-grandson. In this story, Shin'yo sent a Dharma-Protector ahead of him to heal Yorimichi, which effectively scared off the spectral offenders.<sup>43</sup> The ritual imagined in this story differs from the usual possession rite, but as we have seen, the Dharma-Protector was a key meta-participant in the therapeutic conversion of the karmically warped spirit.

Along with other comrades from Onjōji, Shin'yo played a crucial role in managing *mononoke* to secure safe childbirth for important members of Michinaga's family. The *Diary of Lady Murasaki* (*Murasaki Shikibu nikki* 紫式部日記) opens with various rituals surrounding the labor of Shōshi, Michinaga's oldest daughter, who went on to successfully give birth to the prince who became Emperor Go-Ichijō. Corresponding entries in the *Shōyūki* make it clear that Shōshi was understood at this critical juncture to be afflicted by evil spirits. In her account, Murasaki mentions six monks who participated in the rites to protect Shōshi. Not surprisingly, the three easily identifiable monks all belong to the Jimon lineage: Shin'yo, Eikō 永効 (dates unknown), and Nenaku 念覚 (dates unknown). In his analysis of the account, Sakō Nobuyuki identifies two others—Myōson 妙尊 (dates unknown) and Sensan 千算 (or Chisō; dates unknown)—as Jimon monks, making it plausible that the sixth monk, otherwise unknown, was also part of the ritual team led by Shin'yo.<sup>44</sup>

Shin'yo also “empowered” Michinaga in yet another way: by equipping his patron with esoteric ritual techniques for self-defense against evil *qi* spirits. A diary entry from the day Michinaga died in 1028 recalls that he had received from Shin'yo teachings regarding the two mandalas—the Diamond Realm (Kongōkai 金剛界) mandala and the Womb Realm (Taizōkai 胎藏界)

mandala—and rituals to various individual deities (*besson* 別尊).<sup>45</sup> There is good reason to suspect that Shin'yo's lessons to his studious patron included ritual techniques for exorcising the resentful dead. Sure enough, during an episode in 1020, Michinaga's praying voice was said to sound like an "efficacious one" (*genza*), implying that he was conducting the possession rite as if he were a member of an esoteric lineage himself.<sup>46</sup> An entry for the next month reports something similar and also notes that Michinaga's commanding voice blended with the voices of evil spirits.<sup>47</sup>

Michinaga was known for crossing the boundary between ritual patron and professional, especially when the lives of his family members were in jeopardy. In 1025, his daughter Kishi 嬉子 (1007–1025), who was afflicted by measles (*akamogasa*) and evil *qi*, was about to go into labor.<sup>48</sup> Divination by the yin-yang master Yoshihira suggested that empowerment ought to be performed, but the monks who were summoned refused to perform it. They may have been concerned about incurring defilement from the labor, but the records suggest they feared the evil spirits and were apprehensive about upsetting epidemic deities. Rather than stand idly by while his daughter was menaced by the evil dead, Michinaga began conducting empowerment against the wraiths himself, thereby prompting the monks—no doubt embarrassed to have their role usurped by an amateur—to participate. Yet as the foregoing discussion suggests, Michinaga was perhaps not as amateur as we might assume of a politician. In fact, he may have been thoroughly prepared for such spectral surprises by no less than Shin'yo, one of the court's leading practitioners of possession rite therapeutics in the early eleventh century.

## THE ERA OF ABDICATED SOVEREIGNS AND THE CASE OF HORIKAWA

The late eleventh and early twelfth centuries marked the beginning of the Era of Abdicated Sovereigns. The era is named after a new political configuration in which emperors "retired"—and took the tonsure, thereby becoming Buddhist monks—as a political strategy to control succession and keep it from falling into the hands of powerful members of the Fujiwara, as had occurred with Michinaga in the preceding era. In this changing political landscape, Jimon monks continued to maintain the ties their forebears had established with Michinaga's lineage by attending to the health of his descendants with performances of the possession rite. Those ties were especially pronounced in the case of Tadazane, Michinaga's great-great-grandson, who kept the family history alive by recording stories about Michinaga and the lineage in *Stories of Lord Fuke*.

When it was divined that Tadazane's biological mother was ill with evil *qi* in 1106, Jimon monks such as Raiki 頼基 (ca. 1050–1134) were brought in to treat

her with a possession rite.<sup>49</sup> A monk associated with Shōsan's temple Shūgakuin, Raiki was the brother of Jimon monk Gyōson.<sup>50</sup> Raiki also treated Minamoto no Shishi 源師子 (1070–1149), Tadazane's wife, such as in the sixth month of 1107, when Raiki expelled a spirit from her and she recovered.<sup>51</sup> In the eighth month of 1107, a Jimon monk named Kenkaku 顕覚 (ca. 1072–1122) was summoned to treat her.<sup>52</sup> Tadazane also suspected that his wife was suffering from evil spirits in 1112, whereupon he had various rituals performed, including a Sonjō 尊星王 rite by Jimon monk Gyōshō 行勝 (1049–1124) and a Fudō rite at Onjōji.<sup>53</sup>

Jimon monks are mentioned in connection to the possession rite in Tadazane's diary, the *Denryaku* 殿曆. Tadazane records several episodes of Jimon monks offering ritual treatment for Retired Emperor Shirakawa. In 1104, a monk referred to as "esoteric master Shirakawa" (Shirakawa *ajari* 白河阿闍梨)—that is, Zōchi 増智 (1078–1135)—transferred the spirit afflicting the retired emperor.<sup>54</sup> In 1105, Zōyo, the nephew of the eminent Jimon monk Ryūmyō, provided similar treatment to Retired Emperor Shirakawa.<sup>55</sup> Dozens of other entries mention the possession rite. These entries frequently note the ritual transfer of an offending spirit or spirits, suggesting that this aspect of the possession rite had become rather routine by this time. What is often missing in these entries are the names of the monks who performed the rite. Given that these entries mostly involve the illnesses of Tadazane and his family, it is likely that in many cases the unspecified monks belonged to the Jimon lineage, either those in Tadazane's extended family, such as Raiki, or important lineage members such as Zōyo.

The importance of Jimon monks is supported by later narratives describing Tadazane's treatment. One scene in the *Illustrated Miracles of the Kasuga Deity* (*Kasuga gongen genki e* 春日権現験記絵) depicts an ailing Tadazane lying face down in his bed, flushed red with affliction. On the veranda outside the room, Zōyo is shown ministering to Tadazane at a distance with prayers (see figure 3). A line attributed to Zōyo in the narrative portion of the scroll reads, "The efficacious one (*genza*) must first know the signs of the disease. He checks whether it is the spirit of a living person or that of a deceased one, and discriminates between the work of big gods and small gods. Only then does he perform empowerment and protective contemplations."<sup>56</sup> The emphasis in Zōyo's lines on correctly correlating the signs of the disease with the identity of its spectral cause resonates with a similar passage found in the "Procedures of the Efficacious Ones" (*Genza sahō*), one of the only surviving prescriptive sources on the possession rite. The passage reads: "It may be a demon without an obvious and knowable form, or it may have a knowable form; it may be a *māra* or a spirit—the manifestations of each are distinct. You should read the *Sutra of the Questions of Subāhu* for more details about this."<sup>57</sup> In showing Zōyo's prayers addressed to Tadazane accompanied by lines that recall prescriptive texts for *genza*, the author of the illustrated scroll clearly had the possession rite in mind.

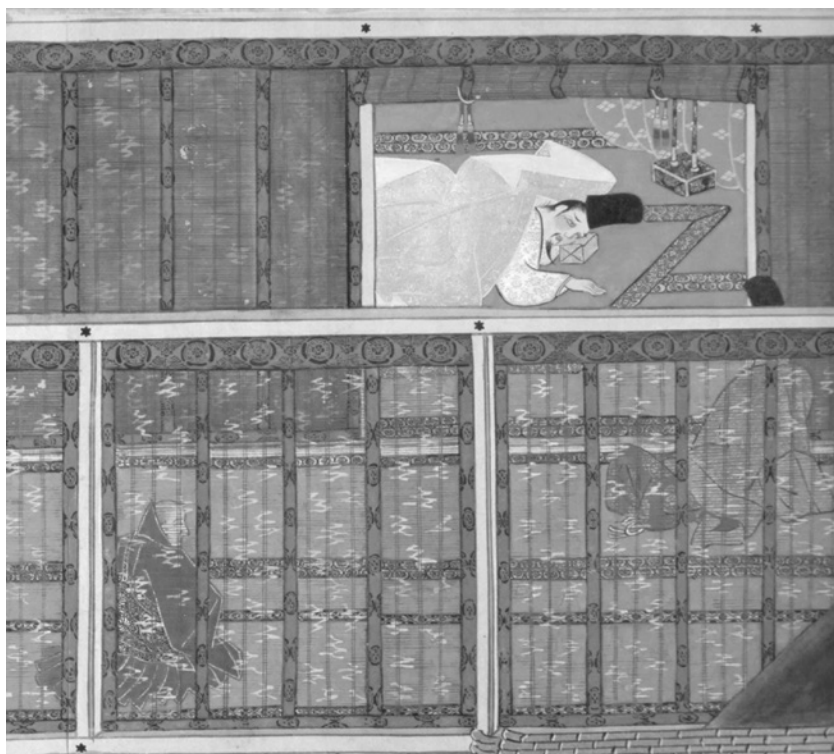


Figure 3. Zōyo (lower left) providing ritual treatment for the ailing Tadazane (top) in the *Kasuga gongen genki e* (Meiji-period reproduction by Itabashi Tsurao 板橋貫雄, 1809–1872). National Diet Library Digital Collection.

One way to understand how Jimon monks performed the possession rite during the Era of Abdicated Sovereigns is to examine a complex example for which there are numerous extant records. Few cases are more illustrative than that of Emperor Horikawa's final illness and treatment in the seventh month of 1107. This case demonstrates that Jimon monks attended not only to powerful aristocrats such as Michinaga's descendants but also to emperors and retired emperors in a time when the latter were consolidating power in new ways. In Horikawa's case, his illness was attributed to "wind" disease, but some suspected that it was caused by evil *qi*.<sup>58</sup> As Munetada reports in his diary, Horikawa's illness prompted a flurry of large-scale ritual treatments, one of which was a possession rite performed by a Jimon monk.

On the thirteenth day, the Jimon monk Gyōshō performed an altar rite near the throne, backed by twenty monks reciting the spells of Fudō. On the fourteenth day, when action picked up considerably, ten monks in the Futama

(a small room next to the sleeping quarters of the emperor in the Seiryōden) chanted the Superlative Spell (Sonshō darani 尊勝陀羅尼), which was to be a three-day affair in total; a copy of the *Lotus Sutra* in gold characters and navy blue paper was offered; offerings were also made to a Śākyamuni triad; and an order was given to compile a list of the monks to be assigned to chant sutras on the nineteenth. Various rites continued on the sixteenth, including purification rites at shrines. On the seventeenth day, the Shingon monk Kanjo 寛助 (1057–1125) and twenty attendant monks were compensated for completing a *Peacock Sutra* rite. On the same day, a decision was made to prolong the chanting of the Superlative Spell, as ladies-in-waiting reported that the emperor's condition was worsening. On the eighteenth day, as some of these rites continued, monks from Enryakuji led by the archbishop Ningen 仁源 (dates unknown) were called in to perform the Seven Medicine Buddhas Rite. Around the same time, the Jimon monk Zōyo was summoned to offer prayers, which he did just outside of the folding screen enclosing the emperor.

From this dizzying buffet of therapeutic rites, we can glean an especially important role for Jimon monks such as Gyōshō and Zōyo. But what happens next is of particular significance for this discussion. For these details, we turn to the *Diary of Sanuki no Suke* (*Sanuki no suke nikki* 讃岐典侍日記) by Fujiwara no Nagako 藤原長子 (ca. 1079–after 1119), a woman related to Horikawa's wet-nurse who served Horikawa closely from 1100 until the end of his life in 1107. In one especially striking entry in her diary, Nagako notes that twelve Sanmon monks had been summoned to the emperor's palace. These monks—all of whom had considerable experience performing austerities on Mt. Hiei—were performing the venerable esoteric rite for the Seven Medicine Buddhas. The scene of their chanting is described as “impressive,” but “as if acknowledging that all else had failed,” the diarist writes, the emperor sent word to Retired Emperor Shirakawa to summon the Jimon monk Gyōson, whose services Shirakawa had recommended on an earlier occasion. Once Gyōson arrived, he chanted the *Thousand Arm Sutra*, which immediately provided solace to Nagako, who was close enough to hear Gyōson's chanting. She wrote, “As it was the practice of priests from Miidera to revere the *Thousand Arm Sutra*, Gyōson was reading it with great devotion. I derived comfort from hearing him slowly chanting, ‘May his illness be cured and may his life be long.’”<sup>59</sup>

There are several important takeaways from this passage and the event it describes. The first pertains to Horikawa's initially surprising choice of healer. At the beginning, he is being ritually treated by as many as twelve eminent monks from Enryakuji, whose ritual performance of the Seven Medicine Buddhas is said to have made an “impressive sight.” Summoning as many as twelve monks suggests that Horikawa was initially banking on the heightened efficacy of maximization: The more buddhas, and the more ritualists chanting to invoke them,

the greater the therapeutic potency. A similar logic was clearly at play in the staggering array of other rituals that were performed for Horikawa in the days before.

Because the healing ritual performed by Sanmon monks did not seem to have any tangible effect, Horikawa has the minister of the center summon Gyōson, who had been recommended to him by his father, Retired Emperor Shirakawa. Although Enryakuji monks continue to perform their ritual, Horikawa effectively replaces these twelve formidable Sanmon monks with one Jimon monk, Gyōson, who then takes the spotlight in Nagako's description of Horikawa's treatment. The fact that the prayers of a lone Jimon monk drew the attention of both patient and onlookers in this ritually dense scene points to the reputation that Jimon monks had cultivated in the field of ritual healing, especially when it came to managing evil spirits through the possession rite. Sure enough, the choice proves to be judicious: The rite provides solace to Nagako, Horikawa's attendant; soon after, the spectral culprits appear, thereby opening the possibility for a therapeutic conversation.

#### SENJU KANNON

Putting aside the spirits for the moment, we should also notice the way Gyōson's performance of the possession rite embeds a key signature of ritual healing in the Jimon lineage. In his ritual procedures for Horikawa, Gyōson facilitates therapeutic spirit possession by chanting the *Thousand Arm Sutra* dedicated to Senju Kannon, a bodhisattva whose cultic worship among Jimon monks was discussed extensively in chapter 1. Gyōson's invocation of the bodhisattva Senju Kannon in the context of the possession rite can be understood from multiple perspectives, beginning with his ritual background. Gyōson is known to have trained at Kokawadera, a temple that became a key site for the worship of Senju Kannon among Jimon monks. Kannon was certainly an important deity at Kokawadera in the Heian period.

Second, it would have made therapeutic sense for Gyōson to call on Senju Kannon in treating Horikawa specifically. The *Thousand Arm Sutra* that Nagako and probably Horikawa had come to associate with Jimon monks and that Gyōson recited for him was centered around a *dhāraṇī* invoking the bodhisattva. The *Thousand Arm Sutra* describes the *dhāraṇī* as effective against a breathtaking range of diseases and the agents who cause them: plagues, eye diseases and eye disorders, venomous pests (flies, snakes, scorpions), fevers, the illnesses of children, hearing difficulties, tapeworms, paralysis, and pain in the chest and abdomen. One passage of the sutra that would have been especially comforting to patients who felt they were nearing the end of their life—as we know retrospectively was the case with Horikawa—was the passage that describes the *dhāraṇī*'s effectiveness against the “fifteen kinds of wicked death.” This list of

horrific ways to die includes confrontation with enemies, medical poisoning, “*gu* poisoning,” and mad confusion and loss of contemplation. Most important, it mentions deadly diseases wrought by pathogenic agents that would have been of special concern in Horikawa’s case: evil diseases that envelop the body, sudden death by deviant spirits and evil spirits, and assassination by an evil necromancer’s magically controlled demon (*akunin enmi* 惡人厭魅; Skt. *vetāla*).<sup>60</sup> Thus, Gyōson would have good reason to deem Senju Kannon’s *dhāraṇī* appropriate for a possession rite targeting the evil spirits harassing Horikawa. Resonating with the way his contemporary Zōyo was imagined in the *Illustrated Miracles of the Kasuga Deity*, Gyōson was a ritual doctor who built his treatments on the proper diagnosis of disease pathogens.

In fact, invoking Senju Kannon in possession rite performances may have been a hundred-year-old tradition in the Jimon lineage by the time Gyōson deployed the *dhāraṇī* for Horikawa’s benefit. The temples at which Jimon monks enshrined statues of Kannon appear to have become associated with the treatment of evil *qi* around the year 1000. In 1005, when Takashina no Akinobu 高階明順 (?–1009?) suspected he was afflicted with evil *qi*, he went straight to Kannon’in, a hall at the Jimon temple Daiunji.<sup>61</sup> We might also recall the famous exorcism episode in the *Pillow Book* with which we began the previous chapter. Literary scholars have yet to identify the monk who makes an impressive performance of the possession rite that Sei Shōnagon describes. But Sei’s description embeds a key detail that scholars have overlooked: The awe-inspiring monk performing the rite facilitates the possession by chanting the *dhāraṇī* of Senju Kannon.<sup>62</sup> Given that Jimon monks like Kanju were performing the Senju Kannon ritual for healing at this precise time, it seems plausible that this unnamed monk belonged to the Jimon lineage.<sup>63</sup>

At precisely this time in the mid-Heian period, Jimon monks seem to have been alternating performances of the possession rite with altar rites dedicated to Senju Kannon. For example, in the eighth month of 999, Kanju performed empowerment for the Senior Grand Empress, which may have been the possession rite.<sup>64</sup> Months later in the same year, he performed the Senju Kannon rite for her.<sup>65</sup> Just two days before Kanju’s ritual, Shōsan performed the possession rite for her, transferring two spirits into the medium.<sup>66</sup> In sum, perhaps as early as the beginning of the eleventh century, Jimon monks may have been using Senju Kannon’s *dhāraṇī* in the context of the possession rite, thus combining their expertise in the altar ritual dedicated to that bodhisattva with their experiments in exorcism.

#### THE THERAPEUTIC HAUNTING OF JIMON GHOSTS

Another aspect of Gyōson’s exorcism for Horikawa that may have been distinctive to Jimon-style possession rites during the Era of Abdicated Sovereigns

pertains to the identity of the spectral metapersons. Through the rite Gyōson elicits the spirits of two deceased monks, not the spirits of courtiers or emperors. We have in fact seen this pattern twice before, first with the appearance of the spirit of the monk Gashō (discussed in chapter 2) and second with Jitsuin (noted above). In both cases, the spirit of a deceased Sanmon monk, one who was denied abbacy of Enryakuji, allegedly came back to cause harm in the form of disease. Moreover, in both cases, the pathogenic Sanmon spirit was elicited and managed by a monk of the Jimon lineage: Gashō by Shin'yo and Jitsuin by Kanju.

In the present case of Horikawa, the exorcist Gyōson and the spirits—Raigō and Ryūmyō—all belong to the Jimon lineage. Consequently, the dynamics at play here, and the therapeutic conclusions provisionally reached, differ considerably from those of Jitsuin and Gashō. Jitsuin was subjugated immediately. In the more complicated case of Gashō, we saw that the presiding abbot of Keien, a monk of the same Sanmon lineage, fought to deny Gashō's request for posthumous abbacy. For Horikawa, Gyōson adopts a different approach in engaging with the spectral metapersons from his Jimon lineage, one that is arguably therapeutically more productive. Rather than shut down the request of the spectral metapersons, he allows them to propose their own solution for Horikawa's illness. Speaking through the medium, the spirits ask that Horikawa make an imperial pilgrimage to Onjōji, suggesting that the pathogenic hauntings will stop should he do so.

We can see how Gyōson guides his conversation with the dead in the possession rite in a direction that will strengthen the ties between the imperial patient and the Jimon lineage. The appearance of Jimon monks coming back as spirits is haunting, especially because of the unavoidable implications that these spirits are suffering in unfortunate realms due to warped karma and are now to blame (at least in part) for Horikawa's affliction. But because Gyōson is in control of the situation, Horikawa may have been comforted by the fact that all he needed to overcome his affliction was to make a pilgrimage to this lineage's head temple. After all, he would have known the identities of these spirits well, including the fact that when alive they were prominent healers. Ryūmyō was the uncle of Zōyo, who on a separate occasion around the same time was also summoned to treat Horikawa.<sup>67</sup> In Tadazane's *Stories of Lord Fuke*, Ryūmyō is mentioned explicitly alongside his nephew Zōyo as an "efficacious one" (*genza*).<sup>68</sup>

On the other hand, conjuring restless Jimon spirits by living Jimon ritualists expresses an ambivalence about members of the Jimon lineage, the significance of which would not have been lost on their courtly or imperial clients. Jimon monks were known as powerful healers, but they too might take to their graves disappointment with the actions and decisions of courtiers and emperors. When



that happens, the ghostbusters can just as readily become pathogenic ghosts themselves. For example, Raigō was one of the ghosts who came back to antagonize Horikawa in the present case, and he is said to have become a vengeful spirit after he was denied permission to construct an ordination platform at Onjōji. Raigō becoming a ghoul was undoubtedly intertwined with earlier causes and conditions, namely, the lingering resentment Jimon monks held toward monks of the Sanmon branch and members of the court before, during, and after the Hosshōji abbacy controversy; the split between the siblings of Tendai; and the migration of Jimon monks from Mt. Hiei. Thus, even as the court recognized Jimon monks as effective therapists for ghost afflictions, they also knew their identity might shift from compassionate healer to resentful spirit. In fact, it was rumored that Raigō had deliberately taken his own life by fasting and in his last moments launched a curse at Shirakawa's first son, directly causing his death.<sup>69</sup>

At the same time, this ambivalence about ritual healers and Jimon monks in particular was always operating in the background of the courtly perception of these monks. Indeed, it was imagined as a source for their impressive ritual and therapeutic efficacy. When a Jimon monk became a living incarnation of Fudō Myōō during a performance of altar rites, he was imagined to ritually assume the persona of this wrathful and violent deity to effectively subjugate threats that were as aggressive and violent as the deity. It was in part due to the wrathful manifestation of Jimon monks in ritual performance that they were perceived to embody the power to battle demons and disease. This dynamic interplay of healing and harming, a common feature of Buddhist ritual healing in medieval Japan, is a topic I return to in chapter 7.

#### MOUNTAIN POWER

Another idea about how Jimon monks cultivated their ritual power for use in the possession rite gained traction in the early twelfth century and can be seen in the activities of Gyōson, Horikawa's healer, and Zōyo before him: the idea that Jimon monks charged their ritual batteries by performing austerities on mountains inhabited by buddhas, bodhisattvas, and gods. Courtiers had linked mountain practice with ritual efficacy long before. Sei Shōnagon hinted as much in her *Pillow Book*, written around 1000: "The lot of an exorcist is still more painful. On his pilgrimages to Mitake, Kumano, and all the other sacred mountains he often undergoes the greatest hardships. When people come to hear that his prayers are effective, they summon him here and there to perform services of exorcism: the more popular he becomes, the less peace he enjoys."<sup>70</sup>

The associations between mountain practice and ritual efficacy grew stronger in the early twelfth century. In a foundational study on the development of Shugendō, a syncretic form of esoteric Buddhism rooted in mountain austerities,

Tokunaga Seiko linked the court's employment of Jimon monks as ritualists for safe childbirth with their role as supervisors over pilgrimages in the mountains of Kumano.<sup>71</sup> Tokunaga's analysis can be extended to their role as *genza* healers. As noted in chapter 1, Shirakawa appointed Zōyo the first administrator of the pilgrimage route on the mountains of Kumano. After Zōyo, this position was monopolized by the principal abbots of Onjōji until the early Kamakura period. Horikawa's healer Gyōson, who was known for practicing in the mountains of Kumano, Ōmine 大峰, Kōyasan 高野山, and Kokawadera, was the second appointed administrator. The roles Zōyo and Gyōson played as pilgrimage guides likely informed their patrons' perceptions of their healing prowess, and this undoubtedly contributed to Toba's decision to appoint Gyōson as his personal protector monk, just as Shirakawa chose Zōyo for the same role earlier. Indeed, appointment to the role of protector monk assumes that these monks possessed unusual ritual powers and could thus safeguard these sovereigns from the manifold threats that populated their lifeworlds. As we have seen, Zōyo and Gyōson were praised for their efficacy, a fact that their patrons would have readily linked to their ritual adventures on sacred peaks, rock grottoes, and numinous valleys.<sup>72</sup>

At the same time, there is an important difference here from the earlier general perception that monks cultivated ritual power by performing austerities on mountains, and something distinctive as to how this played out in the Jimon lineage. Jimon monks, acting as pilgrimage guides, actually led their patrons to and through the mountains of Kumano, where they no doubt introduced them to the temples and shrines at which the monks practiced. There, patrons might witness, firsthand and in real time, the kinds of austerities by which efficacy (*gen*) is generated. If ritual efficacy can be understood as a product that Jimon monks delivered to their patrons at court by way of the possession rite, altar rites, and other rituals, then these guided pilgrimages to the mountains constituted no less than a behind-the-scenes tour of the sacred factories at which Jimon monks manufactured that product. We need only recall from chapter 1 the episode of Kakusan who, acting as mountain guide, facilitated Go-Shirakawa's extraordinary experience of Senju Kannon's powers during one of his early pilgrimages to Kumano.

Indeed, control over the Kumano mountains as pilgrimage guides provided a key basis for the Jimon claim that their lineage had exclusive access to robust sources of ritual power. For this reason, as D. Max Moerman explains, Kumano "served as the training ground for what would become the earliest Shugendō organization, established in the late eleventh century."<sup>73</sup> One intriguing document in which this claim was advanced was a petition written by Jimon monks titled *Ōmi Onjōji gakuto shukurō ra mōshijō* 近江園城寺学徒宿老等申状 (1319). As Haruko Wakabayashi has shown in her translation and

analysis, the petition demonstrates significant overlap with content of the earlier *Scrolls of the Tengu* (*Tengu zōshi* 天狗草紙, 1296), an illustrated narrative that Wakabayashi argues was authored by Jimon monks. Both works attempt to carve out the distinctive identity of the Jimon lineage by invoking claims about efficacy, claims the Jimon lineage had been developing and conveying to patrons since the twelfth century and probably earlier. For example, one passage in the petition reads: “When we ponder the essence of other temples, Nanto [Nara] and Kōfukuji are exoteric but not esoteric, Tōji and Ninnaji are esoteric but not exoteric. Although Tōdaiji and Enryakuji are both exoteric and esoteric, their virtues are far from *shugen* [i.e., “efficacy cultivation”]. Onjōji is the only temple that studies all three: exoteric, esoteric, and *shugen*.<sup>74</sup> Although the matter of efficacy was of concern for all monastic communities offering ritual services to elite patrons in early medieval Japan, as pilgrimage guides, Jimon monks were perhaps uniquely poised to draw on their mountain austerities to substantiate claims of special access to ritual efficacy. As *genza* who plugged themselves routinely into the spiritually electric mountains of Kumano, they were neither simply esoteric nor exoteric but also reliable producers of *gen*, ritual efficacy.

## KEISEI: THE ULTIMATE GHOSTBUSTER

Finally, I analyze a complex case of a Jimon monk performing the possession rite in the early thirteenth century, that of Keisei. As I shall discuss in the remaining chapters of this book, Keisei played a pivotal role in producing and transmitting manuscripts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons. Here I first consider his role as an exorcist of the evil dead, a role that places him in the long line of ritual healers in the Jimon lineage.

On three occasions in the fifth month of 1239, Keisei performed the possession rite on behalf of his ailing brother, statesman Michiie. At the time Michiie was residing at Hosshōji, a temple that was an important site for the identity and ritual activity of Jimon monks over the Heian period. Yokei’s appointment as abbot of Hosshōji provoked the clash with Sanmon monks of Enryakuji, eventuating the migration of Jimon monks away from Mt. Hiei. Hosshōji was where Jimon monks performed numerous rituals for powerful members of the Fujiwara family, including altar rites and the possession rite for Michinaga and his son Yorimichi. In the thirteenth century, even as Michiie was on the verge of ushering in a new era for the temple—eventually leading to the invitation of Enni Ben’en 円爾弁円 (1202–1280) and the temple’s transformation into Tōfukuji—Keisei followed the tradition of his lineage and once again made the temple a venue for interacting with spirits, by this point a relatively domesticated species of pathogenic metaperson for Jimon monks.

The account of this event appears in *Spirit Oracles from the Old Man of Mt. Hira* (*Hirasan kojīn reitaku* 比良山古人靈託), an intriguing work written by Keisei himself. Given that he was both the ritual officiant and the author of this work—and a writer with noted literary skill, as can be seen in his collection of tales (*setsuwa*), *A Companion in Solitude* (*Kankyo no tomo* 閑居友)—one might conclude that he simply fabricated the entire affair. However, given the frequency with which Jimon monks performed the possession rite over the Heian period, it is hard to chalk the episode up to Keisei's idiosyncratic imagination. He may indeed have reshaped and even invented certain aspects of the event in his telling. However, as we have seen, Jimon monks were directing their conversations with spirits in the possession rite in particular ways long before Keisei. His translation of his own interactions with spectral entities into literary form, while another step removed from actual performance, was simply another form of mediation, a process familiar to Jimon monks who were conducting and guiding mediums in the possession rite for centuries. It is reasonable enough to assume that Keisei, as a Jimon monk, was summoned from his temple Hokke-sanji to perform a possession rite for his ailing younger brother, just as other Jimon monks were called on to perform the possession rite for relatives and acquaintances throughout the Heian period.

As we shall see, Keisei undoubtedly played the role of protector monk (*gojisō*) for Michiie and the Kujō family, just as earlier Jimon monks did for emperors. In his captivating telling, Keisei demonstrates unusual telecommunicative prowess with visitors from the world of the departed. He opens himself up to potentially dangerous spirit influence but is sufficiently grounded to keep the conversation between the living and the dead productive, all without preemptively overdetermining the course of the interaction. In these interactions, Keisei proves adroit at shifting between the different roles we have seen to be critical in the possession rite: He is a detective of postmortem identities, a sympathetic listener, an interrogator, a diplomat, a preacher, and a subjugator. In these ways, he figures—albeit in a text of his own brush—as the ultimate exorcist, hailing from a long lineage of ghostbusters.

The exorcism that Keisei performed preserves the basic format of the possession rite—with several notable layers of increased complexity. As was always the case, the occasion for the performance was an illness provoked by spirits, and as usual a medium was employed to facilitate interaction with those spirits. The medium in this case differs little from the pattern we described in chapter 2. A young woman aged twenty-one, the medium belonged to the afflicted household as the wife of one of Michiie's retainers, Iemori 家盛 (dates unknown). Her embeddedness in the Kujō household no doubt made her an eminently qualified informant. Through interactions with the medium, Keisei communicates with a spirit, the "old man of Mt. Hira," who also describes himself as a "big

*tengu*.” Here is one layer of new complexity, since the “old man” is both a spirit harassing Michiie and a second medium of sorts with which Keisei interacts. Through the old man spirit, Keisei receives information about the postmortem whereabouts of other spirits, some of whom are harassing Michiie, others that were feared might cause future disruption, and still others about whom the Kujō family would have good reason to be concerned. Throughout, Keisei’s record reflects an anxiety that members of any lineage would have held about not knowing where their ancestors had ended up after death. This anxiety was heightened by the fact that by the early Kamakura period, the possibilities for postmortem destinations had increased. In addition to the Pure Land and the heavens (which represented the best cases), or one of the other six realms of rebirth, there emerged the possibility of being reborn in the path of the *tengu* and the related “realm of *māras*” (*makai* 魔界) or “path of *māras*” (*madō* 魔道).<sup>75</sup>

Keisei’s exorcism accords with the multilayered understanding of the possession rite’s therapeutic addressees, an aspect discussed in chapter 2. In the possession rite, the officiant monk addresses three patients, or “metapatient”: the ailing patient, the lineage in which the patient belonged, and the spirit who menaces the patient. In Keisei’s exorcism, the first patient is the most obvious: Michiie, who has become ill. Because Michiie was said to have gotten better in the next month, we know that the ritual functioned in a straightforwardly therapeutic sense, as had always been the case with the possession rite.

The second therapeutic addressee of Keisei’s rite was Michiie’s lineage. Michiie was the chieftain of the Kujō family at the time, hence any personal illness he suffered would necessarily implicate his lineage. This focus on the second, extended metapatient is especially important and detailed in Keisei’s account of his interactions with spirits. Keisei asks the old man spirit about members of the Kujō family and those connected to it, all of whom had died in the past thirty years: Yoshitsune 良経 (1169–1206), the father of Keisei and Michiie; Kanazane 兼実 (1149–1207), author of the *Gyokuyō* and their grandfather; Jien 慈円 (1155–1225), the famous Sanmon monk and their grand-uncle; and the most recent passings in the clan, including Shunshi 尊子 (1209–1233), Michiie’s daughter; Norizane 教実 (1211–1235), Michiie’s oldest son; Emperor Go-Horikawa 後堀河 (1212–1234), with whom Shunshi had been wedded as primary consort before her own death; and Go-Toba 後鳥羽 (1180–1239), who died just three months before the exorcism.

Several of the deaths that occurred in the previous decade had major consequences for Michiie and the Kujō lineage. For example, consider Norizane. Michiie appointed his first son, Norizane, as chieftain of the Kujō family in 1231.<sup>76</sup> When Norizane passed away in 1235, Michiie was forced to take the reins of the lineage again. Other recent deaths of concern were tragic and shrouded in mystery and thus called for explication. This was the case for the deaths of

Go-Horikawa and Shunshi. Michiie's daughter and Go-Horikawa's primary consort, Shunshi had died tragically while giving birth in 1233. Her death was followed by the death of Go-Horikawa the following year. Rumors flew that this unexpected sequence of deaths in the Kujō line had been the work of malicious spirits with a bone to pick. One spirit held responsible was the deceased Sanmon monk Ninkyō 仁慶 (dates unknown). Ninkyō had served as Go-Horikawa's teacher in the dharma, but he is said to have died clinging to much resentment against the Kujō family.<sup>77</sup> In his diary, Fujiwara no Teika 藤原定家 (1162–1241) wrote that Michiie obstructed Ninkyō's plans to become abbot of Enryakuji and, through political maneuvering, facilitated instead the promotion of the monk Ryōkai 良快 (1185–1243?), a disciple of Jien and son of Kanezane, and thus Michiie's uncle.<sup>78</sup> The appearance of a perturbed spirit of a Sanmon monk recalls the earlier cases of Gashō and Jitsuin. It is evident that even in Keisei's time, the antagonistic relationship between Sanmon and Jimon monks was far from fully mended.

A second individual suspected to be behind the deaths of Go-Horikawa and Shunshi was Emperor Go-Toba. Go-Toba was alive at the time, but it was feared that he was festering with anger at his site of exile in Oki 隠岐 in the aftermath of the Jōkyū disturbance (*Jōkyū no ran* 承久の乱) in 1221, when his rebellion against the warrior government in Kamakura failed.<sup>79</sup> Michiie probably feared the all-too-likely postmortem resurgence of Go-Toba as a vengeful spirit who would surely wreak havoc on his son Yoritsune, then in charge of the warrior government in Kamakura, thus making the determination of his whereabouts and precise ontological status (first and foremost, has he died yet?) an urgent issue.<sup>80</sup>

All the same, it is clear that information on any of the aforementioned spirits would have been useful for Michiie and the Kujō lineage, vigilant as they were against all potential spirit-driven attacks. Keisei's performance of the possession rite thus provided up-to-date data about the spirit world that might be a kind of preventive self-defense strategy. It was also no doubt therapeutic for the lineage to acquire knowledge about the postmortem whereabouts of deceased family members. For these reasons, Obara Hitoshi and Ikemi Chōryū have suggested that in Keisei's performance, we can discern his "public" function (in the sense of providing a service for his courtly patrons) and one that had wider practical utility for the lineage. In eliciting postmortem intelligence from spirits about spirits, Keisei therapeutically tended to a lineage that had witnessed an unprecedented degree of tragedy in recent years, trauma-generating events that demanded an acknowledgment with a broader public dimension. Indeed, this may have been one of Keisei's motivations in writing the record of his performance.

Because the information conveyed by the old man of Mt. Hira was not always comforting, the pathway toward resolution was not always clear. For example, regarding the rebirth fates of Shunshi and Ninkyō, the old man

reported that they had fallen together into the “*tengu* path” (*tengudō* 天狗道). Michiie’s daughter had been reborn in what was, by all accounts, an unfavorable path of rebirth and did so together with the monk whose spirit was rumored to have killed her. Moreover, the old man reports that the spirits of both people have become the “playthings” of *tengu* there.

Yet even in this case, a therapeutic pathway is hinted at by way of the unsettling knowledge provided. The old man says that even though the two have fallen into the *tengu* path, they are residing together at Rendaino 蓮台野.<sup>81</sup> Rendaino was a gravesite on the northwest outskirts of the Heiankyō capital. At the very least, the old man spirit provides an address for a spectral residence, a site on the plane of the living toward which the lineage might direct their memorial rituals, thus making it possible to effectively transfer merit to the deceased and improve their chances for a better rebirth down the line. Because no one can be certain about the whereabouts of the dead, ritualists must engage with informants from the beyond; Keisei skillfully facilitated this interaction.

As we saw earlier, the third metapatient of the possession rite was the malign spirit. In Keisei’s exorcism, the question of who constitutes the malign spirit is complicated. The “old man of Mt. Hira” with whom Keisei speaks is, after all, far from the only spirit menacing Michiie. Others seem to be harassing him as well, some of whom are said to have been encouraged to do so by the vengeful spirit of Sutoku 崇徳 (1119–1164), another figure who died in exile. Yet it remains the case that the old man is an afflicted spirit in addition to being an afflictive one. This is even more the case since the spirit appears to be tied to the Kujō lineage. The spirit in fact claims to be a Fujiwara ancestor whose existence extends even further back than Fujiwara no Kamatari 鎌足 (614–669), the great (and actual historical) ancestor of the Fujiwara family.

Giving the spirit the attention it desires and a supplement of morally nourishing Buddhist teachings, Keisei engages it as a metapatient in its own right. Keisei displays a willingness to listen to the spirit, despite his afflictive tendencies. In his analysis, Abe Yasurō contrasts Keisei’s diplomatic approach to the spirits here with that adopted by Jien, who responded to similar kinds of spirit oracles by dismissing them as wild foxes and *tengu*.<sup>82</sup> At certain moments in their dialogue, Keisei even acknowledges the spirit’s suffering. He tells the spirit that Iemori, Michiie’s retainer, was wrong for neglecting the spirit’s earlier requests for worship by sutra transcription. In this gesture Keisei takes the spirit’s side, validating its grievance. His approach resonates with the preaching script found in the “Procedures for Efficacious Ones”: “I reprimand you, but it’s because I take pity on the person who now suffers this affliction and not, demon, because I hate you. Therefore, I assume the authority of the Buddha-Dharma to bring release to the sick one as well as to you demon, with the goal of leading you to the correct view.”<sup>83</sup>

Keisei also promises he will cultivate merit to be transferred to the spirit, and even asks the spirit what kinds of “wholesome roots” (*zenkon* 善根) he should ritually generate for it. He displays his readiness to do the ritual work necessary to better the spirit’s postmortem existence, which, given the fact that the spirit has come back to harass the living, is no doubt presently unfortunate. He invites the spirit into a relationship of mutual exchange, asking the spirit to serve as the “protector deity” (*shugoshin* 守護神) for the temple that Michiie plans to build on the spirit’s ancestral land. From one perspective, Keisei was inviting the spirit to play the same role for Michiie’s temple that Keisei plays for Michiie and the Kujō family—a medium capable of tuning into the frequencies of the spirit world when the lineage needs it. The efficacy of Keisei’s possession rite also incorporates the critical dimension of conversion. Leave behind your resentments, Keisei seems to be saying, and instead collaborate on the project of protecting the lineage that binds us together.

While Keisei’s exorcism works to heal these three metapatients (Michie, the Jimon lineage, and the old man spirit), and thus functions as a holistic sociotherapy for the Kujō lineage, the Jimon monk also steers the ritual in directions that would be of direct benefit to himself and his monastic projects. For example, Keisei asks the spirit to speak on the prospects of his own temple, Hokkesanji, thus recalling the original divinatory function of *āveśa* that was less emphasized in Heian Japan. Keisei’s inquiry pertains in particular to possible “dangers from *māras*” (*ma’nan* 魔難), those beings who disrupted Buddhist practices and moral cultivation. Any insight the old man may have for Keisei on this question stems from the fact that the spirit is said to hail from the *makai*, the “realm of *māras*.”

Keisei’s attention to the *māras* and the realm of *māras* is noteworthy. Potential threats from *māras* were not an issue that exorcist monks acknowledged in any explicit way in performances of the possession rite in the Heian period. *Māras* are mentioned briefly in the Kamakura period “Procedures for Efficacious Ones” as a type of spirit entity that might appear when inducing possession in the possession rite, but not an entity with which the exorcist would want to engage directly. *Māras* are Buddhism’s trolls—they show up to obstruct Buddhist practice, typically by hijacking the agency of the monk, nun, or layperson they invade; thus, whatever information they provide is not to be trusted. The reason Keisei likely focused on the *māras* in the possession rite where his forebears did not is likely because he understood that *māras*, like resentful spirits, are metapersons that can cause disease, an idea that may have become more prominent in the late Heian period. As we shall see in the analysis of the Ritual for Expelling Demons in chapter 6, the notion of the *māras* was central to how Keisei and his senior Keihan imagined the agency of diseases caused by corpses.



When we read Keisei's description of his performance of the possession rite for Michiie, we notice numerous divergences from what we have seen in the rest of the chapter: The number of deceased individuals implicated is greater, its numerous mentions of *tengu* and the realm of the *māras* reflect anxieties about postmortem existence that were new in the late Heian and early Kamakura period, and we are no doubt dealing, in many of the details, with embellishments conjured by the author, who might be regarded as something of an auteur. Yet in its most basic form, the *Spirit Oracles from the Old Man of Mt. Hira* remains a compelling account of a Buddhist monk prevailing over pathogenic spirits.

Indeed, the genealogy of the possession rite developed here allows us to firmly situate Keisei-the-exorcist at the pinnacle of the longer history of this ritual, developed as it was by a lineage whose technical skills in the matters of living/dead relations were centuries in the making. To understand Keisei's ritual treatment for his brother, it is necessary to go back through Gyōson, Shin'yo, Kanju, Yokei, and other mid-Heian period monks, perhaps even as far as the early experiments of Enchin. Keisei's ghostbusting certainly fits into the pattern of immunitary relations and interdependence we have observed time and again, the ways that Jimon monks used spirit diplomacy to make themselves vitally relevant to the lives and lineages of elite patrons, from Michinaga and Tadazane to Horikawa and Michiie.



## PART II

### Corpse Disease



## CHAPTER 4

### The Ritual of Shōmen Kongō for Expelling Demons and *Māras*



THE RITUAL OFFENSIVE THAT JIMON MONKS WAGED AGAINST THE EVIL DEAD marks just one episode in the story of how Buddhist ritual immunity came to be preoccupied with postmortem contagion in early medieval Japan. Although Jimon monks often prevailed over pathogenic spirits in the mansions of their elite patrons, bringing a sense of order and harmony back to the lifeworld of the aristocracy, the mansion was not the only place where aristocrats in Heian Japan sensed—and soon feared—a confluence of death and disease. By the late twelfth century, another death-related disease germinated, this time outside the mansion and on the streets of Heiankyō, a city that was increasingly permeated with noxious defilement emanating from the material dead. As we shall see in chapter 5, they called this new affliction corpse-vector disease.

Against this disease, Jimon monks designed a new healing ritual, the Ritual for Expelling Demons. This chapter provides an overview of the ritual and its sources. It introduces extant manuscripts; discusses the Jimon monks who were involved in the production, transcription, revision, and transmission of the manuscripts; and provides an overview of the textual sources the monks relied on in crafting those manuscripts. It also sketches the contours of the rite's basic format, central deity, and ritual procedures.

#### MANUSCRIPTS

The Ritual for Expelling Demons is preserved in two related categories of manuscripts for which multiple editions exist. The first category is the rite's primary liturgical text, the *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō for Expelling Demons and Māras* (*Shōshiki Daikongō Yasha byaku kima hō* 青色大金剛葉叉辟鬼魔法; hereafter, *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō*). At least four editions of this work survive. Best known to scholars is the typeset edition in the Taishō canon (T 21, 1221), but this edition is rife with omissions and errors; the whereabouts of the parent manuscript, presumably once held by Hōbodai'in 宝菩提院 of the Shingon temple Tōji, are now unknown. To fill in the lacunae of this inferior edition, a partial

transcription of a better-preserved manuscript dating to 1758 held at Kōyasan University was published by Daoist scholar Yoshioka Yoshitoyo 吉岡義豊 (1916–1979) in 1967.<sup>1</sup> More recently, two other editions, written much earlier and preserved in exemplary condition, were discovered in the following collections: the Ōsu Bunko 大須文庫 library of Shinpukuji (Ōsu Kannon Hōshōin 大須観音宝生院), Nagoya 名古屋, Aichi prefecture (see figure 4);<sup>2</sup> and the Kissuizō 吉水蔵 library of Shōren'in 青蓮院, Kyoto.<sup>3</sup> These excellent editions were transmitted and preserved by monks of the Anō lineage 穴太流, a sublineage in the Sanmon branch of Tendai. The colophons indicate that they were transcribed in 1308 by Gyōhen 行遍 (fl. late Kamakura period), who revised an edition transmitted by his teacher, Chōgō 澄豪 (1259–1350).

Manuscript transmission for the Ritual for Expelling Demons to and within the Anō lineage is a complicated matter I do not consider in detail here, except to note the following. There is no doubt that Jimon monks of the late Heian period authored, copied, and transmitted the earliest manuscripts. These were transmitted to monks of the Anō lineage more than a hundred years after their

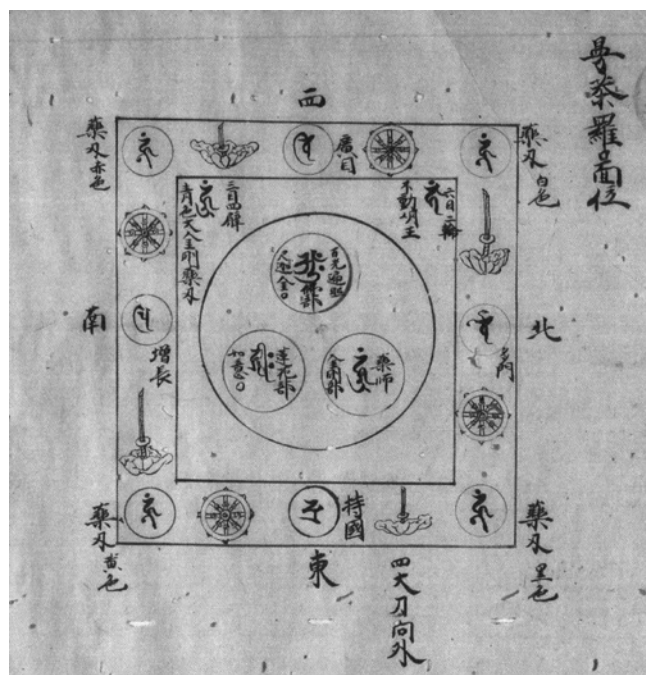


Figure 4. Altar mandala configuration. *Shōshiki Daikongō Yasha byaku kima hō*. Manuscript. Courtesy of Ōsu Kannon Hōshōin (Shinpukuji), Nagoya.

initial creation in the early 1170s. A comparison of the four editions noted above reveals that Anō monks did not edit the manuscripts in significant ways but sought to make faithful copies. Nonetheless they played a crucial role in preserving Jimon works that might have otherwise been lost. The significance of their transcriptions cannot be overstated, especially given the relative paucity of manuscripts that have survived at Onjōji.

The second category of manuscript is *Essential Notes on Corpse-Vector Disease and Treatment Methods for Wasting Disease* (*Denshibyō kanjin shō narabini sōbyō chihō* 伝屍病肝心抄并瘦病治方; hereafter, *Essential Notes*).<sup>4</sup> This work conveys a number of oral transmissions (*kuden* 口伝), notes (*shō* 抄), and other secret teachings necessary for performing the ritual. The most important manuscript of this work is a one-volume scroll that survived in the hand of one Jimon monk, Rishin 理真 (dates unknown). There is no date for Rishin's colophon, but a different edition from the Kissuizō suggests that Rishin transcribed it in 1257. An undated external title appended to the exterior of the scroll reads, "Collection of the Medical Methods of Keisei" (Keisei ihōshū 慶政医方集), a reference to another Jimon monk, Keisei. Designated an Important Cultural Property in 2007, the manuscript belongs to the Agency for Cultural Affairs (Bunkachō 文化庁; see figure 5).<sup>5</sup> A partial transcription of this work, with tracings of two illustrations in the original, is contained in the Taishō canon as two separate texts, *Denshibyō kuden* 伝屍病口伝 (T 2507) and *Denshibyō kyūji* 伝屍病灸治 (T 2508). A complete transcription was published by Ōta Yukiko in 2014.<sup>6</sup> Two other derivative editions are extant: (1) *Shōshiki kongō yasha myōō hō* 青色金剛藥叉明王法, held at the Shōren'in in Kissuizō;<sup>7</sup> and (2) *Denshibyō kanjin shō* 伝屍病肝心鈔, held at the Kyōu Shooku 杏雨書屋 library in Osaka.<sup>8</sup> There are also two extant manuscripts that blend passages from *Essential Notes* and *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō*. First is *Ōsu Shinpukuji shozō koshichū shō ijisha shōsha* 大須真福寺所藏故紙中涉医事者抄写, a manuscript preserved in the Fujikawa Bunko 富士川文庫 library at Kyoto University but that, as the title indicates, was preserved in Shinpukuji and transcribed by Anō monks.<sup>9</sup> Second is an identical manuscript known as the *Denshi chihō hihō* 伝屍治法秘法, currently held in the National Palace Museum 台北故宮 in Taipei.

The sheer number of extant manuscripts preserving the textual categories of the Ritual for Expelling Demons is a testament to the immense value of this innovative healing ritual in medieval Japan, even among monks of different lineages. The earliest history of this ritual, and its conception and transmission in the Jimon lineage, is what concerns me here. Although the *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō* is the core liturgical text and *Essential Notes* appears to be supplementary teachings on the ritual, the earliest colophons for both sets of manuscripts demonstrate that they were committed to writing at around the same time in the early 1170s. As Matsumoto Ikuyo has shown, in the final decades of the late twelfth century, Onjōji

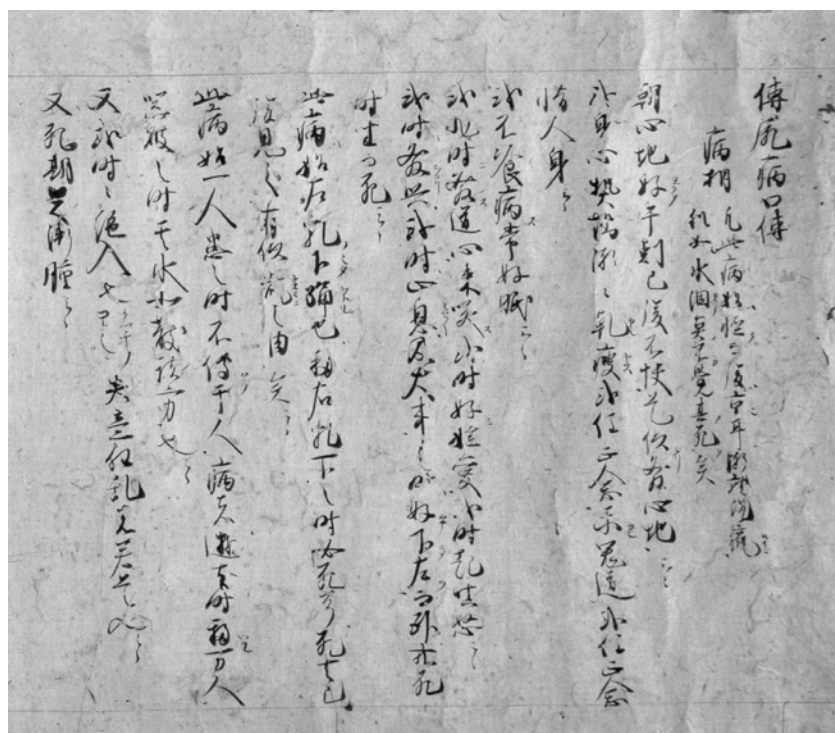


Figure 5. *Denshibiyō kanjin shō narabini sōbyō chihō*. Manuscript. Courtesy of the Japanese government (Agency for Cultural Affairs, Bunkachō). Image: TNM Archives.

monks made considerable efforts to consolidate different sublineages under the Jimon umbrella by collecting and organizing teachings produced and circulating in this monastic community.<sup>10</sup> The broader project of lineage consolidation by organizing teachings likely motivated the initial compilation of a complete liturgy for the Ritual for Expelling Demons and its associated teachings and methods. The project of transcribing, expanding, and editing the manuscripts continued for multiple generations. The colophons reveal the following typical line of transmission at Onjōji: The manuscripts were transcribed first by Keihan, who received them from one of his teachers, Jōjōbō 乗々房 (dates unknown), in the early 1170s; they were transcribed and reworked again in the 1220s by Keisei; and they were copied and revised once again by Rishin in the 1250s, giving us the final form in which *Essential Notes* was transcribed or, for the *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō*, the stage at which the works were passed from the Jimon lineage to Anō monks. The Taishō edition of *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō* likewise contains colophons by Keihan in 1171 and 1172; it was then copied by a Jimon monk named Kōun 公雲 (dates



unknown) in 1207, and finally by Sōkaku 相覺 (dates unknown) in 1220. This is the only edition with this line of transmission, thus it appears to have been less influential than the line that passed through Keisei and Rishin to the Anō lineage.

Given the importance of these monks to the process by which the Ritual for Expelling Demons was produced, I provide brief profiles with a description of their involvement. As the following discussion demonstrates, the transmission of the Ritual for Expelling Demons was supported in significant ways by the court lineage known as the Kujō family, one of the five branches of the towering Northern Fujiwara family network.

## MONKS

The *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō* liturgy begins with the following attribution: “Recorded by the *ācārya* Kūki (Ch. Kongji) of Shark-Dragon Grotto.” Several scholars have long taken this Kongji 空基 to be a Tang-period monk, suggesting that the liturgy was, like many esoteric ritual scriptures in Japan, imported from China.<sup>11</sup> In my view, the claim that the *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō* was imported from China (or the continent) was just a claim, one made to legitimate a new ritual that Jimon monks created in the twelfth century. In the Taishō canon edition of the liturgy, a colophon by a Jimon monk named Sōkaku dated 1220 indicates that the work was “imported” (*shōrai* 請來), suggesting it was brought to Japan by Enchin. The claim was apparently accepted by monks of other lineages, for in his fourteenth-century *Collection of Leaves Gathered by Storms in the Valley* (*Keiranshūyōshū* 溪嵐拾葉集), Kōshū 光宗 (1276–1350) repeated it, adding that the rite was originally transmitted only in the Jimon lineage at Miidera but had spread among lineages of the Sanmon branch as well.<sup>12</sup>

The success of the claim does not substantiate its historical validity. For one thing, there are no other mentions of a Tang-period monk named Kongji in the Taishō canon. Moreover, this was not the only attribution Jimon monks entertained. In *Record of Treasured Secrets* (*Hōhiki* 宝秘記), Keihan noted that the work was written by Fangzhi 防制, identified as one of the four main disciples of Xuanzang 玄奘 (602–664).<sup>13</sup> Although this must be a reference to the Sillan monk Sinbang 神昉 (fl. seventh century), a member of Xuanzang’s team of translators, Sinbang was a Yogacara monk not typically associated with the compilation of esoteric scriptures.<sup>14</sup> This attribution may reflect an attempt to link the Onjōji community to Silla, a strategy that Sujung Kim has shown to define much discourse of self-identification in Jimon writings.<sup>15</sup> Perhaps the attribution that Keihan reports was meant to be Kuiji 窺基 (632–682), who was one of Xuanzang’s best-known disciples and whose name closely resembles Kongji. Yet enough is known about the writings of Kuiji to conclude that he was most certainly not an author of an esoteric ritual scripture.

The stance adopted here is that the *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō* was created by Jimon monks in the mid- to late twelfth century.<sup>16</sup> Besides the tenuous nature of all the attributions to monks outside Japan, the strongest evidence that Jimon monks in Japan were its authors is found in the content of the ritual text. The combination of quotations from the writings of Zhiyi and esoteric liturgical scriptures points squarely to a monk with a Taimitsu (Tendai esotericism) background. The incorporated medical texts likewise point to an author in late Heian Japan, as does the incorporation of a curious Daoist scripture, which suggests in particular the hand of a Jimon monk, as we shall discuss in the next chapters. No esoteric scripture that combines such sources has been discovered in China or Korea. To my knowledge, there are no Chinese esoteric scriptures that incorporate moxibustion as a central therapeutic modality nor focus specifically on treatment for corpse-vector disease. These distinctive characteristics of the *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō*—and *Essential Notes*, which was designed to accompany it—are described in more detail below and in the chapters that follow. My central argument is that we can only understand the Ritual for Expelling Demons with reference to the monastic environment in which it was created and the historically situated pathological situation to which it responds: the Jimon lineage in the late twelfth century and the emergence of corpse-vector disease.

The earliest colophons typically begin with Keihan noting that he received the teaching and texts from a monk named Jōjōbō. Information about the identity and career of this monk would shed much light on the origins of the Ritual for Expelling Demons, but very little is known. Jōjōbō was likely the name of the hall with which this figure was associated. The name Jōjōbō is mentioned several times in Keihan's *Record of Treasured Secrets*, suggesting that he was one of Keihan's teachers.<sup>17</sup> One mention of Jōjōbō in the same work is glossed "Preceptor Chi" (Chi risshi 智律師), which turns out to correspond to another name that appears in *Essential Notes* before the colophons of Keihan: Gyōchi 行智.<sup>18</sup> We can cautiously conclude that Jōjōbō Gyōchi was a precept master and one of Keihan's teachers, thus Keihan received from him teachings concerning the Ritual for Expelling Demons.

We are on sturdier ground with Keihan, whose colophons are typically the earliest, chronologically speaking, in the manuscripts. As a son of Taira no Chikanori, Keihan belonged to the Taira clan. He is known primarily for compiling the teachings of his master, Shin'en, resulting in the *Record of Treasured Secrets*, a rare and significant anthology of Jimon ritual knowledge in the early medieval period. Colophons in that record show that much of Keihan's work was completed at Nyoiji.<sup>19</sup> Founded as a Taira clan temple, Nyoiji was assimilated into Onjōji in the first half of the thirteenth century, largely because of Keihan's efforts as its abbot.<sup>20</sup> Keihan completed other parts of the record at a villa belonging to the Kujō family, suggesting the family was a staunch supporter

of Jimon activities.<sup>21</sup> In his *Record of Treasured Secrets*, Keihan records rites performed by Shin'en to ensure the safe delivery of the child of Kujō Taeko 任子 (1173–1239), consort to Emperor Go-Toba 後鳥羽 and daughter of Kujō Kanezane, a powerful statesman seen by some as the progenitor of the Kujō family.<sup>22</sup> It is evident that members of the Kujō family were patrons of the Jimon lineage, not least because they stood to benefit from the ritual services the monks offered. Given Keihan's critical role in the institutional expansion of Onjōji, the textual consolidation of its ritual teachings, and his ties with the Kujō family, it is not surprising that his name appears first in the colophons for most surviving texts of the Ritual for Expelling Demons.

The manuscripts were transcribed next, in the early 1220s, by Keisei. Believed to be a son of Kujō Yoshitsune and the older brother of Kujō Michiie, one of the most powerful politicians in the Kamakura period, Keisei was also a member of the Kujō family.<sup>23</sup> He was the grandson of Kanezane, for whose daughter Shin'en performed rituals for safe childbirth. As we might expect, Keisei was also Keihan's student at Onjōji. That would be reason enough for him to receive the Ritual for Expelling Demons from Keihan. But it is clear that Keisei held a special interest in this ritual, for he made several of his own copies of the manuscripts and significantly revised them. Ōta Yukiko, who has examined the history of these manuscripts, suggests that Keisei was aiming to expand his collection of "sacred works" (*shōgyō* 聖教) at his modest temple in Matsunoo 松尾 in Nishiyama 西山 (west Kyoto), Hokkesanji 法華山寺.<sup>24</sup> Between 1219 and 1222, around the time he copied the ritual manuscripts, Keisei is said to have been setting up camp at Hokkesanji and building its library, his major project following his return from a trip to Song China in 1217.

Beyond a general desire to increase his collection of sacred works, Keisei had several personal reasons to be drawn to the topics that uniquely intersected in the Ritual for Expelling Demons. Andrew Goble writes that Keisei "was quite interested in bodily afflictions, having suffered from a crooked spine as a result of a childhood accident, and was influenced by the Tendai notion that contemplation of pollution (e.g., rotting corpses) was an aid to enlightenment."<sup>25</sup> Indeed, in his collection of didactic tales, *A Companion in Solitude* (*Kankyo no tomo* 閑居友), Keisei included several memorable episodes revolving around gruesome encounters with corpses. Besides his fascination with the material dead, he was also an expert ritual healer. As we saw in chapter 3, Keisei used the possession rite to treat his brother Michiie for an illness caused by a swarm of resentful spirits. It is thus difficult to imagine a rite that would pique his interest more than a healing ritual designed to treat an unusual affliction caused by corpses and demons.

The third and typically last of the Jimon monks to appear in the colophons is Rishin. Although little can be said with certainty about Rishin's motivations

for transcribing the manuscripts, it seems clear he was influenced by family connections. Known originally by the Buddhist name Saijo 濟助, Rishin was also a member of the Kujō family. The genealogical work *Continued Lamp Record of Miidera* (*Mii zoku tōki* 三井続燈記, 1483) identifies Rishin as the son of the regent (*sesshō* 摂政) Kujō Norizane 九条教実 (1211–1235). Norizane was Michiie's son, so Rishin would have been the nephew of Keisei, who was also his monastic superior at Onjōji. In addition to the manuscripts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons, Rishin received other works from Keisei, including the *Shoshazan shingon sho* 書写山真言書.<sup>26</sup> Moreover, Rishin may have lived at Ichion'in 一音院, a subtemple of Hosshōji, the monastery where Keisei cured Michiie of his ghostly afflictions and where Michiie eventually built Tōfukuji.

## TEXTUAL SOURCES

Jimon monks crafted the manuscripts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons using what we can reasonably assume were manuscripts on hand at the Tōin, the library of sacred works at Onjōji. Their usage of specific texts are examined in detail in subsequent chapters. For now it will suffice to note that the monks incorporated four main types of textual knowledge in the ritual manuscripts. Two are Buddhist. First, they incorporated writings attributed to Zhiyi, the Chinese founder of the Tendai (Ch. Tiantai) school with which Jimon monks identified, most especially his *Great Calming and Contemplation* (Ch. *Mohe zhiguan* 摩訶止觀), which they explicitly cite. Although Zhiyi does not discuss corpse-vector disease, he does discuss numerous categories of disease, as well as their causes and pathogens.

A greater portion of the ritual manuscripts comprise passages from the second type: esoteric ritual scriptures. Besides the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra* (*Tuoluoni ji jing* 陀羅尼集經), which is arguably the most important of the ritual texts they used, they incorporated esoteric sutras centering on deities such as Senju Kannon, Āṭavaka (Atakugu 阿吒薄俱), Fudō Myōō, and the Peacock King (Kujaku Myōō 孔雀明王; Skt. Mahāmāyūrī). Corpse-vector disease is mentioned in at least three esoteric Buddhist scriptures, all of which Jimon monks were undoubtedly using in crafting the Ritual for Expelling Demons.<sup>27</sup> This includes the *Sutra on Mixing Medicines and Healing Illness by the Thousand-Armed, Thousand-Eyed Avalokiteśvara*, focused on Senju Kannon. Given that Jimon monks performed rituals to Senju Kannon extensively over the Heian period (as we saw in chapters 1 and 3), it is unsurprising they would make use of this bodhisattva's sutra in the Ritual for Expelling Demons manuscripts.

Substantial information about corpse-vector disease appears only in texts in the corpus of classical Chinese medicine, the third type of source on which

Jimon monks drew. In this category I include two kinds of works: texts that belong to the classical literary medical corpus that developed in China and was partially imported to Japan and works composed in Japan that drew heavily on the Chinese medical corpus. That Jimon monks drew on this medical literature is immediately evident in the fact that they focused their rite on corpse-vector disease and moxibustion, a healing technology that derives from classical medicine.

It is reasonable to assume that Tendai pilgrims acquired medical texts while traveling abroad in China and that these would have been transcribed at some point by Jimon monks at Enryakuji, Onjōji, or elsewhere. Here I wish to highlight the possibility that Jimon monks may also have had access to a copy of the *Ishinpō* 医心方. Compiled by court physician Tanba no Yasuyori 丹波康頼 (912–995), the *Ishinpō* represents Japan's oldest extant medical compendium and a benchmark for medical knowledge in Japan for centuries. It is a critical text because the thirteenth fascicle includes extensive discussions of corpse-vector disease.<sup>28</sup> Jimon monks may have acquired a copy of the *Ishinpō* through their long-standing ties to the Kujō family, which probably owned one or two copies of this work. One copy, the so-called Uji-bon 宇治本, an edition passed down in the lineage of regents since the time of Yorimichi, was held by Kanezane.<sup>29</sup> Kanezane was an occasional patron of Jimon monks, a consequence of the ritual services they provided him as well as family connections. As just noted, in 1195, Shin'en performed rituals for the safe delivery of the child of Kanezane's daughter, Taeko. It is not hard to imagine that he would have been willing to share valuable medical knowledge with his trusted healers.

Another copy of the *Ishinpō* survives at the temple Kongōji 金剛寺 in Kawachi 河内, Osaka.<sup>30</sup> As it turns out, one of Kongōji's most active patrons and visitors was Taeko, Kanezane's daughter. The temple came to be managed by nuns such as Kakua 覚阿 (dates unknown) and her sister, Jōkaku 浄覚 (dates unknown), two women who served Taeko as ladies-in-waiting. What is most intriguing about the Kongōji copy of the *Ishinpō*—which likely dates to the early Kamakura period—is that it survives in only one fascicle: the thirteenth, the one that discusses corpse-vector disease. Perhaps there once was a full copy of the *Ishinpō* at Kongōji. Or perhaps what mattered most to the nuns and patrons of the temple was the fascicle with vital information about an unfamiliar disease that in their time started plaguing aristocratic society. In any case, the temple had close ties with the Jimon lineage, as evidenced by the numerous Jimon manuscripts preserved in the temple's library, including one of the best early copies of Enchin's biography.<sup>31</sup> Given the alliances between Jimon monks, Kanezane, and Taeko, it is reasonable to assume the monks were working with medical texts such as the *Ishinpō* when compiling the Ritual for Expelling Demons manuscripts.

The fourth kind of textual source has garnered the most interest among scholars because of its association with Daoism: the *Scripture of Seeking Long Life by Guarding the Fifty-Seventh Day by Laozi* (*Rōshi shu kōshin gu chōsei kyō* 老子守庚申求長生經; hereafter, *Kōshin Scripture*). Although scholars have often approached the inclusion of this work in terms of the question of Daoism's reception in premodern Japan, I demonstrate in chapter 6 that its use must be understood in terms of how its content enabled Jimon monks to patch together a coherent picture of corpse-vector disease, the curious affliction they sought to make sense of and eliminate.

## RITUAL OVERVIEW

Because Jimon monks incorporated various prescriptions from a wide array of textual sources—and often at different stages of the evolution of the ritual texts—the prescriptions for the ritual in the manuscripts are somewhat convoluted, with the result that the precise sequence and structure of the ritual are difficult to reconstruct. Even so, the general contours are clear enough: The ritual is structured as an elaborate ceremony dedicated to a deity (Shōmen Kongō), during which the officiating priest uses a variety of ritual techniques to treat corpse-vector disease, largely by engaging in ritual warfare against the pathogenic agents understood to cause it. Because the rite is focused around the worship of Shōmen Kongō by a monk at an altar, in historical terms the rite is an “altar ritual” (*danpō* 壇方) or “rite for a single deity” (*bessonhō* 別尊法). More specifically, it is structured and organized as a fire ceremony (*goma*), which means that the altar is equipped with a hearth at the center for creating a ritual fire, into which the monk tosses various offerings and effigies. As is often the case with such fire ceremonies, which typically focus on Fudō or other wrathful deities such as the wisdom kings, the Ritual for Expelling Demons can be classed as a rite of “subjugation” (*chōbuku* 調伏; Skt. *abhicāra*), the most aggressive and violent of esoteric ritual genres, with the objective of eradicating enemies, demons, and disease-causing entities.

The primary object of worship (*honzon* 本尊) is Shōmen Kongō, the “Blue-Faced Vajra,” sometimes referred to as the “Great Blue-Colored Vajrayakṣa” (Shōshiki Daikongō Yasha). Aside from an eleventh-century statue believed to be Shōmen Kongō preserved at Tōdaiji 東大寺 in Nara, this deity was largely unknown on the archipelago before his incorporation into this ritual.<sup>32</sup> Moreover, the Jimon adoption of Shōmen Kongō took place long before he achieved sweeping popularity as the tutelary god of the *kōshin* rite. Jimon monks probably drafted Shōmen Kongō from an appendix to a fascicle of the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra* focused on Ucchuṣma (Ususama Myōō 烏枢沙摩明王). Based on descriptions in that work, the Ritual for Shōmen Kongō describes Shōmen Kongō as

having blue skin, three red eyes, and four arms, each holding a symbolic weapon—a wish-fulfilling jewel staff, a noose, a long sword, and a golden wheel. A skull nests in his blazing red hair, and additional skulls adorn the jewelry of his neck, around which a snake coils. He wears a tiger skin skirt. His mount is of special interest: Shōmen Kongō is depicted standing on two demons said to resemble corpses. One of those demons is even named, rather specifically, “corpse demon.”<sup>33</sup> Much of this iconography can be seen in a hanging scroll, dated to the Muromachi period, which is the oldest extant icon of Shōmen Kongō to survive at Onjōji (see figure 6).<sup>34</sup>

Besides the fact that Shōmen Kongō was a “free agent” in the esoteric corpus that Jimon monks could adopt and reshape for their ritual, it is clear that already in esoteric scriptures the deity was linked with the kinds of topics that interested Jimon monks. Indeed, these monks no doubt knew that in the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra* Shōmen Kongō was associated with the elimination of corpse-vector disease.<sup>35</sup> My suspicion is that Jimon monks did not create the Ritual for Expelling Demons to worship Shōmen Kongō, as we might initially assume. Rather, it seems more likely that they began with the pathological problem of corpse-vector disease and then located a deity that authoritative scriptures claimed could cure its victims. Hence, my focus in the next chapters is less on the cult of Shōmen Kongō and more on the relationship between the imagination of the disease and the treatment the Jimon monks proposed for it.

During the ritual, the officiating priest faces west, with the altar before him arranged in the following manner as a mandala. In the center were enshrined three senior deities, the bodhisattva Nyoirin Kannon and the buddhas Yakushi Nyorai (the Medicine Buddha) and Shaka Kinrin 釈迦金輪, referred to in this context as the “King of a Hundred Lights Universally Illuminating, Shaka Golden Wheel Buddha” (Hyakkō Henjō Ō Shaka Kinrin Butsu 百光遍照王釈迦金輪仏). In the northwest quadrant was placed an icon of Fudō Myōō with six eyes, an unusual form of the deity that was probably a Jimon invention.<sup>36</sup> An icon of Shōmen Kongō, with three eyes and four arms, was placed in a parallel position in the southwest quadrant. Surrounding the altar at each of the four cardinal directions were the Four Heavenly Kings (Shitennō 四天王: Jikokuten 持国天, Zōchōten 增長天, Kōmokuten 広目天, Tamonten 多聞天), along with weapons: four swords and four dharma wheels (*hōrin* 宝輪). The corners of the altar were guarded by four *yakṣas*, each a different color (yellow, red, white, and black).

During the performance of the ritual, the priest used mudras and mantras to invoke Shōmen Kongō, Fudō Myōō, and the Peacock King. For Shōmen Kongō, this included his “Great Fundamental Mudra” (Daikonpon’in 大根本印) and “Mantra for Eliminating the Harms of All *Māras* and Demons” (Saimetsu issai maki nangai shingon 摧滅一切魔鬼難害真言), a name that resonates



Figure 6. Shōmen Kongō.  
Muromachi period. Onjōji.  
Courtesy of Miidera and  
Fuke Shungen.



with the title of the liturgy. Others had similar symbolic flavor: “Treating All Demonic Diseases Mudra” (Ryō issai kibyō in 療一切鬼病印), “Subjugating *Māras* Mudra” (Gōbuku ma in 降伏魔印), “Mudra of *Yakṣas* Expelling Heavenly Demons” (Yasha tsui tenki in 薬叉追天鬼印), and “[Spells for] Treating Diseases of Body and Mind” (Chi shinshin-byō 治心身病). After noting that if sufferers of corpse-vector disease are not treated in forty-nine days they will die, the liturgy prescribes a number of aggressive ritual techniques: tossing mustard seeds in the face of the patient, flogging the patient with willow and pomegranate tree branches, and fumigating their nostrils with *gum guggul* incense. Another important technique involves molding effigies of the three demons out of dough and tossing them into the flames of the altar’s hearth.

As we will see in chapter 7, although these techniques appear miscellaneous, their inclusion was informed by strategic ritual design. These methods lead up to and support the rite’s central and most innovative therapeutic feature: applying moxibustion directly on the patient’s body. The liturgy sets this up by noting that if the foregoing methods fail, the priest is to turn to moxibustion. The ritual manuscripts give eleven distinct names of points or loci on the body on which to apply moxibustion. The sequence of application follows a roughly vertical progression that moves downward, starting at a point on the crown of the head and concluding on points on the feet. For the first six points, the manuscripts give mantras arrayed in sequences of Siddham characters (*shittan bonji* 悉曇梵字), suggesting that the priest is to recite these as he applies moxibustion on each point. Instructions thereafter state that Shōmen Kongō’s “Great Body Spell” is to be recited when performing moxibustion and that the ritualist is to perform “empowerment” (*kaji*) on the moxa points using the “fundamental mudra” of Shōmen Kongō.

As noted already, the precise sequence and structure of the ritual is not clear, making a reconstruction of the ceremony difficult. The problem is compounded by the fact that we have yet to find a historical record that attests to an actual performance of the ritual. Neither issue is a major concern for the present study. I focus above all on ritual conception, innovation, and design, and how that process was shaped by and responded to transformations in the imagination of disease and pathogenic agents. In its innovative promotion of moxibustion against the strange affliction of corpse-vector disease, the Ritual for Expelling Demons vividly illustrates how, through the dynamic and messy processes of ritual immunity, Jimon monks creatively grappled with a new variety of post-mortem contagion in early medieval Japan.

## CHAPTER 5

### Corpse Influx in a Defiled Capital



IN THE FINAL DECADES OF THE HEIAN PERIOD, A STRANGE NEW DISEASE began wringing the life out of some of aristocratic society's most prominent people. In 1165, the disease was blamed for murdering Nijō 二条 (1143–1165), a newly retired emperor and the eldest son of Retired Emperor Go-Shirakawa. In 1175, the disease nearly killed the pregnant Fujiwara no Tadako 忠子 (?–1220), the wife of the former prime minister and regent at the time, Matsudono Moto-fusa 松殿基房 (1145–1231). In 1179, the disease triggered the demise of Taira no Moriko 平盛子 (1156–1179), who owned a significant amount of Fujiwara land and was the daughter of Taira no Kiyomori 平清盛 (1118–1181), the man who had brought unprecedented power to the warrior class. The affliction was not the spirit disease of prior centuries—that is, it was not caused by resentful ghosts. Rather, this new mutation of postmortem contagion was coming from corpses, the material dead.

The concept of corpse-vector disease (*denshibyō*) derived originally from Tang period Chinese medical literature known in Japan since at least Tanba no Yasuyori's *Ishinpō* (984).<sup>1</sup> Some medical historians have speculated that corpse-vector disease was the premodern term for tuberculosis (*kekaku* 結核).<sup>2</sup> Although this identification is not without merit, the sudden appearance of the term in late Heian Japan remains mysterious for at least two reasons. First, archeological evidence of skeletons with lesions characteristic of tubercular infection suggests that tuberculosis was prevalent in Japan already by the sixth or seventh centuries CE, yet nearly six hundred years passed before the term “corpse-vector disease” was invoked to name the pathological and cadaverous conditions of living patients like Nijō, Tadako, and Moriko.

Second, dozens of other disease terms that might have been used to refer to the symptoms of tuberculosis were already in use by this later date. Literary sources such as the *Utsuho monogatari* 宇津保物語 (ca. 976–983), the *Pillow Book* (ca. 1000), and the *Tale of Genji* mention afflictions such as “*qi* of the chest” (*mune no ke* 胸気), “chest sickness” (*mune no yamai* 胸病), and “chest constriction” (*munese* 胸狭), and medical sources such as the *Ishinpō* and its source texts

are replete with more sophisticated concepts, including “depletion-exhaustion” (*kyorō* 虚劳), “bones steaming” (*kotsujō* 骨蒸), “wasting disease” (*sōbyō* 瘦病), and “lung dysfunction” (*haii* 肺萎), to name only a few examples.<sup>3</sup> If Nijō and the others suffered from a wasting disease in the chest, like tuberculosis, any of the terms in this constellation of disease concepts might have been chosen to describe their affliction.

The key question is not whether these people were suffering from tuberculosis in a biomedical sense, a conclusion that would be impossible to reach based on necessarily limited historical evidence. Instead, the appearance of corpse-vector disease in this period raises a more interesting question for this book’s examination of postmortem contagion. Given that courtiers had routinely attributed afflictions to immaterial spirits for centuries, why in the early medieval period did they begin attributing the rise of an apparently new affliction to corpses?

In this chapter, I examine the emergence of corpse-vector disease in the late twelfth century, by which I mean its appearance as a viable disease concept, one that had not been used before to name a disease actively afflicting known patients in aristocratic society. I argue that the emergence of this disease was tied to an intensification of anxieties in the early medieval period concerning defilement (*kegare* 穢), a form of pollution that was imagined to negatively alter the ritual and ontological status of human bodies and spaces. As Jacqueline Stone has observed, scholars have yet to sufficiently assess the wide-ranging effects of the notion of defilement on developments in Japanese religion and Buddhism.<sup>4</sup> The issue of defilement also has special importance in the historical study of disease in Japan, since scholars have long taken for granted the idea that disease and defilement were categorically related in premodern eras.

The assumption that defilement was imagined to cause disease is largely unfounded, but in the pages that follow, I suggest that corpse-vector disease constitutes a case of a disease that was profoundly shaped by notions of defilement. In particular, by situating diary entries describing victims of the disease in the context of changing notions of defilement, I contend that the emergence of corpse-vector disease must be understood in light of growing anxieties toward “death defilement” (*shie* 死穢). These diary entries suggest that in the eyes of highly educated courtiers, corpse-vector disease was anomalous, quite unlike the disease categories with which they were acquainted, including spirit disease. At the same time, corpse-vector disease was disturbingly familiar, for it reflected mounting concerns about death pollution that permeated life in a capital overflowing with corpses.

Then I turn to the manuscripts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons, the ritual that monks of Jimon lineage crafted as a direct response to the emergence of corpse-vector disease. An examination of numerous passages in these manuscripts confirms that the notion of corpse-vector disease resonated with the

broad imagination of death and death defilement. Such passages allow us to understand how notions of pollution came to shape a disease imaginary that Buddhist healers shared with their elite patients in this period. This chapter shows that to understand the appearance of corpse-vector disease, we must move beyond received assumptions about some kind of categorical relationship between disease and defilement. Instead, we must attend to the many factors—religious, medical, environmental, and social—by which correlations between them were established at particular moments; the late twelfth century was one such moment.

## HEIANKYŌ, 1170–1220: CITY OF THE DEAD

At many times throughout history, inhabitants of urban centers on the Japanese archipelago found themselves inundated by a proliferation of human corpses.<sup>5</sup> One of the most overwhelming and historically consequential periods of corpse proliferation fell roughly between 1170 and 1220. In this fifty-year period, the capital of Heiankyō witnessed a deadly trifecta of disaster, disease, and warfare. In his book, *The Middle Ages of the Dead* (*Shishatachi no chūsei* 死者たちの中世), Katsuda Itaru demonstrates this fact with statistics gleaned from entries in the diaries of courtiers spanning the two-hundred-year period between 1100 and 1300.<sup>6</sup> Counting the mentions of what elite courtiers called “death defilement,” Katsuda charts a significant increase of such incidents between 1180 and 1219, followed by a significant drop-off.<sup>7</sup> This increase in mentions of death defilement, a contamination occasioned by encounters with corpses and detached limbs, suggests a dramatic rise in the population of the material dead on the streets of Heiankyō.

Epidemics were one cause of this corpse proliferation in the capital. According to William Wayne Farris, Japan’s “age of plagues,” which began in 700, ended by 1050. During this period, epidemics occurred on the archipelago at a frequency of approximately one every 2.9 years in the 700s and one every 3.8 years in the “poorly documented” 900s. By any measure, the frequency of epidemics between 1050 and 1260 remained staggering. Farris writes, “There were 50 epidemics over 210 years, an average of one outbreak every 4.2 years.”<sup>8</sup> For example, in the late twelfth and early thirteenth century, Heiankyō saw epidemics of measles or red pox (*akamogasa* 赤疱瘡) in 1163; influenza (*gaibyō* 咳病) in 1175; a severe smallpox (*mogasa* 痘瘡) outbreak in 1175; and what historians speculate may have been an outbreak of chickenpox, which contemporaneous sources call water-pox (*suitō* 水痘), in 1180, followed by a more pervasive outbreak of the same in 1200.<sup>9</sup>

Another major generator of the material dead were disasters, both natural disasters and those exacerbated by human actions. Numerous calamities are

described in vivid detail by Kamo no Chōmei 鴨長明 (ca. 1153–1216) in his *Record of a Ten-Foot Square Hut* (*Hōjōki* 方丈記). Writing safely from the mountain hut in which he shielded himself from the hazards of urban life, Chōmei describes such disasters as the “Great Angen Fire” in 1177 that quickly blanketed the city, fueled by misguided urban construction and given speed by unusual winds; a whirlwind in the fourth month of 1180; the expensive, tumultuous, and ultimately unsuccessful move of the capital in the sixth month of 1180; a famine in 1181 and 1182; and a major earthquake in 1185.<sup>10</sup>

Among the deadliest disasters was a sequence of calamities that took place around the 1181–1182 Yōwa famine. Farmers throughout the country had been recruited to serve in the civil war between the warrior clans of the Heike 平家 and the Genji 源氏, greatly diminishing the supply of food to the capital. To make matters worse, the famine was followed shortly by an epidemic the next year. On the fatal aftermath, Chōmei reported a breathtaking death count he heard from an abbot of the Shingon temple Ninnaji. He was told there were 42,300 corpses in the capital streets, to say nothing of more distant areas.<sup>11</sup> Notably the abbot’s count far exceeds the number of death defilement cases Katsuda noted. Given the coincidence of epidemics, disasters, and dislocation in this period, the number speaks to just how far reaching the problem of corpses would have been.

Customs for managing the sick and the dying spurred the increase of cadavers throughout the capital. Families often evicted members of their household who became terminally ill. The tragic decision to abandon family members when they were most vulnerable was not driven by a fear of disease contagion, as we might initially expect during this time of multiple outbreaks. Instead, what appears to have driven families to abandon their ill to the streets was a fear of the defiling corpse.<sup>12</sup> A death that occurred in the household, it was believed, would render the entire space defiled, putting the family at risk.<sup>13</sup> Tossing out the sick was a prophylactic measure to prevent domestic pollution caused by death, the inevitable terminus for many who acquired illness.

In accounting for the proliferation of corpses, we can also cite the management—or mismanagement—of cadavers. The sheer numbers of dead in this time meant that not all corpses could be properly processed. Indeed, the decrease in death defilement cases after 1220 noted by Katsuda suggests that a functioning system for cremation and earth burial was probably established in this later period. This sharply contrasts with the half-century prior, when there was no robust system for managing the dead, and certainly not one that could hold up to the disease outbreaks and disasters that repeatedly stressed Heiankyō. Thus, most of the dead were given natural burials (literally “wind burials,” *fūsō* 風葬), which is to say, they were abandoned outside, at best at the necropolises that surrounded the capital (such as Toribeno), but mostly, it seems, by the Kamo

River and in the streets. Such was the certain fate for the countless people who did not have families to begin with and those who succumbed to death on the streets. Chōmei's observations give us a vivid sense of the city's inability to manage its dead and the resulting problems: "None knew how to dispose of all these corpses; the air was filled with their stench, and one could only avert the eyes from the frequent sight of slowly decomposing bodies. As for the dry river bed [by the Kamo River], the bodies lay so thick that there was no room for horses and carts to pass."<sup>14</sup>

### IMPURITY, IMPERMANENCE, AND REVULSION: DIDACTIC CADAVERS

In the urban environment of Heiankyō—the "ultimate corpse metropolis" (*kyūkyoku no shigai toshi* 究極の死骸都市), in the words of Kamikawa Michio—opportunities to observe corpses, desired or not, were many.<sup>15</sup> These encounters had mixed effects for people and families. For many laypersons, a chance encounter with the material dead became a motivation to renounce the world, take the tonsure, and devote their lives to Buddhist practice. Buddhist tale literature of the period, such as the twelfth-century anthology *Tales of Times Now Past*, provides many accounts of such corpse-induced awakenings. One story tells of a man abandoning his four-year-old daughter and becoming the disciple of a famous holy man after seeing his wife's corpse. Another man is thrust into the religious life after he kisses a corpse, the body of his deceased wife, with whom he had refused to part for several days. The story tells how the stench generates inside him at once revulsion and a desire for renunciation.<sup>16</sup> Encounters with corpses in this period thus signified the dismemberment of families even as they propelled individual religious careers, typically for men.

One perceptive individual who took special interest in encounters with corpses was the Jimon monk Keisei. Keisei's collection of didactic tales, *A Companion in Solitude*, contains several memorable stories featuring gruesome encounters with corpses. His interest in this macabre topic, scholars of Japanese literature have pointed out, is a distinct characteristic of his writing.<sup>17</sup> Rajyashree Pandey summarizes one especially intense tale in which a "noblewoman enlightens a high-ranking monk regarding the foulness of the female body, but she does so by *simulating* the grotesqueness of a corpse: she smears her robes with blood, colors her face yellow and blue to conjure up pus and putrefaction, and dishevels her hair so that she looks like a demon."<sup>18</sup> The tale suggests that for Keisei, corpses were not merely passive objects to contemplate but also, much like demons, strange and disfigured beings into which one might mutate, even while still alive. I return to this point when I discuss the Ritual for Expelling Demons later in this chapter.

The early thirteenth century marked the height of popularity in stories surrounding voluntary and involuntary encounters with corpses.<sup>19</sup> Many suggest that Buddhist monks took deliberate advantage of such jolting exposures with the material dead. For Buddhist monks, an encounter with a corpse provided an unusually potent chance to advance in religious insight. In one story, written by Keisei, a servant-monk secretly leaves his monastery every night to visit a necropolis on the outskirts of the city. When the master learns of the monk's nightly homework, he praises the monk's wisdom and his "wonderful and rare" capacity for such a difficult meditation.<sup>20</sup>

The practice of contemplating the body via the decomposition of the corpse had roots in earlier Buddhist contemplative practices going back to South Asia. The corpse figures as an object of contemplation in the Pali scripture known as the *Satipatthana Sutta*: "Again, bhikkhus, as though he were to see a corpse thrown aside in a charnel ground, one, two, or three days dead, bloated, livid, and oozing matter, a bhikkhu compares this same body with it thus: 'This body too is of the same nature, it will be like that, it is not exempt from that fate.'"<sup>21</sup> Similar practices came to be established in China. One influential program was proposed by Zhiyi, to whom Tendai monks in Japan looked as their patriarch. In his *Great Calming and Contemplation*, Zhiyi outlines a corpse contemplation divided into nine stages of decomposition: bloating, decay, blood smears, rotting pus, bruising, chewing by scavengers, scattering of parts, reduction to white bones, and cremation.<sup>22</sup> These practices, which typically described visualization or contemplation, came to inform influential discourse on the impurity of the body in Japan, including Genshin's *Essentials of Rebirth*.<sup>23</sup>

Practices of corpse contemplation and observation gave rise to a special genre of illustrations and paintings called the images of nine stages (*kusōzu* 九相図).<sup>24</sup> These images, such as the *Kusō zukan* 九相図巻, depict the decomposition of a corpse in nine stages, drawing from earlier Chinese Buddhist discourse like that of Zhiyi, who described them in his *Great Calming and Contemplation* (see figure 7).<sup>25</sup> Scholars have drawn attention to the fact that these images almost invariably show the corpses of aristocratic women and thus are rooted in much older forms of Buddhist misogyny. Indeed, there is an obvious parallel in the choice to depict a corpse of a woman with the stories of men being propelled into religious life through encounters with the corpses of their deceased wives. One subtext of this visual genre is that women constitute obstacles to the Buddhist path, which men must overcome.

The timing of the appearance of this corpse imagery genre is significant. These images first begin to appear in the mid-thirteenth century, the period immediately after the heyday of corpses that concerns us here. It also closely follows the height of popularity of *setsuwa* stories detailing encounters with corpses in the early thirteenth century. This suggests in part that the genre not only

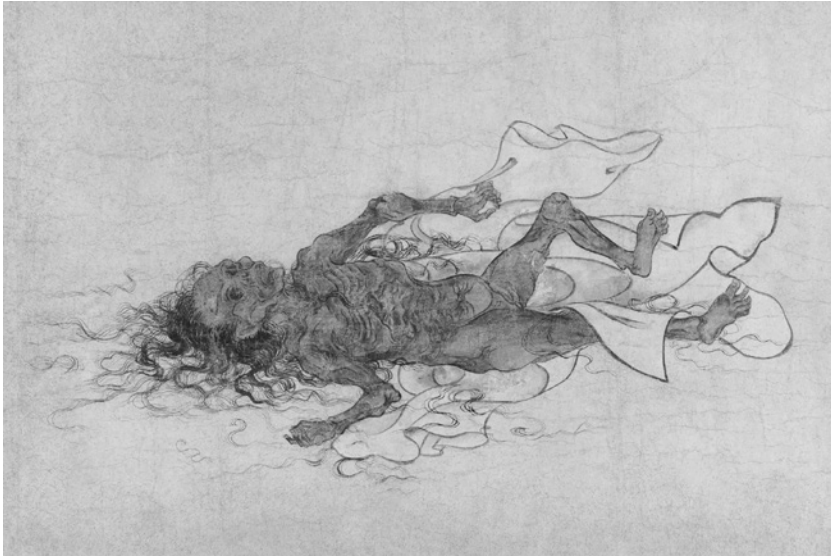


Figure 7. Detail from *Kusō zukan*. Fourteenth century. Kyushu National Museum. Source: ColBase ([https://colbase.nich.go.jp/collection\\_items/kyuhaku/A70](https://colbase.nich.go.jp/collection_items/kyuhaku/A70)).

developed alongside deliberate corpse exposure practices but also emerged as a reflection of and a means to metabolize decades of direct and mostly undesired exposure to rotting corpses in and around the urban environment of Heiankyō. It was perhaps to anesthetize these unpleasant encounters with the material dead that Buddhists doubled their efforts to read the realities of the decaying humanity around them in terms of Buddhist doctrine, which at least promised salvation as a result. Moreover, because the creation of this visual genre required at least a rudimentary understanding of the stages of decomposition, we can assume that there were ample real-life models from which to study in this period.

## THE DANGERS OF DEATH DEFILEMENT

The corpses that littered the capital and its environs were not merely passive texts for Buddhist monks and budding renunciants to take their doctrinal study into the real world. In the eyes of courtiers and emperors in Heiankyō during this period, corpses were vectors of a very dangerous entity. The material dead emanated a special kind of contagion known as “defilement” or “death defilement.” The defilement that worried elite Heian society differs from the Buddhist notion of impurity. For Buddhists such as Zhiyi and Genshin, corpses were indeed animated by the active processes of decomposition, but they were ultimately passive interfaces for realizing one’s mortality.<sup>26</sup> In contrast, the



defilement feared by elite society in Japan, which radiated from corpses, exerted harmful effects on court life, ritual, and even one's physical safety.

Defilement was defined in legal codes such as the *Procedures of the Engi Era* (*Engishiki* 延喜式, 927). Such works identified numerous sources of defilement, including blood, childbirth, menstruation, and fire. The severest form of defilement came from death, whether by mourning the deceased, participating in a Buddhist mortuary ritual, visiting a burial mound, or most commonly, encountering a corpse or orphaned appendages.<sup>27</sup> Those who contracted death defilement, and were thereby ritually contaminated, were not allowed to serve at court for thirty days, nor were they to visit shrines to the *kami* gods. To visit a shrine while contaminated by death was to risk incurring a curse (*tatari* 祟り) from the gods, which could result in sickness, injury, or even death. Defilement often put a stop to court politics and led to the cancellation of rites at *kami* shrines.

Death defilement operated as a kind of contagion. In legal codes such as the *Procedures of the Engi Era* and *New Procedures* (*Shingishiki* 新儀式, after 963), the transmission of defilement was defined in a more or less clear sequence of four positions: *kō* 甲, *otsu* 乙, *hei* 丙, and sometimes *tei* 丁. *Kō* marked the first site or person defiled, such as encountering a corpse. *Otsu*, or secondhand defilement, occurred when a person entered a *kō* space after the corpse was removed or if a *kō* person entered a second space, rendering that space *otsu*. Thirdhand (*hei*) defilement likewise occurred through interaction with *otsu*, and there was also the possibility of fourthhand (*tei*) defilement.<sup>28</sup>

In theory, the linear sequence of defilement contagion meant pathways of transmission were easily traceable back to a "patient zero." In practice, things quickly became messy, spurring debates between courtiers that often required the intervention of specialists such as yin-yang masters.<sup>29</sup> Reconstructing transmission pathways was frequently undermined by the fact that defiled individuals were often unaware of their compromised, contaminated state.<sup>30</sup> That is, it did not matter whether you actually saw the dismembered limb that a dog brought into your garden; you were contaminated nonetheless. There were also debates about how to assess the severity of defilement. For example, courtiers debated whether exposure to partial corpse limbs constituted the same level of defilement as intact corpses; whether exposure to white bones without flesh should constitute defilement, and if so, how severe; and whether defilement exposure on a major boulevard posed the same threat it did in more confined spaces.<sup>31</sup>

For aristocrats, then, encounters with corpses in Heiankyō were less opportunities to ponder impermanence and more a terrifying impetus to ramp up measures for self-protection. The court occasionally tried to curb the underlying sanitation problem that led to contamination by defilement, mainly by ordering metropolitan police (*kebiishi* 檢非違使), "purifiers" (*kiyome* 淨人), *rai* sufferers

(*katai* カタイ), “non-persons” (*hinin* 非人), and members of other outcast groups to deposit corpses at the “virtual ring of necropoli [that] took shape in the hills and fields surrounding Heiankyō.”<sup>32</sup> But these attempts to expel material death to the boundaries had little effect on what by all accounts had become a veritable epidemic by the late Heian period. To borrow the words of Yoshida Tsunefusa 吉田経房 (1142–1200) from an entry recorded in his diary *Kikki* 吉記 during the 1181–1182 famine, “Nanto (Nara) and Kyoto are pervaded with great defilement” (*daishokue* 大触穢).<sup>33</sup>

One of the most disconcerting aspects of corpse pollution was how it short-circuited the ritual apparatus, thereby disarming once reliable sacred sites on whose potency depended the well-being of the city’s inhabitants. For instance, plans in 1191 to revive prayers for much-needed rain at Shinsen’en 神泉苑 were canceled on account of a site survey that concluded, “Corpses abundantly fill [the grounds]; the pollution and defilement is beyond measure.”<sup>34</sup> A request to remove the offending pollution was conveyed to the head of the metropolitan police (*kebiishi bettō* 檢非違使別当), but the priest in charge of the rites countered that without functioning walls, protection from further pollution could not be guaranteed, thus one could not hope for “dharmic efficacy” (*hōgen* 法驗) at the site. This is just one example of important rituals and ceremonies postponed or canceled because of death defilement.

Courtiers increasingly found their day-to-day lives organized by anxieties surrounding defilement, which cast its shadows on their minds, their conversations, their movements. As noted already, much time was spent anxiously deliberating how best to traverse the city roads without crossing paths with the abandoned dead. Courtiers sent police ahead of their palanquins to scout for and clear the roads of bodies, heads, and limbs. Courtiers could cite good reasons for their fears. In an entry from the *Taiki* 台記 from 1145, a funeral palanquin (*sōsha* 葬車) was said to have passed in front of the procession of Emperor Konoe 近衛天皇 (1139–1155). Commenting on the inauspiciousness of the event, Fujiwara no Tadazane recounted to his son Yorinaga 頼長 (1120–1156) an incident some forty years earlier when the imperial procession of Retired Emperor Horikawa encountered a corpse on the road. The emperor is said to have suffered from “coughing sickness” for many years after, and this was thought to have been the cause of his death in 1107.<sup>35</sup> Tadazane, however, hypothesized that it was ultimately the emperor’s encounter with death defilement that was to blame.<sup>36</sup> For some courtiers, therefore, the danger of encountering the dead was no longer limited to inauspicious contamination of shrine, court, or palace; rather, in anxious rumors, defilement was now an “inauspicious sign” (*fukichi no shō* 不吉之象) that might directly spell death. As Tadazane commented, “When corpses are on the road [the people who encounter them] do not last long; how much more so [when they encounter] funeral palanquins [of the recently deceased]!”<sup>37</sup>

## THE EPIDEMIC SPREAD AND PATHOLOGICAL INFLUX OF DEFILEMENT

One cannot read descriptions of the transmission of defilement from Heian Japan without recalling another kind of noxious influence with which humanity must contend: contagious disease. Indeed, descriptions of defilement transmission resulting from interactions with others, visits to public spaces, and encounters with dead bodies betray a strong resemblance to observations of the spread of a disease over a particular location—and in particular, our sometimes unquestioned intuition that cadavers are vectors for the spread of disease. Such impressions might lead any historian of the Heian period to surmise that for courtiers, defilement and disease must have belonged to a shared category of contagion. In part because of these apparent similarities, scholars of premodern Japan have long assumed that defilement and disease must have been categorically related.<sup>38</sup> The two have been linked in three main ways: the notion that disease constituted a form of defilement, the idea that sick persons were seen as defiled, and the etiological premise that defilement can become a cause of illness.

None of these assumptions about a categorical relationship between disease and defilement have been substantiated with historical evidence from premodern periods. In fact, we know that *kegare*, unlike disease, was not understood to present on the body. When acquired, defilement was unseen; moreover, defiled people were largely asymptomatic, at least until they violated a taboo by, for example, visiting a shrine or court. This is precisely the reason for the frequency of cases in which people unknowingly contaminate multiple persons and places. Unlike disease, there was no physical symptom by which they could have known of their contaminated condition.

However, as anxieties about death defilement began to increase from the mid-Heian period on—peaking with the explosion of the cadaveric population in the late twelfth and early thirteenth centuries—it appears that people in aristocratic society did begin to imagine defilement in ways that increasingly resembled disease.

First, defilement was starting to act more like a disease epidemic. Beginning in the late eleventh century, people began to imagine that *qi* emanating from dead bodies—defiled *qi* (*ekelege* 穢気)—could spread across large expanses of territory like an outbreak of contagious disease. One example comes from 1096, when crowds flocked to witness the eminent monk Keichō 慶朝 (dates unknown) consecrate a new temple attached to Sumiyoshi Shrine 住吉大社. The pilgrims were so numerous that crowds began interrupting the assembly. In response, shrine authorities began expelling the pilgrims, sending dozens into a nearby pond, where many drowned. When participants in the ceremony

thereafter went to court, stained with death defilement, it was declared that the realm at large (*tenka* 天下) was now polluted.<sup>39</sup>

In another example, just two days after a separate case of realm-wide defilement had ended (the details of which are unknown), a ferocious fire broke out at the residence of Fujiwara no Sanemori 藤原実盛 (dates unknown), leading to the death of many in his household. In his *Chūyūki* 中右記, Fujiwara no Munetada 藤原宗忠 (1062–1141) commented gravely, “In recent days the realm is filled [*henman* 遍満] with thirdhand defiled *qi* [*hei eki* 丙穢氣].” Munetada then began linking the tragedy to other “strange happenings” (*kaii* 怪異), including those that had occurred in the middle of the night—a bell in a treasure hall spontaneously ringing by itself and an earthquake. He took these strange signs as good reason to observe taboos (*monoimi* 物忌) that day.<sup>40</sup>

A third example, bringing us to the late Heian period, is the well-known battle of Ichi no Tani in 1184. In the *Notes on the Origins of the Shrine-Temple* (*Gūji enji shō* 宮寺縁事抄), a Kamakura period record of Iwashimizu Hachimangū 石清水八幡宮, this particularly brutal battle is said to have released defilement throughout the realm.<sup>41</sup>

Collectively, such descriptions of defilement—articulated with phrases such as “defilement in the world” (*seken-e* 世間穢), “defilement under heaven [i.e., in the realm]” (*tenka-e* 天下穢), and “touch defilement under heaven” (*tenka shokue* 天下触穢)—register anxieties new in the late Heian period about the ontology of death defilement. Certain forms of death defilement, these articulations suggest, not only transmit between individuals but disperse rather unpredictably and on a vast scale. Defilement was now acting in a way more characteristic of other epidemic phenomena: natural disasters, vengeful spirits (*goryō* 御霊), epidemic deities (*ekishin* 疫神), and disease epidemics.

Many examples of this new epidemic defilement pertain to contamination of the imperial palace. In one episode reported in the *Chūyūki*, secondhand defilement contaminating the imperial palace resulted in “defiled *qi* pervading the world.” If the emperor was understood to be the center of purity in early medieval Japan, the imperial palace, once polluted, became the platform by which defilement was broadcast throughout the realm. One striking event is the Angen fire of 1177 that destroyed the Daigokuden 大極殿, a critical ritual venue where ceremonies for national protection were performed.<sup>42</sup> Its destruction provoked lengthy deliberation by specialists from the Jingikan 神祇官 and the Onmyōryō 陰陽寮, both of whom declared that indeed this was a case of realm-wide defiled *qi*.<sup>43</sup>

The death of an emperor or warrior ruler could also cause the mass spread of defiled *qi*. The most famous example is the death of Minamoto no Yoritomo 源頼朝 (1147–1199) in Kamakura, which created “a state of national pollution,” resulting in the postponement of many ceremonies across the realm.<sup>44</sup> Because

the seat of power had by then shifted to Kamakura, it became the new site from which the deaths of rulers might radiate realm-wide defilement.<sup>45</sup>

The realm-wide circulation of death defilement had palpable effects in the cancellation or postponement of court and shrine ceremonies, as well as temporary bans on hunting, fishing, and music performances throughout Japan, thus affecting not only the elite but common people.<sup>46</sup> More important, to speak and write of defiled *qi* filling the realm was clearly a way to articulate unprecedented concerns over what defilement was capable of in a city overflowing with the dead. To Heian courtiers, the novel sentiment of defilement circulation they expressed by way of defiled *qi* would have evoked the ontology of diseases, both collective and individual.

Although the term *ki/ke* (Ch. *qi*) held multiple meanings in classical Chinese medical discourse, in courtier diaries in Japan, it was often used to refer to a pathological agent or condition. The proliferation of defiled *qi* in the realm immediately conjures images of disease epidemics, one word for which was “epidemic *qi*” (*ekiki* 疫気). An outbreak of measles in 1025 was said to afflict “all under heaven,” language that anticipates later descriptions of defiled *qi*.<sup>47</sup> Second, defiled *qi* imagined to fill the realm was much like the *qi* of disease (*byōki* 病気) said to accumulate in individual ailing bodies. Influenced by Chinese medical discourse, Heian period diaries and literature refer to diseases like “coughing *qi*” (*gaike* 咳気), “chest *qi*” (*mune no ke*), and “leg *qi*” (*ashi no ke* 脚気).<sup>48</sup> As we saw in chapters 2 and 3, two of the most frequently used disease concepts were “evil *qi*” (*jake*) and the “*qi* of things” (*mononoke*). Though both terms could refer to the spirits of individual people, by the late Heian period, these spirits were largely understood as disease entities.

Such associations between defilement and disease had arguably become easier to draw by the late Heian. The reason is that from the mid-Heian period on, the ontology of defilement had already seen significant changes, particularly in regard to how defilement related to the body. In the earlier legal-ritual conception of touch defilement found in texts such as the *Procedures of the Engi Era*, defilement was much like “dirt” in the Douglasian sense of “matter out of place.”<sup>49</sup> As long as defiled individuals waited out the stipulated number of days (typically thirty for contact with the dead) or underwent purification (*harae* 祓, *misogi* 禊), they could be assured they were “clean” and thus fit to resume court service or religious practice at sacred sites enshrining the *kami*. While this physicalist (and largely amoral) understanding of defilement was never supplanted, the newer ontology that began to surface in the mid-Heian period saw defilement as much less amenable to elimination by time or ritual disinfecting. It was now imagined to pour into and accumulate within the body, thus becoming chronic and much harder or even impossible to remove.

To account for these changes to the older notion of defilement, Yokoi Kiyoshi pointed to the influence of Buddhist notions of impurity related to the accumulation of karma in past lives.<sup>50</sup> For convenience, I refer to his argument, which many scholars have since adopted, as the karmic defilement thesis.<sup>51</sup> In his original formulation, Yokoi cited in particular the impact of Genshin's *Essentials of Rebirth*, a clearing house for Buddhist sentiments on bodily impurity (*fujō* 不浄). To spur feelings of aversion for the "defiled body" (*eshin* 穢身) residing in this "defiled world" (*edo* 穢土), Genshin offered an unsettling and vertiginous tour of the body's disgusting anatomy. He discussed at length the eighty thousand worms (*mushi* 蟲 or 虫) that inhabit this polluted body, the process of dying that triggers the worms to devour each other in a fight for survival, and the corpse's multiple stages of decay after death.<sup>52</sup> Genshin's descriptions became one basis for textual and visual depictions of the contemplation on impurity, through which Buddhist adepts might learn to see their own living bodies as they would an abandoned corpse by the roadside.

Genshin's program was soteriological. He wanted readers to sever attachment to their ever-deteriorating physiology so they might direct their mind toward rebirth in Amida's Pure Land.<sup>53</sup> Yet as Yokoi has argued, Genshin's evocative and haunting discourse exerted effects beyond matters of salvation.<sup>54</sup> To the earlier sense of *kegare* was now linked Buddhist terminology surrounding karmic hindrance (*zaishō* 罪障, *zaigō* 罪業), resulting in what Jayne Sun Kim has dubbed "transgression defilement."<sup>55</sup> David Bialock explains this change succinctly: "Doctrine, in brief, was now extending its domain into the body as impurity (*fujō*), was interiorized, and defilement took on the meaning of sinful karmic obstruction (*zaishō*)."<sup>56</sup> It is not the case that older senses of touch defilement were displaced. Indeed, as this chapter has shown already, external forms of pollution such as corpses continued to garner much concern as time went on. But the imagination of defilement, its sources, and effects had changed: Defilement was no longer simply something acquired through external contact or proximity with polluting substances, nor was it any longer reliably deactivated through taboo prudence or purification. That was because defilement came to be envisioned as capable of infusing the body—"a kind of ontological entangling," in Bialock's words—tethering it to the karmic impurity the individual inherited from previous lifetimes.<sup>57</sup>

How did this newer, more somatically oriented ontology of defilement shape the imagination of disease? Where the karmic defilement thesis has surely been the most convincing is in the case of *rai* 癩, a broad term for a wide range of disfiguring skin disorders, including leprosy. In the condition of *rai*, it is clear where earlier associations of the more transient *kegare* intertwine with an embodied and chronic pathological condition. That *rai* sufferers (*raisha* 癩者) were seen as defiled in the earlier sense is obvious from how they were

barred from entering shrines, just as somebody who had recently encountered a corpse might have been.<sup>58</sup> Some vow texts (*kishōmon* 起請文) suggested they were as damned as those punished by gods and buddhas.<sup>59</sup> Encyclopedic works expressly defined them as one of the “plentifully defiled” (*eta* 穢多),<sup>60</sup> and there were social practices of marginalization in which they were grouped along with beggars, disabled persons, “purifiers,” and other *hinin* in what Susan Burns has called “the geography of exclusion.”<sup>61</sup> At the same time, the chronicity of their condition was grounded in the Mahāyāna perspective of *rai* as a karmic illness. In fact, the *Treatise on the Great Perfection of Wisdom* (*Da zhidu lun* 大智度論) claimed that “of the many diseases, *rai* disease is the most severe. Due to causes and conditions from transgressions of previous lifetimes, it is difficult to treat.”<sup>62</sup>

I propose that *rai* is not the only case in which inhabitants of Heiankyō discerned a close link between disease and defilement. In fact, an even closer connection between pathology and pollution can be seen in the primary affliction that concerns us: corpse-vector disease. The case of corpse-vector disease is illustrative because it reveals two features of the disease–defilement entanglement not seen for *rai*. For one, corpse-vector disease afflicted aristocrats and emperors rather than marginalized outcasts. Most important, its emergence was directly tied to what was long understood as the ultimate source of defilement—death.

## AFFLICTED BY CORPSES

At the peak of these developments in the late twelfth century—when corpses flooded the capital with pollution and anxieties about defiled *qi* crisscrossed with rumors about death and disease at court—aristocrats and members of the imperial family found themselves afflicted with a mysterious and by all accounts unheard-of illness. “Transferring-corpse disease” (*tenshibyō* 轉屍病), synonymous with corpse-vector disease, was thought to be the affliction that struck three high-profile patients in 1165, 1175, and 1179. A close reading of diary entries describing these cases reveals that although this disease was largely anomalous in the eyes of observers, its emergence also reflected growing anxieties about corpses as pathogenic agents.

The first to be afflicted by the disease was no less than a newly retired emperor, Nijō. The eldest son of Go-Shirakawa, Nijō had been weak in disposition since his youth. At age twenty-three, in 1165, he was stricken with an illness that spelled the end of his reign and eventually his life, on 7/28. In the months leading up to his demise, monks and shrine priests conducted a dizzying array of ceremonies on Nijō’s behalf, including purification rites (*ōharae* 大祓) and offerings (*hōhei* 奉幣) at ten shrines, recitations of the *Peacock Sutra* at the imperial palace led by Go-Shirakawa’s younger brother Kakushō Hosshinō 覺性法親王 (1129–1169), an Aizen Myōō 愛染明王 ritual performed at the

Seiryōden Futama, offerings at Ise Shrine, and the consecration of one hundred images of Fudō Myōō (*Fudō zō hyakutai kuyō* 不動像百体供養) at Ninnaji.<sup>63</sup> The stubborn affliction refused to abate, and Nijō was forced to retire on 5/25; the throne was passed to Go-Shirakawa's second son, Yorihiro, then a one-year-old infant. As Nakayama no Tadachika 中山忠親 (1131–1195) reports in *Sankaiki* 山槐記 on 6/28, Nijō was not yet abandoned, for his caretakers began resorting to unorthodox measures: "Someone reported: 'The Newly Retired Emperor's affliction has yet to lessen. Today, Iwaya Shōnin visited in secret and applied moxibustion on two spots on [Nijō's] chest, twenty-one cones each. The Governor of Sagami, Nobuyasu, offered moxibustion. . . . It is said that [Iwaya] Shōnin treats transferring-corpse disease [*tenshibyō*]. [The idea to summon Iwaya] was proposed by Middle Counselor Taira.'"<sup>64</sup>

Although this is the earliest extant mention of Iwaya Shōnin 岩屋聖人 (dates unknown) in the historical record, Tadachika implies that the "holy man" (*shōnin*) had already made a name for himself as a healer of transferring-corpse disease, an affliction that, at least in the eyes of Nijō's caretakers, refused all manner of premier ritual treatments and thus called for an unusual option: moxibustion conducted by a *hijiri*. This unorthodox, last-ditch attempt apparently did not work. Tadachika reports that not long after his treatment, Nijō got diarrhea after eating coarse food and lost consciousness, whereafter he refused to eat, commencing the month-long countdown to his death.

In speaking generally about Iwaya's reputation as a healer of corpse-vector disease, Tadachika's entry hints that other sufferers had this affliction in court society. But the next case that survives in the historical record comes from nearly ten years later, in 1175, when the same diagnosis was proposed for Fujiwara no Tadako, wife of Matsudono Motofusa. Her illness received considerable attention from contemporaries. Motofusa was then regent, the marriage between him and Tadako had been opposed by certain factions at court, and Tadako was five months pregnant at the time. Accounts of her illness are given in the *Sankaiki* and *Gyokuyō* 玉葉, the diary of Kujō Kanazane.

The entry for 8/16 of 1175 in the *Sankaiki* notes that Iwaya was summoned to treat her because of his reputation. In possibly the only firsthand account of the entries examined here, Tadachika writes, Iwaya is "the dharma master that protects the body from the *tenshinbyō* 轉申病 that has arisen in recent years." Somebody around her evidently surmised that Tadako was suffering from the same disease that afflicted Nijō. Indeed, her symptoms recall those that incapacitated Nijō: "[Tadako] has become unable to eat," Tadachika reported. "Sometimes she has warm *qi* [*onki*], the inside of her body is acrid and bitter, she has dramatically emaciated from her exhaustion, and she wears fright and fear on her face."<sup>65</sup> In Tadachika's entry, *tenshinbyō* is undoubtedly a mistranscription for *tenshibyō*, transferring-corpse disease.



The second entry concerning Tadako's sickness, from the *Gyokuyō*, sheds light on additional observations about her condition and its cause. The secondhand report Kanezane conveys indicates that Tadako is suffering from *jake*, evil *qi*. But in an interlinear note, he wonders: "Was it suspected [that the affliction was] transferring-*gyaku* disease?" The reason for speculating the affliction might be "transferring-*gyaku* disease" (*tengyakubyō* 転虐病) is the fact that Iwaya had been summoned.<sup>66</sup> This is again consistent with Iwaya's reputation in aristocratic society as a healer of this new disease. It also suggests that Kanezane's *tengyakubyō* is either a conflation of two distinct disease concepts—*gyakubyō* 虐病 (malaria), a pathology mentioned frequently in diaries of the period, and transferring-corpse disease—or, more straightforwardly, a mistranscription of transferring-corpse disease, a disease concept that perhaps eluded his vocabulary, given that it had only recently emerged in court society.

Reading further into Kanezane's entry, we learn that Iwaya was not the only healer summoned. As a result, a dramatic scene erupted around Tadako's sickbed: "Court Chaplain Kakukan—son of Masakane; of Miidera—also [came to] pray for her. During that time, the aforementioned Shōnin [i.e., Iwaya], likewise prayed for her, from within the screen. The Court Chaplain overheard this from his side and, in a great burst of anger, stormed out. Although the Regent tried assertively to stop him, he still would not consent [to stay], whereupon another monk was requested [to replace him]."<sup>67</sup> As this passage reveals, on each side of the folding screen enclosing the patient were two Buddhist healers, each representing different ends of the social spectrum of late Heian Buddhism. Son of Minamoto no Masakane 源雅兼 (1079–1143) and priest of the elite monastery Onjōji, Kakukan 覚寛 held the title of court chaplain (*naigu*), also known as the "meditation master in imperial service," a prestigious position that entailed serving emperors and other members of the imperial family in the palace, often through therapeutic rituals.<sup>68</sup> As we saw in chapter 1, Tendai monks frequently held that office since the early Heian period.

Kakukan performed his prayers for Tadako outside the folding screens, not unlike when Ennin, likewise acting as court chaplain, performed a Yakushi rite for Emperor Ninmyō outside his folding screens. Meanwhile, other therapeutic actions were performed by Iwaya, a holy man of unknown rank and status. (Kanezane makes a point to note elsewhere that he does not even know the monk's surname!) Astonishingly, Iwaya performs prayers and moxibustion from within the folding screen; after all, moxibustion requires that he be close enough to her body to apply the treatment directly. Once again, it seems that the strange disease linked to corpses calls for unconventional means, this time in the simultaneous employment of two healers of different pedigrees, a decision that clearly upset the career cleric (*kansō* 官僧) Kakukan.

The third case concerns the illness of Taira no Moriko, daughter of Taira no Kiyomori. In the sixth month of 1179, Tadachika reports that Moriko is “wasting and withering day by day.” Here, he uses the same term he used some four years earlier with Tadako, *shōsui* 憔悴, to which he adds *kokō* 枯槁, which refers to the withering of plants and the wasting of persons, perhaps a *kanbun* flourish to aestheticize (and thus euphemize) this difficult situation. Reflecting on Moriko’s symptoms, Tadachika rhetorically asks, “Is it not *hakushibyō* 博死病?”<sup>69</sup> Because Tadachika used “transferring” (*ten*) as the first character in the disease name in his earlier entries on Nijō and Tadako, the first character in the entry for Moriko (*haku*) is almost certainly a mistranscription; correctly, it should be *ten* 轉 (or *den* 傳, i.e., 伝). Moreover, Tadachika uses the character for “death” where we might expect “corpse,” yet the meaning is largely the same: Tadachika evidently speculates that Moriko, like Nijō and Tadako before her, was suffering from transferring-corpse disease.

The second relevant entry on Moriko, from the *Gyokuyō*, was written after Moriko had passed away. It offers critical information on the final stages of her illness:

The aforementioned honorary empress (Moriko) had been afflicted and not eating since the past spring. The *qi* [of the illness] gradually increased. The Head of the Medical Bureau Sadanari applied moxibustion, but because [the *qi*] did not decrease even after this, a body-protection [rite] was carried out to transfer the evil *qi* [out of her body and into a medium’s body]. Although the [*qi* of the disease] diminished a little after that, these means had not taken care of it for good, and so she passed away.<sup>70</sup>

Recalling the precedent of Iwaya, once again moxibustion is tried for a victim of corpse-vector disease, but this time it is applied by the head of the Bureau of Medicine (Tenyakuryō no kami 典藥寮頭), Wake no Sadanari 和气定成 (1123–1188). Because the *qi* of the disease did not diminish, they change strategy, and an unnamed monk is called to perform a “body-protection rite.” Because the treatment involved “transferring a *jake*,” we know this was the possession rite examined in detail in chapters 2 and 3. As such, it possibly represents a change in diagnosis from transferring-corpse disease to evil *qi*. The possession rite for Moriko may have been performed by Iwaya, who was called in for cases of corpse-vector disease, yet it is more likely that the healer belonged to one of the major monasteries from which we know *genza* hailed. In any case, the rite was not successful, and Moriko soon passed away.

Several important takeaways emerge from across these diary entries about corpse-vector disease and its first known human victims in premodern Japan.

For one thing, the inconsistent and incorrect transcriptions of what was likely the same disease term make it clear that the illness was seen as anomalous. Writing in 1175, Tadachika comments that the disease has “arisen in recent years,” suggesting that it had been spreading throughout aristocratic society and yet was new and thus unfamiliar. The mistranscription is particularly surprising in the case of Kanezane, since he was one of the best educated men in his day and had formidable medical knowledge, rivaling even that of court physicians. The undecidability of the diagnosis—accompanied by changes in treatment methods—suggests that the unfamiliarity extended to the healers as well, and there were likely disagreements among them as to the affliction’s identity. Notable here are the attempts to make this strange disease legible by drawing on a more familiar disease vernacular in the way of *qi* diagnostics and better-known pathologies such as *gyakubyō* and evil *qi*. Even as courtiers floundered in their attempts at transcription, they were already in the process of making this anomalous disease less alien. As Charles E. Rosenberg has maintained, “In some ways disease does not exist until we agree that it does, by perceiving, naming, and responding to it.”<sup>71</sup> These entries witness the coming into existence of a new disease, one that had not been known to Heian society before.

One of the least ambiguous indications that the disease was seen as anomalous is the unconventional treatment that was attempted. For Nijō, a buffet of rituals was performed, including rites based on the *Peacock Sutra*—long revered in Japan for its efficacy in healing and safe childbirth—and rituals for the wrathful wisdom kings, Aizen Myōō and Fudō Myōō, the latter of whom was the central divinity in the Five Altar Rite. When these rituals failed, those caring for Nijō chose to summon the “holy man” Iwaya, perhaps as a last-ditch measure. We can surmise that a similar sequence happened for Tadako. Although *hijiri* like Iwaya played critical roles as healers at court, these semi-reclusive figures with sometimes unknown pedigrees were looked on with much suspicion in aristocratic society.<sup>72</sup> As Kikuchi Hiroki has noted, Kanezane praised several *hijiri*, yet even he did not know Iwaya. Thus, for Nijō, it is not surprising that the recommendation to employ Iwaya came from Middle Counselor Kiyomori, also an eccentric figure seeking to establish what Bialock calls a “heterotopic court,” and whose daughter Moriko later acquired the disease.<sup>73</sup> In the case of Tadako, Iwaya’s presence offends a career cleric serving as court chaplain, a venerable office long associated with treating the emperor and members of the imperial family.

Despite the anomalous character of the disease, the presence of a *hijiri* points to another dimension that was likely unsettling to contemporaries in its familiarity: the association between this disease and death. As Stone points out, *hijiri* were seen as “death-managing monks” who, like those “good friends” (*zenchishiki* 善知識) who guided and assisted deathbed rituals (*rinjū gyōgi*

臨終行儀), “represent an important step in the development of an emergent class of Buddhist practitioners able to handle the dying and diseased and contain the pollution of death.”<sup>74</sup> Indeed, it seems that all three elite patients were presumed to be on their deathbed. Nijō and Tadako passed away not long after the events were recorded. In his entry for Nijō, Tadachika explicitly references the stories of Myōren 命蓮 and Mitaki Shōnin 三瀧聖人, two *hijiri* famously said to have cured emperors on their deathbeds (*kakurin* 獲麟).<sup>75</sup> As such, the defilement expected to attend the death of the patient would have been less of a concern for *hijiri*—who performs prayers near the patient, inside the folding screen—than it might for an official cleric such as Kakukan—who performs healing rituals on the other side of the folding screen, safe from potential contamination.

## CHINESE MEDICINE

Although in its earliest conceptions death defilement was not imagined to cause sickness, courtiers, physicians, and Buddhist monks of the late twelfth century had good reason to begin seeing corpses as vectors of not only defilement but also disease. Besides the increasingly epidemic character of death defilement, the concept of the corpse as pathogenic agent, including the specific term “corpse-vector disease,” was available by way of medical literature, including texts that had been in Japan for well over two hundred years. Corpse-generated diseases were described in medical writings that were brought over from China in waves during the Heian period. This literature formed the basis of medical education in Japan for court physicians, those healers who attended to the illnesses of aristocrats and emperors. It was also studied by Buddhist monks, some of whom had collected these medical texts, along with Buddhist writings such as sutras, commentaries, and ritual texts, during their pilgrimages to the continent. The imagination of the corpse as pathogenic agent evolved in Japan in idiosyncratic ways, but the influence of Chinese medicine on those developments cannot be overstated. It was based on Chinese medical writings that Japanese physicians and monks began to transpose the contagion of the corpse from the realm of ritual defilement to that of disease pathology.

The literature of Chinese medicine contains numerous variations of the idea that corpses cause disease. Many of these notions were developed first in the category of *zhu* (J. *chū* 注) diseases. The first extensive discussion of *zhu* diseases is found in *Disease Origins* by Chao Yuanfang 巢元方 (550?–630?), the only extant medical treatise from the Sui period. On “transferring infusion” (*chuanzhu* 轉注), one type of the affliction, Chao wrote, “Transferring infusion refers to [the illness acquired] when one individual dies and [the disease] is exchanged with people nearby.”<sup>76</sup> Some types of *zhu* disease directly evoked the

idea of etiological corpses in their name, such as “corpse-influence” (*shiqi* 尸氣). “There are times when people directly touch the corpses of the dead or look over corpses,” Chao explained. “The *qi* of those corpses will enter the belly of the person and, in mutual attraction with the [already existing] corpse-worms, generate disease.” He goes on to note that “this disease is called corpse-influence because it begins when one smells the *qi* of corpses.”<sup>77</sup>

For those living in the city of Heiankyō in Japan, which to observers like Kamo no Chōmei was permeated with the stench of the dead, such descriptions would have resonated with how they already viewed the problem of death defilement, that is, as a contagion that emanated from dead bodies. Chinese medical literature would have encouraged them to transpose similar notions onto the imagination of disease transmission as well. The transposition from one to the other was logical, especially since the category of *zhu* diseases and similar disease concepts developed originally in material and religious environments in medieval China very similar to the environment of early medieval Heiankyō. For example, Li Jianmin argues that notions of the corpse as pathogenic agent developed in medieval China in tandem with anxieties about the pollution of the dead, which was seen to be highly inauspicious. Such disease concepts were closely linked to the idea of “killing airs” (*shaqi* 殺氣) that were imagined to emanate from individuals on their death. The idea of killing airs, a kind of miasma, is similar to the Japanese notion of death defilement, especially as it came to be increasingly imagined in the idiom of *qi* influence, that is, defiled *qi*.<sup>78</sup>

In Japan, the *qi* of death defilement was imagined to become epidemic depending on the particular manner and scope of the initial death or deaths; similarly, in medieval China, the manner of death altered its degree of inauspiciousness and thus its severity as a form of pollution and influence on the human body. In medieval China, if the death was unnatural, tragic, or successive (multiple deaths one after another), or if the corpse had been improperly handled, the severity of pollution increased.<sup>79</sup> As we have seen, similar contagion scales and severity metrics operated in medieval Japan. The death of the emperor, innocent people like children, or many people all at once (as in warfare or disaster) typically meant that the severity of defilement was of greater influence.<sup>80</sup> Li suggests that for medieval China, these notions of pollution shaped medical thinking, especially the ideas about corpse etiology articulated in *Disease Origins*. It is thus not surprising that in Japan, where aristocratic society developed similar notions of death pollution, people also began to imagine corpses as having etiological effects on living bodies, especially when corpses were legion.

Over time in China, the notions of infusion and corpse infusion became the conceptual basis for corpse-vector disease, the primary disease concept through which the Japanese would imagine corpses as pathogenic agents for the first time in the late twelfth century (albeit with the slightly altered term,

transferring-corpse disease). The most influential discussion of corpse-vector disease in Chinese medical literature is found in quotations from now-lost monographs incorporated into *Arcane Essentials from the Imperial Library* (*Waitai miyao fang* 外台秘要方), compiled by Wang Tao 王燾 (670–755) in the Tang period.<sup>81</sup> *Arcane Essentials* was hugely influential in Japan. It served as the basis for much of the structure and content of the *Ishinpō*, compiled by court physician Tanba no Yasuyori, even if Yasuyori made the editorial decision not to attribute the work in name.

Further indication that physicians were beginning to talk about corpses causing disease in early medieval Japan, and doing so through specifically medical genres informed by the classical tradition from China, comes from the *Collection on the Five Portions of the Body* (*Gotai shinbun shū* 五体身分集). Scholars have long assumed this work was compiled during the Muromachi period (1336–1392), but Nagano Hitoshi and Tomita Takahiro have proposed that it was actually compiled between 1191 and 1194.<sup>82</sup> This newly proposed date is significant for my purposes because it places the text squarely within the heyday of corpse proliferation in the early medieval period.

The *Collection on the Five Portions of the Body* mentions a “disease called ‘corpse.’” The description reads: “The disease called ‘corpse’ is a disease acquired when a person unknowingly steps on the bones of some [deceased human or animal] at night. If you do not treat it and injure yourself by cutting your feet, you get sick.”<sup>83</sup> The text goes on to prescribe treatment primarily by moxibustion, which may have been used to cauterize lacerations caused by skeletal shards. Notably this entry does not quote or draw directly from any Chinese medical text. Moreover, as an illness caused by an injury from stepping on bones rather than an influx of noxious influence from a corpse, it differs from the idea of corpse-vector disease, which entails a miasmatic transmission of *qi*. Nonetheless, it reflects what was probably a common experience by courtiers in Heiankyō, who would have occasionally cut their feet on bones that littered the dark streets at night. Thus, even if the notion differs from corpse-vector disease, the “disease called ‘corpse’” represents one of the ways physicians were beginning to pathologize encounters with corpses in this era.

This example demonstrates that authors of medical texts were not merely writing about these new afflictions arising from the material dead but also proposing medical treatments to counter their deleterious influences on the living. Another contemporaneous document that stands out in this regard is the *Moxibustion Method of the Four Flowers and Suffering Gate* (*Shika kanmon kyūhō* 四花患門灸法), written by Tanba no Nagamoto 丹波長基 (dates unknown) in 1194.<sup>84</sup> Once again, the date is significant, as the work was composed at the height of the corpse population. The work is entirely practical. It prescribes a method of moxibustion using several props in which moxibustion is to be

performed on four key points on the patient's back. The Four Flowers method was developed in China, where it was quoted in works such as *Arcane Essentials*. What is significant is that the diseases the method addresses all belong, in the framework of Chinese medicine, to the category of "depletion-exhaustion" (*kyorō* 虚劳). In addition to afflictions like "bones steaming" (*kotsujō* 骨蒸), this category included corpse-vector disease, perhaps the most notorious affliction of the group. It is also significant that the Four Flowers method is not referenced in the *Ishinpō*. During the period from 1170 to 1220, no extensive medical treatises were compiled besides the recently redated *Collection on the Five Portions of the Body*. Therefore, it seems clear that this Four Flowers manual was copied at this precise time because of new fears among the aristocracy about corpses causing disease.

## PATHOLOGIZING DEATH IN THE JIMON RITUAL FOR EXPELLING DEMONS

In terms of therapeutic responses to the newly emergent corpse-vector disease at court, the activities of court physicians are reflected only in Nagamoto's *Moxibustion Method of the Four Flowers and Suffering Gate*. Although we can speculate that physicians did more to combat this disease, the most full-throated response came from Buddhist monks. To counter this new disease caused by corpses, Jimon monks in the late twelfth century created the Ritual for Expelling Demons, the basic contours of which were outlined in chapter 4. In terms of Buddhist healing rituals in Japan, the Jimon rite was largely unprecedented in its time: It was one of if not the earliest rite created in Japan to focus on a single, named disease. Why did Jimon monks create a healing ritual at this particular moment to treat corpse-vector disease? In the same way we have seen that transferring-corpse disease appearing in diaries was not arbitrary, I suggest that the Jimon rite was likewise a response to new configurations of disease, defilement, and the dead in the late twelfth century. Moreover, as I demonstrate here, evidence from the ritual documents demonstrates that rather than simply summarizing existing medical or ritual knowledge on the disease, Jimon monks were responding specifically to fears about death-related diseases in Heiankyō.

Descriptions of corpse-vector disease in the Jimon ritual manuscripts, which were written first in the 1170s, resonate on the one hand with contemporary accounts of transferring-corpse disease in aristocratic society and on the other with death and defilement in the capital at large. For example, *Essential Notes*, the ritual "oral transmissions" text, begins with the "Signs of the Disease" (*byōsō* 病相) summarized thus: "In general, [corpse-vector] disease is moderate at first but thereafter turns serious. Gradually the [sufferer] declines and wastes away, just as fish in evaporating water remain unaware of their impending

death.”<sup>85</sup> The statement immediately invites comparison with symptoms experienced by sufferers of transferring-corpse disease as reported in diaries, such as Tadako’s emaciation from exhaustion and Moriko’s wasting and withering as she approached her final moments. At the same time, the analogy to fish in evaporating water corresponds nearly verbatim to how some described the dire conditions of the defiled capital. In 1182, Kamo no Chōmei wrote, “It was thought that the new year would see an improvement, but it brought instead the additional affliction of epidemics, and there was no sign of any amelioration. The people were starving, and with the passage of days approached the extremity, like fish gasping in insufficient water.”<sup>86</sup> Chōmei’s metaphor of the “fish gasping in insufficient water” echoes a similar line in Genshin’s *Essentials of Rebirth*, which was a fundamental text on the karmic impurity of the body.<sup>87</sup> Cited as one of the signs of corpse-vector disease in the Jimon ritual text, the metaphor of the gasping fish concisely invokes two distinct but interlinked registers outside of the ritual text: the disease then afflicting the bodies of nobility and the epidemic of corpses afflicting the urban body of Heiankyō with defilement.

Other striking parallels between descriptions of corpse-vector disease and death defilement are evident when we turn to the subject of contagion. Regarding the transmission of corpse-vector disease, an “oral transmission” in *Essential Notes* reports the following: “At the onset when only a single person is suffering, this affliction is not contagious. Upon the passing of the sufferer, however, it spreads to ten thousand people. It is like when a vessel shatters and the water in it splashes out in all directions.”<sup>88</sup> Jimon monks drew this description from a similar passage from *Recipes for Mysterious Influences and Corpse Transmission* (*Xuangan chuanshi fang* 玄感伝屍方), a Tang period monograph on corpse-vector disease that survived in *Arcane Essentials* and is now presumed lost: “When a sufferer dies, the disease then spreads to the family or somebody close, thus it is called ‘corpse-vector.’”<sup>89</sup> This description was in turn based on earlier conceptualizations of similar afflictions of corpse contagion, as we see in this passage from *Disease Origins* regarding “corpse-zhu infusion”: “After one dies, [the disease entity] is exchanged with people nearby, eventually bringing about the destruction of the family line. It is because this corpse disease pours into and transfers to people nearby that it is called corpse-infusion.”<sup>90</sup>

As suggested earlier, for aristocrats in Heian Japan, such passages from medical literature would surely have recalled the haunting nature of death defilement: Both corpse-infusion and defilement are contagious entities activated at the precise moment of death. Thus, where previously courtiers might have looked at an abandoned corpse on the roadside as a locus of defilement contagion, medical descriptions of corpse-vector disease such as those cited by Jimon monks would have encouraged them to see the corpse as a locus of disease contagion as well. From this view, defilement begins to take on an etiological



dimension, an association that Jimon monks capitalized on and promoted in their ritual manuscripts.

The same passage reveals a key difference between the contagiousness of corpse-vector disease and the earlier conception of the contagiousness of death defilement. We saw previously that the ancient legal account of defilement transmission described a straightforward linear sequence consisting of the four positions *kō*, *otsu*, *hei*, and *tei*. In contrast, comparing contagion to the moment “when a vessel shatters and the water in it splashes out in all directions,” as the Jimon ritual texts do for corpse-vector disease, is to imagine a nonlinear and rather unpredictable and chaotic mode of transmission, whereby the death of a single infected person causes the noxious entity to spread to “ten thousand” others. Here we find another signature of the historical moment. Where the contagiousness of corpse-vector disease differs from the ancient legal account of death defilement transmission, it corresponds precisely to the newer way death defilement transmission had come to be anxiously reenvisioned from the eleventh century. Courtiers had begun to imagine that the deaths of many individuals, the innocent, and sovereigns could generate defiled *qi* capable of pervading all “under heaven,” filling not just narrow spaces like the court but permeating “the world” at large. The nature of realm-wide defiled *qi* closely mirrors the diffusive and explosive nature of the corpse-vector disease contagion. These parallels were surely not lost on Jimon monks, especially those like Keisei, who had a habit of observing and writing about corpses and their weird influences.

In collecting and synthesizing these notions of corpse-vector disease contagion in their ritual texts, Jimon monks were trying to articulate the affliction of corpse-vector disease through the medical knowledge that was available to them. We can imagine how this elaboration might have appeared to some onlookers as an application of technical, specialized medical knowledge to the better-known problem of death defilement. In effect, Jimon monks were offering a compelling explanation for what happens when somebody gets sick in a corpse-ridden and defiled capital from a strange and mysterious disease. In the next section, I show how a sustained focus on death and dying shaped how Jimon monks depicted even the living patients of the affliction, furthering demonstrating that they saw corpse-vector disease as an affliction closely tied to death defilement.

## MINISTERING TO THE LIVING DEAD

Although the Jimon ritual was designed for eliminating corpse-vector disease and thus aims ultimately at curing sufferers, descriptions of the patient in the ritual texts underscore an inextricable connection between this disease and death, a connection that can be further understood in relation to issues of defilement.

As we saw in the descriptions of the transmission of corpse-vector disease, the still-breathing patient was figured as a kind of “becoming-contagion,” a potential vector for a disease contagion that activates once the patient dies. This way of imagining a disease of the living in terms of the dying and the dead shaped how Jimon monks chose to describe the living patient who was to be the object of a ritual ostensibly meant to heal. Indeed, the descriptions of the patient in the ritual texts blur the boundaries between life and death in striking ways.

Already at the beginning of *Essential Notes*, in a section labeled “Signs of the Disease,” after the analogy to gasping fish, we find descriptions hinting that the patient is already well on their way to another realm of existence:

Some experience agony in body and mind, progressively dehydrate, and become emaciated. While trying to abide in correct mindfulness, some sufferers indulge [in thoughts of] the demonic paths; others trying to abide in correct mindfulness begrudge [losing] their human body. Some sufferers cannot eat at all and constantly desire to sleep. Some might awaken the aspiration for enlightenment at the wrong time [i.e., when it is already too late] and weep sporadically. Lustful desires may develop, along with feelings of hatred and anger. At times the sick one is excited but at other times they rest. When the great matter of death approaches, they favor lying down on their lower left side; when they die, no effort is expended. In the beginning, the disease throbs under the left breast. When this [throbbing sensation] transfers to the right breast, death is certain. After the sufferer has passed away, one observes that [the corpse] resembles the flesh of a rat.<sup>91</sup>

For a description of the signs and symptoms to be observed in a living patient, this passage places considerable emphasis on the process by which that patient dies. Any court physician in Japan with passable medical knowledge who read these words would have been reminded of fascicle 13 of the *Arcane Essentials* or the *Ishinpō*, which detail the “proofs of [impending] death” (Ch. *si zhi zheng* 死之証) that attend the advanced stages of corpse-vector disease. In his monograph on corpse-vector disease, *Recipes for Mysterious Influences and Corpse Transmission*, which survives in *Arcane Essentials*, Su You 蘇遊 (dates unknown) includes the analogy of water evaporating to explain the sufferer’s lack of awareness of their gradual death. He also notes that “death may be just around the corner, while [the sufferer remains] in good spirits.”<sup>92</sup> In medical discourse, then, corpse-vector disease sufferers were understood to vacillate between presenting signs of an imminent death and returning to what seemed to be a normal state of health. This is one of the reasons Su You warns readers that corpse-vector disease is apt to resemble a “feigned illness” (Ch. *yang bing* 佯病).<sup>93</sup>

On a different register, the description of the patient's cadaverous condition in *Essential Notes* also resonates with Buddhist discourses on the process of dying. Indeed, the signs of corpse-vector disease are virtually synonymous with what might be called, in other genres of Buddhist texts, the "signs of death" (*shisō* 死相).<sup>94</sup> In particular, the corpse-vector disease sufferer is remarkably similar to the dying individual that becomes the focus of deathbed rites, those rituals performed to secure an auspicious rebirth in Amida's Pure Land. Jimon monks in fact contributed to such discourses on dying. For example, the above passage from *Essential Notes* resonates with one from the *Record of Arousing the Ten Vows* (*Jūgan hosshinki* 十願発心記), authored by Onjōji monk Senkan 千観 (918–983). Senkan details the "three attachments" (*san'ai* 三愛) that may present themselves along with the "suffering [experienced] on the verge of death": attachment to objects, such as "one's beloved wife and children"; attachment to self, which one relinquishes only begrudgingly; and attachment to the place of one's future rebirth. "Because the mind is bent by these three attachments," Senkan notes, "mental anguish arises . . . so that one cannot concentrate on the Buddha."<sup>95</sup>

The second attachment he describes, "attachment to self," echoes the corpse-vector disease sufferer's reluctance to give up their body and life to the death that beckons. The third type of attachment—toward one's future site of rebirth—parallels the deviance that warps the corpse-vector disease sufferer's mind. *Essential Notes* indicates that the sufferer tries to "abide in correct contemplation" (*jūshōnen* 住正念), a foundational technique in deathbed rituals for keeping one's mind trained on the Pure Land—"right thoughts at the last moment," in Jacqueline Stone's succinct phrase.<sup>96</sup> Yet a sufferer afflicted with corpse-vector disease finds their mind gravitate uncontrollably downward, as it were, slanting toward the "path of ghosts" (*kidō* 鬼道), a reference to the "path of hungry ghosts" (*gakidō* 餓鬼道). Just as they are on the edge of becoming a contagion of defilement and disease, the sufferer is in the process of becoming one of those miserable ghouls trapped between this life and the hell-realms, transmigratory parasites who live off polluting and defiling substances—urine, feces, vomit, discarded food scraps, newborn infants, and dead bodies.

The way corpse-vector disease drags the victim into the realm of the hungry ghosts suggests both a moral corruption (disease as tied to poor karmic status and the resulting impurity of the body) and a physical deterioration that can be observed with the naked eye. One wonders if Tadako, who in her emaciated and exhausted state was said to "wear fright and fear on her face," had begun to see her impending descent into the dark path of the hungry ghosts. To those around her, who watched in horror as she gradually wasted away, she may have even begun to look like a hungry ghost.<sup>97</sup> In *Essential Notes*, another passage indicates that "after the sufferer has passed away, one observes that [the corpse] resembles

the flesh of a rat,” a gruesome process of decomposition-while-alive that no doubt begins sooner in the course of the disease.<sup>98</sup> In this way, descriptions of the corpse-vector disease patient in the Jimon ritual texts, while relying on Chinese medical literature, find themselves in good company with early medieval discourses on death and dying in Buddhist contexts.

Another noteworthy area of resonance—one much related to the ideal of correct contemplation on one’s deathbed—pertains to the sense that both the sufferer of corpse-vector disease and those who will fail to achieve rebirth in the Pure Land are likely to expire in a state of madness. The *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō*, the rite’s liturgical text, reports: “Sometimes [the sufferer] falls into despair and goes mad. Sometimes, without a path, they give rise to an evil mind of anger. Sometimes they are broken to their core [*kotsuzui kudaite* 骨髓碎イテ].”<sup>99</sup> This grim prognosis is repeated in *Essential Notes*: “Sometimes the sufferer loses consciousness. (This is like epilepsy.) This resembles despair and madness [*kyōran*].” This passage is immediately followed by a description of the beginning stages of dying: “Around the time of death the legs will gradually swell.”<sup>100</sup> To define madness as the final condition preceding death recalls what deathbed ritual discourses called the “death of madness and losing contemplation” (*kyōran shitsunen shi* 狂乱失念死), the phrase “losing contemplation” (*shitsunen*) here being nearly synonymous with despair (*shitsui* 失意), or literally “losing one’s intention,” in *Essential Notes*. The “death of madness and losing contemplation” was, in turn, one of the “fifteen types of bad deaths” (*jūgoshu akushi* 十五種悪死), a list we find enumerated in esoteric scriptures of immense significance to Jimon monks, including the *Thousand Arm Sutra*, which provides an associated *dhāraṇī* to avoid the deaths.<sup>101</sup>

The idea of bad deaths brings us back to issues surrounding death defilement. On one hand, we have observed repeatedly that death was generally understood to be defiling, regardless of how it happened. Yet as Stone has pointed out, authors of deathbed discourse in early medieval Japan made an important distinction between good and bad deaths. Good deaths, which were understood as facilitating and demonstrating successful rebirth in the Pure Land, were sometimes seen to radically transcend the very pollution of death. The bodies left behind were thus not defiled but in fact materially auspicious, as marked by the appearance of purple clouds or the emanation of incense-like fragrance. In contrast, bad deaths were not only seen as failed attempts at advantageous rebirth but also, in some cases, described as more defiling than a typical death.<sup>102</sup> While the Jimon ritual texts do not describe the death of patients in so many terms, the descriptions of symptoms examined here—gravitating toward the ghost realms, losing wholesome intentions, going mad—suggest that the death of a corpse-vector disease sufferer would have been seen as especially

defiling. This again reflects the close connections between this disease and the defilement that emanated from the dead.

Here I have suggested that in a capital littered with the unburied dead—a city that aristocrats feared was stalked daily by the specter of defilement—a previously unfamiliar pathological entity rose to the surface of the elite's disease imaginary. In Heiankyō of the late twelfth century, corpse-vector disease became more than just another disease concept of classical medical literature, a corpus that describes hundreds of other disease concepts. As a pathological figure for unprecedented anxieties about death pollution, corpse-vector disease took on a life of its own—and claimed lives in the process. In this way, the apparently novel emergence of this mysterious affliction was not completely novel, since that emergence was grounded in material conditions several centuries in the making (urbanization, overpopulation, disaster, disease epidemics). It was also prefigured by an anxious imaginary surrounding the most severe form of defilement, that produced by death.

That the emergence of corpse-vector disease was tied to the imagination of death and death defilement is also evident from the manuscripts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons compiled by Jimon monks. We have seen that monks had good reason to respond to the new affliction. Not only was the disease threatening the lives of their patrons but its appearance brought new and unusual competition out of the woodwork. Armed with an unprecedented combination of moxibustion and ritual techniques, the holy man Iwaya clearly captured the attention of the ailing aristocracy—and no doubt sparked both fear and outrage in the minds of Jimon monks, a lineage long renowned for their healing prowess. In the dramatic episode of Kakukan versus Iwaya—a microcosm of the dynamic economy of ritual efficacy in early medieval Japan—we can easily imagine what inspired the monks to create an entirely new ritual to combat corpse-vector disease.

Here Jimon monks had an overwhelming advantage over the new competition. The lineage was steeped in centuries of ritual experimentation against spirit disease, the other primary variety of postmortem contagion. In addition, at Onjōji, Jimon monks had a library of ritual and medical manuscripts by which they could craft a robust ritual response to the novel affliction. In so doing, Jimon monks could transform corpse-vector disease from an unknown affliction only vaguely understood to be caused by cadavers in the capital into a known disease with precisely defined pathogens, metapersons they could engage through ritual and medical techniques.

## CHAPTER 6

### Demons, *Māras*, and Corpse-Worms



THE EMERGENCE OF CORPSE-VECTOR DISEASE WAS INTIMATELY TIED TO THE nightmarish conditions that had come to define Heiankyō's urban environment in the late twelfth century, especially the preponderance of corpses throughout the capital, a cadaveric density that began to alter the perceived relationship between defilement and pathology. Aristocrats seem to have at least understood that the contagion of this new disease passed from the corpse of the deceased to living bodies, an idea conveyed in the name of the affliction and one similar enough to the more familiar condition of death defilement. Yet as we saw in the last chapter, beyond this basic image of a corpse-driven contagion, aristocrats struggled to comprehend its causation and pathological activity in sophisticated or systematic ways.

Around the same time that corpse-vector disease began afflicting the “good people” of the nobility, monks of the Jimon lineage based on Onjōji began compiling ritual manuscripts outlining a novel treatment program to address it, but first they sought to grapple with it on an epistemological front. In their manuscripts, the monks synthesized the findings of their research into various Buddhist, ritual, and medical literature, aiming to construct coherent frameworks of knowledge for making sense of this new disease.

In chapter 5, we observed how the monks referenced classical medical understandings of the disease as a contagion emanating from corpses. This was only one of the explanations they offered. A much more salient theme throughout the ritual manuscripts is the notion that corpse-vector disease was caused and then spread by multiple pathogenic agents. Jimon monks identified these agents variably as demons (*ki* 鬼), *māras* (*mara* 魔羅 or *ma* 魔), and corpse-worms (*shi* 尸). Given that the ritual manuscripts were ostensibly focused on elucidating a single disease, how are we to understand the multiplicity of disease agents these monks held responsible for corpse-vector disease?

Jimon monks did not multiply the disease agents arbitrarily or out of an abstract desire to be comprehensive. Rather, they were constructing what can be called “the body multiple,” a term I borrow from Annemarie Mol. She argues

that even modern biomedical diseases we assume to represent singular phenomena are in fact enacted at the nexus of multiple and sometimes strikingly divergent knowledge practices. For example, diseased tissue seen under the microscope by a pathologist in one wing of a hospital differs significantly from the disease that figures in the patient's articulation of pain recorded by a clinician in another area. The object of knowledge differs because the practices of enacting those knowledges differ, hence, "reality multiples."<sup>1</sup> To make a disease "hang together" as a single epistemic object in biomedicine, it becomes necessary to relate these epistemic objects to each other. Pathologists, clinicians, and researchers must coordinate, translate, frame, and distribute these objects to maintain the coherence of the disease. To study the body multiple is to ask how such practices enable incongruent objects of knowledge to hang together and cogently represent the disease in question as singular.

The multiplicity of corpse-vector disease and its pathogens was a product of the multiple streams of knowledge that Jimon monks channeled into their ritual manuscripts. This included Chinese Buddhist writings attributed to the patriarch of the Tendai school, esoteric Buddhist ritual scriptures, Chinese medical texts, and one scripture that was nominally Daoist. Modern scholars, nudged by disciplinary habit, might want to parse these different knowledge sources by institutional affiliation—esoteric versus exoteric Buddhism, Buddhism versus Daoism, religious (belief) versus medical (knowledge), and so on. But Jimon monks engaged with these various and sometimes incongruent forms of knowledge to construct a corpse-vector disease that would hang together. In other words, they sought to bring coherence to an affliction that was then, especially for their concerned patients, a strange and anomalous disease.<sup>2</sup>

As I demonstrate, Jimon monks undoubtedly saw corpse-vector disease as emanating from corpses, but by also identifying other disease agents—demons, *māras*, and corpse-worms—they sought to create a network of pathogenic agents that would be sensible in the intellectual and technical frameworks in which they were working. I refer to these agents equally as "metapersons." By doing so, I set aside the distinct categories into which scholars have often placed them, including the question of which religious tradition or form of Buddhism they represent and the question of whether they should be defined as "religious" or "medical." For example, scholars have often deemed demons as "religious" entities, implying that they are conjured by the imagination of religious practitioners and have little to do with empirical reality, whereas corpse-worms are "medical" entities, suggesting they have some biological or parasitological reality known and managed by physicians.<sup>3</sup> In fact, only when we examine demons, *māras*, and corpse-worms together as a related group of pathogenic metapersons can we begin to appreciate how and why the monks incorporated them into their attempt to make epistemological heads or tails of corpse-vector disease.

As noted elsewhere in the book, the concept of metapersons is useful for drawing attention to how pathogenic entities possess agency and even person-like characteristics. What linked the metapersons of corpse-vector disease for Jimon monks, I argue, was not just that they had agency of their own but that they hijacked the agency of their human victims. According to Jimon monks, demons, *māras*, and corpse-worms intertwined with the bodies and minds of victims and thereby expropriated their motivations and behavior. Our study of these metapersons in this chapter demonstrates that at a fundamental level, these monks were grappling with the problem of agency in the vicious circle of the pathological process, that strange feeling that illness is something that happens to us yet is also a consequence of our own doing. They understood this problem in karmic moral terms. In their view, the metapersons of corpse-vector disease matter because they challenge the immunitary integrity of the self, corroding its ontological and moral boundaries.

## DISEASE CATEGORIES AND THE WRITINGS OF ZHIYI

“Corpse-vector disease” is conspicuously absent from the title of the Jimon rite’s liturgy, which is called “The Ritual of Shōmen Kongō for Expelling Demons and *Māras*.” Rather than name the disease, the title draws attention to its pathogens, for which two primary categories are given: demons and *māras*. Yet in identifying multiple agents behind the affliction, the title raises questions about the rite’s focus and coherence. What is the relationship between demons and *māras*? Do these terms denote separate pathogenic entities, or are they synonyms for the same kind of entity? How exactly do they cause corpse-vector disease? Do they work in tandem or cause it separately?

At least one passage in the liturgy suggests that these entities are to be understood as conceptually distinct from one another and also distinct from a third etiological concept. A quote attributed to Zhiyi’s *Great Calming and Contemplation* toward the end of the liturgy notes: “If an adept is suffering from an illness due to either of the two diseases [caused by] demons or *māras*, these should be treated through contemplative practices or powerful spirit spells [i.e., *dhāraṇī*], then the sufferer will improve. If it is a karmic disease, then the adept should use the power of contemplation internally while practicing repentance externally; his condition will improve.”<sup>4</sup>

This passage is one of several in the ritual manuscripts that demonstrate the influence of the writings of Zhiyi, the Chinese patriarch of the Tiantai school, revered by Jimon monks. That Jimon monks included the quote in the liturgy suggests that they probably saw demons, *māras*, and karma as three etiological concepts crucial for grasping the nature of corpse-vector disease. To understand how they related these disease categories to corpse-vector disease, it is helpful to



begin by considering how these categories were discussed by Zhiyi. Perhaps “the first Chinese author to systematically integrate Indian and Chinese medicine,” Zhiyi’s work was closely studied by Jimon monks, including those who compiled the manuscripts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons.<sup>5</sup>

The three disease concepts in fact belong to Zhiyi’s sixfold classification of disease types, which he outlines in *Great Calming and Contemplation*: (1) discord among the Four Elements (*shidai* 四大: earth, water, fire, wind), (2) unregulated diet, (3) disharmony in sitting meditation, (4) demon diseases, (5) *māra* diseases, and (6) karmic diseases (Ch. *yebing*; J. *gōbyō* 業病).<sup>6</sup> As this classification implies, Zhiyi saw demons, *māras*, and karma as distinct categories. Indeed, the definitions he provides are often presented in explicitly contrasting terms, as we shall see.

Zhiyi begins his discussion of demon diseases by noting that although demons are afflictions of neither the four elements nor the five viscera, they are no less real. “If a person claims demon diseases do not exist,” he wrote, they ought to recall the fact that “when evil spirit mediums earnestly perform demon treatments, a cure is sometimes obtained.”<sup>7</sup> This is no different from diseases of the four elements, he continues, cures for which can be observed when medical practitioners use liquid medicines.

After establishing the ontology of demon diseases by analogy to bodily illnesses that might be easier for readers to observe themselves, Zhiyi highlights the especially pernicious nature of demonic agency as it pertains to illness. He relates the story of a king who successfully treated diseases caused by demons residing in the empty cavities of his body by applying needles. One day, however, “the demon king” arrived and strategically hid itself above the king’s heart, making further treatment impossible.<sup>8</sup>

It is helpful to consider the discussion on Zhiyi’s episode given by Zhanran 湛然 (711–782), the sixth patriarch of the Tiantai school. Tendai monks in Japan were reading the writings of Zhiyi through Zhanran’s commentaries since the time of Saichō. In his commentary on the foregoing episode in the *Delineations on Supporting Practice and Broadly Disseminating the [Great] Calming and Contemplation* (*Zhiguan fuxing chuanhong jue* 止觀輔行伝弘決), Zhanran introduces a story about the physician Zhang Hua. Hua was to treat the illness of one Li Ziyu, but once the doctor realized the illness was hiding in the patient’s *gao* and *huang*—meaning that it would be too deep within the body to reach with any known treatment—he fled from his patient on horseback. While hiding below the road, Hua by chance heard a demon rustling in the grass. He asked the demon why he was not hiding. The demon replied, “I reside in the *gao* and *huang* [of the body] where needles and moxibustion do not reach. What need would I have to hide? I only fear [the doctor] who uses the Eight-Poisons Pill [Badu wan 八毒丸].”<sup>9</sup> Without intending to, the demon had disclosed to a

physician an effective treatment for furtive demonic disease. Hua returned to his patient and cured him using the Eight-Poisons Pill.

In sum, these narratives reveal that for both Zhiyi and Zhanran, demons are stealthy agents who strategically conceal themselves in the human body, seeking hiding places from which they can do harm while avoiding invasive treatments. The consequences, Zhiyi concludes, are grave: “If these diseases are not treated and persist for a long time, they will kill the person.”<sup>10</sup>

Afflictions of the second category, *māra* diseases, are likewise difficult to treat, but for Zhiyi they differ in important ways from demon diseases. As he writes, “While demons afflict the body and kill the body, *māras* break the contemplative mind, destroy the life of wisdom of the Dharma body, and trigger evil thoughts that rob practitioners of their merits and virtues.” *Māras* do so by appearing in the adept’s mind while they sit in meditation, conjuring images of “sundry robes, drink and food, the seven treasures, and other miscellaneous things”—all manner of attractive material possessions a monastic on the path of renunciation would have cast aside.<sup>11</sup> Whereas disease-causing demons reside in the body of victims as discrete ontological agents, therefore, *māras* infect the *mind* of the practitioner, working to muddle the integrity of the self—their agency and intentionality—by stirring up desires that lead them astray from the path.

The mischievous and agency-hijacking character of *māra* diseases raises the issue of morality and its role in causing sickness. A concern for morality seems lacking in Zhiyi’s descriptions of demonic etiology, which operates according to hide-and-seek power plays. Morality is, however, inherently central to the sixth category in his framework, karmic diseases. For Zhiyi, karmic disease is either caused by karma carried over from past lives or from breaking precepts in this lifetime, which activates the latent karma of past lives. The notion of karmic disease is found throughout Mahāyāna Buddhist scriptures.<sup>12</sup> What makes Zhiyi’s conceptualization distinct is the way karmic disease operates according to systematic correlations in the body. If karma is accrued through murder, Zhiyi reasons, liver or eye disease will be the result; if karma is accrued through drinking alcohol, one acquires heart or mouth diseases; if lustful activities, then kidney or ear diseases; if deluded speech, then spleen or tongue diseases; and if stealing, then lung or nose diseases. In this framework, a deft integration of Indian Buddhist physiomoralism and the “systematic correspondence” of Chinese medicine, Zhiyi links the violation of the five precepts with diseases of the five viscera and the five sense organs.<sup>13</sup> For Zhiyi, moral offenses manifest as disease in specific body parts.

To summarize, Zhiyi presents demons, *māras*, and karma as distinct disease categories. Demons and *māras* are exogenous agents that invade the body from the outside, and karmic illness is endogenous, arising from within according

to the meditator's karma. Although the matter of moral conduct is central to karmic diseases and implied in the case of *māra* disturbances, Zhiyi does not explicitly link these categories in his discussion. He may have wanted to maintain a strict distinction between diseases for which the practitioner is responsible and must repent (i.e., karmic) and those for which the practitioner is a passive victim (i.e., demons and *māras*) but must therefore be vigilant while performing meditation. Moreover, although demonic and karmic illness are equally implicated in causing physical disease, this suggestion is absent in the case of *māra* afflictions, where the emphasis is on psychological symptoms. In considering these disease categories, it is important to remember that Zhiyi's imagined patient was the meditating adept. In the context of his meditation manuals, grasping the firm distinctions between disease categories is part and parcel of the analytical meditative exercise, required so that the practitioner may navigate meditation unscathed and for the therapeutic benefits Zhiyi describes.

## EPIDEMICS, DEMONS, AND VICE IN THE AGE OF THE FINAL DHARMA

Although in citing his writings Jimon monks of twelfth-century Japan were "contemplating disease" with Zhiyi, they were not seeking to reproduce the strict analytical distinctions he carefully outlines. As Paul Groner has observed, "medieval Tendai monks often interpreted [Zhiyi's] teachings in dramatically new ways."<sup>14</sup> As we will observe, the entities in Zhiyi's meditative framework coincide in important ways with those of the Jimon ritual, but they do not wholly align. Remember that where Zhiyi sought to present three separate disease categories, Jimon monks were incorporating these categories in the framework of their explanation for a single affliction, corpse-vector disease.

In fact, it was the ambivalent and hybrid nature of corpse-vector disease to which Jimon monks drew attention. In particular, when it comes to corpse-vector disease, they stressed, exogenous disease agents are not so easily separated from internal personal karma or from collective karmic climates. One of the compelling ways they made this case was by situating the emergence of the disease in the age of the Final Dharma. As discussed in the introduction, in medieval Japan, the concept of the Final Dharma was seen as a corrupt and dismal age in terms of the lack of availability and quality of Buddhist teachings and the impossibility of effective Buddhist practice; it was also seen as a breeding ground for demons, spirits, witch animals, and other strange entities, many of which bore pestilence. In the manuscripts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons, Jimon monks make the Final Dharma the setting for corpse-vector disease's "outbreak narrative," the story of its emergence and spread, its damage to society, and attempts to manage it, some unsuccessful and others (i.e., theirs) triumphant.<sup>15</sup>

“This demonic disease progressively circulates from place to place, roaming around,” says one passage in *The Ritual of Shōmen Kongō*. The disease “spreads from husband to wife to children, and then to brothers and sisters. Thus, some call it ‘corpse-vector demon-disease.’” In the face of this apocalyptic pandemonium, their narrative went, traditional healing modalities prove useless: “None under heaven, even eminent physicians, can treat it.” Because the disease was spawned of a corrupt age, there would be no place to hide: “When the Buddhist Law degenerates, kings, officials, queens, concubines, and monks and nuns of the realm will all suffer harm wrought by this demon-god.”<sup>16</sup>

The notion of the Final Dharma infuses this outbreak narrative with an undeniable rhetorical force. As D. Max Moerman points out in his study of Heian period sutra burials, one practice for overcoming the end of days, the idea of the Final Dharma was broad enough to encompass “a variety of religious desires while at the same time charging them with a heightened sense of historical urgency.”<sup>17</sup> For monks and laypersons, the imagination of this degenerate age became a “rhetorical center on which other personal, familial, and political anxieties converged”—as did medical anxieties.<sup>18</sup> Thus, although the known victims of corpse-vector disease in the late Heian numbered only a handful (we met them in chapter 5), by casting corpse-vector disease as an epidemic roaming through a corrupt realm, Jimon monks effectively amplified the severity of the affliction.

According to the monks, the disease begins at the level of families, echoing similar discourse about contagious corpse disease found in Chinese medical literature.<sup>19</sup> From there, it spreads to those at the highest levels of society, including the sovereign and his court of officials, queens, and concubines. Although members of the Sangha might fall prey to this demonic disease themselves, Jimon monks imply that monastics are uniquely qualified to respond to the epidemic by dismissing the possibility that “eminent physicians” (*mei* 名醫) can treat the illness. In so doing, Jimon monks assert the superiority of their therapeutic program over the medicines and techniques wielded by court physicians, those professionals who, owing to their education in classical Chinese medicine, might be expected to be more familiar with corpse-vector disease than anyone else in the late Heian period. The overall message of this apocalyptic rhetoric to sovereigns and other prominent patients, then, is that they must seek the aid of Jimon monks.

Jimon monks were not the only ones to make such claims in this period. A similar rhetorical strategy can be found in the *Record of Nourishing Life by Drinking Tea* by Yōsai, compiled in roughly the same period. For Yōsai, the Final Dharma was defined not only by monastic communities “violating proper deportment,” or by monks, nuns, and laypersons failing to live “in accord with the teachings of the Buddha,” but also by a pandemonium of “demons and

spirits” who create chaos and disease, against which existing medical practices are ineffective.<sup>20</sup> The notion of the Final Dharma was thus of obvious rhetorical utility for Buddhist healers seeking to establish novel therapeutic programs. For Yōsai the Final Dharma set the stage for innovative applications of tea and mulberry, whereas Jimon monks were promoting a ritualized form of moxi-bustion (chapter 7).

Yet if there was any rhetorical currency to the notion of the Final Dharma in early medieval Japan, it was because patients and healers did not see it as mere rhetoric but as a pressing reality. Given the relentless onslaught of natural disasters and epidemics, societal unrest and warfare (including monks taking up arms), the great number of corpses in the capital, and increased encounters with spectral and demonic beings, Heian society was not lacking in evidence for the Final Dharma, which many claimed began in 1052, five hundred years after the official arrival of Buddhism to the archipelago and only about one hundred years before the disease caused by cadavers.

What is unique about the Final Dharma in the outbreak narrative for corpse-vector disease is how it enabled Jimon monks to link the notion of an epidemic with the idea of corrupted internal moral states. Viewing corpse-vector disease as a salient and especially alarming pathological cross-section in the larger epidemic of the Final Dharma, they present the idea that the precise manifestations of the disease depend wholly on the karma of the infected person. “In its most virulent form,” Jimon monks wrote, the epidemic “will become leprosy [*rai*]; in the second degree, it will become corpse-vector [disease]; and in the third degree, it will become madness [*kyōran* 狂乱]. As a result, fathers and mothers will forget their parental affections and wives and children will become suspicious of gratitude and justice.”<sup>21</sup>

This passage conveys an astonishing idea: The larger epidemic of the Final Dharma is not singular but assumes three different pathological forms: *rai*, corpse-vector disease, and madness. As the epidemic spreads throughout the realm, its precise morphology is configured by the particular grade of “virtue”—the moral status—of the people it afflicts. This explains why the monks give *rai* as the most virulent of the three afflictions, since from the Buddhist perspective, *rai* was always seen as the severest manifestation of karmic illness. What this means is that corpse-vector disease, *rai*, and madness are different manifestations of the same roaming entity—the epidemic of the Final Dharma—the pathological form of which changes through a kind of physio-moral transformation. Already, then, we have the suggestion of a larger epidemic, spread by pathogenic demons yet also configured by karma; the categories here (epidemic, demonic agents, individual moral disposition) are interactive rather than exclusive, and karma clearly interfaces internal moral states and the external moral climate.

Relationships between exogenous disease-bearing demons, the Final Dharma, and morality were interwoven in a second, related outbreak narrative in *Essential Notes*. After descriptions of the symptoms of corpse-vector disease, an unmarked text is quoted, the first half of which reads:

This demon has a retinue of ninety thousand demons. They reside on the mountain known as Cold Mountain. Every day they devour the vital energy [*seiki* 精気], blood, and flesh of people. Its name is Harita Yakṣa. This demon emerged from the mountain and crossed over the wastelands, at which time Āṭavaka [a demon-god] came to subjugate this demon, saying, “You eat the blood and flesh of humans. I will eat your blood and flesh.” At that time, Harita fainted and fell to the ground, spitting out blood. It pronounced, “From today onwards I will not consume blood or flesh! I pray that you will not eat me!”<sup>22</sup>

At first glance, this tale of demon subjugation appears to have little to do with the disease and its treatment, neither of which are explicitly mentioned. When the context of the passage is taken into account, however, the tale can be read as an origin story for corpse-vector disease and its ritual eradication, told through a series of homologies with the narrative’s protagonist and villain.

The villain in this narrative is Harita Yakṣa of Cold Mountain, better known in other scriptures as the demoness Hārītī (Kariteimo 訶梨帝母 or Kishimojin 鬼子母神). In the distant past, Hārītī preyed on innocent humans by consuming their vital energy, flesh, and blood. The Jimon outbreak narrative gives a new spin-off to the story of Hārītī, a figure with her own robust and dynamic cult in East Asian Buddhism.<sup>23</sup> The narrative casts her as an analogue of the demons that cause corpse-vector disease, an affliction that vampirically sucks the life out of its victims. That Jimon monks selected Hārītī for this role surely relates to the fact that her cult was well developed at Onjōji in this period. Two icons of Hārītī from this period survive at Onjōji, one from the twelfth century and the other from the thirteenth.<sup>24</sup>

Presented in opposition to Hārītī is Āṭavaka, the hero who subjugates her. In this narrative, Āṭavaka becomes a surrogate or alter-ego of Shōmen Kongō, the central deity of the Jimon ritual. Just as Shōmen Kongō is a wrathful deity, Āṭavaka is identified as a demon-god, suggesting that those who can control demons are in fact demons who have already been converted. At a second level of interpretation, Āṭavaka is the mythologized persona of the Jimon monks themselves, who similarly engage in battle against pathogenic demons. The mythic narrative thus asserts the superiority of Shōmen Kongō and Jimon monks over the demonic, variably understood. The suggestion that this requires the kind of violent encounter that plays out between Āṭavaka

and Hārītī—and by extension healer and patient—is considered in depth in the next chapter.

The narrative goes on to suggest that the superiority of Āṭavaka over Hārītī and healer over pathogen is built not least on a moral foundation:

In the past, during the time of the King of Emptiness Buddha [J. Kūō Butsu 空王仏; Skt. Dharmagahanābhyudgata-rāja], this Great Deity Āṭavaka was a householder. It was the age of the Final Dharma for that Buddha, and a great many were dying left and right of starvation and thirst. Saddened by this, the householder cast aside his wife and son and carried food to distribute to sentient beings. Due to the merits accumulated through these activities, Āṭavaka attained the authority to control the demon kings.<sup>25</sup>

Readers learn that Āṭavaka has the authoritative power to control demons because of merit accrued during a time when merit-making was especially difficult if not impossible—the age of Final Dharma in an earlier epoch. Āṭavaka distributed food for sentient beings languishing in that ruinous age, precisely the positive inverse of Hārītī's vampiric snatching of sentient beings as food. The contrast between disease and treatment is thus not simply a matter of physical power that plays out in a violent encounter, since the power difference that decides the outcome of that encounter depends on moral authority in the way of accumulated virtue. In this way, the mythic outbreak narrative again inscribes the pathological phenomenon of corpse-vector disease in decidedly moral terms.

## IDENTIFYING DEMONIC *MĀRAS*

Linking corpse-vector disease to the epidemic of the Final Dharma demonstrates that in contrast to Zhiyi, who was concerned with helping meditators navigate the contemplative mental landscape unscathed, Jimon monks saw the disease as a pathological convergence at the intersection of the individual moral subject and the environment, the latter defined in terms of the dismal karmic climate of the Final Dharma. But the Jimon monks also appear to have rejected the strict conceptual distinctions Zhiyi constructed between demons and *māras* as categories. When describing the specific demons that cause corpse-vector disease, Jimon monks were interested in a more porous division between what Zhiyi saw as their respective fields of assault—the body, in the case of demons, and the mind, in the case of *māras*. Furthermore, for Jimon monks, the work of these external malignant agents cannot be as easily divorced from the karma of the individual as Zhiyi, who isolated karmic disease as a distinct category, might have insisted. For corpse-vector disease, karma is precisely what mediates the

divide between the internal and the external. This fact is evident when examining the three disease-causing metapersons Jimon monks identified by name—Tenmarakeishitta, Tokeira, and Cat Demon. These metapersons were selected as the pathogens of corpse-vector disease, I suggest, because of the ways they cohered to the pathological logic the monks were developing: They all blur the boundaries between embodied patient and disease agent.

The first demon introduced in the liturgy is Tenmarakeishitta (Tenmarakeishitta-ki; Ch. Tianmoluojishituo-gui 天魔羅雞室陀鬼). The Jimon compilers drafted Tenmarakeishitta from the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra*, the only scripture to mention this demon. This collection was an essential resource for the Jimon compilers, since it is one of very few esoteric scriptures to mention corpse-vector disease by name and one of the only to mention Shōmen Kongō, the deity they placed at the center of their rite. Whereas corpse-vector disease and Shōmen Kongō appear in a section in the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra* pertaining to Ucchuṣma (J. Ususama 烏枢沙摩) affixed to fascicle 9, Tenmarakeishitta appears in fascicle 11, which pertains to Cāmuṇḍā (J. Shamonda 遮文荼), a demoness who makes no appearance in the Jimon liturgical texts. Given that Tenmarakeishitta figures in a section of the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra* that was less relevant to the topic of their ritual, we should ask: Why did the compilers identify this demon as one pathogenic metaperson of corpse-vector disease?

One possibility is pathological resemblance. The *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra* describes the symptoms provoked by the demon as follows: “If there is a person who suddenly acquires the disease of Tianmoluojishituo Demon, the symptoms will resemble wind-*dian* [Ch. *fengdian* 風癲]. Some [sufferers] will be like mad persons, sometimes crying and other times laughing. If forty-nine days pass without treatment, that person is certain to die.”<sup>26</sup> These symptoms align closely with how Jimon monks understood symptoms of corpse-vector disease, beginning with the idea that the demon’s illness resembles wind-*dian*. In Chinese medical literature, wind-*dian* refers to a form of mental disturbance characterized by unstable emotional states, and sometimes epilepsy, which was caused by wind.<sup>27</sup> A comment in *Essential Notes* specifies that corpse-vector disease “arises following wind-fever” (*fūnetsu*), suggesting the affliction was likewise linked to wind.<sup>28</sup> Once acquired, patients were said to experience a kind of paroxysmal vacillation, maddening emotional shifts that resembled wind-*dian*. “At times the sick one is excited,” one passage in *Essential Notes* reads, “but at other times they rest” or “weep sporadically.”<sup>29</sup> That the term wind-*dian* also included epilepsy is notable, since the compilers similarly note that corpse-vector disease resembles epilepsy, which they render with the vernacular Japanese term *kutsuchi* クツチ. Finally, wind-*dian* and corpse-vector disease result in death if not treated for forty-nine days, a length of time corresponding in the Buddhist notion of rebirth to the limbo period between one lifetime and the next.<sup>30</sup>



Another germane reason to draft Tenmarakeishitta as an agent of corpse-vector disease (one we observe for the other demonic agents as well) was its relationship to entities that disrupt the boundaries between the patient self and the demonic other. Tenmarakeishitta is identified as a demon, but its polysemous name points to multiple associations, including with *māra* disturbances. Although any investigation of the meaning of the demon's name is limited by the fact that it appears only in the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra* and no other known text outside of medieval Japanese Buddhist texts on corpse-vector disease, “Tenmarakeishitta” can be parsed as a combination of transliterated Sanskrit and Chinese characters, for which different meanings can be surmised. The first part of the name—Tenmara—is the complete term for what was often abbreviated as *tenma*. In the most basic meaning, Tenma refers to King Māra (Mara Ō 魔羅王), the deity of desire and death best known for trying to disrupt Śākyamuni Buddha's meditation under the bodhi tree.

King Māra was defeated, but as Bernard Faure points out, he continued to follow the Buddha—and the Buddhist tradition—“like his shadow.”<sup>31</sup> Over time, Māra inspired a species of irritants: The term *māra* generalized and came to refer to various troublesome entities whose *raison d'être*, being heirs to King Māra's disruptive tendencies, was to bother, distract, and thwart Buddhist practitioners. In the process of this generalization, four different types of *māras* were identified: passion *māras*, *skandha māras*, death *māras*, and “heavenly *māras*” (*tenma*; Skt. *devamāra*), also referred to as “son-of-god *māras*” or, more pointedly, “demon-god *māras*” (*guishenmo* 鬼神魔).<sup>32</sup> These *māras* became chronic irritants in the Buddhist immune system. Because they were imagined to manifest to obstruct meditation, scripture recitation, and other ritual practices, their management constituted a necessary kind of “pest control” for monastic institutions and practitioners. This is one important use to which Yōsai assigned mulberry in *Record of Nourishing Life by Drinking Tea*. “If one holds on to this tree as a rosary, as a staff, or as a pillow,” he wrote, “Māra cannot invade, to say nothing of those lesser demons and spirits [who will have no chance] of approaching.”<sup>33</sup> For their part, Jimon monks were known to have developed a secret ritual revolving around Kongō Dōji 金剛童子 that was aimed at destroying the armies of *tenma*, re-creating Śākyamuni's expulsion of Māra and his demonic army.<sup>34</sup>

There is more to the name of Tenmarakeishitta. The second term in the demon's name—*shitta* 室陀—invokes the second category of *māras*, those associated with the *skandhas*. *Shitta* is likely an abbreviated transliteration of the Sanskrit term *skandha*, more commonly rendered *shikkenta* 室建陀 or *shikenta* 私建陀. The *shikkenta* variety of *māras* (Skt. *skandhamāra*) refers to the “five aggregates” (*goun* 五蘊; form, sensation, perception, intention, and consciousness) that trouble meditators during practice.

A third type of *māra* may be lurking in the name Tenmarakeishitta as well, in the character *kei* 雞. Just as the characters *ten* (heaven) and *ki* (demon) can be read for meaning rather than as transliterations, *kei* can also be read simply to mean “chicken” or “rooster.” One piece of visual evidence suggesting that Jimon monks would have understood the character to have this meaning comes in a later text. An illustrated manuscript on corpse-vector disease from the late thirteenth century—*On the Types of Corpse-Vector Disease* (*Denshibyō shu no koto* 伝屍病種事)—depicts this demon quite literally with a chicken head.<sup>35</sup> The inclusion of this character in the name Tenmarakeishitta also fits into the pattern emerging here, since once again it can be related to a subtype of *māra*, namely, demon-god *māras*. In Zhiyi’s discussion of the three types of demon-god *māras*, he calls them “mischievous spirits” that manifest to adepts in human form as young women or old men and at different hours of the day as zodiac animals. The “chicken” of Tenmarakeishitta is perhaps related to the *māra* that appears between the hours of 5 and 7 pm.<sup>36</sup>

Overall, Tenmarakeishitta represents the hybridizing of multiple notions of *māra* subtypes (and sub-subtypes)—heavenly *māra*, *skandha*, and chicken. It is difficult to reconstruct exactly how Jimon monks saw this demon, but these different components reveal that Tenmarakeishitta was a Frankenstein of different *māras* cobbled together. In other words, it was a demon who enters minds to confuse practitioners and, in the process, infects them with maddening, wind-like disease.

Like the composition of the name Tenmarakeishitta, Tokeira-ki 兜醯羅鬼 (Ch. *Douxiluo-gui*) is likely a transliteration of a Sanskrit term to which “demon” was added. In the Taishō canon, the name Tokeira only appears in Chinese Tiantai works attributed to Zhiyi and Zhanran and Japanese Tendai texts, specifically the Jimon liturgy and the fourteenth-century *Collection of Leaves Gathered by Storms in the Valley*, which draws on the earlier Jimon ritual manuscripts.<sup>37</sup> Thus, Tokeira is a demon specific to this rite, the Tiantai works on which its manuscripts draw, and derivative passages in ritual texts in Japan.<sup>38</sup>

In *Oral Transmission on the Dhyāna Gate by Master Tiantai Zhizhe* (*Tiantai Zhizhe Dashi chanmen koujue* 天台智者大師禪門口訣), Zhiyi introduces the demon: “When first sitting [in meditation], there are various things that provoke the adept and cause disturbances. Sometimes [a voice] slandering the Buddha-Dharma and spoken in barbarian and Chinese tongues causes the person to lose understanding. This evil demon enters the body and is called *Douxiluo*.”<sup>39</sup> Commenting on this passage, Zhanran notes that *Douxiluo* is a demon of five colors, referencing an earlier section where he discusses systematic correspondences between the five phases and the five viscera, recalling Zhiyi’s correlative framework for karmic pathology.<sup>40</sup>

A longer description of this demon appears in Zhiyi's discussion on demonic diseases in *Great Calming and Contemplation*:

Demons do not randomly afflict persons with sickness. [Rather, they become a problem] when people engage in evil thoughts about all manner of material things or desire to know what is auspicious or inauspicious. The demon Douxiluo manifests assorted transformations, causing colors such as blue-green or yellow to enter the five sense organs, whereupon the mind ground unravels in a perverse manner and the adept will know the auspicious and inauspicious, or will know the auspicious and inauspicious of a particular person, family, village, or country. This is not sacred [i.e., orthodox] knowledge.<sup>41</sup>

Compared with Zhiyi's stringent sixfold classification, the demon he describes here betrays a greater degree of categorical promiscuity. The ambivalence stems from the fact that this "demon" acts a lot like what Zhiyi ascribes more explicitly to *māras*, which infiltrate and befuddle the mind. Zhiyi recognizes that Douxiluo's demonic influence is not a mere distraction for the practitioner; Douxiluo promises the meditator a special kind of power, divinatory knowledge a medium might receive through divine possession and impart to clients seeking to expand their influence in the world. However, Zhiyi suggests that for an adept meditating to advance on the Buddhist path, this knowledge is neither orthodox nor wholesome. The alluring promises of extended cognition create an obstacle all their own, tempting the practitioner with power and control, thus perverting the mind and sending them astray.

The temptation of extended cognition and self-power is also an important aspect of the third demonic agent of corpse-vector disease, Cat Demon. Lest there be any suspicion about the form this demon assumes, a later copyist, perhaps Rishin, made a point of inscribing the following comment on the verso of the *Essential Notes* manuscript: "Cat Demon [*myōki* 猫鬼; Ch. *maogui*] is a demon in the form of a cat [*neko* ネコ]."

The Cat Demon belongs to an eponymous class of demons with a genealogy that is longer and more easily traceable than Tenmarakeishitta or Tokeira. Cat demons appear in Chinese medical literature and Buddhist texts, not to mention other literary and historical works. The most famous episode is undoubtedly that of Dugu Tuo 獨孤陀 (dates unknown), a half-brother of the empress of the Sui dynasty (581–618) Empress Dugu 獨孤皇后 (544–604), who was accused of employing a cat demon to antagonize the royal household. In an extensive study of the *maogui* in medieval Chinese history, Rebecca Doran draws attention to the gendered dimension of Dugu's story, since it was eventually revealed that the Cat Demon was worshipped and employed by his female servant.<sup>42</sup> In Doran's

words, “the cat demon is summoned by women and set upon women,” an aspect of the practice that continued to resurface in medieval Chinese history.<sup>43</sup> From another perspective, Minakata Kumagusu 南方熊楠 (1867–1941) suggested that the Dugu affair reflected the influence of Indian images of the cat as a malicious and mischievous demon (*mamono* 魔物).<sup>44</sup> The domesticated cat was imported from India just before the Sui dynasty, during the Era of Division (220–589).<sup>45</sup> The influence of Buddhism is already evident in the Sui dynasty medical text *Disease Origins*, which offers some of the earliest medical discourse on the Cat Demon.<sup>46</sup>

The Cat Demon figures in all major Chinese medical sources from the Sui and Tang periods, including *Disease Origins*, *Essential Formulas Worth a Thousand in Gold for Emergencies* (*Beiji qianjin yaofang* 備急千金要方), *Supplemental Formulas Worth a Thousand in Gold* (*Qianjin yifang* 千金翼方), and *Arcane Essentials*. As was often the case, *Disease Origins* proved to be a critical source for later medical texts, which is especially notable given that the text was composed around the time of the Dugu scandal in the Sui dynasty. In *Disease Origins*, Chao Yuanfang categorizes the Cat Demon with ailments related to *gu* poisoning (Ch. *gudu bing* 蠱毒病).<sup>47</sup> Chao notes that the Cat Demon affliction “refers to the essence of old wildcats and wild things that transform into the likes of demon spirits [Ch. *guiyu* 鬼蜮], which attach to people.”<sup>48</sup> What makes the Cat Demon similar to *gu* poisoning is that people domesticate the spirit and use it to harm others. When the Cat Demon spirit is served up to unsuspecting persons, Chao writes, “the disease manifests as sharp pain in the heart and abdomen [as the poison] eats through a person’s viscera and bowels, [causing them to] vomit blood and urinate blood, whereafter they die.”<sup>49</sup>

In contrast, Ge Hong’s 葛洪 (281?–341) *Formulas for Emergencies to Keep at Hand* (*Zhouhou beiji fang* 肘後備急方), *Formulas Worth a Thousand in Gold*, and *Supplemental Formulas Worth a Thousand in Gold* contain no hints of a human agent behind the pathological workings of the Cat Demon.<sup>50</sup> As Doran points out, in these later works, the Cat Demon was often explicitly linked to *yedao* 野道 (literally “wild path”), which she translates as “masterless venom.” Christine Mollier describes *yedao* as “a sort of orphan bewitchment that loiters in nature and strikes by chance.”<sup>51</sup> The shift from intentional sorcery (behind which is always an implied agent, no matter how shadowy or elusive) to chance phenomenon parallels the generalizing drift seen in the shift from King Māra to *māras*, whereby individual agents become diffused and legion pathological threats. In any case, the Jimon compilers may have been aware of these various perspectives on the Cat Demon phenomenon, as described in the medical sources. After all, in *Formulas Worth a Thousand in Gold*, Sun Simiao 孫思邈 (581–682) describes a popular moxibustion method with divine efficacy for treating *gu* and Cat Demon ailments, which would have certainly piqued the

interest of Jimon monks, who were designing a moxibustion ritual for an ailment they understood to be caused by pathogens of the same name.<sup>52</sup>

At the same time, it is more likely that the Jimon monks culled their cat demon from a Chinese esoteric Buddhist scripture. Cat demons are mentioned in the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra*. One section includes a prescription for “curing all ailments of *gu* sorcery [Ch. *yagu* 壓蟲], wild paths, and cat demons.” The method involves making a human-shaped effigy out of wheat flour dough—a ritual surrogate for the furtive sorcerer—and using a *vajra* staff to smash the effigy while continuously reciting a spell. The pieces of the effigy are then to be scattered and *gum guggul* incense burned.<sup>53</sup> Chapter 7 will discuss the creation and destruction of effigies and the burning of *gum guggul* incense, two techniques prescribed in the Jimon ritual, suggesting that Jimon monks were reading these passages. Another method for the extermination of cat demons and “wild paths” in the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra* appears in fascicle 9. Because this was the fascicle that mentions Shōmen Kongō and corpse-vector disease, the passage was probably the immediate inspiration for Jimon monks. “If there is a person who suffers from cat demons or wild paths,” the passage reads, “recite the spell [of Shōmen Kongō] one thousand times and the cat demon will thereupon manifest for all people to see.”<sup>54</sup> The passage suggests that the Cat Demon and wild paths typically perform their malicious work from the shadows and that Shōmen Kongō’s spell can be used to expose them, defanging their furtive harm.

A nearly identical passage appears in the Jimon liturgy, with a small but important alteration. “If you wish to eliminate the harms wrought by the Cat Demon and wild paths,” the liturgy reads, “face Shōshiki Daikongō Yasha Myōō and chant [the spell] 108 times. The Cat Demon will thereupon manifest in its physical body [*sono shikishin* 其色身] and empower the practitioner.” This is followed by a parallel passage: “If you wish to eliminate the harms wrought by the diseases of demonic spirits, face Shōshiki Kongō and recite the spell seven hundred times. Again, the person will be made to manifest the body of the demonic spirit and will protect the practitioner.”<sup>55</sup> The logic follows the passage from the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra*: The Shōmen Kongō spell compels the Cat Demon to make itself visible in physical form. Jimon monks add that by doing so, the Cat Demon will come to the aid of the ritualist by empowering them. With the assistance of Shōmen Kongō, the ritualist not only releases the patient from the harm of the Cat Demon but also comes to exert control over this strange spirit animal. This passage is somewhat mysterious, given that the tenor of the ritual stresses eradicating disease agents rather than domesticating them. It suggests, however, that Jimon monks were perhaps more open to the idea of converting *māra*-like entities for their own purposes than was Zhiyi, who warned against the temptation of doing so.

In sum, the three disease agents identified by Jimon monks relate in significant ways. First, in the *Ritual for Expelling Demons* manuscripts, they are all referred to as demons, and each is held responsible for causing corpse-vector disease. Second, they relate to or evoke the specific threat known as the *māra*: Tenmarakeishitta's name embeds several subtypes of *māras*; Tokeira works by infecting the mind and hijacking the patient's agency, fanning the flames of desire for power, control, and knowledge; and the threat of the Cat Demon likewise stems from its connection to sorcery, hinting that the demon's master will, much like a *māra*, control and harm the patient via possession. Third, because of these *māra* tendencies, the demons might initially come from the outside but do their harm from within, making victims acquiesce to unwholesome desires and causing them to abandon Buddhist practice and commit karma-generating acts.

## THE THREE CORPSE-WORMS

The boundaries between pathogenic metapersons and patient are blurred to an even greater extent in a third group of pathogens identified by Jimon monks as responsible for corpse-vector disease: the Three Corpse-Worms (Sanshi 三尸). In contrast to the demonic *māras*, which Jimon monks drafted from Buddhist writings, the Three Corpse-Worms were drafted from a scripture that is nominally Daoist: the *Scripture of Seeking Long Life by Guarding the Fifty-Seventh Day* by Laozi (Rōshi shu kōshin gu chōsei kyō 老子守庚申求長生經; hereafter, *Kōshin Scripture*).

Numerous questions have been raised about the origins of this work.<sup>56</sup> The *Kōshin Scripture* is undoubtedly linked—in intellectual and ritual senses—with the Daoist canon in China, which includes related works like the *Central Scripture of the Three Corpse-Worms* (Ch. *Sanshi zhongjing* 三尸中經), a text preserved in the Song period encyclopedia *Seven Tablets in a Cloudy Satchel* (Ch. *Yunji qiqian* 雲笈七籤), as well as the ninth-century *Scripture for Protecting Life by Eliminating the Three Corpse-Worms and Nine Worms* (Ch. *Chu sanshi jiuchong baosheng jing* 除三尸九蟲保生經).<sup>57</sup> However, a text with the same title as the *Kōshin Scripture* has yet to be discovered among extant Chinese writings, leading Kubo Noritada 窪徳忠 (1913–2010), the scholar who established the field of *kōshin* studies, to suggest that the work was composed in Japan.<sup>58</sup> Although the *Kōshin Scripture* is briefly referenced in a diary entry for 1145 in the *Taiki* 台記, the diary of Fujiwara no Yōrinaga 藤原頼長 (1120–1156), the bulk of surviving evidence of the work from this period is preserved in the Jimon ritual manuscripts.<sup>59</sup> Several passages of the *Kōshin Scripture* are cited in the *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō*, and even more extensive portions are included in *Essential Notes*. Therefore, despite the absence on the Japanese archipelago of

Daoist institutions or any widespread cult devoted to Laozi, the earliest evidence for a text of this title comes from Japan in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries.

Kubo argued that the *Kōshin Scripture* may have been compiled in Japan, whereas others such as Yoshioka Yoshitoyo and Nagai Yoshinori leaned toward the possibility of a Chinese origin.<sup>60</sup> Not coincidentally, important evidence for a Chinese provenance comes from the writings of Jimon monks. One passage in the *Records of Onjōji*, a collection of Jimon temple transmissions compiled after 1343, cites the *Kōshin Scripture* and concludes that the work is a “profoundly secret transmission of [Chishō] Daishi,” that is, Enchin. It further notes that because of its exclusive transmission at Onjōji, monks there do not acquire the “illness,” presumably a reference to corpse-vector disease.<sup>61</sup> Another passage in the *Records of Onjōji* cites the *Kōshin Scripture* along with the *Huichong cunbai meilüe* 虬蟲寸白梅略, a text that also discusses the Three Corpse-Worms and other pathogenic worms. The passage in the *Records of Onjōji* opens with the following attribution: “Written by Śramaṇa of China, Tripiṭaka Master Xuanzang. Transmitted by Śramaṇa of Japan, Enchin, of the rank Master Transmitting the Light.” It concludes: “Chishō Daishi imported [this text] from the Great Tang. It exists only within the scriptural treasury of Miidera and thus does not circulate in the world. It very must be kept secret, must be kept secret.”<sup>62</sup> Still another passage in the *Record of Onjōji* attributes Onjōji’s possession of the *Kōshin Scripture* to the monk Jōjin, who is said to have sent the work, together with his *Record of a Pilgrimage to the Tiantai and Wutai Mountains* (*San Tendai Godaisan ki* 參天台五台山記), the travelogue of his trip to Song China, to Onjōji’s Tōin library.<sup>63</sup>

Together, these passages from the *Records of Onjōji* indicate that Jimon monks in the medieval period saw the *Kōshin Scripture* as a work imported from China, by either Enchin or Jōjin, and that the work was preserved in the Tōin, the scriptural treasury of Onjōji known for housing the sacred writings Enchin brought from China. This fact helps explain the extensive citation of the *Kōshin Scripture* that appears in *Essential Notes*, since a colophon indicates that the quotation was added by Keisei. Keisei was then copying other writings held at Tōin to expand the holdings of his library of sacred works at Hokkesanji; he surely had access to the *Kōshin Scripture* there as well, if the manuscript was on hand.<sup>64</sup> It is also possible that Keisei secured a copy of the *Kōshin Scripture* while abroad in China, a trip he took just a few years before copying the *Ritual for Expelling Demons* manuscripts, but quotations from it, albeit shorter, already appear in the *Ritual for Shōmen Kongō*.

To date, it has primarily been the question of origins—native or Chinese—that has most shaped the study of the *Kōshin Scripture*’s incorporation in the Jimon ritual manuscripts. Two related perspectives have dominated. First, the incorporation has been seen as tantalizing evidence of what Yoshioka called

“one form of the Japanese transmission of Daoism.”<sup>65</sup> Livia Kohn likewise suggests that in linking “the deathbringers and the tantric deity Shōmen kongō,” the Jimon monks were effectively “expelling Daoist demons [i.e., the Three Corpse-Worms] through Buddhist means.”<sup>66</sup> In contrast, other scholars have understood the incorporation of the *Kōshin Scripture* in the Jimon ritual manuscripts as early evidence of what later developed into the popular *kōshin* cult. Tracing the origins of the *kōshin* cult back to the Ritual for Expelling Demons is not without some justification, since one prevalent form of the later *kōshin* cult takes Shōmen Kongō as the central object of veneration, hence the many extant stone *kōshin* stupas (*kōshin tō* 庚申塔) and hanging scrolls from these periods inscribed with his figural depiction.<sup>67</sup>

However, there is no indication that Jimon monks of the twelfth and thirteenth centuries saw their ritual as primarily a modification of the *kōshin* ceremony—one form of which was already practiced among the Heian aristocracy—with the addition of Shōmen Kongō. Although Jimon monks were undoubtedly the first to link *kōshin* ideas and practices to Shōmen Kongō, that alone was not their objective. Despite the irrefutable associations between the Three Corpse-Worms and Daoist rites and scriptures, the manuscripts for the Jimon ritual give no indication that Jimon monks entertained the idea that they were expelling demons they considered Daoist. The parsing of the Jimon ritual into “Daoist” and “Buddhist” elements may not have been a completely unintelligible exercise to the monks who created the ritual; they certainly would have known something about Laozi and the differences between Buddhist and Daoist scriptures. However, identifying Daoist elements in Buddhist rituals from medieval Japan is largely a retroactive concern. It is more productive to consider these borrowed ideas and practices from the perspective of the medieval Buddhist monks who engaged them.

A more profitable approach would be investigating what significance *kōshin* ideas would have had in the context of the Jimon ritual manuscripts. To what use did the monks put those ideas and why? As we have seen, their first and most urgent priority was getting a handle on a new affliction caused by corpses and hammering out a healing ritual to eradicate it. Here, I argue that Jimon monks cast the Three Corpse-Worms alongside demons and *māras* as the pathogenic metapersons of corpse-vector disease for a specific reason. Like the demonic *māras*, the corpse-worms muddle the ontological and agential boundaries between disease agent and patient through a kind of karmic entanglement. As I will show, the notion of the Three Corpse-Worms enabled Jimon monks to develop an image of corpse-vector disease pathogens in ways that were not possible with the demonic *māras* culled from Buddhist scriptures alone.

Before examining their place in the etiology and pathology of corpse-vector disease, we must review some basic facts about the Three Corpse-Worms as



presented in the *Kōshin Scripture* and known to Jimon monks.<sup>68</sup> Every human body is home to the Three Corpse-Worms, all of whom share the surname Hō (Ch. Peng): Hō Ko (Ch. Peng Ju 彭涓), Hō Shitsu (Ch. Peng Zhi 彭質), Hō Kyō (Ch. Peng Jiao 彭矯). Among the manifold creatures that dwell in the human body, the Three Corpse-Worms rank above the countless worms (*mushi*) in the abdomen, over which they function as generals. (In Chinese medical works such as *Disease Origins*, the worms constituted a major category of pathogens.) Some passages suggest the Three Corpse-Worms reside in the five viscera. More frequently, they are said to reside in different locations in the body: Ko resides in the head, Shitsu in the throat or the belly, and Kyō in the legs. At one level, the Three Corpse-Worms are much like the pathological body worms they are said to command, because they damage the host's body from the inside and cause disease like parasites. Ko invades the eyes, whereupon they blacken, the face wrinkles, the mouth becomes foul in odor, and teeth fall out; Shitsu invades the five viscera, sapping them of *qi*; Kyō, in the lower half of the body, obstructs the passage of feces and urine.

At the same time, the Three Corpse-Worms display much more personality than do abdominal worms. As full-fledged metapersons rather than mere parasites, they have a higher-order agency, most pronounced in their activities as mindful observers and record-keepers. The Three Corpse-Worms maintain sleepless surveillance over everything their human host does, a process that accords to cycles of sixty days following the sexagenary calendar, a ritual calendar of sixty days that was transmitted to Japan from China.<sup>69</sup> On the night corresponding to the fifty-seventh day of that calendar—the so-called *kōshin* day—the corpse-worms ascend to heaven, where they report to heavenly arbiters in control of human destiny and life span, identified either as the Celestial Emperor or the Directors of Destiny. The corpse-worms only report misdeeds committed by their host; as the scripture notes, “They do not speak a word about virtues.” If the misdeeds reported are misdemeanors, a day is subtracted from the host's life span; if the misdeeds constitute more severe offenses, an entire year is subtracted.

The objective of this elaborate biospiritual snitching operation is to shorten their host's allotted life span and hasten their death. Hence, some scholars prefer to translate *shi* in *sanshi* as “deathbringer.” But the corpse-worms relate to death in other ways. Once their host has died and their earthly soul passes into the Three Springs of the underworld, the corpse-worms are said to remain on Earth, becoming “ghosts” (Ch. *gui* 鬼). (In the context of the Jimon ritual, this term is better rendered “demon.”) Liberated from the corpse of their host, the corpse-worms become free to roam and scavenge for libations not meant for them, the wine that humans offer to gods and ancestors. Indeed, the corpse-worms kill their host because they desire the freedom to act like deities or spirits.

The *Kōshin Scripture* prescribes three primary strategies a person can use to protect themselves against the corpse-worms. The strategy depended on the quality of the individual: “Those of superior quality cultivate [virtue],” the text reads, “and thereby subdue [the Three Corpse-Worms]. Those of medium quality protect themselves from the Three Corpse-Worms by not sleeping any day that falls on the fifty-seventh [*kōshin* day]. Those of inferior quality consume good medicines to kill them.”<sup>70</sup> The logic of the superior method is clear: By being a good person and avoiding misdeeds, the corpse-worms will be left with nothing to report. In actual practice in Heian Japan, the most prevalent strategy was that of not sleeping on the evening of the fifty-seventh day, a practice also known as the *kōshin* vigil (*kōshin machi* 庚申待). The *Kōshin Scripture* admonishes readers, “If when approaching daybreak, you begin to feel tired, you mustn’t lie down for sleep. Wake yourself again and again, and if you do so, [the corpse-worms] will not succeed in making their report to the Celestial Emperor.”<sup>71</sup> To rouse themselves, courtiers in Japan composed poetry, drank sake, and played *sugoroku* 双六 (Japanese backgammon).<sup>72</sup> They recited a spell that was given at the end of the *Kōshin Scripture* in which the reciter told the Three Corpse-Worms to “enter the dark oblivion and depart from my body!”<sup>73</sup> We know courtiers recited the spell because it is included in the *Kuchizusami* 口遊, a textbook written by Minamoto no Tamenori 源為憲 (?–1011) for an aristocratic child, and it is mentioned in the *Taiki* entry noted above.

## A VICIOUS CIRCLE

Ideas about the Three Corpse-Worms conveyed in the *Kōshin Scripture* intersect with the imagination of corpse-vector disease in the Jimon ritual manuscripts in several ways. Examining those intersections allows us to understand why Jimon monks would incorporate ideas about corpse-worms to construct knowledge about corpse-vector disease in their ritual manuscripts. With the Three Corpse-Worms cast as pathogenic metapersons, corpse-vector disease hangs together in remarkably coherent ways.

The first and most obvious link pertains to how corpse-worms and the disease are associated with the material dead. Indeed, as we saw in chapter 5, in the classical medical understanding of corpse-vector disease, the pathogen was identified as the corpse or some entity emanating from the corpse. As Li Jianmin has shown, in ancient China, when the notion of corpse-vector disease began to coalesce, disease concepts characterized by contagion (*chuanran* 伝染) were closely tied to fears over death pollution.<sup>74</sup> Two categories of such afflictions, first expounded in *Disease Origins*, became the building blocks of corpse-vector disease. First were the “*zhu*-infusion diseases” (*zhubing* 注病), in which malicious *qi* was said to invade and (by way of a pun) “reside” (*zhu* 住) in the body.<sup>75</sup>

Second were the “corpse-diseases” (*shibing* 尸病), a category that included the Three Corpse-Worms and adjacent disorders, such as corpse-*qi*. The latter was described as follows: “There are times when people directly touch the corpses of the deceased or look over them. The *qi* of those corpses enters the belly of those persons and, in mutual attraction with the corpse-worms [already residing in the human body], produces disease.”<sup>76</sup> Moreover, the categories of *zhu*-infusion and corpse diseases had already crisscrossed in *Disease Origins*, forming the hybrid pathogen variant known as corpse-*zhu*: “After one dies,” the text reads, the disease entity is “exchanged with people nearby, eventually bringing about the destruction of the family line. It is because this corpse-worm disease pours into and transfers to people nearby that it is called corpse-infusion.”<sup>77</sup> What these passages suggest is that diseases of both types are generated by way of a curious “corpse” resonance, when pathogenic agents or *qi* emitted from dead bodies interacts with corpse-worms dwelling in living bodies. This connection would not have been lost on Jimon monks, who attributed corpse-vector disease infection to external demons and corpse-worms already present in the body.

Jimon monks were also undoubtedly drawn to the ways the Three Corpse-Worms were ontologically intertwined with the human body. After all, the Three Corpse-Worms represented a congenital pathology that was transmitted hereditarily. As the *Kōshin Scripture* notes, “All human life obtains its physical form from the vital essence of the grains within the father and mother. This is why all humans have the Three Corpse-Worms within them that cause great injury.”<sup>78</sup> Humans, in other words, are born with entities referred to as “corpses.” In this strange conception, death is not just the end of individual existence but an active part of the living human body from its inception.

In *Essential Notes*, Keihan drew special attention to this idea, writing that the three named corpse-worms are identical to the “worms” (*mushi*) born in the body from the beginning of human life. Here he is not referencing the worms of Chinese medicine. He instead quotes Genshin’s *Essentials of Rebirth*, according to which, “when people are born, in seven days the worms are born.”<sup>79</sup> By incorporating Genshin’s text, Keihan suggests that the Three Corpse-Worms are likewise features of the fundamental impurity of the human body, which Buddhists understood physiologically as tied to karma.

Indeed, the idea that the Three Corpse-Worms participated in the physiological system of karma generation internal to the human body was a key point for Jimon monks. As one passage in the *Kōshin Scripture* notes, “People who are wicked and evil will have the greatest number of worms,” an understanding that resonates with the Buddhist idea that the impurity of the body corresponds to its karma—the more karma, the more impurity.<sup>80</sup> Keihan sought to incorporate these ideas even more firmly in a Buddhist framework, writing, “These worms report the person’s offenses to Indra [Tentaishaku 天帝釈].”<sup>81</sup> Here he

changes what was “Celestial Emperor” in other discourse similar to that of the *Kōshin Scripture* to Indra, an Indian Buddhist deity, thereby inscribing the Three Corpse-Worms into a Buddhist cosmology defined by the operations of karma. Keihan makes a similar move when he links the Three Corpse-Worms with the “born-together-gods” (*kushōjin* 俱生神), entities who exist in the human body since birth and keep watch over the person’s good and evil activities.<sup>82</sup> Just as the corpse-worms report misdeeds to celestial beings, the born-together-gods report those vices to the judges of hell, such as King Yama, who decides what punishments the karmic sinner deserves.

For Jimon monks, the idea of the corpse-worms was productive for thinking about corpse-vector disease not just because these indwelling entities observed their host’s behavior and kept a record of their accumulated karma. The monks were arguably most interested in how corpse-worms actively hijacked the agency of their host in various ways and spurred them to vice. One section of the *Kōshin Scripture* says that Shitsu “makes the host forgetful and causes them to commit evil deeds, including eating [the meat] of other living beings.” Another section describes how Kyō “confuses the hosts and stirs up the five senses, leaving the person without the control to regulate himself.”<sup>83</sup> In other words, the corpse-worms control how their host behaves by disrupting the pathways between desire, intention, and action. In so doing, they blur the boundaries between what their host wants and what *they* (the corpses) want. An early passage in the *Kōshin Scripture* brings this unsettling point home strongly, noting that the “upper corpse-worm causes its host to be fond of horse-driven carriages and clothing,” “the middle corpse-worm makes its host enjoy the five flavors of food and drink, and the lower corpse-worm causes its host to take pleasure in sex.” The Three Corpse-Worms are none other than “the roots of the Three Poisons,” the *Kōshin Scripture* notes. They “make their host feel euphoric and enraptured, diminishing the host’s desire to be free of fear or acute and bright in his ears and eyes.” “It is the pleasure” these corpse-worms create, the passage concludes, that “conceals” the more virtuous desires for liberation and health.<sup>84</sup>

The Buddhist terminology of the “Three Poisons” is especially revealing of how Jimon monks conceptualized the links between the corpse-worms and corpse-vector disease and the blurred boundaries between pathogen and patient. The mention of the concept of the “Three Poisons” suggests the *Kōshin Scripture* Jimon monks were quoting was already informed by Buddhist conceptions of morality to some degree, making the scripture easier for Jimon monks to incorporate into their own ritual framework. In the Buddhist notion, the Three Poisons of greed, hatred, and ignorance are major psychic engines of karma generation. By clouding and afflicting the individual already at the psychic levels of intention and desire, the Three Poisons spur unwholesome actions that will inevitably result in karmic accumulation.

Therefore, within the imagination of corpse-vector disease that Jimon monks constructed in their ritual manuscripts, the Three Corpse-Worms become obvious counterparts of the three demonic *māras*, Tenmarakeishitta, Tokeira, and Cat Demon. Both categories of pathogenic agents were understood to get inside the patient, whether from birth (the corpse-worms) or by invasion (the demonic *māras*). Both were understood to infect the patient's mind—the fundamental characteristic of the *māra*, according to Zhiyi—and tempt them with desires for material possessions, sex, power, and control. These entities are especially vexatious precisely because the infected person, whose mind has become as cloudy as his eyes and ears, comes to believe his depraved actions are the result of his own intentions and desire. Regardless, the result is the same: Karma is accrued and added to the person's account, which makes inevitable a reduction of precious life span, a longer sentence and worse punishments in the hells, or karmic illness while alive.

Jimon monks sought to link these different images of etiology in relation to the multiple pathological agencies they discuss, which is vividly illustrated in one dense passage at the conclusion of the *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō*. To be sure, the monks do not unpack the links explicitly, but the sequence of statements makes clear that they understood these metapersons to operate in an interdependent network of pathogenic agency, ultimately forming a relatively coherent yet vicious circle of desire, disease, death, and contagion formation. For the purposes of analysis, I have numbered distinct sections of the passage, each number marking the start of a new link:

[1] The [*Great*] *Calming and Contemplation* says, “If an adept is suffering from an illness due to either of the two diseases [caused by] demons or *māra* disturbances, these should be treated through contemplative practices or powerful spirit spells and then the sufferer will improve. If it is a karmic disease, then the adept should use the power of contemplation internally while practicing repentance externally—his condition will then improve. These methods of treatment are not the same. The adept must understand this well. One must not wield a sword by grasping the blade only to bring harm to themselves.”

[2] The [*Kōshin Scripture*] says: “Hō Ko resides in the eyes, darkens them, wrinkles the face, causes bad breath, and makes the teeth fall out. Hō Shitsu resides within the abdomen, attacks the person's five viscera, reduces their *qi*, and increases their avoidances, making them enjoy evil and the consumption of [the meat of] sentient beings. Hō Kyō resides within the feet, causes the person to have blockade, agitates their five emotions to chaos, and makes them unable to control their own self. If the three worms become gods, then they will harm

descendants, thus this affliction does not cease. [On the] fifty-seventh [day], if you do not sleep, the Three Corpse-Worms will cease for a long time. On the night of the fifty-seventh, these Three Corpse-Worms will always report to the Celestial Emperor a record of the person's misdoings to cut short their life registry. They always want to make [their host] die quickly so that the *hun* souls enter the Three Springs." [3] Sometimes these demons cause harm to people, inducing pain in the chest and paralyzing the person with exhaustion. The disease harm [caused by] one demon transmits to the offspring and brothers and sisters [of the sufferer]. [4] Therefore, people of the time also call it transmitting-death [i.e., corpse-vector disease], *enchō* 厭蝶,<sup>85</sup> *fukuren* 復連,<sup>86</sup> and bones-steaming disease. Also, when within one household all are dying and there are none to determine the reason, soon it will progressively increase; those with severe cases will die if not treated within a few months. Therefore, in despising this [disease], the parental ties between father and son are terminated, and husband and wife grow suspicious about their marital obligations. [5] This is a disease of accumulated karma.<sup>87</sup>

Put together, the passage describes the vicious circle of corpse-vector disease as it was imagined by Jimon monks. It begins where we started in this chapter, with the disease categories defined by Zhiyi: demons, *māras*, and karma. In my reading, including this quote from Zhiyi at the start of the passage is meant to signal readers that these categories are key for understanding what follows in the passage. The descriptions begin immediately thereafter with a quotation from the *Kōshin Scripture* about the Three Corpse-Worms. This material is familiar to us by now, but it is noteworthy that the Jimon monks deliberately chose passages from the *Kōshin Scripture* that stress not simply how the corpse-worms observe the vices of their host but how they hijack their host's agency and thereby provoke the vices from within. Jimon monks thus emphasize how corpse-worms, as agents of corpse-vector disease, blur the boundaries between disease agent and patient, much like the demonic *māras* discussed elsewhere in the liturgy.

Indeed, the monks connect the long quotation of the *Kōshin Scripture* [2] to the next passage [3] by opening with the demonstrative phrase "these demons." "These demons" points first backward to the passage on the Three Corpse-Worms just discussed. Specifically, it is a reference to the form that corpse-worms assume after their host dies (J. *ki*; Ch. *guī*). In the original Chinese context of the scripture, "ghosts" is perhaps the appropriate translation for *ki*, but in the Ritual for Expelling Demons manuscripts, Jimon monks were surely thinking "demons." That is because in the discursive world of the Jimon ritual manuscripts, "these demons" invariably becomes a reference to the other

demons discussed throughout, most notably Tenmarakeishitta, Tokeira, and Cat Demon. Because the ritual manuscripts have already established several homologies between corpse-worms and demons, a precise or more direct identification of them is not required in this passage: The reader is to assume that they share an identity—even as they represent different stages in the cycle of corpse-vector disease.

As the passage continues, these demonic entities are said to be what cause the specific constellation of symptoms associated with corpse-vector disease, as well as its contagion, whereby it infects offspring (recalling the hereditary aspect of the corpse-worms) and passes between brothers and sisters. The text goes on to mention diseases that are roughly synonymous with or adjacent to corpse-vector disease in classical medical literature, and again stresses how the affliction ultimately causes death and destroys families.

The passage ends with a statement [5] whose meaning should be abundantly clear at this point: Corpse-vector disease is “an affliction of accumulated karma.” The preceding analysis enables us to understand that this is not simply a reiteration of the basic Mahāyāna idea that karma causes illness, since Jimon monks also understood corpse-vector disease etiology in terms of external and internal pathogenic agents. Instead, karma is the adhesive that links the meta-persons of corpse-vector disease: Demons, *māras*, and corpse-worms all blur the ontological, agential, and moral boundaries with the people they infect, thus generating dense layers of pathogenic karma.

If we were to put all the pieces together and speculatively reconstruct a schematic of the cycle of corpse-vector disease in terms of a single victim as Jimon monks would have imagined it, the picture would look something like this: The agency of the victim is hijacked, either by corpse-worms inside the body since birth or demonic *māras*, who are roaming about in the epidemic of the Final Age—or more precisely, as a resonance between such indwelling worms and external disease agents. Controlling the victim’s behavior, these demonic metapersons cause them to commit immoral acts, generating karma that shores up in the victim. This leads to sickness, understood variably as a kind of divine or celestial judgment, karmic illness, or physical corruption of the body by parasitical worms. Once the person is finally brought to their death—which is suggested in the Jimon texts to be virtually inevitable—their body becomes the source of contagion in at least two partially overlapping respects. First, the end of one patient’s life activates their corpse as a prime vector in transmitting the disease to new victims (the contagion characteristic that corpse-vector disease shares with death defilement). Second, the indwelling corpse-worms achieve liberation from the body and transform into demons, and perhaps into the same demonic *māras* the Jimon manuscripts name, Tenmarakeishitta, Tokeira, Cat Demon. The cycle of the disease then starts all over again.

Jimon monks do not explicitly outline a perfectly ironed-out theory of disease causation or transmission. But it should be clear that the inchoate schematic of the pathological ecology of corpse-vector disease they were trying to work out was pervaded by an imagination of disease and disease agents as inextricable from moral conditions, both external (the Final Dharma) and internal (inner karmic accumulation). The pathogenic metapersons have in common the fact that they irritate and threaten the patient at the interface between self and not-self, which is to say the field of karma, the unexpectedly porous field of morally inflected action and consequences. At this karmic interface of self and not-self, patients and pathogenic metapersons were imagined in fact to co-produce a vicious circle of desire, disease, and death, thereby generating contagion and pestilential chaos on an epidemic scale.

One way to understand the relationships between the different aspects and metapersons of corpse-vector disease—one that would have made sense for the Jimon monks—would be to carefully trace the various homologies established throughout the ritual manuscripts. The homologies are presented by way of a correlative logic of threes: Zhiyi's three categories of disease (demons, *māras*, karma), the three demonic *māras* (Tenmarakeishitta, Tokeira, Cat Demon), a second set of three demons (heaven, human, Earth; discussed in the next chapter), the Three Corpse-Worms, the Three Poisons, the three pathological varieties of the Final Dharma epidemic (*rai*, corpse-vector disease, madness), and the three levels of virtue for which there are three different methods for eliminating corpse-worms. The repetition of threes constitutes no less than a subterranean text running through the ritual manuscripts, one that Jimon monks constructed to clarify the multiple overlapping registers of corpse-vector disease's complex etiology and pathology. Together, the homologies establish threads of coherence across a field of diverse pathogenic metapersons, conditions, and symptoms and across several notions of disease causation—ontological, environmental, temporal, psychological, and moral.

If one theme organizes and links these diverse perspectives, it is the deterioration of boundaries. In its complexity, corpse-vector disease devours the boundaries between the internal and external, self and not-self. As we saw in chapter 5, from the perspective of courtiers in Heiankyō, corpse-vector disease was no less than the influx into the mansion and body of what should have been outside and ritually exiled to the margins—the corpse and its polluting *qi*. I discussed how this influx was spurred by a new internalization of defilement, which came to be linked to the karmic impurity of the body, thereby giving rise to anomalous pathological phenomena. Now we can appreciate how Jimon monks took this thinking further by identifying the demonic agents of corpse-vector disease as *māras*, troublesome irritants of the Buddhist immune system who



hijack the agency of victims, cause them to create karma, and thus infect them with corpse-vector disease. Indeed, recall from chapter 5 how Jimon monks described the dying patient. “While trying to abide in correct mindfulness,” one passage in *Essential Notes* reads, “some sufferers indulge [in thoughts of] demonic paths.” “Lustful desires may develop,” the passage continues, “along with feelings of hatred and anger.”<sup>88</sup> We can appreciate these as descriptions not simply of the pessimistic thoughts of a patient on the verge of dying but also, as is clear from the spawning of the Three Poisons in the patient’s mind, the process of losing agential ground to the pernicious influence of demonic *māras*.

Why did Jimon monks rely so heavily on the notion of *māras* in their attempt to explain the etiology of corpse-vector disease? Would it not have been enough to say that the patient was being attacked by this or that external demon, much like the demon king and the *gao*-and-*huang* demon described by Zhiyi and Zhanran, or perhaps the vampiric Hāriti from their own esoteric mythology?

For one thing, the late twelfth and early thirteenth centuries were a time of increased concern about *māras* and the question of where they came from, which came to be called the “realm of *māras*” (*makai*). As we saw in chapter 3, Keisei, a major contributor to the Ritual for Expelling Demons manuscripts, used the possession rite to engage with an ancient spirit of Mt. Hira said to hail from that realm, a spirit who was also described as a *tengu* inflicting his brother with disease. Many of the other spirits with which Keisei engaged were also said to have ended up in the realm of *māras*, which was increasingly being conceptualized as a possible postmortem destination for the dead, a dark place where spirits found themselves at the mercy of *tengu* and suffered in other ways, having been disconnected from the living because of perceived karmic crimes while alive and their tragic deaths.

Seen from a genealogy of the dead, what this means is that *māras*, or those who ended up in the realm of *māras*, were actually quite similar to *jake*, the evil dead, those spirits whose disease-causing antics were discussed in chapters 2 and 3. Like *māras*, one of the defining characteristics of *jake* was how they commandeer the agency of their victims. Thus, even as Jimon monks were imagining a new disease caused by corpses, their imagination continued to be guided by earlier ideas of the disease caused by spirits, now tethered to newer anxieties about *māras*.

In constructing an understanding of corpse-vector disease around demonic *māras*, mischievous agents acting in some ways like the more familiar *jake* spirits, Jimon monks may have sought to render the affliction one that their elite patients might grasp more readily. This is almost certainly one of the reasons the monks incorporated the notion of the Three Corpse-Worms, besides the coherence it brought to their conception of corpse-vector disease. The idea of

the corpse-worms would have been familiar to their noble patients, who regularly practiced the *kōshin* vigil, a fixture of their calendar-driven lives. Thus, even as Jimon monks were multiplying the pathogenic metapersons and writing them into the body in ways that surely would have disturbed their courtier patients, they were also making that disease more legible and coherent to them. Another purpose must not be ignored: They were also making the pathogenic metapersons actionable in the context of a healing ritual, a topic I turn to in the next chapter.

## CHAPTER 7

### Playing with Fire

#### *Therapeutic Violence Through Ritual Pyrotechnics*



The content articulated in the old medical maxim *vulnerando sanamus*—we heal by wounding—translates on the patient side into a hypothesis: by allowing the infliction of skilled injury on myself, I contribute to my recovery.

—Peter Sloterdijk, *You Must Change Your Life*

#### *Things That Give One a Hot Feeling*

... An esoteric master performing a rite of incantation at noon in the Sixth or Seventh Month. Or at the same time a year a copper-smith working in his foundry.

—Sei Shōnagon, *The Pillow Book*

AS USUAL, SEI SHŌNAGON OFFERS A JUXTAPOSITION THAT ON FIRST READ seems curious. In her mind, the esoteric master and the coppersmith are closely linked, and not just by season or time of year. The association, it seems, is technological. Both coppersmiths and esoteric masters are pyrotechnicians, who differ only in the purpose for which they harness the metabolic power of fire. One uses fire to melt copper to make tools and weapons; the other, as this chapter will show, uses it to torch demons and incinerate disease.

In the manuscripts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons, Jimon monks cast corpse-vector disease as a thorny affliction that disrupts and distorts the boundaries between its demonic metapersons and the embodied patient. That these manuscripts shed light on how Jimon monks understood the disease shows us that in medieval Japan, the genre of ritual text functioned epistemologically, as a site for producing medical knowledge. At the same time, we would only grasp the function of such texts partially if we did not also read them as they were most explicitly intended, that is, as prescriptive ritual documents that outline a healing program aimed at the elimination of pathogens and the diseases they cause.

As a therapeutic program, the Ritual for Expelling Demons was structured as a *goma* ceremony, with a centerpiece of an altar of fire. In that sense, the ritual was similar to many esoteric altar rituals for healing performed in Japan since the mid-Heian period. Yet this was no ordinary fire ceremony. The core modality Jimon monks prescribed was not a traditional esoteric ritual technique but moxibustion, a therapeutic practice in which the healer burns the patient's skin directly with mugwort tinder.

At first glance, the promotion of moxibustion as the central healing technology of an esoteric ritual is perplexing. Since the mid-Heian, esoteric rituals such as the *goma* were sponsored with great frequency, reflecting the pervasive conviction—no doubt shared by priests and their patrons—that these rituals had the power to treat diseases by eradicating the demonic entities who caused them. If Sei associated esoteric masters with a hot feeling, it was because already in her time she witnessed the power of the fire those masters kindled in ritual. Moxibustion, however, derives not from the ritual corpus of esoteric Buddhism but from classical Chinese medicine. Why would monks of a monastic community like the Jimon lineage craft a healing program centered on a modality that was patently outside the tried-and-true therapeutic apparatus of esoteric ritual?

A second perplexity emerges here, one related to the body of the patient. The first three chapters of this book examined several esoteric rituals, many of which were pioneered and performed by Jimon monks and all of which shared one thing in common: They did not require direct contact with the patient's physical body. Given the divine influence of distance-traversing deities like Senju Kannon and Fudō Myōō, on whom monks called in altar rites, and the employment of mediums, who absorbed the pathological shocks of spirit-wrought affliction in the possession rite, esoteric rituals were seen to be effective against disease-causing demons and spirits at a distance. By contrast, moxibustion therapy involves a deliberate wounding of the patient's body through burning. Why, we must ask, had Jimon monks come to decide it was necessary—in the context of esoteric ritual no less—to directly burn the patient's body to therapeutically prevail over demonic disease?

To shed light on these questions, this chapter explores the ways that moxibustion uniquely contributed to the efficacy of ritual healing as it was configured by Jimon monks in the Ritual for Expelling Demons. To understand why they adopted moxibustion, I argue that we have to pay attention to how Buddhist monks in medieval Japan designed therapeutic efficacy. Drawing on an archive of images, symbols, and practices, monks had to design ritual efficacy in ways that proved compelling to themselves and their patients. This often meant making efficacy visible, legible, and thus verifiable. Recall that *gen*—the most common term for describing “efficacy” in ritual, medical, documentary, and narrative genres in premodern Japan—had the meaning of *shirushi*, meaning

“signs,” “manifestation,” and “evidence.” Even when the divine agencies understood to facilitate healing and ritual power were deemed beyond perception, it was nonetheless necessary for monks to translate ritual power into visible, tangible, and even tactile forms.

This chapter shows how adopting moxibustion enabled Jimon monks to reimagine ritual efficacy by creatively invoking images of efficacious fire in the esoteric tradition. Far more than a static fixture of the fire ceremony, fire has long been at the heart of how esoteric traditions envision transformation, whether soteriological, ritual, or therapeutic. By incorporating moxibustion into their healing program, the monks sought to reinscribe moxibustion with esoteric meanings and powers in ways unanticipated by the extensive career of this modality in classical medicine. In its new role as a tool of ritual pyrotechnics, moxibustion literalized a virtual metaphysics of efficacy long kindled by the esoteric imaginary. In turn, I show how moxibustion, as a healing modality that blurs the boundaries between healing and harming, offered a solution superior to then-known ritual technologies against a disease understood to be both demonic and embodied. Moxibustion gave Jimon monks an unusually effective material medium by which they might subjugate disease-demons on the surface of their patient’s skin.

## THERAPEUTIC FIRE

Moxibustion (*kyū*; Ch. *jiu* 灸) is a technique in which the healer burns *Artemisia* tinder directly on or near the body.<sup>1</sup> The most commonly used form of *Artemisia* in Japan was and continues to be mugwort (*yomogi* 蓬), which is harvested, dried, and processed into the tinder known in English as “moxa,” a term derived from the Japanese *mogusa* 艾, from *moe kusa* 燃え草, “burning herb.”<sup>2</sup> In common practice, the moxa is formed into cones burned on specific places on the body—tender or painful areas, sites associated with disease, infection, or injury, or “acumoxa” (acupuncture-moxibustion) points or “holes” (*ketsu* 穴).

An early standardization of acumoxa loci was achieved in the Han dynasty (206 BCE–220 CE) with the *Yellow Emperor’s Inner Classic* (*Huangdi neijing* 黄帝内经) corpus in the context of theorizing the vessels (Ch. *mo/mai* 脉), tracts in the body through which blood and *qi* were thought to circulate and along which the acumoxa loci were placed. Around this same time, acupuncture (*shin/hari* 針 or 鍼; Ch. *zhen*; therapeutic needling) and moxibustion came to be intertwined, such that it thereafter became common to refer to them by the single term “acumoxa” (*shinkyū*; Ch. *zhenjiu*). The term was used partly to distinguish these externally applied techniques meant for manipulating *qi* in the vessels from the other major branch of Chinese medical practice, *materia medica* (*honzō* 本草; Ch. *bencao*).

Despite the term that conjoined them, moxibustion and acupuncture were distinct in provenance. Early evidence from the Mawangdui 馬王堆 manuscripts, which include several texts focused on moxibustion relating to nascent notions of the *mo* vessels, points to the historical antecedence of moxibustion. As Donald Harper points out, prescriptions in the Mawangdui manuscripts mention the use of a mugwort cigarette, which is distinct from but certainly anticipates processed moxa tinder.<sup>3</sup> More consequentially, the two techniques had separate trajectories throughout history. In early medieval Japan, acupuncture faded into virtual extinction, while moxibustion rose in popularity, developments that in some respects were prefigured by received Chinese medical literature.

Writing in the thirteenth century, court physician Koremune Tomotoshi 惟宗具俊 (dates unknown) summarized the status moxibustion had reached in Japan by his time. He wrote, “A good physician is generally understood as one who performs both acupuncture and moxibustion. We see in the *Classic on Nurturing Life [with Acupuncture and Moxibustion]* ([Zhenjiu] *zisheng jing* 針灸資生經) that, ‘If one needles but does not cauterize, or if one uses cautery but does not needle, this is not a good physician.’” He also notes that “the technique of acupuncture has perished and thus is not used.” He concludes, “It is moxibustion that, even until this latter age, remains number one among treatments.”<sup>4</sup> Tomotoshi’s remarks offer a window on the ascendancy of moxibustion among healing technologies in early medieval Japan. Documentary evidence from this “latter age”—here Tomotoshi invokes the Buddhist notion of the Final Dharma—particularly in the form of diaries written in the late tenth through thirteenth centuries by members of the aristocracy, vouches for this retrospective and historical assessment in two respects. Although transmitted to Japan as interrelated modalities of classical medicine, acupuncture and moxibustion had divergent careers in their reception over the Heian period. Needles did see therapeutic use, but this was mainly relegated to dentistry and petty surgery, not quite the chief functions of acupuncture as Tomotoshi might have understood them. Moxibustion, in contrast, was used with great frequency for a wide range of disorders.

Aspects of these developments were anticipated by the textual sources for classical medicine transmitted to Japan. Moxibustion was a preferred modality in various Chinese medical texts, most notably the *Yellow Emperor’s Toad Canon* (*Huangdi hama jing* 黃帝蝦蟇經), Ge Hong’s *Formulas for Emergencies to Keep at Hand*, *Prescriptions in Brief* (*Xiaopin fang* 小品方), and *Arcane Essentials*, a trend that might reflect popular reliance on the technique in China over the periods of compilation.<sup>5</sup> It was used as the sole treatment in Cui Zhiti’s 崔知悌 (b. ca. 620) monograph for afflictions in the depletion-exhaustion category, which included corpse-vector disease, *Moxibustion Method for Bones-Steam*

*Disease* (*Guzhengbing jiu fa* 骨蒸病灸法). In *Arcane Essentials*, compiler Wang Tao—who relies extensively on Cui Zhiti’s now-lost work—famously declared that acupuncture can kill but not revive a person.<sup>6</sup> Taking the risks of needling to heart, Wang replaced nearly every instance of the character for “acupuncture” (*zhen*) or “pierce” (*ci* 刺) in quoted sources with the character for “moxibustion” (*jiu*).<sup>7</sup> Wang’s treatise exerted considerable influence on court medicine in the Heian period, most conspicuously on Tanba no Yasuyori’s *Ishinpō*, Japan’s oldest extant medical compendium and a benchmark for therapeutic knowledge for centuries.

The *Ishinpō* organizes acumoxa loci according to region of the body, rather than the circulation vessels or channels.<sup>8</sup> Therapy followed suit. Diary entries from the centuries after the *Ishinpō* suggest that in actual cases the channels were not taken into consideration by members of leading medical lineages, such as the Tanba and Wake.<sup>9</sup> Instead, those sources indicate physicians were above all concerned with applying moxibustion according to interdiction related to “body-gods” (*jinshin* 人神), spirits believed to circulate in the body in harmony with calendrical cycles. Diary entries allow us to glimpse the social contexts in which these ideas played out in Japan and demonstrate that medical families did not simply follow received literature but came to hold contrasting theories on this topic, leading to much deliberation and debate. These exchanges, as intellectual as they were clinically relevant, led to the compilation of specialized manuals and secret transmissions. The possession of such enchiridia alone could authorize a specific position regarding body-god locations, giving one the upper hand in the eyes of discerning patients. An important parallel is to be noted here with the *Yellow Emperor’s Toad Canon* and several Dunhuang manuscripts.<sup>10</sup> In those sources and in Heian Japan, applying moxibustion to the current residence of a body spirit was understood to be dangerous or even fatal, thus correct knowledge about calendrical taboos was deemed critical. Although less dangerous than needling, moxibustion was still seen as a risky modality, albeit one with wide-reaching therapeutic potential if properly harnessed.

The increasing prominence of moxibustion in the healing activities at court through the Heian period was likely a stimulus for its eventual uptake among Buddhist monks of various stripes, who also touted “oral transmissions” and secret techniques. Diaries suggest that some of the first among Buddhist communities to adopt the modality were *hijiri*.<sup>11</sup> These semi-recluse and sometimes peripatetic figures, who were often summoned to court to perform healing for the nobility, are better known for thaumaturgical therapies involving spells, the *nenbutsu* 念仏 (reciting the Buddha’s name), and recitations of the *Lotus Sutra*. They also used moxibustion, as we saw with Iwaya in chapter 5. It is not hard to imagine why *hijiri* would come to include moxibustion in their

repertoire. These monks of the margins were among the least likely to acquire rarefied and expensive herbal medicines and aromatics from the continent that even large monasteries and physicians struggled to acquire. Moxibustion offered a potent modality made from mugwort, a sprawling weed *hijiri* would have found in abundance along the roads of their travels and on the mountains where they carried out their austerities.

It is evident that the adoption of moxibustion by Jimon monks in their Ritual for Expelling Demons was partly a response to these broader trends in the medical culture of the early medieval period, especially the popularity of moxibustion among various competitors in the field of healing. The manuscripts for the Jimon ritual contain many oral transmissions and secret teachings regarding moxibustion, paralleling the esoteric knowledge on body-gods produced by court physicians and novel methods developed by *hijiri*.

At the same time, the adoption of moxibustion by the monks of Onjōji cannot be fully explained with reference to the religio-medical marketplace of early medieval Japan alone.<sup>12</sup> After all, as chapters 1–3 have shown, Jimon monks had a great variety of esoteric healing rituals that were widely seen as effective by their elite patrons, including altar rituals for Senju Kannon and Fudō Myōō. They played a large role in developing the possession rite, in which patrons throughout the Heian period placed considerable confidence when afflicted with spirit disease, the predominant variety of postmortem contagion that preceded corpse-vector disease. There is no obvious reason Jimon monks would look outside their widely respected ritual traditions and adopt techniques that were also being used by their competition. To understand why Jimon monks selected moxibustion, we need to examine two aspects: first, the innovation they brought to the therapeutic design of moxibustion in their ritual, and second, the modality's distinctive material form as a therapy of fire.

## MOXIBUSTION THERAPY REDESIGNED

The moxibustion program outlined in the Ritual for Expelling Demons manuscripts is innovative first for its combination of moxibustion with esoteric ritual techniques. Both manuscripts list eleven named moxibustion points or holes, and since several come in pairs, this makes a total of sixteen loci on the patient's body. These are the points on which the ritualist is to apply moxibustion. Generally speaking, the loci fall in a sequence that begins at the crown of the head (with a point with that name) and ends with points on the soles of the feet. For the first six points, mantras in the form of a series of Siddham characters are given. Instructions indicate that the ritualist is to recite these mantras fifty-seven times as he applies moxibustion to the corresponding point. Further instructions state that the ritualist must recite the "Great Body Spell" while



performing moxibustion and “empower” (*kaji*) the moxibustion points using the “root mudra” of Shōmen Kongō.

To be sure, Jimon monks were not the first to combine moxibustion with ritual techniques such as intoning spells. The second fascicle of the *Ishinpō* already included spells for moxibustion (*kyūji shō* 灸治頌) after its discussion of the body-gods. Culled from the *Yellow Emperor’s Toad Canon*, these spells were addressed to deities such as Heavenly Physician (Ten’i 天医), whose seasonal movements and locations in the body had to be carefully monitored to ensure safe and correct administration of moxibustion. The spells read as petitions to these deities for protection during treatment.<sup>13</sup> Moreover, diary entries on corpse-vector disease (chapter 5) suggest that the holy man Iwaya also used moxibustion and prayers simultaneously. We can speculate that Iwaya’s method was similar to the combination of moxibustion with empowerment prayers Jimon monks prescribed in the Ritual for Expelling Demons.

That said, neither the use of spells in classical medicine nor Iwaya’s healing approaches the complexity of the Jimon moxibustion program. In classical medicine the spells are intoned only prior to treatment, whereas in the Jimon program they are intoned at every step of the treatment and have also been tailored to several specific points, with each receiving its own unique mantra. Although Iwaya’s combination of prayers and moxibustion was no doubt innovative, diary entries suggest his practice was much less comprehensive and systematic than the *goma* ritual into which Jimon monks incorporated moxibustion, which was set in a dense imaginary of efficacy.

The comprehensiveness of the Jimon moxibustion program constitutes a second area of innovation. As noted already, the program involves applying moxibustion to a clearly defined sequence of eleven points and sixteen loci on a patient’s body. It would be difficult to find a moxibustion program known or practiced in early medieval Japan that would have been comparable in scope. Among contemporaneous examples the closest might be the *Moxibustion Method of the Four Flowers and Suffering Gate*, written by Tanba no Nagamoto in 1194. However, the method described in his text, which was used to treat corpse-vector disease and similar afflictions like “bones steaming,” involved just four points on the patient’s back. In fact, it is difficult to locate a moxibustion program of comparable scale in received medical literature from medieval China, with perhaps a few exceptions, such as Ge Hong’s nine points for the treatment of “foot *qi*.”<sup>14</sup> Further afield, manuscripts depicting body charts for moxibustion associated with Tibetan and Chinese medical traditions preserved at Dunhuang do prescribe the application of many points on the body. However, in these works, each point seems to address certain groups of symptoms; these charts do not appear to outline programs to be carried out in full as a sequence against one affliction.<sup>15</sup>

What is also remarkable, and indeed a third area of innovation, is that Jimon monks illustrated their own charts to guide moxibustion application (see figure 8). *Essential Notes* contains two illustrations depicting, respectively, the front and back sides of an unclothed, adult male figure of the Heian period, identified as such by the topknot hairstyle (*sakayaki* 月代). Drawn simply by lines in black ink, the bodies are marked with the majority of the moxibustion points prescribed in the ritual using dots, with textual instructions to help the healer accurately locate points that do not commonly appear in medical literature.

The moxibustion body charts in *Essential Notes* were largely without precedent. Although the charts are predated by illustrations showing the progression of pregnancy in the body of a woman in fascicle 22 of the *Ishinpō*, which includes instructions for acupuncture as well, the illustrations in *Essential Notes* are the earliest in several respects. They are the earliest extant body chart illustrations for a male figure, the earliest to focus on moxibustion specifically, and the earliest produced for a therapeutic program aimed at eliminating a single disease.<sup>16</sup> The only comparable work from the period is, again, the *Moxibustion Method of the Four Flowers and Suffering Gate*, which includes a series of illustrations. However, this work was almost entirely derivative of a method described in Chinese medical literature.<sup>17</sup>

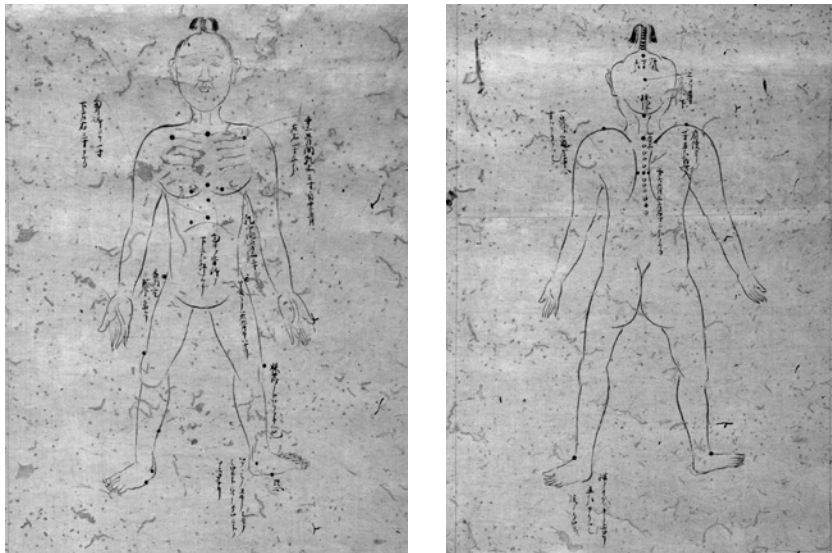


Figure 8. *Denshibyō kanjin shō narabini sōbyō chihō*. Manuscript. Detail of body chart (front and back). Courtesy of the Japanese government (Agency for Cultural Affairs, Bunkachō). Image: TNM Archives.

Additional layers of creativity and innovation can be observed in the specific points selected and curated for this ritual, which Jimon monks gathered from several different textual sources. The list of points as they appear in the ritual manuscripts is as follows, with a brief explanation of where they were to be located.

1. Character-Ten on the Crown (*chōjūji* 頂十字): one point on the crown of the head
2. Wind Gate (*fūmon* 風門): the first bone of the spinal cord on the nape of the neck
3. Platform Mirror, above and below (*dankyō jōge* 亶鏡上下): one *sun* 寸 (approximately one inch) above the *dan* (“platform,” i.e., the space between the breasts) and one *sun* below [two points]
4. Heart (*shinzō* 心臟): less than one *sun* above the navel
5. Cinnabar Field (*tanden* 丹田): two and a half *sun* below the navel
6. Wind Gathering (*fūji* 風市): the middle of each thigh at the point where the arms reach when hanging down [two points]
7. Hō Kyō 彭矯: under the bone that protrudes from the sides of each inner ankle [two points]
8. Back of the Platform (*danhai* 亶背): located behind the *dan* (platform) loci described in 3, on the back
9. Shoulder Well (*kensei* 肩井): the hollow spaces of one’s shoulders [two points]
10. Benevolence (*jin* 仁): the center of the sole of each foot [two points]
11. Back of the Head (*tōhai* 頭背)

As we might expect, some of these points are typical in medical texts focusing on acupuncture-moxibustion practice, including Wind Gate (2), Wind Gathering (6), and Shoulder Well (8), though precise locations differ slightly. The focus on wind in two points is notable. In Chinese medicine, wind was a key pathogenic agent. Early texts in the Yellow Emperor corpus refer to wind as the “origin of the hundred diseases.”<sup>18</sup> Jimon monks probably included these wind-related points because they saw the contraction of corpse-vector disease as being tied to wind. As noted in chapter 6, one passage of *Essential Notes* indicated that the disease followed “wind-fever,” and there was a connection between epilepsy, one of the symptoms of corpse-vector disease, and the pathology of wind-*dian* discussed in esoteric scriptures.<sup>19</sup>

That Jimon monks would have taken points like these from medical literature is hinted at by another passage in *Essential Notes*, which reads: “(You) must use medical books to know (these point locations).”<sup>20</sup> The instruction implies that those who perform the ritual will have reliable access to medical texts at

their temple, Onjōji. There are good reasons to believe that Jimon monks had access to medical literature when creating their moxibustion program. Chapter 4 mentioned that the monks may have acquired a copy of the *Ishinpō* via their ties to the Kujō family. The Kujō family owned other medical texts, including several relevant for moxibustion, as we know from the *Fumon'in kyō ron shō so goroku jusho ra mokuroku* 普門院經論章疏語錄儒書等目錄, a catalog for the library of Fumon'in, a hall belonging to the temple Tōfukuji, a major Rinzai Zen monastery in eastern Kyoto that was originally established by Michiie, Keisei's brother. The catalog primarily includes writings imported from China by Enni Ben'en. The first abbot of Tōfukuji, Enni is best known for his study of Zen lineages under the disciples of Yōsai, but he also received Taimitsu teachings associated with Yōsai's Yōjōryū 葉上流 lineage.<sup>21</sup> Scholars have noted that he studied at Onjōji, where he took the tonsure. If he maintained these ties later into his career, he may have allowed Jimon monks the use of these texts. In any case, Michiie also likely donated works to and could claim some degree of control over the Fumon'in collection.<sup>22</sup> It is not hard to imagine that he would allow Onjōji monks, including his brother Keisei, to make copies.

In terms of moxibustion-related texts, there were two notable works in the library. One is the *Notes on Essential Points* (*Yōketsu shō* 要穴抄), a text undoubtedly prescribing points for moxibustion practice and one that may have been composed in Japan. The existence of the second, *Treatment for the External* (*Gekyō chihō* 外境治方), provides nearly conclusive evidence for the possibility that Jimon monks used the Fumon'in library when designing their moxibustion program.<sup>23</sup> The work is directly cited in *Essential Notes*.<sup>24</sup> This is the only text in which I have seen this work mentioned besides the Fumon'in catalog. Perhaps Jimon monks had access to these medical texts as early as the 1170s or when Keisei copied the ritual manuscripts in the early 1220s. Another possibility is that Keisei's student Rishin, who lived in one of Hosshōji's sub-temples, drew on them in the 1250s.

Other points were selected because of their connection to the pathogenic agents of corpse-vector disease. This is most obvious with the inclusion of the Hō Kyō points (7), an unambiguous reference to the third and lower corpse-worm, who was said to reside in the feet. The therapeutic strategy here is clear: Jimon monks targeted the locations of the disease agents in the patient's body, as was the case with the wind points. Although no other points are explicitly named after the Three Corpse-Worms, the Cinnabar Field (5) may have been chosen according to the same strategy, since in the *Kōshin Scripture* the middle corpse-worm was said to reside in the belly. If that was the case, perhaps the crown of the head (1) was chosen for a similar reason, since the head was home to the upper corpse-worm. More generally, recall that the ritualist was to chant the mantras for each point fifty-seven times while applying moxibustion. The number

fifty-seven derives from the *kōshin* day, the fifty-seventh day of the calendar. Therefore, by applying mantra-infused moxibustion to these points in a numerologically precise way, the ritualist directly engaged the Three Corpse-Worms.

At the same time, when Jimon monks were designing this moxibustion program, they probably had in mind the subtle body as defined by esoteric ritual traditions. This spiritual body-within-the-body was the one Jimon monks frequently engaged with during empowerment rites (*kaji*). We know that their moxibustion treatment doubles as an empowerment program because the healer was to recite mantras at each location. Moreover, the crown of the head, the navel (corresponding to the Cinnabar Field), the two shoulders (corresponding to the Shoulder Well points [9]), and the Heart (point 4) were all points at which esoteric monks routinely directed the powers of empowerment prayers, as we saw in chapter 1. In general, Jimon monks may have been especially interested in points they found across multiple genres of ritual and medical texts, for which multiple registers of efficacy could be imagined. Besides their place in esoteric ritual practice, the Heart (one of the five viscera) and Cinnabar Field figure prominently in medical literature.

This strategy of gathering into a single moxibustion program multiple points with multiple meanings can be seen in the incorporation of body points from the writings of Zhiyi. In his writings, Zhiyi drew extensively on the medical imagination of the body and incorporated it, point by point, into the fold of his discourse on meditation practice. For him, this incorporation of the medical body was aimed at helping his disciples navigate the obstacles of meditation, and as sites on which to contemplate the nature of disease for soteriological advancement. For example, Zhiyi's "contemplating disease" (Ch. *guan binghuan jing* 觀病患境) section of the *Great Calming and Contemplation* mentions *sanri* 三里 (Ch. *sanli*), a frequently cited point in acupuncture-moxibustion practice to which Zhiyi instructs adepts to direct their mind for alleviation of sharp pains during practice.<sup>25</sup>

Zhiyi also discusses several points that Jimon monks incorporated into their moxibustion program, including the Heart, Cinnabar Field, and Shoulder Well. That Jimon monks were learning from Zhiyi is made explicit in *Essential Notes* in a note attached to the instructions for Cinnabar Field, which reads, "The twelve illnesses emerge from the Cinnabar Field." They list those illnesses after the instructions for moxibustion by citing Zhiyi's *Great Cessation and Contemplation*.<sup>26</sup> The passage reads:

The *Great Calming and Contemplation* says: "Rising *qi* that fills the chest (1); pain on the left and right flanks [of the body] (2, 3); cramping of the back (4); illness of the left and right Shoulder Well [points] (5, 6); suffering from vexing heat in the heart (7); inability to drink

or eat (8); descending cold and ascending heat in the heart (9); chill below the navel (10); imbalance of yin and yang (11); weak and sporadic *qi* (12).<sup>27</sup>

Besides the focus on the Cinnabar Field, Zhiyi's focus on the heart and his mention of the Shoulder Well points seem to have been noticed by Jimon monks.

In addition to referring to the writings of Zhiyi when constructing knowledge about the pathogens of corpse-vector disease, Jimon monks also carried his inspiration when designing their moxibustion program. The monks were exploiting Zhiyi's rich writings for multiple purposes and doing so in a highly creative way. They effectively extracted vital body loci Zhiyi discussed in the context of meditation instructions and externalized them as sites for empowerment-boosted moxibustion. All this was to be conducted during an esoteric fire ceremony.

## INCENDIARY CULTURES

In these ways, Jimon monks designed their moxibustion program by hybridizing ritual and medical techniques and notions of the body and disease, thereby allowing them to inscribe multiple layers of efficacy. To understand why the monks incorporated moxibustion into their healing ritual, however, we must consider the materiality of this healing modality. In particular, we must examine how the materiality of moxibustion resonated with the imaginary of efficacy in esoteric Buddhism. As a therapy of fire used to burn the patient's skin directly, moxibustion deeply resonated with the long-standing ritual significance of fire, both in the continental esoteric ritual corpus and the reception of that corpus in early medieval Japan.

### VIRTUAL FIRE: IMAGES OF EFFICACY IN ESOTERIC SCRIPTURES

In the corpus of esoteric ritual scriptures imported to Japan, fire had wide-ranging significance as both ritual material and symbol. It figured prominently in esoteric doctrines, theology, metaphysical thought, ritual theory, aesthetics, and practical ritual procedures. What captivated the compilers of esoteric scriptures was its inherently ambivalent nature: Fire is a uniquely destructive force that, when properly harnessed through ritual actions, can be used to transform self, other, and world. One scripture that concisely articulated the polyvalence and ambivalence surrounding fire in esoteric discourses was the *Secret Method of Reciting the Trisamaya of the Worthy and Holy Acala* (*Dili sanmeiye Budongzun shengzhe niansong bimi fa* 底哩三昧耶不動尊聖者念誦秘密法; hereafter, *Secret Method of Fudō*), which circulated widely among Taimitsu and Shingon

monks in Japan. It outlines some of the basic images and ideas that esoteric monks, including Jimon monks, would have held about fire.

One key passage in the *Secret Method of Fudō* begins by noting that fire has both mundane and transmundane meanings. In the mundane sense, there is first an “outer fire,” the material fire common to all humanity, which “perfects sentient beings and nourishes the ten-thousand things,” through its warmth, cooking, protection, and all the practical uses to which mankind has applied it. In a second mundane sense, Buddhists also speak of “inner fire,” a reference to the manifold afflictions that “scorch” the virtues and merits that sentient beings cultivate, and which thereby bring suffering. Among the most damaging of such “inner fire” afflictions were the Three Poisons (greed, hatred, ignorance). Recall that Jimon monks imagined the Three Poisons in the guises of the body’s Three Corpse-Worms, metapersons who also operated as corrupting forces from the inside, largely by generating karma.

The image conveyed in the *Secret Method of Fudō* of the afflictions as a deleterious inner fire reflects the broader ways that traditional Buddhist ideas about the inner causes of suffering were articulated as a kind of soteriopathology, that is, understanding mental afflictions and the karma they generate in terms of a metaphor of disease. In traditional terms, the cure for such afflictions was nirvana, the allopathic “blowing out” or extinguishing of these vexatious pathogenic flames. For those who failed to do so, more flames awaited them in the hells. But the flames of hell were sometimes interpreted in terms of one’s “inner fire,” rather than as a literal fire of the subterranean prison. In *Essentials of Rebirth*, one of the wardens of hell is said to inform the inmates: “You, hearing the voices from hell, / Are already full of fear in this way. / How much more (fearful will you be when you are) burned in hell, / In the same way that dried kindling and grass are burned. / The fire burns, but it is not (the fire) that burns (you). / It is (your) evil karma that burns (you).”<sup>28</sup>

The *Secret Method of Fudō* goes on to note that superior to the two mundane forms of fire is “supramundane fire,” defined in the scripture as the Great Wisdom Fire. The text likens the superiority of supramundane over mundane fire to the supremacy of the fire ceremony (*goma*) over all other non-Buddhist practices. This is an implicit acknowledgment of the non-Buddhist origins of the fire ceremony, for indeed, Buddhists were aware of its Vedic roots.<sup>29</sup> At the same time, by linking the fire ceremony to the Great Wisdom Fire, it confirms the centrality of the ceremony to esoteric Buddhist ritual practice.

The Great Wisdom Fire is the fire possessed by Fudō, the scripture’s primary deity. Fudō harnesses this Great Wisdom Fire to subjugate the Fire Dragon; to curb heterodox, non-Buddhist practices; and to realize perfect awakening above and save sentient beings below. That is, Fudō uses the great wisdom of bodhi to burn away the habitual energies of the afflictions of sentient beings, their inner

fire.<sup>30</sup> In sum, the passage conveys that through the performance of the fire ceremony and identification with Fudō, ritual adepts can domesticate the innately violent force of fire and—in the manner of “fighting fire with fire”—destroy the pernicious flames that harm sentient beings from within and without. The passage draws attention to the inextricable link between the ritual power of fire and Fudō. Indeed, throughout esoteric scriptures, this wrathful divinity was said to constantly abide in a ball of flames emanating from his body, his “Fire Generating Samādhi” (Kashō zanmai 火生三昧 in medieval Japanese sources). Moreover, as an instantiation of Dainichi Nyorai’s “wisdom fire,” Fudō was seen to be identical with Agni (Katen 火天), the fire god who is ritually installed in the fire ceremony altar as the fire itself. Agni plays a central role in ritual digestion: The god “consumes the offerings and purifies them so that they are acceptable to the deities.”<sup>31</sup>

Because of fire’s pervasive associations with Fudō, the fire ceremony, and transformative power, its image was often used in prescriptive ritual sources to articulate ritual efficacy, especially when the ritual action was imagined to be violent and destructive. For example, images of fire were commonly used to describe the annihilation of the inner afflictions, the eradication of karma, the subjugation of demons, and the conquering of enemies.

One ritual scripture that is shot through with the trope of destruction by flames is the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra*. “This *dhāraṇī* method,” one commonly encountered passage reads, “is like the sun shining on frost, like fire that burns all things.”<sup>32</sup> The obliteration of karmic sins is described similarly: “If [the adept] makes offerings to the buddhas and recites daily, the erasure of karmic crimes will be as fire burning up grass and trees.”<sup>33</sup> Another passage amplifies the image: “If there is a person who sees, hears, and studies this rite and conducts it according to the method, the four grave [offenses] and the five contrary [acts] as well as the sins as numerous as grains of sand in the Ganges will be instantly annihilated, like a ferocious fire that burns up all grasses and trees.”<sup>34</sup>

A Buddhist practitioner reading these passages would have understood such images in terms of ritual efficacy, which is certain from the occasional explicit use of a term with that meaning in these scriptures. For example, another hyperbolic passage reads: “Afterward, the various techniques [described previously] will all obtain efficacious results [Ch. *xiaoyan* 効驗]. For treating illness, [these techniques work as] ferocious flames scorching dry grass; their power is like pouring hot water over snow.”<sup>35</sup> In his study of therapeutic poison in Chinese medicine, Yan Liu has discussed the use of nearly identical images and metaphors in the articulation of efficacy, as in the work of Sun Simiao.<sup>36</sup> In Chinese medicine and esoteric scriptures, such expressions would have enabled readers to visualize therapeutic operations and effects otherwise invisible to the naked eye.



Indeed, on the rare occasions that esoteric ritual scriptures break from their default prescriptive mode and allude to anything we might want to call an effect or a sign of potency, such passages often rely on metaphors of or allusions to fire and its violent yet transformative virtues. Sometimes it is suggested that the ritualist will in some way directly witness these effects. The *Scripture of the Peacock King's Spell* (*Mahāmayūri vidyārājñī sūtra*; Ch. *Kongquewang zhou jing* 孔雀王咒經), which predates the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra* by over a century, includes the following passage: “When the mustard seeds are consumed within the fire, the body of the evil demon will light up in flames. Draw the demon image and whip it with a pomegranate branch; blood will spill from the evil demon’s mouth.”<sup>37</sup> Other passages suggest that the patient will actually feel the heat of ritual power. Among incantatory treatments for demonic possession mentioned in the *Sutra on the Amoghapāśa Dhāraṇī of Avalokiteśvara* (*Bukong juansuo tuoluoni zizai wang zhou zhing* 不空羼索陀羅尼自在王呪), one reads: “Once you finish reciting this spell, the body of the spellcast patient will [feel as] fire burning, and [the demon will be] made to say, ‘I will leave and never come back.’”<sup>38</sup> The burning here is not a symptom of the ailment but a sign by which both patient and healer might confirm the therapy is indeed working as expected—in this case by ritually cauterizing the demon.

These images of fire are frequently juxtaposed in esoteric scriptures with prescriptions for ritual methods that involve actually burning material substances combined with ritual acts like chanting spells or forming mudras. The *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra* often calls for burning mustard, sesame, or poppy seeds or aromatics like *gum guggul*, aloeswood, sandalwood, and many others. Stock phrases used frequently in the scripture instruct the ritualist to perform “one spell, one burn” (Ch. *yi zhou yi shao* 一呪一燒), “for each burn recite the spell” (*geshao songzho* 各燒誦呪), or “one spell, one toss into the fire” 一呪一投於火中. Such passages recall the close fusion of spells and moxibustion in the Ritual for Expelling Demons.

Despite their frequency in esoteric scriptures, the parallels between efficacious image and combusive ritual action have only rarely been noted by scholars. Indeed, such passages are so frequent that they become almost difficult to notice. Commenting on the *Scripture of the Peacock King's Spell* passage, Charles D. Orzech notes, “What is clear is that the ritual relies on an analogy with incineration. Fire burns and consumes, and the acrid burning of mustard seed, by analogy, burns and consumes the bodies of demons.”<sup>39</sup> Orzech also rightly observes that details are otherwise sparse. The analogy by fire we see in these examples are—just as Liu has noted of similar expressions in Chinese medical literature—conventional and formulaic. Such phrases are far from what we might call a theoretical or systematic account of the effects these rites and methods were presumed to have. Yet as it turns out, these compelling images

were not lost on readers. For monks in early medieval Japan, images of fire as a potent expression of ritual power seem to have encouraged the use of fire as a weapon in bouts against other monks, both real and imagined.

#### THE FIRE REALM: A SPELL THAT HEALS AND HARMS

Despite their conventional nature, images of fire and associated ritual techniques described in esoteric ritual scriptures exerted a major shaping force on the imagination of ritual efficacy in early medieval Japan. This becomes obvious when reading Buddhist didactic tales (*setsuwa*). Because the authors of these tales had more freedom and creativity in how they depicted ritual and its effects, they allow us to glimpse how efficacy was imagined in ways not possible with prescriptive texts.

Many tales in medieval Japan spotlight the power of the “Fire Realm Spell” (Kakai shingon 火界呪), a mantra associated with Fudō that became a popular element across tales about ritual healing, including many produced and transmitted by Jimon monks. One monk celebrated in tales for his use of the Fire Realm Spell was Jōzō, an early Tendai monk celebrated for his ritual prowess. The oldest version of Jōzō’s biography appears in *A Gleaning of Tales of Rebirth* (*Shūi ōjōden* 拾遺往生伝). His first and longest story appears in the second fascicle of an extant copy of that collection made by Keisei. Besides performing a Fudō rite to treat the chronic lower back ailment of an imperial princess, one of Jōzō’s therapeutic accomplishments recounted in this hagiography is his use of the Fire Realm Spell to revive a prince four days after his death.<sup>40</sup>

In other tales, authors seeking to make ritual efficacy more tangible for readers used images of fire to make that efficacy literally visible in the world of the tale.<sup>41</sup> In one especially intriguing story from *Tales of Times Now Past*, a warrior is turned invisible when a gang of demons spit on him. Seeking divine assistance, he visits the temple Rokkakudō 六角堂, where a mysterious herdboy urges him to enter a narrow crevice inside the temple. Upon doing so, the man finds himself in a room in an aristocratic mansion, at the center of which a young lady lies in a sickbed. Invisible to everyone in the mansion, the man is encouraged by the herdboy to strike the ailing lady’s body with a mallet; when he does as instructed, the lady’s agony visibly increases. As any medieval reader of this story would easily understand, the herdboy is instructing the man to act exactly as an unseen disease-causing demon might, using a mallet to inflict harm on a human victim. The reader soon learns this is a brilliant tactic, for it puts the invisible man directly in the “line of fire” when a priest enters the mansion to heal the lady. “When the priest recited the Fire Realm Spell of Fudō and performed empowerment over the patient,” the invisible “man’s robes caught fire,” and as the man burned, “he became truly visible again.” Initially confused by

the sudden appearance of the man, the household is soon filled with joy when they realize that the ailing lady has been cured in the same moment. In this tale's depiction of ritual efficacy, the priest's Fire Realm Spell displays the dual power of healing and revealing. The parallel between curing and conjuring into material form recalls the reading of *gen* (efficacy) as *shirushi*, that is, as a sign or demonstration of miraculous unseen operations.

In other stories, the Fire Realm Spell was used not to heal but to harm. In one story from *A Collection of Tales from Uji* (*Uji shūi monogatari* 宇治拾遺物語), a *hijiri* with excessive confidence in his ritual prowess challenges an elderly monk to a duel by using the Fire Realm Spell to ignite the hut in which the older monk sleeps.<sup>42</sup> The tables quickly turn when the older monk reveals his superior proficiency with the spell. "Still sleeping, the [elderly] *hijiri* took hold of his *sanjō* staff, soaked it in fragrant water, and then splashed [the water] in the four directions. No sooner had the fire of the hut extinguish did the [lesser] monk's own robes catch fire." In another tale, a *tengu* from China visits Mt. Hiei to test the powers of Japanese monks. When the Jimon monk Yokei appears, making his way down the mountain from the Thousand Arm Hall, the *tengu* takes cover in the bushes. As to why he hid, the *tengu* says, "As I looked over to make my move, I could no longer see the monk's form, only a blaze of flames burning high above his palanquin. If I got closer, I'd only burn up, so I thought I'll let this one pass and took to hiding."<sup>43</sup>

These tales are structured by the narrative trope of the "efficacy competition" (*gen kurabe* 験競べ). Found in all major *setsuwa* collections, the trope stages contests between monks who deploy thaumaturgical skills against one another, demonstrating—or failing to demonstrate—their potencies through bouts of ritual power. The tales wrap up with lessons conventional to this trope about the perils of arrogance. More than the moral, however, readers would surely have been spellbound by the fireworks of the competition, central to which was the imagination of the Fire Realm Spell. Readers of the second tale learn that when descending Mt. Hiei Yokei was intoning the spell, thereby engulfing himself in a "great fire blazing over his palanquin," a sight that instantly humbled the goblin from abroad. The tale imagines that esoteric masters might use the Fire Realm Spell to generate a literal bubble of flames surrounding them, a personal fire realm of sorts, as the spell's name suggests.<sup>44</sup> The implication is that by chanting the Fire Realm Spell, the master merges with Fudō and thereby conjures the same mandorla of flames for which the latter is famous. To the same degree as Fudō himself, this protective field of fire prophylactically repels meddling entities (mountain goblins not least), allowing the eminent monk—now a human torch—to pass through the mountains unscathed.<sup>45</sup>

The focus on Yokei and the fact that monks like Keisei transmitted such tales leaves little doubt that Jimon monks in the early medieval period would

have been well aware of the efficacy of the Fire Realm Spell for therapeutic, apotropaic, and defensive purposes. At the same time, beyond the pyrotechnic special effects animating these narratives, they would have also known about and perhaps even experienced the real-life confrontations in which material fire played a disturbing role. Indeed, efficacy competition stories allude to and play on actual historical skirmishes that took place between rival monastic factions, in particular between the Jimon and Sanmon branches of the Tendai school. As discussed in chapter 1, after the court appointed Yokei as abbot of Hosshōji in 981, rumors flew that Sanmon monks under Ryōgen were planning to set fire to halls of great importance to the Jimon lineage and its founder, Enchin, on Mt. Hiei. One key target for the planned arson was the Thousand Arm Hall, as this was Enchin's former residence, the library of his sacred works, and the home base of the Jimon lineage on Mt. Hiei. It is no coincidence that the above tale depicts Yokei descending Mt. Hiei from the Thousand Arm Hall.<sup>46</sup> It is also no coincidence that later in the same story, the two other monks the *tengu* challenges are Ryōgen and Jinzen 尋禪 (943–990), major Sanmon monks who were widely seen as the archrivals of Yokei and the Jimon community.

Rumors soon became reality in 993, roughly two years after Yokei's death. Several Jimon monks associated with the Kannon'in desecrated and destroyed personal items that had belonged to Ennin, the patriarch of the Sanmon branch, at the Sekizan Zen'in 赤山禪院. In retaliation, Hyōdai 平代 (dates unknown), a Sanmon monk who resided at Sekizan Zen'in, orchestrated a full-scale attack on the Jimon lineage; his method was arson. Hyōdai and his accomplices burned down some forty halls belonging to the Jimon lineage, including Enchin's Thousand Arm Hall.<sup>47</sup> Jimon monks were forced to vacate Mt. Hiei, the immediate consequences of which were discussed in chapters 1 and 3.

But these were only the inaugural volleys, for the violence and arson continued well into the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, around the time when the Ritual for Expelling Demons was created and transmitted. As Mikael S. Adolphson writes, "During the twelfth century alone, there were six separate occasions of attacks, battles, and arson—occurring in 1121, 1123, 1140, 1142, 1146, and 1163. In the thirteenth century, confrontations are recorded for 1214–1215, when hundreds of buildings were destroyed despite newly erected barricades, and for 1247, 1264, and 1280, with a few attacks also reported for the early fourteenth century."<sup>48</sup> Such attacks by fire were fitting with the reputation of certain factions of Enryakuji monks. Consider commentary on the Great Angen Fire of 1177, which resulted in the deaths of hundreds of people and animals in Heiankyō. "That fire was no ordinary occurrence," says one passage in the *Tale of the Heike* (*Heike monogatari* 平家物語). "Someone had a dream in which two or three thousand big monkeys, each carrying a lighted

pine torch, came down from Mount Hiei to burn the city as a punishment from the Sannō god.”<sup>49</sup>

It was not just the torches of Enryakuji that reduced Onjōji’s sacred halls, icons, and treasures to ashes in this period. The most notorious arson attack on the Jimon community was launched by Taira warriors in 1180. The Taira clan sought to punish the Jimon community for sheltering Prince Mochihito 以仁王 (1151–1180), Go-Shirakawa’s third son. The prince had ordered the Minamoto clan, as well as temples and shrines, to bring down the Taira.<sup>50</sup> Once his plot was discovered, the prince was forced to flee and take refuge at Onjōji, where he was protected for a while, before having to flee again to Byōdōin in Uji, where he was eventually struck down by his pursuers. For their involvement, the Taira sought revenge on Jimon monks. The *Tale of the Heike* details the ruinous “night engagement” on Onjōji,

during which the court’s warriors put the temple to the torch after forcing their way inside in the darkness. Most tragically, the flames consumed the Hongakuin; the Jōkiin; the Shinnyoin; the Kaon’in; the Fugendō; the Daihōin; the Shōryūin; the cloister containing Preceptor Kyōdai’s image; the temple’s main image, that of Maitreya; the square Great Lecture Hall, with its eight bays; the bell tower; the sutra treasury; the Sacramental Water Hall; the guardian shrines; and the New Kumano Shrine. A total of six hundred thirty-seven buildings and pagodas were all transformed into ash in an instant, as were eighteen hundred fifty-three lay persons’ houses in Ōtsu, more than seven thousand scrolls of the Buddhist canon brought back by Chishō [i.e., Enchin], and more than two thousand images.<sup>51</sup>

This storied history of arson attacks on the Jimon monastic community lends an undeniable reality to tales in which monks use the Fire Realm Spell as a ritual weapon to light other monks on fire. In particular, this legacy of monastic violence, intertwined as it was with military violence, provides context for the depiction of Yokei using the Fire Realm Spell to create a force-field of sorts to surround and protect his palanquin; in fact, it was undoubtedly against more than *tengu* tomfoolery that Jimon monks felt they needed to protect themselves when traveling on Mt. Hiei or even at their home temple.<sup>52</sup> Although the brief historical account above suggests that Jimon monks were often on the receiving end of arson attacks, just as they too used the Fire Realm Spell, they seem to have internalized the power of fire, both ritual and real, as a weapon against enemies. This is surely one reason the imagination of fire pervades the Ritual for Expelling Demons. There it is reconfigured as a weapon against the pathogenic enemies that cause corpse-vector disease.

## PYROTECHNIC DESIGN: FIRE IN THE RITUAL FOR EXPELLING DEMONS

The Ritual for Expelling Demons takes fire as its organizing thematic index in several ways. First, images of fire are deployed in the ritual manuscripts to articulate the violent potency of the ritual's techniques. In one section, the healer is told to recite Shōmen Kongō's "Great Body Spell" thirty-seven times while throwing white mustard seeds into the face of the sick patient, whereupon it is said that "the demon body will break and split apart as if consumed by flames."<sup>53</sup> The passage goes on to instruct the healer to use willow or pomegranate tree branches to flog the patient; continuing these methods for three days will cause the "demon to depart and the disease to be cured." Jimon monks drew such techniques from passages in the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra*, where they stand out not just as methods but as vivid expressions of ritual efficacy. As a forceful image, fire is critical in articulating the destruction of disease-demons, tropes that pervaded the *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra*.

In addition to the imagery of efficacy, numerous ritual actions prescribed in the Ritual for Expelling Demons invoke fire in symbolic ways. This is evident in the rite's palette of mudras, mantras, and visualization, the basic building blocks of esoteric ritual. Throughout the performance, the ritualist is instructed to abide in the Fire Generating Samādhi and constantly intone the Fire Realm Spell. Besides the fact that these techniques were associated with Fudō, Jimon monks were probably hoping to incorporate the miraculous effects these techniques were linked to in tale literature. Stories about their therapeutic and defensive use by figures such as Jōzō and Yokei would have been well known to them. Keisei even transcribed such stories himself.

The ritualist is also told to use the "Fifteen Mudras," a set of hand gestures associated with Fudō. Although only a few specific mudras of this set are named in *Essential Notes*, the names that are given betray an attempt to amplify the distinctive efficacy of the rite. For example, the ritual prescribes the "Treating All Demonic Diseases Mudra" (Ryō issai kibyō in 療一切鬼病印) and the "Subjugating Māras Mudra" (Gōbuku ma in 降伏魔印), obvious references to the two types of pathogens Jimon monks linked with corpse-vector disease. Another key mudra draws power from the rite's fiery thematic: the "Flame Wheel Mudra" (Kaenrin in 火焰輪印). Although the liturgical manuscripts lack an illustration for this mudra, a secret transmission in the *Notes on A, Sa, and Ba* provides a useful description of what this mudra signified in the early medieval period: "Take wind to point at the base of flames on the left [hand]. This means to use wind to fan up flames."<sup>54</sup> In the bio-semiotic ritual system of esotericism, in which body parts are encoded with metaphysical significance, the five fingers that form mudra shapes are associated with the five Indian elements (earth,

water, fire, wind, space).<sup>55</sup> In the Flame Wheel Mudra, the pointer finger, representing the element wind, is to touch the base of the middle finger, representing fire. The *Notes on A, Sa, and Ba* suggests that the ritual performer can use the Flame Wheel Mudra to conjure flames with their fingers, a feat of symbolic ritual efficacy that Jimon monks were clearly trying to incorporate into their ritual by prescribing the mudra.

The somatic techniques prescribed in the Ritual for Expelling Demons thus simultaneously evoke fire and Fudō, a common pairing in esoteric rites in early medieval Japan. “This is why,” Bernard Faure has written of this pairing, “in subjugation rituals Fudō is represented inside a triangle, a shape that symbolizes fire.”<sup>56</sup> Michel Strickmann has observed that esoteric priests also created the shape of a triangle during performances of the *goma* ritual by joining the tips of the two ritual ladles, an act that signifies the ontological fusion of deity and priest, enabling the latter to become Fudō in his very body.<sup>57</sup> What has not been noted is that these acts betray an attempt to “become *fire* in this very body,” even if ritualists did not explicitly articulate that goal. In any case, although Jimon monks adopted Shōmen Kongō as the primary deity for the Ritual for Expelling Demons, they also leaned heavily on Fudō imagery and associated techniques precisely because of his close connection with fire, the element adopted as the rite’s central theme.

The Ritual for Expelling Demons also makes use of material fire, and not simply because it was structured as a *goma* ritual. During one part of the rite, the healer was to burn *gum guggul* incense (*ansokukō* 安息香) and fumigate the patient’s nostrils to quell the disease. The direct suffusion into the patient’s body of potent smoke resonates with the direct application of moxibustion, which I examine shortly. Another important sequence in the rite that incorporates material fire and brings together other fire-evoking elements centers around burning effigies. The healer is instructed to make effigies of the “Three Demons” using wheat dough, which are to be boiled in a vat of oil. When boiling the images, the officiant “enters the Fire Generation Samādhi” of Fudō. Thereafter they “abide in the mind of fierce courage and chant the Fire Realm spell of Fudō a hundred and eight times” while they throw the effigies into the fire of the *goma* hearth. From this point, the ritual is to continue for thirty-seven days and nights. If the ritual is efficacious, after thirty-seven days—or another round, if necessary—a miraculous sign will manifest from the flames of the *goma* altar: “The Three Demons will become ash and lose their form, and in the ash will emerge the (Siddham) character A, which will in turn transform into the tranquility of suchness that is the Venerable Immovable Worthy. This is called returning the three evil paths to the immovable suchness of original awakening.”<sup>58</sup>

There are two noteworthy aspects of this fire-laden sequence. First, fire is cast not merely as an image that the healer must visualize in their mind to “see”

the efficacy of the rite; it is also used as an external medium to empirically verify said efficacy. The ritualist verifies efficacy by carefully watching the hearth, waiting for the magical appearance of the Siddham character A in its ashes. This appearance is said to signify the extinction of the disease-causing agents in the “tranquility of suchness” and the “immovable suchness of original awakening,” references to the Mahāyāna notion of absolute reality as fundamentally empty, linked here with Fudō and “original awakening” (*hongaku* 本覺), a core doctrine of medieval Tendai.<sup>59</sup>

This sequence is also noteworthy for how it links images of efficacious fire to an engagement with the rite’s pathogenic metapersons through symbolic violence. The Three Demons—now familiar to us as being homologous with the Three Corpse-Worms and the Three Poisons, afflictive agents of the human “inner fire”—are equated with the “three evil paths” of transmigration (i.e., the realms of the hells, hungry ghosts, and animals). Elsewhere, the *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō* describes the Three Demons in this way: “The first is the Human Demon, which resembles the corpse of an enemy. The second is the Celestial Demon, which assumes the shape of an owl; one name for it is Heavenly Fox, another is Madness Demon. The third is the Earth God, which assumes the shape of the Terrestrial Fox and is also called Mad-Sickness Demon.”<sup>60</sup> Besides the Jimon Ritual for Expelling Demons, these three agents of disease, in the precise forms described here, also figure in the *goma* for the “Six-Syllable Rite” (*Rokujikyō hō* 六字經法) as Benedetta Lomi has shown. In the exorcistic context of that rite and this one, the Three Demons were to be incinerated in the flames of the fire altar.<sup>61</sup> This procedure assimilates fire in two ways simultaneously, combining the material incineration of dough effigies in the fire altar with the symbolic destruction of pathogens in realms unseen. For the doughy raw demons on the receiving end of these ritual actions, “becoming fire in this very body” means something different altogether: They’re cooked.

#### ENACTING SYMBOLIC VIOLENCE

The Ritual for Expelling Demons capitalizes on the symbolic power of fire, and its inherently destructive and violent qualities, toward the goal of enacting symbolic violence. In so doing, it partakes of the aggressive orientation that has long defined esoteric ritual traditions. The esoteric ritual corpus is replete with techniques of forceful expulsion, coercion, intimidation, and downright physical destruction by smashing, stomping, boiling, and burning. Given their aggressive and violent nature, such methods were usually performed symbolically, that is, they were to be performed not on the patient’s body but on surrogate bodies—representations that were physical proxies of the pathogen or meta-personal stunt doubles of the patient. For example, the *Sutra of Dhāraṇīs for*



*Protecting the Nation and the Ruler* (*Shouhu guojiezhzhu tuoluoni jing* 守護國界主陀羅尼經) says that if a patient is possessed by “falling frenzy” or demons and spirits, the ritualist is to draw the shape of the offending demon on the ground where *gum guggul* incense has been burned. The youth medium is then to take a willow or pomegranate branch to whip the form of the demon on places like the chest and back. “Then,” the text notes, “it will be as if [the youth is] beating the body of the sufferer, who will howl, yell, wail, and cry, lowering their head and seeking relief. ‘From now until forever I dare not return again,’ so the master will make the demon vow.”<sup>62</sup>

As this example suggests—and as we already observed in the Ritual for Expelling Demons—symbolic violence enacted through ritual technique is justified by the fact that ritualists understood they were dealing with demons, aggressive and malicious metapersons threatening the lives of sufferers with the violence of disease. In the esoteric ritual corpus, these demonic metapersons were thus sometimes referred to as “enemies” (*onke* 怨家). In Amoghavajra’s translation of the *Recitation Method for Generating Miraculous Effects Through the Venerable Wrathful King Yamāntaka* (*Sheng Yanmandejia weinuwang licheng dashen yan niansong fa* 聖閻曼德迦威怒王立成大神驗念誦法), one prescription instructs the adept to draw the form of the “enemy” in the ash of a triangle altar (representing fire). The adept is to then chant the mantra while driving a *khādhira* wood stake through the image. Then the ritualist is instructed: “Visualize your own body becoming the Venerable Wrathful Yamāntaka [J. Daiitoku Myōō 大威德明王] and stomp the enemy’s heart with your left foot. Chant the mantra one thousand times, stating that person’s name in the phrases of the mantra. The person will thereupon come to ruin.”<sup>63</sup>

Just as the manuscripts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons clearly source the esoteric ritual corpus for specific techniques, they borrow this combative language of “enemies.” When the manuscripts describe the “human demon” of the Three Demons, they use same term for “enemy” as in the above passage, commonly written in Chinese characters as *shatoro* (Ch. *shedulu* 設吐盧 or 設都嚧), a transliteration of the Sanskrit *śatru*. They tailor it to the specific world of their rite, referring to the human demon as “the corpse of an enemy,” a phrase that effectively makes an enemy of the corpse, an unambiguous reference to the rite’s villain, pathogenic corpses. It makes sense that a ritual designed to quell such disease-causing enemies would be a subjugation rite for wrathful deities and rely on aggressive techniques, which included flogging the patient with tree branches and throwing mustard seeds in their face. The focus on eliminating demonic entities also makes the utility of weaponized fire obvious. Fire enables the ritualist to burn these enemies and thus literally witness their eradication, their dissolution into the unseen world, with the hope that the diseases they brought will do likewise.

In considering the role and function of symbolic violence enacted by ritual, it is important to remember that when the Ritual for Expelling Demons was created, virtual violence was often employed to enact real harm. For Jimon monks, the most immediate context for such violence was the continuing conflict with their enemies, monks of the Sanmon branch. Besides burning down Jimon temples, Sanmon monks almost certainly performed esoteric rituals to do much the same thing by drawing on the power of wrathful deities. Although Jimon monks surely launched their own violent rituals, one passage of the *Tale of the Heike* brings home what such rituals probably looked like on Mt. Hiei among Sanmon monks, who also used them to subdue warrior enemies:

Meanwhile, at the Enryakuji, the monks said, “When you come down to it, our worst enemies are Saikō and his sons.” They wrote out the names of the three and placed the paper under the left foot of the Konpira image in the Central Hall group of Twelve Divine Commanders. Then they shouted, yelled, and uttered maledictions. “Ye Twelve Divine Commanders and Seven Thousand Yakshas, take the lives of Saikō and his sons without an instant’s delay,” they implored. It was terrifying merely to hear them.<sup>64</sup>

#### MOXIBUSTION: LITERALIZING THE VIRTUAL EFFICACY OF FIRE

Even as the Ritual for Expelling Demons partakes of and participates in esoteric traditions of symbolic ritual violence, with special attention to fire, it takes a step beyond the horizons of those traditions with an important modification: the incorporation of moxibustion. To understand how moxibustion draws on images of symbolic ritual violence yet also pushes esoteric ritual into uncharted territory, we need to step further into the mind of the medieval Japanese monk. We must try to see how Keihan or Keisei might have viewed the efficacy of violence, the use of fire, and direct ritual engagement with the patient’s body. I consider a few illustrative examples from prescriptive ritual sources and tale literature, two genres that contributed to the imagination of efficacy. Comparing these snapshots of partially analogous ritual scenarios allows us to clarify what makes the adoption of moxibustion in esoteric ritual logical—from a traditional perspective—and yet unusually innovative.

The first example comes from the Dunhuang corpus. Although the Buddhist cave libraries of Dunhuang at the borderlands of west China were quite far from the Japanese archipelago, both places were profoundly shaped by esotericism and its ritual culture. In fact, the Dunhuang ritual for our example was dedicated to Āṭavaka, a deity that Jimon monks identified with Shōmen Kongō. What interests us are the procedures in the Dunhuang rite: The officiant is told

to grasp Āṭavaka's sword and tap it on areas of the patient's body infected with disease, an act understood to kill the underlying demons responsible for the affliction.<sup>65</sup>

This pinpoint targeting of areas of disease through direct touch is an important aspect of applying moxibustion in the Ritual for Expelling Demons. But I begin with a difference: The instructions for the Dunhuang ritual give no suggestion that the ritualist was to use the sword to actually pierce the flesh of the patient. Even so, we can appreciate that such a prescription would not have been entirely inconceivable, for in fact, therapeutic needling was an established healing practice in medieval China, sometimes criticized as dangerous and even lethal. It would thus have been fully in the realm of possibility for the monks who designed this Āṭavaka healing ritual (or those who later received it) to prescribe the literal piercing of the patient's flesh, ritually transforming an ordinary acupuncture needle into Āṭavaka's sword. Yet it is significant that the monks did not make this decision, and presumably they did not do so because they deemed direct piercing to be unnecessary. As with the violent efficacy of countless ritual techniques outlined in the esoteric corpus, invoking Āṭavaka, a deity with great authority in vanquishing disease-causing demons, provides sufficient potency for the ritual therapy in this case. The act remains symbolic, and in that regard differs from applying moxibustion fire in the Jimon ritual, by which the patient's body was to be deliberately harmed using a Chinese medical modality.

The second example would have been closer to home for Jimon monks, for it comes from medieval Japan and pertains to Raigō, the Jimon monk said to have transformed into a vengeful spirit after his petition to establish an ordination platform at Onjōji was rejected due to opposition from Sanmon monks. Although this example comes slightly later in history, it adds another layer to my comparative analysis because it involves a case of ritual healing using the actual fire of the *goma* ceremony and the Fire Realm Spell, two key elements of the Ritual for Expelling Demons. According to the *Collection of Sand and Pebbles* (*Shasekishū* 沙石集, ca. 1283), Raigō was asked to treat Emperor Shirakawa's daughter, who was suffering from a stone-like growth in her abdomen, causing vexatious chills that were driving her mad. "Whether the cause be a curse or an illness," Raigō is said to have replied, "since these are both eliminated with the wisdom fire of the (Siddham) character RA, how could (the lady's illness) not be cured?" Performing a small fire ceremony, Raigō chanted the Fire Realm Spell while empowering the patient, whereupon her abdomen grew warm and the lump in her belly gradually melted, eventually disappearing.<sup>66</sup>

The story suggests that the *goma* fire kindled by Raigō had a very literal one-to-one effect in warming the patient's belly, dissolving the lump that was causing her chills. Unlike the case of Āṭavaka's sword, Raigō does not apply the *goma*

flames directly to her body or her abdomen, the site of her illness. Perhaps the patient was in the vicinity of the ritual hearth and benefited from the warmth of its salubrious flames. Nonetheless, the efficacy of Raigō's ritual, bolstered by the Fire Realm Spell, remains remote; as with any performance of the fire ceremony in Japan, it was effective at a distance, necessitating no direct contact. This differs starkly from moxibustion in the Ritual for Expelling Demons, which was to be directly applied to the patient's body, and more aggressively than Āṭavaka's sword, which only involved touching.

The third example, while still in the imaginative realm of tale literature—Keisei's copy of the *Continued Rebirth Tales of Our Realm* (*Zoku honchō ōjōden* 続本朝往生伝)—brings us to a kind of physical violence that has been absent in the first two cases.<sup>67</sup> In this story, a *tengu* confesses that he is making a man ill by stepping on his chest. As with the Āṭavaka rite, illness is imagined to be located in a particular place in the body. Moreover, in the same way that esoteric monks attacked demons by stepping on their effigies and images of demons, so can demons and creatures like *tengu* create disease in victims by doing much the same. According to the story, the archbishop Henjō 遍照 (816–890) was summoned, whereupon he ritually conjured many Dharma Protectors, suggesting he was performing some form of the possession rite. The Dharma Protectors do what is only logical to treat the man's affliction: They grab the menacing *tengu* and throw it straight into the flames of the *goma* fire.

Alongside the earlier two examples, this story brings into relief what was innovative about the incorporation of moxibustion in the esoteric ritual. As we might imagine, Jimon monks were not going to toss their ailing aristocratic patients into the ritual fire, as the Dharma Protectors did the *tengu*, even if the disease was deeply entangled with their physical bodies. In any case, that would not be necessary, for two reasons. First, Jimon monks could use moxibustion to bring the flames of the *goma* fire to the patient's body, thereby bringing the patient into direct contact with the violent efficacy inscribed in the *goma* fire. Second, moxibustion would allow them to enact this therapeutic violence in a more targeted fashion. Like the demonic diseases that localized on the chest, in the abdomen, and at various sites on the body, corpse-vector disease was caused by pathogens that were hiding out, as it were, in "holes" spread over the body. In the Ritual for Expelling Demons, the healer was to apply moxibustion directly to those holes, hence in the *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō* we read: "For the above [application of moxibustion], you should use the aforementioned root mudra [of Shōmen Kongō] to empower the moxibustion points. These [points] to which you apply moxa are those places where the Cat Demon and the Tokeira Demon hinder and harm."<sup>68</sup> This statement suggests that all the holes prescribed in the ritual text as points for moxibustion are also the locations of demonic infestation and thus sites for allopathic therapeutic action.

The moxibustion method was also designed to target other pathogens of corpse-vector disease, namely, the Three Corpse-Worms, those entities identified as the Three Demons, made into effigies, and burned in the *goma* fire. A pair of holes on the feet takes its name directly from one of the corpse-worms: Hō Kyō. On this point, Jimon monks warned: “If you do not apply moxibustion to the [Hō] Kyō hole, the bottom of the person’s foot will collapse, forming a hole that resembles [the hollow stalk of] bamboo.”<sup>69</sup> Another point, the Cinnabar Field, was probably imagined as another location to target the corpse-worms, since the *Kōshin Scripture* indicates that is where the middle corpse-worm resides. Although less definitive, moxibustion applied to the crown of the head point may have been a way to target the upper corpse-worm. This application of moxibustion fire to target disease-causing demons recalls another story written by Keisei in *A Companion in Solitude*: When a man-eating demon is holed up at an old temple, the villagers deliberately set fire to the temple to smoke it out. The intentional and demonifugic arson in this story differs little from the use of fire as a weapon against disease-demons in the body, but now Jimon monks have refined it with the precision afforded by moxibustion.

Having surveyed analogous examples from the esoteric ritual tradition and the imagination of efficacy in medieval Japan, we are now in a better position to grasp why Jimon monks adopted moxibustion for their healing program. If fire was the organizing thematic index of the rite, then moxibustion, as a form of fire therapy, offered a medium for citing the virtual fire of the esoteric ritual imaginary in a felicitous but novel way. The logic of sympathetic magic applies here, according to which, in the words of Marcel Mauss, “each object contains, in its entirety, the essential principle of the species of which it forms a part.” This logic suggests that “every flame contains fire, any bone from a dead body contains death, in just the same way as a single hair is thought to contain a man’s life force.”<sup>70</sup> Incorporated into an esoteric *goma* ritual, moxibustion becomes an “alloform” (alternative shape) of the fire that constitutes the very heart of the *goma*. Moxibustion’s adoption in this rich semiotic context necessarily gathers to it, by an aesthetic-symbolic immediacy and the magic of sympathetic association, the multidimensional significance that fire possessed in the esoteric ritual imaginary.

To be sure, Mauss’s generalized logic of sympathetic magic would apply equally to other alloforms of fire in the ritual. The visualization of fire in the Fire Generating Samādhi, its evocation in speech through the Fire Realm Spell, and the mimesis of its shape with the fingers of the Flame Wheel Mudra all work according to the logic of synecdoche (part standing for whole). In fact, however, what moxibustion offers in this ritual context is not fully replicatable by any of these traditional ritual means of enacting fire. Moxibustion is simply a better and more precise synecdoche for efficacious esoteric flames. For one thing, it

constitutes a material fire in the form of burning mugwort tinder. Thus, like the fire of the *goma* hearth, moxibustion is not merely symbolic. Yet in contrast to the flames of the altar, the fire of moxibustion is not a static fixture at the spatial center of the ritual scene; instead, it is a portable form of fire that can be brought to and applied on the physical body of the patient, thereby scorching their flesh. Moxibustion thus constituted a material medium by which Jimon monks could literalize the virtual efficacy of fire in the esoteric imaginary and bring that fire to the body of the afflicted person.

From a therapeutic standpoint, what necessitated the direct application of moxibustion on the body was, I suggest, the thorny nature of corpse-vector disease. If the affliction were caused by spirits, as in the case of *jake*, priests could transfer the pathogenic spirit from the body of the patient to the body of the medium with the possession rite (chapters 2 and 3). But as chapter 6 discussed, for Jimon monks, the pathogenic metapersons of corpse-vector disease do not simply possess the victim temporarily; they are ontologically and agentially intertwined with their body and person, resulting in chronic somatic disease that warps their behavior and leads to karma accumulation. Therefore, the treatment of corpse-vector disease would appear to require no less than the subjugation of disease-demons on the very sites at which they infect the patient's body. In the same way that moxibustion literalizes the virtual efficacy of fire, it enables the healer to translate the violent subjugation of disease-demons from the symbolic realm to the physical.

## HEALING AND HARMING, SKILLED INJURY AND SUBJUGATION

Having established that Jimon monks adopted moxibustion into the Ritual for Expelling Demons with the aim of translating the efficacy of symbolic violence into a material therapy, I return to the specificity of moxibustion. In particular, the foregoing analysis proceeded from an assumption that as yet I have left unexplored: that the application of moxibustion indeed constituted a kind of therapeutic violence. Is "violent" an appropriate way to describe the effects of this healing modality? After all, it cannot be denied that healers in the medieval period performed moxibustion not to harm their patients but rather to heal them. As I demonstrate below, moxibustion was seen as painful and injurious, even potentially dangerously so. Even in therapeutic contexts, its harm was imagined as part and parcel of its healing.

### THE VIOLENCE OF MOXIBUSTION

When considering the question of whether moxibustion was historically seen as a violent technique, it is helpful to consider a major difference in its

application between now and then. Unlike the indirect application of moxibustion that has become popular in Japan today, in which a moxibustion cigar is held at a distance from the body to warm it, or the patient's body is protected from direct heat by a slice of ginger or other material, moxibustion in medieval Japan (and China) was most often a direct application, meaning that cones of mugwort tinder would be attached to and burned down to the skin. Numerous sources from China and Japan capture the voice of pain that attended this kind of direct therapy. That pain is virtually audible in *Moxibustion Painting* (*Jiuai tu* 灸艾図), a Song period work by Li Tang 李唐 (ca. 1050–1130).<sup>71</sup> In the painting, two people restrain a patient by holding his arms while the doctor performs moxibustion on two locations on the patient's back, causing the patient to cry out (see figure 9). In medieval Japan, one story tells of how Retired Emperor Toba had to be comforted with stories of unrelated topics to distract him from the searing heat of moxibustion therapy.<sup>72</sup>

Pain was not a mere side effect of moxibustion; for practitioners, it was integral to the practice. Even before applying moxibustion, the presence of



Figure 9. *Moxibustion Painting*, attributed to Li Tang (ca. 1050–1130). Courtesy of National Palace Museum, Taiwan.

pain served as a guide by which the healer learned the correct position of an application point on the body. This is the idea behind Sun Simiao's famous "ah! points," named after the instinctual exclamation patients make when healers press them.<sup>73</sup> Moreover, the intensity of the flames of the moxa cone was important. A moxa cone should ideally produce a sound like it was yelling or "running," a kind of hissing noise that likely mirrored the sound many patients would have made while undergoing treatment. In his *Discussions on Medical Matters* (*Idanshō* 医談抄, ca. 1284), Koremune Tomotoshi went so far as to claim that was a "sign" the disease would be successfully treated.<sup>74</sup> This is why in the *Moxibustion Painting* the doctor appears to be deliberately fanning the moxa embers, despite the patient's nearly unbearable pain; increasing the heat, doctors knew, amplified the efficacy.

In fact, fanning moxa embers to raise their temperature was just one strategy healers used to obtain a key therapeutic component of moxibustion practice: to intentionally create sores and scarring on the patient's body. Moxa sores often had a distinctive and gruesome appearance. In *Notes of a Simple Physician*, Kajiware Shōzen compared moxa burns to the sores produced by a type of *rai* disease, highlighting the fact that therapeutic wounds were not so different in appearance from the severest pathological ones.<sup>75</sup> Therapeutic logic guided this component of moxibustion practice as well. Knowingly created and then carefully observed, moxa sores and scarring provided the healer with important information about the illness, the condition of the patient's overall health, and the efficacy of the treatment.<sup>76</sup> Sometimes healers sought to keep their patient's moxa sores suppurative by repeatedly applying moxa on the same point over many days, a practice dating back to at least Sun Simiao.<sup>77</sup> *Hijiri* in early medieval Japan, who adopted moxibustion practice, such as the monk Shinjakubō 心寂房 (d. 1231), closely investigated the sores of their aristocratic patients to make sure the treatment was working.<sup>78</sup> Koremune Tomotoshi addressed the diagnostic significance of moxa sores under a separate header in *Discussions on Medical Matters*, titled "On the Chaotic Moxa Sores." "If moxa sores are not chaotic [i.e., producing sores]," he wrote, "the illness will not be cured. This is because [the patient's] *qi* and blood are in decline."<sup>79</sup>

But the violence of moxibustion was not always intended, visible, or therapeutic. In aristocratic society in early medieval Japan, moxibustion was sometimes understood to cause defilement (*kegaré*). Chapter 5 discussed issues related to the defilement of death, but another source of defilement was fire. In some sources, moxibustion was named explicitly as a cause. One passage of the *Exegesis of the Nakatomi Purification* glosses the phrase "cutting living flesh" this way: "Wounding people. Healing by burning *moxa* leaves."<sup>80</sup> A significant number of diary entries reveal that noble patients were "relieved" of court duties after undergoing treatment.<sup>81</sup> That this was primarily an issue of



impurity and not simply related to the fatigue caused by the treatment can be discerned from comparable occasions when courtiers like Kanezane canceled visits to shrines for prayers immediately after receiving moxibustion.<sup>82</sup> Although courtiers sought earnestly to visit shrines to have their prayers heard (an outing surely more motivating than conducting duties at court), many suspected that the *kami*, who abhorred defilement, would not appreciate a visitor with fresh and suppurative sores.

Courtiers nevertheless continued to raise the question, since they relied extensively on moxibustion treatment. Konoe Iezane 近衛家実 (1179–1243), for example, wrote about the need to investigate past records to determine whether one must avoid attending the yearly festival rite at the Kamo shrine while undergoing a course of moxibustion.<sup>83</sup> Yoshida Kenkō 吉田兼好 (1283–1350) entered the debate in *Tsurezuregusa* 徒然草. “Recently,” Kenkō wrote, “people say that too many moxa sores render one defiled (and thus unfit) for *kami* rites. There is no mention of this in the old laws and regulations.”<sup>84</sup> Such taboos sometimes extended to Buddhist rites, with some courtiers not attending Buddhist sutra lectures or canceling sutra copying after undergoing moxibustion.<sup>85</sup>

Even Buddhist communities with otherwise radical stances on conventional notions such as purity and pollution avoidance were implicated by these taboos. Hōnen 法然 (1133–1212), the monk later revered as the founder of the Jōdo (Pure Land) school, was once asked by a disciple if pilgrimage to a sacred place following moxibustion treatment would violate a taboo and if one had to discard the robes that would have been sullied from the treatment. In his characteristically radical fashion, Hōnen denied these widespread beliefs; that the question was posed at all, however, is significant. It is evident that moxibustion was valued among his devotees, some of whom were obviously more concerned with the defiling and thus potentially dangerous aspects of moxibustion than he was, even as they hoped this effective treatment would not need to be sacrificed.<sup>86</sup>

Among Buddhist healers, the violence of moxibustion was addressed most stridently by Yōsai in his *Record of Nourishing Life by Drinking Tea*. Yōsai promoted his own preferred substances, namely, tea and mulberry.<sup>87</sup> Part of his strategy was to highlight the disadvantages of other medicines and modalities. Yōsai wrote disparagingly about moxibustion, emphasizing its unique iatrogenic dangers. Performed without proper harmony between treatment and diagnosis, he argued, moxibustion invites unnecessary injury and even loss of life. Used on the wrong disorder, he insists, moxibustion can even induce in patients “fire-poisoning” (*kadoku* 火毒), an iatrogenic affliction he mentions many times throughout the work.

Yōsai was not alone in calling attention to moxibustion’s risks. The topic was also addressed by the physician Tomotoshi in *Discussions on Medical Matters*. In a passage on the importance of determining the number of moxa cones

to be used, Tomotoshi substantiates Yōsai's admonishments with a quote from the *Taisu* 太素, a major work in the Yellow Emperor corpus. "Poisonous fire" introduced into the body from applying an excessive number of moxa cones, the passage warns, creates in the patient a new illness, the "malady of evil fire," causing the bones to wither and the channels to fester with pus.<sup>88</sup> Whereas awareness of such risks led Yōsai to largely discourage readers from using moxibustion at all—and instead drink tea and use mulberry—Tomotoshi maintained that moxibustion was a therapeutic tool used by any physician worth his salt.

I would be remiss to not add one very different context in which moxibustion may have been used precisely because of its connection to violence, particularly its capacity to symbolize fire-induced violence and cause a pain that was socially acceptable to most throughout history. This is the use of moxibustion to burn the crown of the head or the forearm during ordination rituals in China, a practice that survived until contemporary times. As James Benn has shown, ordination burning belonged to a constellation of practices for "burning the body" (Ch. *shaoshen* 燒身), which included "autocremation of the living body, through the burning off or branding of limbs, and the burning off of fingers."<sup>89</sup> These inherently violent applications of fire to the body were seen to constitute merit-making offerings to the Buddha. They drew symbolic authority from the famous episode in the *Lotus Sutra* of the Medicine King's self-immolation for the Buddha. Thus, when apocryphal scriptures composed in China like the eighth-century *Shoulengyan jing* 首楞嚴經 prescribe "burning incense on the body," Benn speculates, "it is to the indigenous Chinese practice of moxibustion that it refers, albeit perhaps indirectly." The reason, he suggests, is that moxibustion has the capacity to scar the body, but its pain is tolerable.<sup>90</sup> The unique suitability of moxibustion for symbolizing extreme fire-mediated forms of violence that Benn highlights adds credibility to the possibility we are developing here, that Jimon monks did much the same in a different context and for different reasons.

#### RITUAL EXPERIMENTS WITH EFFICACY

In navigating the discourse of moxibustion's contested violence in early medieval Japan, Jimon monks were grappling with a problem that physicians of classical medicine likewise sought to negotiate: how to capitalize on the unique virtues of healing modalities and medicines whose efficacy is potentially destructive. As noted in the capsule history of moxibustion at the start of this chapter, physicians often abandoned acupuncture because its therapeutic efficacy could not be adequately balanced with its life-threatening risks; according to physicians like Wang Tao, this modality had the power to kill but not revive. Physicians were also constantly negotiating the balance of healing and harming in their

use of medicines for ingestion, an issue that can be seen most vividly in the case of poison medicines (*doku* 毒; Ch. *du*). Liu has shown that materials such as aconite, mercury, realgar, and others occupied a venerable place in classical *materia medica* traditions in medieval China. Liu points out a close parallel between medicinal poisons and the Greek notion of *pharmakon*, which refers dually to a poison and a remedy.<sup>91</sup> Japanese physicians were also aware of this ambivalence. In his *Discussions on Medical Matters*, Koremune Tomotoshi calls for the careful prescription of medicines, for as he warns, even remedies can become poisons, depending on the disposition of the patient.<sup>92</sup> At the same time, powerful and dangerous medicines were especially useful, Liu points out, to “fight poison with poison,” to wage therapeutic battle against demons, witch animals, *gu*-poisoning, and pathological vermin.<sup>93</sup> As we have seen in the classical tradition and medieval Japan, moxibustion—the origins of which probably lie in the expulsion of demonic agents—can surely be counted alongside acupuncture and poisons as therapies with potentially harmful potency.<sup>94</sup>

Just as doctors in medieval China sought to balance the harmful effects of these powerful medicines with their benefits, Jimon monks were seeking to do the same with moxibustion in the Ritual for Expelling Demons. Indeed, one advantage of moxibustion is that its application can be controlled. Skilled healers can intentionally minimize deleterious side effects. First, rather than prescribe the indiscriminate application of fire to the body, Jimon monks focused the application of moxibustion on sixteen specific points. As noted, moreover, that application was targeted specifically to the holes in which the pathogenic demons resided and other vital points well established in classical moxibustion practice—that is, where moxibustion would be most efficacious and least unnecessarily unharmed.

Second, Jimon monks sought to limit the potential harm of moxibustion—perhaps specifically the issue of “fire poison” highlighted by Yōsai—by caring for the body of the patient after treatment. In the ritual, they prescribe washing the points on which moxibustion has been applied with a fragrant liquid mixture brewed with agarwood, sandalwood, *heisō* 蒨草 grass (effective against the Three Corpse-Worms), and branches from willow and pomegranate trees. It is evident that Jimon monks did not see this washing of moxibustion sores as peripheral. The liturgy notes that this cleaning will likewise contribute to eradicating corpse-vector disease. It is also noteworthy that the materials in this cleansing brew were therapeutic implements in other parts of the rite, often in aggressive sequences like flogging the patient. In this direct fashion, Jimon monks sought to translate the ritual methods for harming into effective forms of bodily care for the moxa-scorched patient, thus heightening the rite’s efficacy.

It is also important to recall who Jimon monks had in mind as the patients of their ritual: aristocratic and imperial individuals such as Nijō,

Tadako, and Moriko, and members of the Kujō family. If such patients were to sponsor this rite, their consent to undergo the therapeutic procedures would have been essential. Without a compelling reason or logic, direct violence on a noble body in a ritual practice meant to heal would no doubt have been deemed unacceptable. From this perspective, moxibustion offered a distinctively advantageous option for translating the symbolic violence of esoteric ritual efficacy. Aristocratic patients had long accepted the healing/harming trade-offs specific to moxibustion. Its potential harms, including pain and sores, were socially tolerable—and stories could always be told to distract from the pain, diligent care provided to burns, and deities invoked to empower bodies weakened by both disease and strong treatment. In medieval Japan, moxibustion was a form of therapeutic injury with unmatched social currency, and this made it an unusually appropriate choice for a healing ritual against demons.

As Elaine Scarry has argued, the pain of others is notoriously silent. “Though indisputably real to the sufferer,” she writes, “it is, unless accompanied by visible body damage or a disease label, unreal to others.”<sup>95</sup> Scarry’s reflections on the ways that pain resists objectification focus on acts of torture, but her insights unexpectedly pertain to what we might initially presume to be the opposite of hurt and harm as well: healing. Even in the writings left throughout history by healers, in which we might expect the sufferer’s pains to occupy a prominent position, those experiences tend to be anesthetized or neglected entirely. The same must be said of ritual scriptures of esoteric Buddhism, which was the raw material for creating new healing rituals in medieval Japan. These prescriptive sources center the perspective of the ritualist-healer, who in many cases performed the healing ritual at an altar at a significant distance from the patient. Overall, their patient’s anguish mattered little for the therapeutic process. In chapter 2, we saw how the possession rite reduced that distance to some extent, with esoteric monks making house calls at the mansions of ailing aristocrats. Yet in the possession rite as well, which zoomed in on interactions between the priest and the spirit via a medium, the patient continued to be marginalized, left alone in her own isolated quarters.

Omitting the element of pain, a somatic experience intertwined with meanings that are always culturally and historically situated, ignores the significant ways the patient’s perception can shape the healing program as a physical performance, one typically occurring in a series of therapeutic acts. It is not hard to imagine how, for patients in medieval Japan who were routinely and ritually ignored, the irreducible pain from therapeutic procedures might have conceivably translated into a positive sign, a palpable indication that the unseen operations of ritual therapy were working on them.

As we have seen throughout this book, making ritual efficacy visible in the form of signs (*gen/shirushi*) was critical for ritual design in early medieval Japan. By writing moxibustion into an esoteric rite, the Jimon compilers were effectively re-encoding the experience of their patient's pain with an imagination of therapeutic harm. What made such controlled harm necessary were the demons of corpse-vector disease, entities that Jimon monks argued were ontologically entangled with the patient's body. In this way, the ritual subjugation of demons—no longer a symbolic or abstract affair, nor a performance from which the patient is removed—became a healing experience the patient actually and acutely feels. In the Ritual for Expelling Demons, moxibustion makes possible, for perhaps the first time in esoteric ritual healing in early medieval Japan, an acceptable performance of ritual violence directly on noble bodies. In crafting this innovative ritual design, Jimon monks kindled new therapeutic life into the marvelously protean and destructive element of fire so central to esoteric traditions of ritual healing.

## Epilogue



ON A HOT SUMMER DAY IN KYOTO—THE SITE OF JAPAN’S OLD CAPITAL, Heiankyō—I took a break from writing this book and headed east on foot to go see a *goma* fire ceremony. My destination was Kongōji 金剛寺, a small Tendai temple in the shadow of the Yasaka Pagoda, a busy intersection of tourists flowing up from Gion and down from Kiyomizudera. One of the three famous *kōshin* sites in the city, the temple is better known as the Yasaka Kōshindō 八坂庚申堂. As on every *kōshin* day (the date is listed on the temple’s website), the abbot, Okumura Shin’ei 奥村真永 (b. 1959) was to perform a fire ceremony, which he also conducts in the morning and the evening. A large flock of domestic and international tourists (Japan had just reopened its doors after the COVID-19 pandemic) dipped in and out of the temple grounds to take photos in front of the colorful acrobatic monkey dolls (*kukuri-zaru*). Inside the temple hall, a smaller crowd, mostly of residents from the neighborhood, join the abbot and his attendants in chanting the praise of the *kōshin* deity, Shōmen Kongō. The short paper liturgy we received on entering reveals that Shōmen Kongō vows to conquer the *māras* and diseases that afflict us as individuals and, on a much grander scale, to protect the nation. After the abbot empowered us with spells and a thump on the back with his metal *vajra*, we circumambulated the hall to make personal prayers before the busy array of icons installed on the altar, including such dignitaries as Fudō Myōō and Prince Shōtoku. Shōmen Kongō’s icon remains hidden; it is displayed once every sixty years. The rite concluded with an apotropaic snack: three squares of *konyaku*, to be eaten in silence while facing north—another strategy to mitigate the harms of the Three Corpse-Worms.

After the rite ended, I walked twenty or so minutes in the auspicious direction toward which I had just eaten my *konyaku*, passing through Maruyama Park and by the gates of Chion’in 知恩院, then under the line of towering camphor trees that adorn the outer wall of Shōren’in. After climbing up a formidable set of stairs just beyond Awata Shrine 粟田神社, I arrived at the Sonshōin 尊勝院, another Tendai temple, this one affiliated with Shōren’in, which it

overlooks. Through a wooden lattice window, I watched a nun perform a ritual much like the one I had just seen: a fire ceremony dedicated to Shōmen Kongō, performed on the occasion of the *kōshin* day.

At that point I considered taking the Keihan train to Osaka to see a similar rite at the Kōshindō of Shitennōji 四天王寺, which I have seen before. Shitennōji claims to be the oldest *kōshin* hall (*kōshindō* 庚申堂) in Japan.<sup>1</sup> Knowing I had another opportunity on the next *kōshin*, I decided instead to walk across the Sanjō bridge over the Kamo River and stop by Kichūdō 其中堂, an old shop on Teramachi Street specializing in Buddhist books. There, I bought a square accordion book (*orihon* 折本) of much relevance for that day's corpse-worm-inspired festivities: a recently published liturgy for a *goma* ritual dedicated to Shōmen Kongō.

When the COVID-19 pandemic began to take shape in early 2020, just as I started drafting the chapters of this book, Buddhist monks of all stripes and affiliations began revisiting the pages of their liturgical texts that addressed healing and disease elimination. They soon began increasing their offering of rites to heal ailing individuals and to eradicate the novel disease. Haneda Shukai 羽田守快 (b. 1957), a Tendai monk active in Kanagawa, published the liturgy I bought that summer day. He hoped to inspire other monks—Taimitsu and Tōmitsu alike—to take up the Shōmen Kongō ritual against COVID-19. In the preface he encourages readers, presumably other monks and nuns, to add it to their own “medicine cabinet” and forgive his use of the Tendai-specific readings that pervade his liturgical text, recommending that they modify and tweak the procedures as they see fit. As it happens, Haneda belongs to the Jimon lineage, the community that first promoted Shōmen Kongō in twelfth-century Japan.<sup>2</sup> Whereas the Jimon ritual was created to treat a rather small and elite audience—the Heian aristocracy—Haneda was reminding Shōmen Kongō of his pre-*kōshin* origins as a wrathful conqueror of novel diseases and asking him for divine assistance against a pandemic operating on a global scale.

I want to reiterate a point I made at the beginning of this book: Strictly speaking, we do not know if Jimon monks performed the Ritual for Expelling Demons. There currently exist no historical records—whether an entry in a courtier's diary or a note in a Buddhist liturgical anthology—indicating that Jimon monks of the twelfth or thirteenth centuries actually performed the rite to treat ailing patients. That said, just as they performed the possession rite and altar rituals for healing and subjugation with great frequency, it seems reasonable to assume that they would have also performed this ritual, and the innovative features of it would have undoubtedly impressed their clients.

In any case, it would be a mistake to assume that just because no account of its performance exists that the Ritual for Expelling Demons was entirely untethered from historical reality and practice. Indeed, as we have also observed

throughout this book, the ritual was a creative response to an unsettling crisis particular to its time and place—the emergence of corpse-vector disease, a novel variant of postmortem contagion, in aristocratic society. Moreover, it directly and innovatively engaged with ideas and practices of considerable currency for that moment. Jimon monks deliberately designed the rite to engage with the cult of *kōshin* and ideas about the Three Corpse-Worms, with new anxieties about those irritants of the Buddhist immune system known as *māras* and with the increasingly popular therapeutic modality of moxibustion. We observed how its creation was interwoven with the ritual signature Jimon monks forged as therapeutic ghostbusters, in which guise they successfully treated elite patrons for centuries. The ritual reflected an imaginary of violence rooted in and animated by the conflicts Jimon monks had with their “enemies” in Tendai, the Sanmon branch on Mt. Hiei, a conflict that sometimes spilled over into ritualized violence and violent pyrotechnics. The Ritual for Expelling Demons may have been virtual, a ceremony performed only in the minds of Jimon monks, but it telescopes the therapeutic lifeworld of early medieval Japan in vivid ways that other surviving evidence does not.

There is yet another way to gauge the palpable historical impact of the Ritual for Expelling Demons, one I have reflected on while walking around postpandemic Kyoto and writing this epilogue: the lasting reverberations of ritual immunity generated by this ritual and inscribed into its manuscripts, defensive and therapeutic memories that were handed down to future generations who likewise engaged in experiments with the ritual eradication of demonic pathogens and disease. My experiences that summer day in Kyoto, the places I visited (and those I did not), the liturgy I bought in the bookstore—all reflect the astonishing durability of the unusual ritual Jimon monks designed in the late twelfth century.

Historical threads can be traced from Yasaka Kōshindō and Sonshōin back to the Jimon ritual. Legend claims that Yasaka Kōshindō was founded in the tenth century by Jōzō. Celebrated retrospectively as Japan’s first *genza*, Jōzō was also the first (according to legend) to establish the cult of Shōmen Kongō as a declaration of war against the Three Corpse-Worms.<sup>3</sup> As this book has demonstrated, it was in fact Jimon monks of the twelfth century who first linked Shōmen Kongō to the corpse-worms. In fact, Yasaka Kōshindō was probably established in the Edo period as a branch temple of Shitennōji, where esoteric rites for Shōmen Kongō involving the Three Corpse-Worms had long existed, perhaps as early as the Kamakura period.<sup>4</sup>

In the twelfth century, the abbacy of Shitennōji (*bettō* 別当) fluctuated between Sanmon and Jimon priests, just as the abbacy of Hosshōji had two centuries before.<sup>5</sup> An imperial decree by Retired Emperor Toba gave some lasting authority of the temple to the Jimon branch. The tables turned again in



1180, when Kiyomori awarded abbacy to a Sanmon monk, reigniting conflict between the Tendai siblings. The position was officially returned to Jimon monks in 1189 by Go-Shirakawa, an emperor who was a devoted patron of Onjōji monks and their ritual healing (see chapter 1). The twists and turns of Shitennōji's administration matter because the position of abbot during this period came to be held by none other than Keihan, the monk who initially compiled the manuscripts of the Ritual for Expelling Demons.<sup>6</sup> Keihan may have brought those manuscripts to Shitennōji and established the rite there. Lingering questions remain, but in light of these facts, it makes good sense that Yasaka Kōshindō, originally a branch temple of Shitennōji, would develop a *kōshin* cult focused on eradicating the Three Corpse-Worms through a fire ceremony centered on Shōmen Kongō.

As it happens, the Yasaka Kōshindō offers a ritualized form of moxibustion in which roughly processed moxa is burned on a clay bowl (*suribachi* すり鉢) recipients place on the top of their head. At Yasaka Kōshindō, this is done to eliminate headaches (*zutsū yoke* 頭痛除け), much like the “willow branch empowerment” rite offered at Sanjūsangendō. Given the ties between Onjōji monks involved with the Ritual for Expelling Demons and Shitennōji, this moxibustion rite may have distant connections to the program that Jimon monks developed to treat corpse-vector disease. In fact, many temples in Japan today continue to offer annual rituals that involve therapeutic applications of moxibustion to the bodies (and often the heads) of lay participants, a phenomenon we do not see elsewhere in East Asia, such as in China and Korea, where moxibustion and Buddhism are otherwise known and practiced. (Ordination burning, while morphologically identical, differs in function, for it is not therapeutic.) In Japan many of these rituals are popularly associated with Kūkai, a cultural hero with countless legendary accomplishments, but the systematic incorporation of moxibustion into Buddhist ritual healing in Japan really began, as we have seen, at Onjōji. Although it would be impossible to precisely trace the genealogies of every popular form of Buddhist-inflected ritual moxibustion back to the Ritual for Expelling Demons—for other Buddhist lineages no doubt created their own versions, to say nothing of countless popular variants—it would be difficult to deny the contribution of the Jimon ritual to crystallizing that compelling combination in premodern Japan.

What then of Sonshōin, the other temple I visited? The *kōshin* day ritual performed at Sonshōin today is a much more recent development. According to Okumura, the abbot of the Yasaka Kōshindō, it was he who transmitted the rite to the nun at Sonshōin. By coincidence, the ties run much deeper if we extend the story to Shōren'in, the temple that presently manages the Sonshōin. Here, too, we must return to the history of Shitennōji. In 1249, Enryakuji monks petitioned again for the abbacy of Shitennōji, which they were awarded in 1269.

Those Enryakuji monks belonged specifically to Shōren'in, the Tendai temple affiliated with the Anō lineage of the Sanmon branch.

The mid- to late thirteenth century was a crucial turning point for the survival of the manuscripts for the Ritual for Expelling Demons. As I mentioned earlier, *Essential Notes* likely survives in the hand of Jimon monk Rishin. The best and earliest editions of the liturgy, the *Ritual of Shōmen Kongō*, however, were copied by Anō lineage monks who would have been affiliated with Shōren'in, especially Chōgō and his student Gyōhen. Unsurprisingly, two manuscripts of the liturgy are preserved in the Kissuizō library of Shōren'in, while the key edition used in this book, a manuscript copied and transmitted by Anō monks, survives in the Ōsu Bunko library of Shinpukuji, a temple in Nagoya, Aichi prefecture.

Anō lineage monks would go on to suggest that they did not receive the liturgy from Jimon monks but that their teacher Chōgō received a direct transmission of the Ritual for Expelling Demons from the god of Hiyoshi Shrine.<sup>7</sup> This may have authorized what they did next: remix the content of the Jimon manuscripts and create new versions of the rite. The manuscripts of these remixed versions survive in substantial numbers in various libraries: The *Denshibyō kanjin shō* 伝屍病肝心鈔, largely a digest of the original Jimon liturgy and *Essential Notes*, is now held at the Kyōu Shooku library. A similar manuscript, the *Ōsu Shinpukuji shozō koshichū shō ijisha shōsha* 大須真福寺所蔵故紙中涉医事者抄写, which at some point was transmitted to Shinpukuji (as the title suggests), is now held at the Fujikawa Bunko library at Kyoto University. An identical manuscript, the *Denshi chihō hihō* 伝屍治法秘法, made its way to Taiwan, perhaps during Japan's colonial occupation (1895–1945); it remains at the National Palace Museum in Taipei.

The creativity of Anō monks did not stop with remixes. Eventually, they produced a highly original illustrated scroll known as *On the Types of Corpse-Vector Disease* (*Denshibyō shu no koto*), which we briefly mentioned in chapter 6. Incredibly, the work survives in two editions: a collection of eight unbound and insect-damaged sheets at Shinpukuji, and a complete and pristine scroll held in storage at the Okayama Prefectural Museum, originally preserved at the temple Kinzanji 金山寺. Between passages of rearranged and altered quotations largely taken from the Jimon manuscripts, the scroll presents for the first time illustrations of the “five heavenly *māra* demons” (*goshu tenmaki* 五種天魔鬼). Besides the fact that these illustrations give face and form to the multiple pathogens of corpse-vector disease in ways inspired by and going beyond earlier Jimon descriptions, they are especially striking because they depict the demonic pathogens in the act of attacking a victim, lying supine on the ground. The illustrations also double as therapeutic prescriptions, since the victim's body is labeled with points that correspond to the moxibustion loci prescribed in the original Jimon ritual texts.

The Anō elaboration of five demonic pathogens went on to inspire a work rather different from the earlier materials: the *Twenty-Five Methods for Corpse-Vector Disease* (*Denshibyō nijūgo hō* 伝屍病二十五法).<sup>8</sup> Three editions of this work survive, with two attested in multiple manuscripts. One edition was incorporated by Kōshū into his fourteenth-century *Collection of Leaves Gathered by Storms in the Valley*.<sup>9</sup> A student of Chōgō, Kōshū received considerable ritual teachings from the Anō lineage, to which he belonged. One manuscript of his edition of *Twenty-Five Methods* was transmitted to Shinpukuji, where other Anō manuscripts on corpse-vector disease were preserved.<sup>10</sup> Given Kōshū's interest in gods and demons, it is unsurprising that his edition emphasizes the demonological aspect of the disease, and he specifically plays up the connection to the five disease demons described in *On the Types of Corpse-Vector Disease*. This demonological aspect is dialed down in another edition, composed by a rather obscure Shingon monk named Gahō 我宝 (b. 1300?) in Sanuki (today's Kagawa prefecture) in 1334. A third edition survives in a later text, *Jivaka's Scripture on the Five Viscera* (*Giba gozōkyō* 耆婆五臟經).<sup>11</sup>

More generally, the Ritual for Expelling Demons may have set in motion a broader shift in the imagination of postmortem contagion and the perceived physicality of pathogens, especially those that, like the Three Corpse-Worms, reside and do harm in the body. To be sure, diseases caused by spirits (*jake*)—the evil dead we encountered in chapters 2 and 3—continued to afflict the living during the Kamakura, Nanbokuchō, and Muromachi periods.<sup>12</sup> Across diaries, however, the number of recorded cases of spirit disease began to decrease significantly after the late Heian and early Kamakura periods, right around the time Jimon monks produced and transmitted the Ritual for Expelling Demons.

Thereafter and throughout the medieval era and into the early modern period, a wide range of Buddhist monks, physicians, monk-physicians, and specialists in moxibustion and acupuncture became energetically preoccupied with the curious disease caused by the material dead and diseases of the same category or caused by similar pathogens. One major development was the increased attention these practitioners showed to afflictions caused by abdominal worms (*mushi*), a category of parasitical creatures related to the Three Corpse-Worms and other pathogenic agents closely linked to corpse-vector disease in Chinese medicine. The medical concern with internal pathogens was paralleled by a sustained focus on visualizing the human body from the inside, in particular, with patterns of correlation linking the five viscera to other body parts, diseases, the body of buddhas, and cosmic elements—a discourse belonging to the system of correlative thought known as the “mandala of the five viscera” (*gozō mandara* 五藏曼荼羅).<sup>13</sup> Moreover, these practitioners prescribed a wide array of therapies and medicines, but moxibustion arguably holds a place of prominence in many of the manuscripts they composed. One illustrative work

of this trend, which is clearly situated in the larger constellation of pathological and therapeutic themes inspired by the Ritual for Expelling Demons, is *Jivaka's Scripture on the Five Viscera*. That this work incorporates the *Twenty-Five Methods* demonstrates that this newer, internally focused trend was rooted in early medieval discourse on corpse-vector disease that Jimon monks helped initiate.

Thus, whereas corpse-vector disease was largely unheard of in 1165—when it afflicted and perhaps killed Go-Shirakawa's first son—by circa 1284, physician Koremune Tomotoshi was pairing the affliction with *rai*, a highly visible and notorious physical condition, calling both “diseases of death.”<sup>14</sup> Scholars have long considered *rai* the paradigmatic disease of Japan's medieval period. It may be time, however, to reexamine medieval medical history through the lens of postmortem contagion. The monumental shift from diseases caused by spirits to diseases caused by corpses, and from immaterial disease agents to indwelling pathogens of the flesh, may have been kindled by the same healers who pioneered therapeutic ghostbusting to begin with—monks of the Jimon lineage at Onjōji. The pyrotechnical prowess of Jimon monks, by which they successfully transformed moxibustion into one of the most innovative modalities in the therapeutic toolbox of esoteric ritual in Japan, may have been the spark that ignited the robust moxibustion culture that prevailed throughout the medieval and early modern periods, the embers of which continue to burn today in the form of popular rituals at temples like Yasaka Kōshindō. The elucidation of this historical shift—the transition from the Jimon ritual against corpse-vector disease to the later appearance of novel healing programs against new mutations of postmortem contagion, along with the question of how these changes reflect broader transformations to notions of ritual and therapeutic efficacy—will define future directions for the study of Buddhism and medicine in premodern Japan.

## NOTES



### Introduction

1. *Sankaiki*, Angen 1 (1175), 8/16, 27:72.
2. In this book, “early medieval” connotes the late Heian and early Kamakura periods, that is, approximately the late tenth through the mid-thirteenth centuries. I follow the rationale outlined in Stone, *Right Thoughts* (24–25), which focuses on roughly the same timeframe.
3. Farris, “Diseases of the Premodern Period in Japan,” 376–382.
4. Also known as the Final Age (*masse* 末世) or Final Generation (*matsudai* 末代).
5. Stone, “Seeking Enlightenment (Part I)”;
6. Stone, “Seeking Enlightenment (Part II)”;
7. Marra, “The Development of *Mappō* Thought (I)”;
8. Marra, “The Development of *Mappō* Thought (II).” On the determination of the 1052 date, see Yiengpruksawan, “Countdown to 1051.”
9. *Dabei jing*, T 12, 380: 972b5–927b10.
10. Zürcher, “‘Prince Moonlight,’” 38. These details come from the *Puxian pusa shuo zhengming jing* 普賢菩薩說証明經 (T 85, 2879). Similar descriptions are found in the *Foshuo famiejing jing* 仏說法滅尽經 (T 12, 396); on this apocryphal scripture, see Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 58–62. A group of four apocalyptic sutras, including those mentioned here, is discussed in Hughes, *Worldly Saviors*, 26–43.
11. Yiengpruksawan, “Countdown to 1051,” 376.
12. Mori, *Honzōgaku kenkyū*, 355.
13. *Denryaku*, Kashō 1 (1106), 1/23, 2:123.
14. Needham, *China and the Origins of Immunology*, 1.
15. Needham, *China and the Origins of Immunology*, 28.
16. Relevant works by the scholars mentioned include Esposito, *Bíos and Immunitas*; Haraway, “The Biopolitics of Postmodern Bodies”; Derrida, *Acts of Religion*; Sloterdijk, *You Must Change Your Life*; Brown, *Immunitary Life*; Martin, *Flexible Bodies*.
17. Sloterdijk, *You Must Change Your Life*, 8.
18. Sloterdijk, *You Must Change Your Life*, 10.
19. *Chūyūki*, Shōtoku 2 (1098), 10/30, DNK 4:89.

17. *Chüyūki*, Kahō 2 (1095), 5/27, DNK 2:224.
18. Sharf, “Thinking Through Shingon Ritual,” 57.
19. Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 59; Sørensen, “The Apocrypha and Esoteric Buddhism in China.” See also Goble, *Chinese Esoteric Buddhism*.
20. Mahāyāna sutras, from which the esoteric scriptures originated, were replete with ritual techniques like *dhāraṇī* for which grand claims of efficacy were also made; see Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 103–106. Yet scriptures of the esoteric corpus, which are largely prescriptive and focused squarely on ritual practices, arguably amplified the therapeutic potential of these techniques even more than had been the case earlier. As Abé notes, “despite the broad efficacy claimed for them in a number of Mahāyāna texts, the *dhāraṇīs* in the exoteric sūtras can be understood essentially as appendages to the sutras’ main body of text,” helping the reader to read, understand, and memorize the text, whereas esoteric *dhāraṇīs*, are not “merely supplementary devices” but key elements of ritual action focused on non-hermeneutic aims outside engaging with the text (*The Weaving of Mantra*, 166–167).
21. Abé, *The Weaving of Mantra*, 161. He cites the *Amoghapāśa Avalokiteśvara Dhāraṇī Sutra* (*Bukong juansuo tuoluoni zizai wang zhou jing* 不空羂索陀羅尼自在王呪經, T 20, 1097). In this sense, esoteric ritual scriptures fit snugly in Buddhist texts organized by the metaphors of occult healing, in Pierce Salguero’s framework, which do not seek to explain disease, therapy, or efficacy but simply claim the diseases will be “instantaneously ‘treated’ (*zhi*), ‘healed’ (*liao*), ‘cured’ (*yu*), ‘purified’ (*jing*), ‘expelled’ (*chu*), ‘cast out’ (*tuo*), or ‘removed’ (*li*); see Salguero, *Translating Buddhist Medicine*, 90.
22. *Chu yiqie jibing tuoluoni jing*, T 21, 1323: 489c20–489c24; translation from Salguero, “Healing Dhāraṇīs,” 297.
23. Strathern, *Unearthly Powers*, 219–254.
24. Salguero, *Translating Buddhist Medicine*, 60–66.
25. The foundational study on the healing activities of *onmyōji* is Shigeta, *Onmyōji to kizoku shakai*.
26. On the *hijiri*, see Gorai, *Kōya hijiri*, and Kleine, “Hermits and Ascetics.”
27. Drott, “Gods, Buddhas, Organs,” 258–266; Triplett, *Buddhism and Medicine*, 134–150. This topic is discussed in several chapters in Salguero and Macomber, *Buddhist Healing in Medieval China and Japan*.
28. For the Ninnaji manuscripts of the *Ishinpō*, see *Ishinpō* (1b).
29. Mori, *Honzōgaku kenkyū*, 476; Benn, *Tea in China*, 145–171; Macomber, “Milk-ing the Bodhi Tree.”
30. See the brief but informative summary of this issue and relevant studies in Payne, “Introduction,” 11–12.
31. Harley, “Rhetoric and the Social Construction of Sickness and Healing.”
32. Kleine (“Buddhist Monks as Healers,” 29–33) suggests that from the mid-Heian period the perception of a healer’s *gen* was a function of their “charisma,” a shift from the “office” charisma that dominated in earlier periods when the state retained

- its authority. Although charisma (both personal and clerical) certainly played a role in how patrons perceived the therapeutic efficacy of their healers, the perception was cyclically engendered—a charismatic healer was one who demonstrated their efficacy—and could be dissolved when the healer failed in their demonstration.
33. The meanings of these characters as I have them in parentheses draw from the *Zen'yaku kanjikai*: “chō” (503), “shō” (1305), “kō” (184).
  34. Tokunaga, “Shugendō seiritsu,” 100.
  35. For a few examples, see *Genji monogatari*, SNKBZ 24:316, 323, 324; *Eiga monogatari*, SNKBZ 31:34, 41, 44, 157; *Uji shūi monogatari* SNKBZ 50:210, 232, 254.
  36. Chimoto, *Genki bungaku no kenkyū*. I thank Michael Jamentz for introducing me to Chimoto Hideshi at the Nara National Museum in 2023.
  37. Esposito, *Immunitas*, 2.
  38. Haraway, “The Biopolitics of Postmodern Bodies,” 204.
  39. Sloterdijk, *You Must Change Your Life*, 8.
  40. Strathern, *Unearthly Powers*, 4.
  41. Tomes, *The Gospel of Germs*, 7.
  42. Strathern, *Unearthly Powers*, 4.
  43. Luhmann, *How God Becomes Real*, 30.
  44. Johnson, *God Is Watching You*, 122–126.
  45. Johnson, *God Is Watching You*, 124.
  46. McBride, “Esoteric Buddhism and Its Relation to Healing and Demonology.”
  47. Faure, *Rage and Ravage*, 5–6.
  48. Latour, *Reassembling the Social*, 50–51.
  49. Lynteris and Evans, “Introduction,” 2.
  50. On this issue, see Macomber, “Disease, Defilement, and the Dead.”
  51. Bernstein, *Modern Passings*, 78.
  52. Rogaski, *Hygienic Modernity*, 160.
  53. Although Hattori discusses “corpse-vector disease,” he operates under the assumption that it was simply an imported disease category from Chinese medicine; see Hattori, *Heian jidai igakushi*, 175–180.
  54. Corpse-vector disease has primarily been discussed in the context of broader studies of medical history in premodern Japan, with only a handful of works addressing its incorporation into Buddhist ritual; see Hattori, *Heian jidai*, 175–180; Shinmura, *Nihon iryō shakaishi*, 203–205; Goble, *Confluences of Medicine*, 77–84; Minobe et al., ‘Hara no mushi,’ 287–324; Shinmura, *Nihon bukkyō no iryōshi*, 47–58. The earliest mention of the Jimon Ritual for Expelling Demons in English was probably Kohn, “Kōshin: A Taoist Cult in Japan,” followed by Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine* (294–295, n136), in a note written by Strickmann and added by the editor. For a capsule study of the ritual, see Macomber, “Ritualizing Moxibustion.”
  55. I refer to the Jimon community as a whole as the “Jimon lineage” or the “Jimon branch” (of Tendai), but it should be noted that many sublineages emerged therein.
  56. Groner, *Saichō*, 30.

57. Tachi, *Onjōji Kōin no kenkyū*; Matsumoto, “Onjōji-bon ‘Hōhiki’”; Kim, *Shinra Myōjin*; Drott, *Buddhism and the Transformation of Old Age*, 74–95; see also Dolce, “Taimitsu.”
58. I predict the situation is going to change significantly in the near future. New discoveries of manuscripts have been made at Onjōji in recent years, which scholars have only begun to process. See the essays by Watanabe Mariko, Tomabechi Seichi, Ishii Yukio, and Nakagawa Jinki in *Setsuwa bungaku kenkyū*, vol. 56 (2021).
59. Nakagawa, “Onjōji-zō ‘Jimon hokke taikai kanrei,’” 71.
60. I am inspired in this approach by Eubanks, *Miracles of Book and Body* (see 90–96).

### Chapter 1: Ritual Healing in the Jimon Lineage

1. *Gonki*, Chōtoku 4 (998), 7/16, 1:86–87. Compare this story with the oneiric surgical removal of organs for therapeutic purposes in the biography of Zhu Fayi, in Campamy, *Signs from the Unseen Realm*, 132.
2. Latour, *Reassembling the Social*, 27–42.
3. In this section I rely extensively on Groner, *Ryōgen and Mount Hiei*, and McMullin, “The Sanmon-Jimon Schism.”
4. Kūkai also made the case that the efficacy of Mahāyāna scriptures and rituals was likewise more convincingly articulated through the language of esoteric scriptures; Abé, *The Weaving of Mantra*, 271.
5. Groner, *Ryōgen and Mount Hiei*, 32.
6. Tōkyō Kokuritsu Hakubutsukan, Kyōto Kokuritsu Hakubutsukan, and Nagoya-shi Hakubutsukan, *Miidera hihōten*, 139.
7. Groner, *Ryōgen and Mount Hiei*, 39.
8. Groner, *Ryōgen and Mount Hiei*, 40.
9. Groner, *Ryōgen and Mount Hiei*, 67.
10. Groner, *Ryōgen and Mount Hiei*, 34.
11. Groner, *Ryōgen and Mount Hiei*, 221.
12. Tōkyō Kokuritsu Hakubutsukan, Kyōto Kokuritsu Hakubutsukan, and Nagoya-shi Hakubutsukan, *Miidera hihōten*, 40, 139–140.
13. *Onjōji denki*, DNBZ 127:68–69; *Jimon denki horoku*, DNBZ 127:311.
14. *Onjōji denki*, DNBZ 127:67.
15. *Jimon denki horoku*, DNBZ 127:325.
16. Dolce, “Taimitsu Rituals,” 337.
17. On esoteric rituals used for safe childbirth, see Andreeva, “Empowering the Pregnancy Sash”; Lomi, “Ox Bezoars”; Gunji, “Taira no Tokushi’s Birth of Emperor Antoku.” For translations of key texts, see Andreeva, “Childbirth in Early Medieval Japan” and Lomi, “The Ox-Bezoar Empowerment.”
18. Brown, *Immunitary Life*, 4.
19. On the important role of early Tendai monks in this office, see Hongō, “Naigubu jūzenji no seiritsu to Tendai-shū.”



20. On Enchin's relationship to this role, see Oyamada, "Naigubu jūzenji-shoku to Enchin."
21. Groner, *Ryōgen and Mount Hiei*, 87; Suzuki, *Medicine Master Buddha*, 109.
22. *Kokuho Miidera-ten*, 35; Abe, *Chūsei Nihon no shūkyō tekusuto taikei*, 201–204.
23. Morris, *The Pillow Book*, 1:131, 2:105.
24. Hori, "Gojisō to tennō," 387, 396–397.
25. One monk who often performed body protection for patrons was Kanju; see *Gonki*, Chōtoku 4 (998), 7/5, 1:80, and Chōhō 2 (1000), 12/16, 2:67–68.
26. Payne, "From Vedic India to Buddhist Japan," 1044.
27. Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 237, 272.
28. Faure, *The Fluid Pantheon*, 117.
29. For a detailed survey on how these functions were fulfilled by the Five Wisdom Kings and Fudō, see Mack, "The Function and Context of Fudō Imagery," 168–247.
30. *Asabashō*, DNBZ 59:89; Tomishima, "Godaidō no keitai henka," 53.
31. Tomishima, "Godaidō no keitai henka," 67–68.
32. Groner, *Ryōgen and Mount Hiei*, 89.
33. *Asabashō*, DNBZ 59:92; Hayami, *Heian kizoku shakai to bukkyō*, 89.
34. *Enchin washō den*, 55.
35. *Enchin washō den*, 57–58. See also Mack, "The Function and Context of Fudō Imagery," 263–264.
36. Mack, "The Function and Context of Fudō Imagery," 44–45.
37. *Onjōji denki*, DNBZ 127:55. See also Mack, "The Function and Context of Fudō Imagery," 267–269.
38. *Asabashō*, DNBZ 59:92.
39. On Yokei *setsuwa*, see Sonobe, "Yokei setsuwa no shiten kara."
40. *Konjaku monogatari shū*, SNKBT 36:228–231; see also Dykstra, *Buddhist Tales*, 503–504.
41. *Onjōji denki*, DNBZ 127:67.
42. In documentary sources, the Five Altar Rite is sometimes referred to only as the Fudō rite; see *Shōyūki*, Jian 1 (1021), 3/7, 6:19.
43. *Shōyūki*, Tengen 5, 3/21, 1:25.
44. *Uji shūi monogatari*, SNKBZ 50:369–370.
45. *Genkō shakusho* 1: 240–241; see also the *Jimon denki horoku*, DNBZ 127: 324.
46. *Konjaku monogatari shū*, SNKBZ 36:221–226; English translation in Dykstra, *Buddhist Tales*, 499–502.
47. *Shōyūki*, Jian 1 (1021), 3/7, 6:19.
48. ten Grotenhuis, *Japanese Mandalas*, 53–57; Winfield, "The Mandala as Metropolis."
49. For example, in 1001, the top monks from eminent monasteries were positioned around the gates surrounding Heiankyō and ordered to chant sutras. This included important Jimon monks such as Kanju, Shōsan, and Bokusan; see *Gonki*, Chōhō 3 (1001), 5/29, 2:111–112.

50. *Asabashō*, DNBZ 59:92.
51. *Sakeiki*, Chōwa 5 (1016), 6/18, 6:26.
52. *Shōyūki*, Jian 2 (1022), 6/4, 6:113. The location was the Ippon-goshodokoro — 本御書所, the library where (theoretically) one copy of every book circulating in the Heian period was stored.
53. Besides Shin'yo, the Jimon monks were Eien 永円 (dates unknown), Myōson 明尊 (971–1063), and Seigi 齊祇 (dates unknown); the lone Sanmon monk was Jin'en 尋円 (dates unknown), a disciple of Ryōgen; see *Dai Nihon shiryō*, 2, 23:119; *Asabashō*, DNBZ 59:92. On the rituals for Go-Ichijō's birth, see Bowring, *The Diary of Lady Murasaki*, 3–4.
54. *Dai Nihon shiryō*, 2, 23:119.
55. *Shōyūki*, Manju 3 (1026), intercalary 5/29, 7:177.
56. *Midō kanpakuki*, Chōwa 1 (1012), 4/28, 2:151–152.
57. *Midō kanpakuki*, Kankō 3 (1006), 10/25, 1:196; see also Tomishima, "Godaidō no keitai henka," 81; Hiraoka, "Fujiwara-shi no ujidera to Tendai-shū."
58. On this icon, see Soejima, "Dōjuin mokuzō Fudō Myōō zō." I thank Daniel Borengasser for introducing me to this icon and sharing relevant research.
59. Kyōto Kokuritsu Hakubutsukan, *Fujiwara Michinaga*, 264.
60. *Shōyūki*, Kannin 2 (1018), intercalary 4/19, 5:22–23.
61. *Midō kanpakuki*, Kannin 2 (1018), intercalary 4/16–17, 3:160.
62. *Sakeiki*, Kannin 4 (1020), 8/6, 6:103.
63. *Hōhiki*, 7:110–114.
64. On this work, see Matsumoto, "Chūgū gosan to mikkyō"; Matsumoto, "Onjō-ji-bon 'Hōhiki'"; Dolce, "Taimitsu."
65. On this bodhisattva in connection to healing practices, specifically vision restoration, see Triplett, "Esoteric Buddhist Eye-Healing Rituals in Japan."
66. *Asabashō*, DNBZ 58:244.
67. Abé, *The Weaving of Mantra*, 108.
68. Full titles for this and other Senju Kannon sutras are provided below.
69. Abé, *The Weaving of Mantra*, 151–152; see also Lowe, *Ritualized Writing*, 128–129, and Hayami, *Heian kizoku shakai to bukkō*, 5–6.
70. Wong, "The Art of *Avataṃsaka* Buddhism," 252–253.
71. Miyazaki, "Tenpyō hōji ninen."
72. Triplett, *Buddhism and Medicine*, 103–105; Triplett, "Esoteric Buddhist Eye-Healing Rituals in Japan," 487–489.
73. *Nihon ryōiki*, SNKBZ 10:275–277.
74. Suzuki, *Medicine Master Buddha*, 75.
75. For an image of the icon, see Onjōji no Butsuzō Hensan Iinkai, *Onjōji no butsuzō*, 2:187.
76. *Jimon denki horoku*, DNBZ 127:236.
77. Onjōji no Butsuzō Hensan Iinkai, *Onjōji no butsuzō*, 2:188. For example, see *Onjōji denki*, DNBZ 127:42.
78. *Onjōji denki*, DNBZ 127:65.

79. *Jimon denki horoku*, DNBZ 127:122–123.
80. *Onjōji monjo*, 1:176, 178.
81. *Chishō Daishi zenshū*, 3:1111; for additional comments by Enchin on the Senju Kannon scriptures, see *Senju giki hiki* 千手儀軌批記, *Chishō Daishi zenshū*, 3:1284.
82. *Onjōji denki*, DNBZ 127:105.
83. *Jimon denki horoku*, DNBZ 127:200.
84. Onjōji no Butsuzō Hensan Iinkai, *Onjōji no butsuzō*, 2:124–125.
85. In 1015, the “withering and wasting” Minamoto no Yorisada 源頼定 (977–1020) went into reclusion at Onjōji to receive healing rites; *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 7/30, 4:63. For other visits to Onjōji, see *Gonki*, Chōhō 2 (1000), 12/23, 2:73, Chōhō 3 (1001), 2/4, 2:86, and Chōhō 3 (1001), 2/14, 2:89.
86. *Shōyūki*, Chōhō 1 (999), 8/28, 2:58.
87. *Shōyūki*, Chōhō 1 (999), 11/6, 2:70.
88. *Fusō ryakki*, KT 6:752; *Jimon denki horoku*, DNBZ 127:328; *Onjōji denki*, DNBZ 127:67, 105. See also Fowler, *Accounts and Images of Six Kannon*, 18–20.
89. *Gonki*, Chōhō 2 (1000), 3/13, 1:190.
90. *Gonki*, Chōhō 2 (1000), 3/16, 1:191.
91. *Gonki*, Chōhō 2 (1000), 4/5, 1:193.
92. *Gonki*, Chōhō 2 (1000), 4/8, 1:196–197.
93. The year Senshi established Gedatsuji is unknown; see *Fusō ryakki*, Chōhō 4 (1002), 7/21, 6:761–762.
94. *Hōhiki*, 188.
95. T 20:1059.
96. I viewed this manuscript at Shōren’in on February 2, 2023. See the entry in the Kissuizō catalog, Kissuizō Shōgyō Chōsadan, *Shōren’in Monzeki Kissuizō shōgyō mokuroku*, 122.
97. On Hōjūjidono, see Takahashi, *Inseiki no dairi, daidairi to ingosho*, 144–241.
98. Nakamae, “Sanjūsangendō sōken setsuwa,” 79.
99. *Kokawadera engi*, 57–58; Matsumoto, “Go-Shirakawa-in no shinkō sekai.”
100. Yiengpruksawan, “The Visual Ideology of Buddhist Sculpture,” 72.
101. Fujikawa, *Nihon shippeishi*, 36, 179.
102. Matsumoto, “Go-Shirakawa-in no shinkō sekai,” 115.
103. This information appears in Goshirawa’s vow text for the hall in the *Kokawadera engi* (discussed below). The modern editors of the *engi* identify the officiating monk (*dōshi* 導師) for the ritual as Genkaku 賢覚 (1080–1156), a Shingon monk who was active at Daigoji 醍醐寺; by the time of the consecration at Shōsenjudō in 1176, Genkaku had been dead for twenty years. Given the connections between Kokawadera, Go-Shirakawa, and Jimon monks, Kenkaku is a more likely candidate. I thank Michael Jamentz for information about Kenkaku.
104. This appears in the founding origin for Kokawadera, discussed later; see *Kokawadera engi*, 57–58.

105. Fujikawa, *Nihon shippeishi*, 36.
106. Shinmura, *Nihon iryō shakaishi no kenkyū*, 216.
107. Como, “Horses, Dragons, and Disease in Nara Japan.”
108. A similar passage in the *Sutra on the Dhāraṇī to Eliminate All Illnesses* reads: “I, with my Buddha-eye, can see all the obstacles facing other people, gods, demons, Brahmas, renunciates, and Brahmins.” T 21, 1323:489c; translation from Salguero, “Healing Dhāraṇīs,” 297.
109. T 20, 1060:108c17–108c18.
110. T 20, 1057:86c28–87a6.
111. *Asabashō*, DNBZ 58:231–235. On these topics, see Hayami, *Kannon shrinkō*, 303–323.
112. This is mentioned in *Anshōji chōchō shiki* 安祥寺牒張私記; see Ueda, *Shingon mikkyō jisō gaisetsu*, 1:118–120.
113. T 20, 1065:122b27.
114. *Hōhiki*, 7:187.
115. *Hōhiki*, 7:215–216.
116. The *Tenpōrinshō* is a collection of liturgical texts compiled by Chōken 澄憲 (1126–1203) and his son Shōkaku 聖覚 (1167–1235).
117. Ryūmyō also accompanied Shirakawa on a memorable pilgrimage to Kinpusen 金峰山 in 1092; see Blair, *Real and Imagined*, 196–197.
118. Yamamoto, “‘Kokawadera engi emaki’ to kyōsetsu,” 479–482.
119. Moerman, *Localizing Paradise*, 139–140, 144.
120. Tokunaga, “Shugendō seiritsu.”
121. Tokunaga, “Kumano sanzan kengyō,” 76; Moerman, *Localizing Paradise*, 160. That said, Zōyō’s appointment is only mentioned in later sources and thus must be taken with caution; see Tokunaga, “Kumano sanzan kengyō,” 95, n12; Blair, *Real and Imagined*, 277.
122. Translation with slight modifications from Kwon, “The Emperor’s Songs,” 290.
123. Found in fascicle 10 of the “oral transmissions” (*kudenshū* 口伝集) section of *Ryōjin hishō* 梁塵秘抄 (SNKBZ 42:370); see also Kwon, “The Emperor’s Songs,” 291; Yamamoto, “‘Kokawadera engi emaki’ to kyōsetsu,” 480.
124. Kwon, “The Emperor’s Songs,” 291.
125. T 20, 1060:111c03–111c07.
126. A variation of this quote appears in the *Nihon ryōiki*, SNKBZ 10:281–283; see also Lazarus, “Retelling the Story of a Song,” 1–3. Chinese Buddhists used similar spells to literally revive withered trees, as Qi Yu famously did for the bodhi tree; see Salguero, “‘A Flock of Ghosts,’” 36.
127. LaFleur, *The Karma of Words*, 63.
128. Yamamoto, “‘Kokawadera engi emaki’ to kyōsetsu,” 481.
129. Moerman, *Localizing Paradise*, 144.
130. On Kenshunmon’in’s swelling, see *Kikki*, Angen 2 (1176) 6/4, 6/9, 6/13, 3:223–225.
131. *Kikki*, Angen 2 (1176), 6/10, 3:224; see also Hayami, *Kannon shrinkō*, 316–317.

132. *Mii zoku tōki*, DNBZ 111:214; *Hōhiki*, 223; see also Tachi, *Onjōji Kōin no kenkyū*, 279–281.
133. Matsumoto, “Go-Shirakawa-in no shinkō sekai.”
134. Tachi, *Onjōji Kōin no kenkyū*, 281, 572–573.

## Chapter 2: Evil Dead in the Aristocratic Mansion

Epigraph is from Sloterdijk, *After God*, 202.

1. *Makura no sōshi*, SNKBZ 18:460–463 and Nōin-bon, 360–363; translation of the final line from Morris, *The Pillow Book*, 1:264–265.
2. Spirit disease continued to appear in the Kamakura, Nanbokuchō, and Muro-machi periods. Across diaries, however, the number of cases noted decreased considerably after the late Heian and early Kamakura periods; see Ueno, *Yume to mononoke*, 285–307.
3. Hattori, *Heian jidai*, 62.
4. Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 194–227; Sakō, *Hyōrei shinkō*; Ueno, *Yume to mononoke*, 77–216; Oda, *Jubaku, gohō, abishahō*; Koyama, *Mononoke no Nihonshi*, 2–131; Koyama, “Heian jidai ni okeru mononoke no hyōshō to chibyō”; Iyanaga, “Healing by Spiritual Possession.”
5. *Makura no sōshi*, SNKBZ 18:318.
6. *Gonki*, Chōtoku 4 (998), 3/3, 1:63–66; *Shōyūki*, Kannin 2 (1018), intercalary 4/17, 5:21–22.
7. Borgen, *A Woman’s Weapon*.
8. Watanabe, *Flowering Tales*.
9. Borgen, *A Woman’s Weapon*, 19.
10. Koyama, *Mononoke no Nihonshi*, 13–14. On ghosts in medieval China, see Poo, “The Culture of Ghosts.”
11. Unschuld, *Medicine in China*, 67–73; Lo, “Tracking the Pain.”
12. For examples, see *Shunki*, Chōryaku 3 (1039), 10/3, 7:40 and *Eiga monogatari*, SNKBZ 32:58–59. See also the discussion in Taniguchi, “Heian kizoku no shippei ninshiki”; Yamada, *Sutokuin onryō no kenkyū*, 26–38; Koyama, “Chūsei zenki no byōki chiryō”; Koyama, *Mononoke no Nihonshi*, 15–16.
13. *Nihon ryōiki*, SNKBZ 10:190.
14. The term *mononoke* is not limited to literary works. It appears in the *Shōyūki*, *Sakeiki*, and *Denryaku*.
15. Li, “They Shall Expel Demons,” 1116, 1147.
16. Unschuld, *Medicine in China*, 67–68.
17. *Zhubing yuanhou lun*, TIZS 6:29.
18. The examples come from the following diary entries: *Shōyūki*, Eiso 1 (989), 7/16, 1:191; *Kankō* 2 (1005), 4/8, 2:108; *Chōwa* 2 (1013), 4/10, 3:105; *Manju* 2 (1025), 9/25, 7:134; *Gonki*, Chōhō 2 (1000), 5/25, 1:208–209; *Shunki*, Chōkyū 1 (1040), 9/24: 212; *Denryaku*, Ten’ei 2 (1111), 8/7, 3:157.

19. *Shōyūki*, Tengen 5 (982), 4/19, 1:29. This entry marks the first appearance of the term “evil *qi*” (*jake*) in Sanesuke’s diary.
20. *Eiga monogatari*, SNKBZ 31:132–133; see also McCullough and McCullough, *A Tale of Flowering Fortunes*, 131–132.
21. *Gonki*, Chōtoku 4 (998), 3/3, 1:63–66.
22. *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 5/4, 4:19, Chōwa 4 (1015), intercalary 6/11, 4:37; *Gonki*, Chōtoku 4 (998), 3/3, 1:63–66; *Chūyūki*, Kashō 1 (1106), 9/21, DNK 6:210; *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 7/23, 4:61, Jian 3 (1023), 6/13, 6:172; *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 6/11, 4:37; *Chūyūki*, Kōwa 5 (1103), 1/25, DNK 5:20–21; *Shōyūki*, Eiso 1 (989), 7/16, 1:192; *Shunki*, Chōkyū 1 (1040) 12/8, 259.
23. *Shōyūki*, Jian 3 (1023), 7/6, 6:181; *Shōyūki*, Chōgen 4 (1031), 3/23, 8:247; *Denryaku*, Ten’ei 3 (1112), 8/6, 3:248.
24. *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 5/20, 4:30–31, 7/13, 4:58, 7/23, 4:61, Kannin 3 (1019), 5/11, 5:145. In this context we might also mention its association with epidemic demons (*ekiki* 疫鬼); see *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 6/19, 4:41.
25. *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 1 (1012), 6/11, 3:36–37, 8/14, 3:53, Chōwa 2 (1013), 4/10, 3:105, Chōwa 4 (1015), 6/19, 4:41; *Sakeiki*, Kannin 2 (1018), intercalary 4/17, 6:67; *Chūyūki*, Eichō 1 (1096), 8/7, DNK 3:82; *Shōyūki*, Manju 2 (1025), 8/29, 7:125; for the meaning of warm disease (*unbyō*), see *Dictionary of the Ben Cao Gang Mu*, 1:313; *Shōyūki*, Manju 2 (1025), 8/29, 7:125; for the meaning of free-flux illness, see *Dictionary of the Ben Cao Gang Mu*, 1:313; *Shōyūki*, Manju 2 (1025), 8/5, 7:115–116, 8/24, 7:124, 8/28–8/29, 7:124–125; *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 12/9, 4:106, Chōgen 1 (1028), 9/28, 8:98–99; *Chūyūki*, Shōtoku 2 (1098), 10/26, DNK 4:86–87; *Denryaku*, Kōwa 5 (1103), 10/14, 1:243; *Chūyūki*, Kashō 2 (1107), 7/12, DNK 7:90; *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 7/13, 4:58; *Denryaku*, Chōji 2 (1105) 7/29, 2:85; *Chūyūki*, Chōji 2 (1105), 8/2, DNK 6:79.
26. *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 7/23, 4:61; *Shunki*, Chōkyū 1 (1040), 9/21, 209–211; *Shōyūki*, Chōgen 1 (1028), 9/28, 8:98–99.
27. *Shōyūki*, Kankō 5 (1008), 9/10, 11:87, Manju 2 (1025), 8/5, 7:115–116, 8/24, 7:124, 8/28–8/29, 7:124–125; *Sakeiki*, Manju 2 (1025), 8/5, 6:151; *Chūyūki*, Kōwa 5 (1103), 1/25, DNK 5:20–21. On pathogenic spirits assaulting pregnant women and women in labor, see Hattori, *Heian jidai*, 71–79; Andreeva, “Childbirth in Aristocratic Households”; Suzuki, “Possessions and the Possessed”; Suzuki, “Twanging Bows and Throwing Rice.”
28. *Gonki*, Chōtoku 4 (998), 3/21, 1:70; *Shōyūki*, Manju 2 (1025), 8/28, 7:124–125; *Chūyūki*, Kashō 1 (1106), 10/19, DNK 6:217. Spirit disease is given as the cause of death in the cases of Michinaga’s daughter Kishi 嬉子 (1007–1025; see *Shōyūki*, Manju 2 (1025), 8/5, 7:115–116 and *Sakeiki*, Manju 2 [1025], 8/5, 6:151), Toyohara Tamenaga 豊原為長 (?–1033), see *Sakeiki*, Chōgen 6 (1033), 4/3, 6: 414; Michimoto 通基 (?–1040), see *Shunki*, Chōkyū 1 (1040), 12/8, 259; Princess Teishi 媞子内親王 (aka Ikuhōmon’in 郁芳門院, 1076–1096), see *Chūyūki*, Eichō 1 (1096), 8/7, 3:82; Emperor Horikawa’s flute teacher, see *Chūyūki*, Shōtoku 1 (1097), intercalary 1/4, DNK 3:155; Horikawa’s consort, Fujiwara no Ishi 苺子

- (1076–1103), see *Chūyūki*, Kōwa 5 (1103), 1/25, DNK 5:20–21; Horikawa himself, see *Chūyūki*, Kashō 2 (1107), 7/19, DNK 7:93; and another individual, see *Shunki*, Eishō 7 (1052) 5/4, 337.
29. *Shōyūki*, Kannin 2 (1018), 6/23, 5:44, Kannin 3 (1019), 3/18, 5:127–128; *Sakeiki*, Manju 3 (1026), intercalary 5/9, 6:178; *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 3 (1014), 3/24, 3:204–205, Manju 4 (1027), 6/5, 7:244, Chōgen 1 (1028), 9/28, 8:98–99, Chōgen 4 (1031), 7/5, 9:2–3; *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 3 (1014), 3/24, 3:204–205, Chōwa 4 (1015), 5/27, 4:34; *Sakeiki*, Manju 3 (1026), intercalary 5/9, 6:178; *Shōyūki*, Jian 3 (1026), 7/14, 6:183. For a list of assorted spirits deemed *mononoke*, see Shigeta, *Onmyōji to kizoku shakai*, 129–131.
  30. McMullin, “On Placating the Gods,” 287–291; Yamada, *Sutokuin onryō no kenkyū*, 38–48; Ooms, *Imperial Politics and Symbolics*, 232–237.
  31. *Hizōshō*, 111.
  32. Yamada, *Sutokuin onryō no kenkyū*, 4–7; Ueno, *Yume to mononoke*, 122.
  33. *Sanuki no suke nikki*, SNKBZ 26:394–395.
  34. See Hayami, *Heian kizoku shakai to bukyō*, 83–84.
  35. These stories are introduced in Shigeta, *Noroi no miyako*, 98–105.
  36. *Honchō monzui*, SNKBT 27:375.
  37. *Honchō hokke genki*, ZGR 8.1:173.
  38. Stone, *Right Thoughts*, 29–30; see also Hayami, *Jigoku to gokuraku*.
  39. *Ōjō yōshū*, 9. I use the Kenpō-era edition of the *Ōjō yōshū* for two reasons: First, this is the oldest printing of the work, dating to 1216; see *Ōjō yōshū*, 537–539. Second, it was an edition that was known to have been transmitted at Onjōji; see Nara Kokuritsu Hakubutsukan, *Genshin*, 57, 274.
  40. Stone, *Right Thoughts*, 221–265.
  41. *Kōsanji kotenseki sanshū*, 657; see also Ueno, *Yume to mononoke*, 90–91.
  42. *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 5/22, 4:31–32.
  43. For examples of violence in courtier diaries, see *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 3 (1014), 6/16, 3:233, Chōwa 3 (1014), 12/8, 3:260, and Chōtoku 2 (996), 12/16, 2:2–3. See also Shigeta, *Naguriau kizokutachi*.
  44. Rikō, *Nihon kodai hōseishi*, 138; Stockdale, *Imagining Exile*, 105–106. See also Togawa, *Heian jidai no shikei*.
  45. The information summarized here derives from the list in *Shōki mokuroku* (*Shōyūki* 10:51–52) and the table in Shigeta, *Noroi no miyako*, 36–39.
  46. *Midō kanpakuki*, Chōwa 1 (1012), 4/10, 2:145; *Shōyūki*, Chōhō 2 (1000), 6/5, 10:51.
  47. *Shōyūki*, Chōtoku 2 (996), 3/28, 2:5.
  48. *Shōyūki*, Jian 3 (1023), 12/27, 6:254. This also appears to have happened in a case mentioned previously in the *Midō kanpakuki*; see Chōwa 1 (1012), 4/11, 2:145–146.
  49. *Shōyūki*, Kannin 1 (1017), 11/18, 4:272.
  50. *Shōyūki*, Kannin 2 (1018), 6/24, 5:44–45.
  51. *Shōyūki*, Manju 1 (1024), 4/12, 7:19–20.

52. *Shōyūki*, Manju 2 (1025), 3/8, 7:94.
53. *Shōyūki*, Manju 4 (1027), 12/28, 8:56.
54. *Shōyūki*, Manju 4 (1027), 12/2, 8:44.
55. *Gonki*, Chōhō 2, 5/18, 1:204–206; *Shōyūki*, Chōhō 2 (1000), 6/5, 10:51.
56. *Eiga monogatari*, SNKBZ 32:58; see also Shigeta, *Noroi no miyako*, 86–88.
57. Kosaka, *Abe no Seimei sen* “*Senji ryakketsu*,” 244–245.
58. A similar phenomenon was the disease agent known simply as “evil” (*aku* 悪); see *Shunki*, Chōkyū 1 (1040), 9/21:209–211.
59. *Onmyōji* were occasionally summoned by courtiers to manage evil *qi*, often diagnosing the disease or evaluating the efficacy of proposed treatments; see *Shōyūki*, Chōhō 1 (999), 9/16, 2:61, Chōwa 4 (1015), 6/19, 4:41, Chōwa 4 (1015), 7/23, 4:61, Chōwa 4 (1015), 9/5, 4:71, Chōwa 4 (1015), 9/5, 4:71, Kannin 4 (1020), 9/14, 5:233–234, Chōgen 1 (1028), 9/28, 8:98–99; *Gonki*, Chōhō 5 (1003), 8/21, 2:236; *Shunki*, Chōkyū 1 (1040), 9/21, 209–211, Chōkyū 1 (1040), 9/24, 212; *Denryaku*, Chōji 2 (1105) 7/29, 2:85, Kashō 2 (1107), 5/25, 2:195, Ten’ei 2 (1111), 5/13, 3:143; *Chūyūki*, Kashō 1 (1106), 9/21, DNK 6:210. On *onmyōji* and *jake*, see Akazawa, “Nihon chūsei ni okeru byō.”
60. *Shōyūki*, Shōryaku 4 (993), 6/8, 1:281, Kannin 2 (1018), intercalary 4/20, 5:22–23 and intercalary 4/29, 5:25; *Sakeiki*, Kannin 4 (1020), 8/6, 6:103; *Denryaku*, Ten’ei 3 (1112), 10/8, 3:261.
61. *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), intercalary 6/11, 4:37; *Chūyūki*, Shōtoku 2 (1098), 10/26, DNK 4:86–87, Shōtoku 2 (1098), 10/28, 4:48, Kashō 2 (1107), 7/19, 7:93; *Denryaku*, Ten’ei 3 (1112), 8/3, 3:247.
62. *Shōyūki*, Eiso 1 (989), 7/16, 1:191, Chōwa 4 (1015), 5/2, 4:17–18, Kannin 2 (1018), intercalary 4/19, 5:22–23; *Sakeiki*, Kannin 4 (1020), 8/6, 6:103; *Denryaku*, Kashō 1 (1106), 9/21, 2:154–155.
63. *Sanuki no suke nikki*, SNKBZ 26:394–395; translation from Brewster, *Sanuki no suke nikki*, 59–60.
64. The composite schematic of the possession rite as a discrete ritual performance outlined here is drawn from accounts from multiple sources: prescriptive ritual texts for monks, such as the “Procedures of the Efficacious Ones” (Genza sahō); courtier observations, such as in the *Pillow Book* account and contemporary diary entries; and sources of a more literary vein, ranging from the journalistic account in *Sanuki no suke nikki* to *A Tale of Flowering Fortunes* and the most imaginative *Tale of Genji*. For similar schematic outlines, see Komatsu, *Akuryōron*, 203–204; Iyanaga, “Healing by Spiritual Possession,” 3.
65. Ueno, *Yume to mononoke*, 141–146; Tokunaga, *Hyōrei shinkō*, 133–138.
66. Tokunaga, *Hyōrei shinkō*, 135–137.
67. Patients improve from the transfer in the following entries: *Shōyūki*, Eiso 1 (989), 7/16, 1:192; Chōhō 1 (999) 11/4, 2:69; Kannin 4 (1020), 9/28, 5:236–237, Jian 2 (1022), 5/30, 6:113, Manju 3 (1026), 5/9, 7:176, Manju 4 (1027), 6/16, 7:246–247; *Gonki*, Chōtoku 4 (998), 3/3, 1:63–66; *Denryaku*, Ten’ei 2 (1111), 6/13, 3:147; Ten’ei 2 (1111), 8/2, 3:156.



68. *Sahō shū*, 239.
69. *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 5/4, 4:19.
70. *Shōyūki*, Shōryaku 4 (993), 6/5, 1:281.
71. *Sakeiki*, Manju 3 (1026), intercalary 5/9, 6:178.
72. *Shōyūki*, Shōryaku 4 (993), 6/18, 1:283.
73. *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 1 (1012), 7/8, 3:46.
74. McKinney, *The Pillow Book*, 251–253.
75. Before becoming a resentful spirit, Atsuyasu had suffered from evil *qi* in 1003; see *Gonki*, Chōhō 5 (1003), 8/21, 2:236.
76. *Jikkinshō*, SNKBZ 51:374–375.
77. Strickmann provides a similar example in the Daoist context and discusses the use of the term “talking cure”; see *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 23, 292, n87.
78. *Shōyūki*, Shōryaku 4 (993), intercalary 10/14, 1:288; see also Hayami, *Heian kizoku shakai to bukkō*, 86–87; Shigeta, *Noroi no miyako*, 109–111.
79. On solidarity in contexts of spirit possession, see Bargen, *A Woman’s Weapon*, 6; Watanabe, *Flowering Tales*, 17–19.
80. *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 5/20 and 5/22, 4:30–32.
81. Suzuki, *Medicine Master Buddha*, 29–34.
82. *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 5/22, 4:30–32.
83. *Sahō shū*, 238–239.
84. On the cult of Gohō in Japan, see Komatsu, *Hyōrei shinkōron*, 171–208; Koyama, *Gohō Dōji*.
85. Tokunaga, *Hyōrei shinkō*, 135–144.
86. Examples of the use of *tsuku* include *Shunki*, Chōkyū 1 (1040), 12/8, 259; *Denryaku*, Kōwa 5 (1103), 10/16, 1:244; *Kashō* 1 (1106), 9/13, 2:153; *Ten’ei* 2 (1111), 8/7, 3:157; *Ten’ei* 3 (1112), 8/8, 3:249; *Gen’ei* 1 (1118), 8/2, 5:71. The term *taku* appears in the following episodes: *Shōyūki*, Kannin 4 (1020), 10/8, 5:240; *Chūyūki*, Kahō 1 (1094), 3/19, DNK 2:37–38.
87. Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 196–198.
88. Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 198.
89. Ueno, *Yume to mononoke*, 83.
90. *Eiga monogatari*, SNKBZ 32:61; see also McCullough and McCullough, *A Tale of Flowering Fortunes*, 436–437.
91. *Sahō shū*, 239.
92. On the mysterious identity of this deity, see Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 214–218.
93. T 18, 895:728a28–728c28. See also select translations in Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 211–214.
94. T 21, 1277:329b; translation from Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 229–232.
95. Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 214.
96. Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 214.
97. *Sahō shū*, 239.
98. Davis, *Society and the Supernatural*, 124.

99. Ueno, *Yume to mononoke*, 138–189; Oda, *Jubaku, gohō, abishahō*, chap. 5; Tokunaga, *Hyōrei shinkō*, 135–136, 150.
100. Blair, “Ladylike Religion,” 6.
101. Blair, “Ladylike Religion,” 7.

### Chapter 3: The Ghostbusters of Onjōji

1. The following anecdote is drawn from *Hirasan kojīn reitaku*, SNKBT 40:456–458; see also Ikemi, “Myōshū to no taiwa,” 33–35.
2. Obara, *Chūsei kizoku shakai to bukkyō*, 117–134.
3. Komatsu, *Nihon yōkai ibunroku*, 11–15; Shimura, *Heiankyō no gōsutobasutā*.
4. This anachronism informs depictions of the possession rite in the 2024 NHK Taiga drama *Hikaru kimi e* 光る君へ, which follows the life of Murasaki Shikibu and her fictional romantic affair with Michinaga.
5. Sakō was the first to argue for the dominance of Jimon monks in the possession rite; Ueno developed his thesis further. See Sakō, *Hyōrei shinkō*, 77; Ueno, *Yume to mononoke*, 93–95.
6. Winfield, “Curing with Kaji” and “Esoteric Ritual Remedies”; Abé, *The Weaving of Mantra*, 158.
7. Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 274–275.
8. Ueno, *Yume to mononoke*, 83. For additional discussion, see Sakō, *Hyōrei shinkō*, 71–72; Oda, *Jubaku, gohō, abishahō*, 243–266; Rhodes, “The Kaihōgyō Practice,” 186–190.
9. I follow the information provided in Orzech, “After Amoghavajra,” 328–329.
10. The work appears in one of Enchin’s catalogs, the *Catalogue of Works Collected Seeking the Dharma at Guoqingsi* (*Kokuseiji guhō mokuroku* 国清寺求法目録), a manuscript with Enchin’s signature; see *Onjōji monjo* 1:158. I viewed this manuscript on August 14, 2024, at the Sakata Bojukudō 坂田墨珠堂 preservation studio in Wani, Shiga. I thank the Sakata family, Kurumado Kunishige, and Fuke Shungen.
11. Groner, *Ryōgen and Mount Hiei*, 41.
12. Hayami, *Heian kizoku shakai to bukkyō*, 152; Tōkyō Kokuritsu Hakubutsukan et al., *Miidera hihōten*, 139.
13. *Fusō ryakki*, 6:680.
14. *Murakami tennō gyoki*, Kōhō 4 (967) 3/18, in *Shinkishū* 1:194.
15. Hayami, *Heian kizoku shakai to bukkyō*, 89.
16. For example, in 1000, Michinaga celebrated Kanju for treating his illness and considered what he might possibly award in return, given that by this time, Kanju had exhausted all of the highest priestly posts; see *Gonki*, Chōhō 2 (1000), 8/11, 2:17–18.
17. *Shōyūki*, Shōryaku 4 (993), intercalary 10/14, 1:288.
18. On Ryōgen’s ties with Morosuke and his lineage, see Groner, *Ryōgen and Mount Hiei*, 72–92; Rhodes, *Genshin’s Ōjōyōshū*, 111–114.

19. *Gonki*, Chōtoku 4 (998), 12/3, 1:109.
20. *Gonki*, Chōhō 4 (1002), 3/14, 2:170.
21. *Gonki*, Chōhō 5 (1003), 8/29, 2:237.
22. Obviously many examples can be found that attest to the opposite result—that is, Sanmon monks preferred over Jimon monks—but my focus here and throughout the book is the Jimon lineage, and the specificity of when such preferences were expressed remains meaningful.
23. *Genkō shakusho*, 1:93.
24. *Gonki*, Chōhō 2 (1000), 12/16, 2:67–68.
25. *Gonki*, Chōhō 2 (1000), 5/14, 1:202–203.
26. *Shōyūki*, Chōhō 1 (999), 11/4, 2:69.
27. *Uji shūi monogatari*, SNKBZ 50:42. Like Shin'yo, Fukō also appears to have participated in possession rites; see *Shōyūki*, Manju 2 (1025), 9/25, 7:134.
28. Hayami, *Heian kizoku shakai to bukkyō*, 33–34.
29. Yasui, “Where Yōkai Enter and Exit,” 61–63. On Jōzō, see Tokunaga, “Shugendō seiritsu,” 101.
30. *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 5/7, 4:23; see also *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 5/20, 4:30–31.
31. *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 5/27, 4:34.
32. *Shōyūki*, Kannin 4 (1020), 10/6, 5:240.
33. *Shōyūki*, Jian 2 (1022), 5/30, 6:113.
34. *Shōyūki*, Manju 4 (1027), 7/2, 8:1.
35. *Midō kanpakuki*, Chōwa 1 (1012), 4/28, 2:151–152.
36. *Shōyūki*, Chōwa 4 (1015), 6/11, 4:37.
37. *Shōyūki*, Kannin 2 (1018), intercalary 4/17, 5:21–22; *Midō kanpakuki*, Kannin 2 (1018), intercalary 4/16–17, 3:160.
38. *Shōyūki*, Kannin 2 (1018), intercalary 4/19, 5:22–23.
39. *Shōyūki*, Jian 3 (1023), 6/13, 6:172.
40. *Shōyūki*, Manju 4 (1027), 6/16, 7:246–247.
41. *Sakeiki*, Kannin 4 (1020), 8/6, 6:103.
42. McCullough and McCullough, *A Tale of Flowering Fortunes*, 435, n18.
43. SNKBT 32:422–423; see also the *Uji shūi monogatari*, SNKBZ 50:42. For more on the later reception and perception of Michinaga's life and that of his lineage among the heirs to his legacy in the twelfth century, see Shigeta, *Mago no mago ga kataru Fujiwara Michinaga*.
44. Sakō, *Hyōrei shinkō*, 72–76.
45. *Sakeiki*, Chōgen 1 (1028), 12/4, 6:254.
46. *Shōyūki*, Kannin 4 (1020), 9/16, 5:234–235.
47. *Shōyūki*, Kannin 4 (1020), 10/9, 5:240–241 and 10/16, 5:243.
48. *Shōyūki*, Manju 2 (1025), 8/5, 7:115–116.
49. *Chūyūki*, Kashō 1 (1106), 9/21, DNK 6:210.
50. Ueno identifies Raiki, Kenkaku, and Shishi as the sons of Minamoto no Aki-fusa 源顕房 (1037–1094), which would mean that Jimon monks performed the

- possession rite for their own family members. See Ueno, *Yume to mononoke*, 155–156. Michael Jamentz alerted me to several likely errors in these identifications. I thank him for his assistance on Raiki's biography and information on Kenkaku.
51. *Denryaku*, Kashō 2 (1107), 6/9, 2:197.
  52. *Denryaku*, Kashō 2 (1107), 8/9, 2:212–213. This Kenkaku is not to be confused with a monk of the same name discussed in the context of the *Kokawadera engi* in chapter 1. The *Denryaku* gives his name as 賢覚, the same characters used for the later Kenkaku. For his dates, see *Denbō kanjō kechimyaku fu*, 359.
  53. *Denryaku*, Ten'ei 3 (1112), 8/6, 3:248.
  54. *Denryaku*, Chōji 1 (1104), 3/19, 1:303–304.
  55. *Denryaku*, Chōji 2 (1105) 7/29, 2:85.
  56. *Kasuga gongen genki e*, 44–45; see also Tokunaga, “Shugendō seiritsu,” 101.
  57. *Kasuga gongen genki e*, 44–45.
  58. The following account is drawn from *Chūyūki*, Kashō 2 (1107), 5/13–18, 7:229–230; see also *Denryaku*, Kashō 2 (1107), 7/16–19, 2:202–206, the English translation in Brewster, *Sanuki no suke nikki*, 57–79. See also the discussion in Stone, *Right Thoughts*, 214–217.
  59. Translation with some modifications from Brewster, *Sanuki no suke nikki*, 66–67.
  60. T 20, 1060:107a28–107b11; for some terms, I closely follow the translation in Giddings, “The Sūtra on the Dhāraṇī,” 259.
  61. *Shōyūki*, Kankō 2 (1005), 4/8, 2:108.
  62. *Makura no sōshi*, Nōin-bon, 360–363.
  63. The monk is said to be around the age of thirty, which means that it may have been Monkyō 文慶 (966–1046) or Myōson, who were disciples of Kanju, or perhaps the younger Gyōen 行延 (977–1047). The identification of the priest as a Jimon monk, however, remains speculative.
  64. *Shōyūki*, Chōhō 1 (999), 8/28, 2:58.
  65. *Shōyūki*, Chōhō 1 (999), 11/6, 2:70.
  66. *Shōyūki*, Chōhō 1 (999) 11/4, 2:69.
  67. See Brewster, *Sanuki no suke nikki*, 59, 65.
  68. SNKBT 32:375.
  69. Brewster, *Sanuki no suke nikki*, 121, n46.
  70. *Makura no sōshi*, Nōin-bon, 28–29; translation from Morris, *Pillow Book*, 1:7.
  71. Tokunaga, “Shugendō seiritsu.”
  72. For example, see *Denryaku*, Eikyū 1 (1113), 9/14, 4:55 and 9/16, 4:55.
  73. Moerman, *Localizing Paradise*, 49.
  74. Wakabayashi, *The Seven Tengu Scrolls*, 169. The note on “efficacy cultivation” is mine.
  75. That one could fall into this path is suggested by the cases of Shunshi and Ninkyō discussed below. See also the discussion on Kamakura-period monks in Wakabayashi, *The Seven Tengu Scrolls*, 34–41, and Abe, “The Book of Tengu,” 220–223.

76. Matsumoto, “Onjōji-bon ‘Hōhiki,’” 300; Adolphson, *The Gates of Power*, 190–191. Norizane was the father of Rishin, Keisei’s disciple and a transmitter of the Ritual for Expelling Demons manuscripts.
77. For a more auspicious presentation of Ninkyō’s passing, see the rebirth hagiography in *Konjaku monogatari shū*, SNKBT 35:391–392.
78. *Meigetsuki*, 1229 (Kangi 1), 4/23, 3:95.
79. The rumors appear in *Stories of Five Reigns and Their Emperors* (*Godai teiō monogatari* 五代帝王物語); see *Godai teiō monogatari*, SGR 2:327; see also Yamada, *Sutokuin onryō no kenkyū*, 203–204; Ikemi, “Myōshū to no taiwa,” 53, fn10.
80. Abe, “The Book of Tengu,” 221.
81. *Hirasan kojīn reitaku*, SNKBT 40:467.
82. Abe, “The Book of Tengu,” 219–220.
83. *Sahō shū*, 238–239.

#### Chapter 4: The Ritual of Shōmen Kongō for Expelling Demons and Māras

1. Yoshioka, “Shōmen Kongō to kōshin shinkō,” 238–241.
2. Ōsu Bunko, item no. 56-157; Chisan Denbōin, *Shinpukuji Bunko satsuei mokuroku*, 2:533. This is the primary edition of the work I use in this book. Because it is unpaginated, when citing from it I also cite the roughly corresponding passage in the Taishō edition, where such a passage exists. I viewed this manuscript at Ōsu Kannon Hōshōin, Shinpukuji.
3. Kissuizō, box 82, 1; see Kissuizō Shōgyō Chōsadan, *Shōren’in Monzeki Kissuizō shōgyō mokuroku*, 431. I examined a facsimile copy of this edition at the Tokyo Historiographical Institute on March 7, 2023.
4. For a partial translation, see Macomber, “Moxibustion for Demons.”
5. In November 2016, I viewed photographs of the manuscript taken by Nagano Hitoshi. Throughout the book I primarily use the transcription in Ōta.
6. Ōta, “Bunkachō zō ‘Denshibyō kanjinshō narabini sōbyō chihō.’”
7. Shōren’in, box 82, 11; see Kissuizō Shōgyō Chōsadan, *Shōren’in Monzeki Kissuizō shōgyō mokuroku*, 434. I examined a facsimile of this edition at the Tokyo Historiographical Institute on March 7, 2023.
8. For a transcription, see Minobe et al., “Denshi ‘oni’ to ‘mushi,’” 69–82.
9. I viewed this manuscript at the library in November 2016. I thank Takeda Tokimasa and Nagano Hitoshi for their assistance.
10. Matsumoto, “Onjōji-bon ‘Hōhiki.’”
11. For example, see the entry in *Bussho kaisetsu daijiten*, 5:341; Kohn, “Kōshin: Expelling Daoist Demons,” 159.
12. *Keiranshūyōshū*, T 76, 2410:619b05–619b07.
13. *Hōhiki*, 221.
14. Sørensen, “Early Esoteric Buddhism in Korea,” 581–582.
15. Kim, *Shinra Myōjin*.

16. Murayama Shūichi agrees with this assessment; see Murayama, *Nihon onmyōdō shiwa*, 308.
17. *Hōhiki*, 109, 143.
18. *Hōhiki*, 137.
19. Matsumoto, “Onjōji-bon ‘Hōhiki,’” 302.
20. Onjōji no butsumō hensan iinkai, *Onjōji no butsumō*, 2:124–125.
21. Matsumoto, “Onjōji-bon ‘Hōhiki,’” 293–299.
22. Matsumoto, “Onjōji-bon ‘Hōhiki,’” 309–316; Matsumoto, “Chūgū gosan to mikkyō.”
23. Hashimoto, “Keisei Shōnin denkō”; Hashimoto, “Keisei Shōnin no jiseki.”
24. Ōta, “Hokkesanji no kyōzō.”
25. Goble, “Images of Illness,” 214, n141. For more discussion, see chapter 5.
26. Shiba, “Shoshazan no hisetsu wo megutte.”
27. *Tuoluoni ji jing*, T 18, 901:867b21–867b23; *Qianshou qianyan Guanshiyin pusa zhibing heyao jing*, T 20, 1059:104a19–104a20; *Qianshou qianyan Guanshiyin pusa guangda yuanman wuai dabeixin tuoluoni jing*, T 20, 1060:110b14–110b16.
28. The main discussion is found in *Ishinpō* (1a), 193–194.
29. Sugitatsu, *Ishinpō no denrai*, 32.
30. Takayama, “Gishūmon’in.” Tōno Haruyuki dates this copy of the *Ishinpō* to the early Kamakura period (Tōno, “Kōchi Kongōji”).
31. Ochiai, “A Treasure-House,” 299.
32. Tōdaiji, *Nara jidai no Tōdaiji*, 115, 195.
33. *Shōshiki daikongō yasha byaku kima hō*; T 21, 1221:101a16–101a23.
34. Ōtsushi Rekishi Hakubutsukan, *Miidera butsumō no bi*, 121.
35. *Tuoluoni ji jing*, T 18, 901:867b21–867b23.
36. As far as I have been able to determine, the only other source mentioning these extra eyes is the *Hōhiki* (216).

## Chapter 5: Corpse Influx in a Defiled Capital

Chapter 5 is a significantly revised and expanded version of “Disease, Defilement, and the Dead: Buddhist Medicine and the Emergence of Corpse-Vector Disease,” *Japanese Journal of Religious Studies* 49, no. 2 (2025).

1. *Ishinpō* (1a), 193–194.
2. Hattori, *Heian jidai*, 80–81; Johnston, *The Modern Epidemic*, 40–43; Maki, *Ishinpō*, 13:x–xi.
3. Hattori, *Heian jidai*, 80–81; Shinmura, *Nihon iryō shakaishi no kenkyū*, 270–273.
4. Stone, “Do Kami Ever Overlook Pollution?,” 205.
5. For ancient Japan, see Como, “*Onmyōji*, the Earth God and Ghosts” and Lowe, “Roads, State, and Religion.”
6. Katsuda, *Shisha no chūsei*, 6–10.

7. Throughout this chapter, I extend Katsuda's range of years back one decade in light of the longer chain of events, including epidemics and disasters, that I view as contributing to the pathologization of encounters with corpses.
8. Farris, "Diseases of the Premodern Period," 381.
9. Farris, "Diseases of the Premodern Period," 381–382.
10. McKinney, *Essays in Idleness and Hōjōki*, 6–11. Often treated as a work of literature, Chōmei's accounts have been shown to be historically accurate; see Ihara, *Shijiutsu chūsei bukk'yō*, 94–117.
11. McKinney, *Essays in Idleness and Hōjōki*, 10.
12. Maruyama, "Kodai no tennō to byōsha," 206; Niunoya, *Keibiishi*, 46–48; Katsuda, *Shisha no chūsei*, 43–44.
13. *Konjaku monogatari shū*, SNKBT 37:326–328; for a translation of the story, see Dykstra, *Buddhist Tales*, 978–990.
14. McKinney, *Essays in Idleness and Hōjōki*, 978–990.
15. Kamikawa, *Heiankyō to chūsei bukk'yō*, 22–23.
16. *Konjaku monogatari shū*, SNKBT 36:106–110; for a translation, see Pandey, "Desire and Disgust," 222–225.
17. Harada, "'Kankyo no tomo' shoshū fujōkan setsuwa"; Fujimoto, "'Kankyo no tomo' fujōkan setsuwa"; Yamamoto, *Chūsei bukk'yō kaiga no zuzōshi*, 371–374. Besides *Kankyo no tomo* and the *Hirasan kojīn reitaku*, Keisei is also known for his production of the *Shozan engi* 諸山縁起; see Blair, *Real and Imagined*, 266–267.
18. Pandey, "Desire and Disgust," 213–214.
19. Yamamoto, *Chūsei bukk'yō kaiga no zuzōshi*, 371–372.
20. *Kankyo no tomo*, 403–407; for a translation, see Pandey, "Desire and Disgust," 220–222.
21. Lopez, *Norton Anthology of World Religions: Buddhism*, 197.
22. *Mohe zhiguan*, T 46, 1911:121c12–122b13; see translation in Swanson, *Clear Serenity, Quiet Insight*, 2:1449–1454.
23. *Ōjō yōshū*, 27–31.
24. On this practice, see Yamamoto, *Kusōzu wo yomu*; Kanda, "Behind the Sensationalism"; Tinsley, "The Composition of Decomposition." For a collection of reproductions of works in this genre, see Yamamoto and Nishiyama, *Kusōzu shiryō shūsei*.
25. Tinsley, "The Composition of Decomposition," 17, 19.
26. See *Mohe zhiguan*, T 46, 1911:122a3–122a5.
27. Shinmura, *Shi to yamai to kango*, 48.
28. Yamamoto, *Kegare to ōharae*, 45–51; Stone, "Do Kami Ever Overlook Pollution?," 207. Roughly the same transmission sequence can be found in the later *Goryōsha bukkiryō*; see Elisonas, "The Jesuits, The Devil, and Pollution in Japan," 12–15.
29. For example, opinions differed on the question of whether fourthhand defilement required a taboo period; see Yamamoto, *Kegare to ōharae*, 51.

30. Yamamoto, *Kegare to ôharae*, 46, 48.
31. As Hank Glassman notes (“The Relic and the Jewel,” 186), from the mid-Heian period on, the “dry white bones” of family members were treated as sacred treasures in aristocratic lineages, and thus were the “polar opposite of the polluting and dangerous untransformed corpses.”
32. Stone, *Right Thoughts*, 145; Niunoya, *Kebiishi*, 53–62.
33. *Kikki*, Yôwa 1 (1181), 5/4, 4:164.
34. *Gyokuyô*, Kenkyû 2 (1191), 5/13, 13:42. The affair is described over entries for two days in the diary (13:41–49); see also Katsuda, *Shisha no chûsei*, 51–56.
35. Yiengpruksawan, “The Visual Ideology of Buddhist Sculpture,” 71.
36. *Taiki*, Kyûan 1 (1145), 11/11, 23:164.
37. *Taiki*, Kyûan 1 (1145), 11/11, 23:164.
38. The source of this assumption in English scholarship appears to be a passage in Lock (*East Asian Medicine*, 25), who wrote that one “theory of disease causation” in early Japan was “coming into contact with polluting agents such as blood, corpses, people with skin diseases, and so on,” thereby causing “a state of *ekiakudoku* [穢気悪毒], which literally means ‘having a spirit polluted by bad poison.’” Lock referenced Fujikawa Yû’s *Nihon igakushi kôyô* (8–10), originally published in 1933. *Eki* (“defiled qi”) and *akudoku* (“evil poison”) are separate terms. Because no *kanji* are given in Lock’s book (though they were included in her 1976 dissertation, “Oriental Medicine in Urban Japan”), different *kanji* were assumed when her passage was cited in Winfield (“Curing with Kaji,” 115) and Kleine (“Buddhist Monks as Healers,” 14), which may have further suggested a connection between epidemic disease (*eki* 疫) and defilement.
39. Yamamoto, *Kegare to ôharae*, 48, 134–135.
40. *Chûyûki*, Kashô 2 (1107), 9/13, 7:137.
41. Yamamoto, *Kegare to ôharae*, 135.
42. *Hôjôki*, 16–17.
43. *Gumaiki*, Jishô 5 (1177), 1/5–6, 2:218.
44. Elisonas, “The Jesuits, the Devil, and Pollution in Japan,” 19–20.
45. Kuroda, *Ô no shintai*.
46. Kuroda, *Ô no shintai*, 40–41.
47. Farris, “Diseases of the Premodern Period,” 379.
48. Hattori, *Heian jidai*, 80–83. On leg (or foot) *qi*, later identified as beriberi, in Chinese medical history, see Smith, *Forgotten Disease*.
49. Douglas, *Purity and Danger*, 36, 165.
50. Yokoi, *Chûsei minshû*, 267–293.
51. For more on this thesis, see Macomber, “Disease, Defilement, and the Dead.”
52. *Ôjô yôshû*, 27–32.
53. A thorough summary of the paths described in the text is given in Rhodes, *Genshin’s Ôjô yôshû*, 183–225.
54. It would be hasty to assume that the *Ôjô yôshû* single-handedly sparked this transformation. Sarah J. Horton casts doubt on the extent to which the work



- had any major influence on the aristocracy after its completion in 985; see “The Influence of the Ōjōyōshū.” On the other hand, Stone has detailed the many ways this work became normative for deathbed ritual manuals in subsequent centuries; see Stone, *Right Thoughts*, 387–388. Genshin’s discourse also informed illustrations of hell that began appearing in the thirteenth century; see Chusid, “Hell.”
55. Kim, “A History of Filth,” 191–258.
  56. Bialock, *Eccentric Spaces, Hidden Histories*, 226.
  57. Bialock, *Eccentric Spaces, Hidden Histories*, 227.
  58. Yamamoto Kōji gives an example from the late Kamakura period *Korō kujitsu den* 古老口実伝 describing how *raisha* were barred from residing in and passing through the boundaries of Ise Shrine; Yamamoto, *Kegare to ōharae*, 311–312.
  59. Kuroda, *Kyōkai no chūsei*, 233–258.
  60. This definition appears in the *Chiribukuro* 塵袋, 1:288–289; see also Keirstead, “Outcasts Before the Law,” 274.
  61. Burns, *Kingdom of the Sick*, 19–46.
  62. T 25, 1509:479a10–479a12.
  63. Komatsu, *Shigisan engi*, 141–144.
  64. *Sankaiki*, Eiman 1 (1165), 6/28, 26:284.
  65. *Sankaiki*, Angen 1 (1175), 8/16, 27:72.
  66. *Gyokuyō*, Angen 1 (1175), 8/22, 3:252.
  67. *Gyokuyō*, Angen 1 (1175), 8/22, 3:252.
  68. Hayami, *Heian kizoku shakai to bukyō*, 22.
  69. *Sankaiki*, Jishō 3 (1179), 6/16, 27:294.
  70. *Gyokuyō*, Jishō 3 (1179), 6/18, 6:210–211.
  71. Rosenberg, *Explaining Epidemics*, 305.
  72. Kikuchi, *Kamakura bukyō*, 80–95.
  73. Bialock, *Eccentric Spaces, Hidden Histories*, 273, 316.
  74. Stone, *Right Thoughts*, 372.
  75. *Sankaiki*, Eiman 1 (1165), 6/28, 26:284.
  76. *Zhubing yuanhou lun*, 124.
  77. *Zhubing yuanhou lun*, 122.
  78. Li, “Contagion and Its Consequences,” 207.
  79. Li, “Contagion and Its Consequences,” 208–214.
  80. Yamamoto, *Kegare to ōharae*, 48, 134–138.
  81. *Waitai miyao fang*, TIZS 4:245–247.
  82. Tomita, “Yōsai to sōshuku”; Nagano, “‘Hyakufuku zusetsu.’”
  83. *Gotai shinbun shū*, 71.
  84. *Shika kanmon kyūhō*, 18–34. The *Shika kanmon kyūhō* is thought to be the oldest text on the Four Flowers method in Japan. The only surviving edition, held in the Kyōu Shooku 杏雨書屋 archive in Osaka (identifier: 乾 3582), dates to a copy from 1801.

85. *Essential Notes*, 8. A version of this phrase appears in Chinese medical literature. In particular, the part from “gradually” 漸就 to “die” 死矣 appears in the *Waitai miyao fang*, where it is attributed to the *Xuangan chuanshi fang*, discussed shortly (*Waitai miyao fang*, TIZS 4:245). However, the inclusion of the character for “fish” (gyo 魚) is not found in the *Waitai miyao fang*, nor in any subsequent medical texts where that quote appears, for example, the *Taiping shenghui fang* (992; 1:891) and the *Shengji zonglu* (1118; 1:961). Intriguingly, this character does appear in the description of the disease in the *Ishinpō*, suggesting the possibility that Jimon monks were working with a related text or a fascicle of the *Ishinpō* itself; *Ishinpō* (1a), 193.
86. *Hōjōki*, 22–23; translation from *Anthology of Japanese Literature*, 202.
87. *Ōjō yōshū*, 31.
88. *Essential Notes*, 8.
89. *Waitai miyao fang*, TIZS 4:246. The *Xuangan chuanshi fang* by Su You is one of at least two known Tang period monographs devoted specifically to corpse-vector disease; see Sivín, *Chinese Alchemy*, 298.
90. *Zhubing yuanhou lun*, 122.
91. *Essential Notes*, 8.
92. *Waitai miyao fang*, TIZS 4:246.
93. *Waitai miyao fang*, TIZS 4:246.
94. Signs of death, and indeed many other “signs,” are described extensively by Kokan Shiren 虎関師錬 (1278–1346), otherwise known for the *Genkō shakusho*, in the context of his personal reflections on diseases in his *Byōgiron* 病儀論; see the translation in Drott, “Overcoming Illness with Insight.”
95. Stone, *Right Thoughts*, 230; Satō, *Eizan Jōdokyō no kenkyū*, 198–199.
96. Stone, *Right Thoughts*.
97. Such was likely the case for famine victims, who were starving in the streets; see LaFleur, “Hungry Ghosts and Hungry People.”
98. *Essential Notes*, 8.
99. *Shōshiki daikongō yasha byaku kima hō*. This section is largely missing in T 21, 1221:99c24–100a02.
100. *Essential Notes*, 8.
101. For the list, see T 20, 1060:107a29–107b11; see also *Bukkyō daijiten*, 3374c.
102. As Stone notes, the distinction was not always clear cut, but this perception seems to have informed certain deathbed discourses; see Stone, *Right Thoughts*, 206–211.

## Chapter 6: Demons, *Māras*, and Corpse-Worms

1. Mol, *The Body Multiple*, 5.
2. For an excellent article on the coexistence and interaction of multiple disease models in Song China, see Hinrichs, “The Catchy Epidemic.”
3. Liu, “The Taoists’ Knowledge of Tuberculosis.”

4. T 21, 1221:101b27–101c01. For the original, see T 46, 1911:108a02–108a05.
5. Salguero, *Translating Buddhist Medicine*, 102.
6. T 46, 1911:106c23–106c25.
7. T 46, 1911:107c05–107c06.
8. T 46, 1911:107c03–107c13; Swanson, *Clear Serenity, Quiet Insight*, 2:1334–1335.
9. *Zhiguan fuxing chuanhong jue*; T 46, 1912:399a19–399a24. For a similar example, see Liu, *Healing with Poisons*, 61–62.
10. T 46, 1911:107c13.
11. T 46, 1911:107c13–107c18; Swanson, *Clear Serenity, Quiet Insight*, 2:1335.
12. A particularly famous example from the *Lotus Sutra* is T 61, 262:62a19–62a23; for a translation, see Hurvitz, *Scripture of the Lotus Blossom of the Fine Dharma*, 336.
13. T 46, 1911:107c18–107c26; Swanson, *Clear Serenity, Quiet Insight*, 2:1336. On systematic correspondence, see Unschuld, *Medicine in China*, chap. 3.
14. Groner, *Saichō*, xx.
15. Wald, *Contagious*, 1–3.
16. *Shōshiki daikongō yasha byaku kima hō*; T 21, 1221:100a03–100a06.
17. Moerman, “The Archeology of Anxiety,” 267.
18. Moerman, “The Archeology of Anxiety,” 267.
19. *Waitai miyao fang*, TIZS 4:246.
20. Mori, *Honzōgaku kenkyū*, 355.
21. *Shōshiki daikongō yasha byaku kima hō*.
22. *Essential Notes*, 8–9.
23. On the wide-ranging cult of Hārītī, see Lazzerini, “Mother of Demons and Dharma Protector.” I thank Simona Lazzerini for confirming this identification and sharing her work.
24. The earlier icon, designated as a “Standing Statue of a Dharma-Protecting Deity” (Gohō Zenshin ritsuzō 護法善神立像), is identified as Hārītī; see Onjōji no Butsuzō Hensan Iinkai, *Onjōji no butsuzō*, 2:22–29, 2:106–111. Hārītī is said to have appeared to Enchin at age five at the temple Konzōji 金倉寺 in Kagawa. Enchin later carved the likeness of the deity and sent it back to Konzōji. On the Kamakura period icon, see Onjōji no Butsuzō Hensan Iinkai, *Onjōji no butsuzō*, vol. 4. For more on the cult of Hārītī at Onjōji, see *Jimon denki horoku*, DNBZ 127:170–183.
25. *Essential Notes*, 9. The Sanskrit for the “King of Emptiness Buddha” is taken from the entry on 空王佛 in the *Digital Dictionary of Buddhism*.
26. T 18, 901:884a28–884b01.
27. Strickmann translates this term as “falling frenzy”; see *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 246.
28. *Essential Notes*, 8.
29. *Essential Notes*, 8.
30. Mentioned in *Essential Notes*.
31. Faure, *Rage and Ravage*, 27.

32. See Swanson, *Clear Serenity, Quiet Insight*, 1:259–261. See also the *Digital Dictionary of Buddhism* for 天魔.
33. *Kissa yōjōki*, 357–358.
34. Hayami, *Heian kizoku shakai to bukyō*, 117–118.
35. Both manuscripts of this work—the Shinpukuji and Kinzanji editions—are unpaginated.
36. *Xiuxi zhiguan zuochan fayao*, T 46, 1915:470b13–470b21.
37. T 76, 2410:618a11 and 765c15.
38. Paul Swanson speculates that Douxiluo might be a transliteration of Hidda, but additional details are not provided as to the identity of this figure; see Swanson, *Clear Serenity, Quiet Insight*, 2:1335.
39. T 46, 1919:584a11–584a13.
40. T 46, 1912:399b14–399b15.
41. T 46, 1911:107c09–107c13; see Swanson, *Clear Serenity, Quiet Insight*, 2:1335.
42. Doran, “The Cat Demon.”
43. Doran, “The Cat Demon,” 692.
44. Minakata, *Minakata Kumagusu bunshū*, 232–233.
45. Liu, *Healing with Poisons*, 75.
46. Examples include the 404 elemental diseases and the 80,000 worms of the impure human body; see Unschuld, *Medicine in China*, 298.
47. On the Cat Demon and *gu* poisoning, see Liu, *Healing with Poisons*, 73–78; Hinrichs, *Shamans, Witchcraft, and Quarantine*. On ancient Japan, see Lowe, *Ritualized Writing*, 199–200.
48. *Zhubing yuanhou lun*, 128.
49. A translation for this passage can also be found in Doran, “The Cat Demon,” 697.
50. Doran, “The Cat Demon,” 696.
51. Mollier, *Buddhism and Taoism Face to Face*, 95.
52. *Beiji qianjing yaofang*, 436b–437a.
53. T 18, 901:860b03–860b06; see Mollier, *Buddhism and Taoism Face to Face*, 85.
54. T 18, 901:867b17–867b18.
55. *Shōshiki daikongō yasha byaku kima hō*. A parallel passage is absent in T 21, 1221.
56. On this issue, see Kubo, *Kōshin shinkō no kenkyū*, 473–530; Yoshioka, “Shōmen Kongō to kōshin shinkō”; Kobanawa, “Kōshin kyō to Byakuki shuhō”; Kobanawa, *Koshin shinkō*; Nagai, “Kōshin kyō denrai kō”; Kohn, “Kōshin: A Taoist Cult” (parts I, II, III); Kohn, “Kōshin: Expelling Daoist Demons.” For a short summary, see Fuke, “Ôtsue no tanjō,” 20–21.
57. In what follows I do not intend to imply that the notion of the Three Corpse-Worms originated in Daoist contexts. The idea was already prominent in medical literature.
58. Kubo, *Kōshin shinkō no kenkyū*, 491.
59. *Taiki*, Kyūan 1 (1145), 1/14, 25:158.
60. Yoshioka, “Shōmen Kongō to kōshin shinkō”; Nagai, “Kōshin kyō denrai kō.”

61. *Onjōji denki*, DNBZ 127:33.
62. *Onjōji denki*, DNBZ 127:30–31.
63. On Jōjin's connection to this scripture, see Nagai, "Kōshin kyō denrai kō"; on his travels to Song China, and his travelogue, *San Tendai Godaisan ki*, see Borgen, "Jōjin's Travels"; Mori, *Jōjin*.
64. *Essential Notes*, 12.
65. Yoshioka, "Shōmen Kongō to kōshin shinkō," 231.
66. Kohn, "Kōshin: Expelling Daoist Demons," 155.
67. See Tokumitsu, *Kawaguchi-shi no Shōmen Kongō*.
68. The *Kōshin Scripture* cites multiple works, leading to considerable variation in details, including the names and behaviors of the Three Corpse-Worms. To keep the discussion focused on the role they play in the Jimon ritual construction of corpse-vector disease, I have omitted discussion of these details.
69. On the sexagenary cycle, see Smith, "The Chinese Sexagenary Cycle."
70. *Essential Notes*, 11.
71. *Essential Notes*, 11.
72. Far from mere party games, these were diversions in a very literal sense, used to keep oneself from falling into a dangerous sleep. Moreover, as Koyama Satoko (*Mononoke no Nihonshi*, 104–131) notes, *sugoroku* was a ritual game, the board for which was seen to possess therapeutic, divinatory, and apotropaic powers. Composing poetry likewise had ritual dimensions overlapping with another common feature of the vigil, intoning a spell to banish the Three Corpse-Worms.
73. This is the passage in *Essential Notes*, 11. *Kuchizusami* uses different characters; see *Kuchizusami*, 46. In other texts, such as the medieval encyclopedia *Jinten ainōshō* 塵添塹囊鈔 (1532), Hō Kō-shi is the name given to the upper corpse; see *Jinten ainōshō*, DNBZ 150:239–240.
74. Li, "They Shall Expel Demons."
75. *Zhubing yuanhou lun*, 123.
76. *Zhubing yuanhou lun*, 122.
77. *Zhubing yuanhou lun*, 122.
78. *Essential Notes*, 11.
79. *Essential Notes*, 10; *Ōjō yōshū*, 29. For a translation of the original passage, in which Genshin quotes the *Ratnakūṭa Sutra* (*Hōshakukyō* 宝積經), see Rhodes, *Genshin's Ōjō yōshū*, 209–210.
80. *Essential Notes*, 11.
81. *Essential Notes*, 10.
82. The *kushōjin* or "companion spirits" are part of a broader network of deities that includes Kōjin, Ugajin, Myōken, and others. For an extensive discussion, see Faure, *Protectors and Predators*.
83. *Essential Notes*, 10–11.
84. *Essential Notes*, 10–11.
85. *Enchō* corresponds to what in Chinese medical literature is known as *yedie* 殛殛. The *Dictionary of the Ben Cao Gang Mu* (1:263) translates this as "progressing

calamity” and takes it as a pathological condition identical to corpse-vector disease. Indeed, in the example in the dictionary from the *Waitai miyao fang*, we read: “The ailment of corpse [evil] transmission . . . in its initial stages, when one lies as much as he is up, this is called progressing calamity.” An explanation is given in the *Denshibyō kanjin shō* of the Anō lineage (76–77).

86. In Chinese medical literature, this is *fulian* 伏連. The *Dictionary of the Ben cao gang mu* (1:175) translates this as “hidden link.” As with *dedie*, the editors take this to be identical to corpse-vector disease and give a passage from *Waitai miyao fang*: “The ailment of corpse [evil] transmission, when it is transmitted internally to the five depots, it is called hidden link.”
87. *Shōshiki daikongō yasha byaku kima hō*. This passage is highly corrupted in the Taishō edition: T 21, 1221:101b27–101c13.
88. *Essential Notes*, 8.

## Chapter 7: Playing with Fire

First epigraph: Sloterdijk, *You Must Change Your Life*, 377. Second epigraph: Morris, *The Pillow Book*, 1:131; modified by author.

1. On the basic features of moxibustion and its different forms, see Kuriyama, “Moxibustion.”
2. Chamberlain, *Things Japanese*, 363.
3. Harper sees the use of the term “moxibustion” as anachronistic for these early manuscripts; see Harper, *Early Chinese Medical Literature*, 5, 95.
4. *Idanshō*, 143.
5. On moxibustion’s prominence in the Tang and decline in the Song, see Yu, “The Progression of Moxibustion Therapy.”
6. *Waitai miyao fang*, TIZS 5:768.
7. Kosoto, *Chūgoku igaku koten to Nihon*, 491–500.
8. *Ishinpō* (1a), 28–46.
9. Mathias Vigouroux argues that the dissemination of channel theory and its therapeutic application would have to wait until the sixteenth century, when Manase Dōsan 曲直瀬道三 (1507–1594) adopted Hua Shou’s 滑壽 *Development on the Fourteen Channels* (*Shisijing fahui* 十四經發揮, 1341); see “The Reception of the Circulation Channels Theory.” To some degree this parallels the state of acumoxa literature in Tang China. As Asaf Goldschmidt has noted of Tang period texts included in the early Song dynasty compilation *Taiping shenghui fang*—the *Zhen jing* 針經 and the moxibustion-leaning *Mingtang* 明堂—“the authors almost completely ignore the circulation tracts as a basis for diagnosis and treatment” (Goldschmidt, “Changing Standards,” 85). Goldschmidt goes on to note that channel theory became more important in Song compilations, paralleling the increasing prevalence of acupuncture highlighted in studies such as Yu, “The Progression of Moxibustion Therapy.”

10. On the *Huangdi hama jing*, see Lo, “Huangdi Hama Jing (Yellow Emperor’s Toad Canon)”; Urayama, *Chūgoku isho*, 293–322. Relevant manuscripts from the Dunhuang cache include the *Xinji beiji jiujiang* 新集備急灸經 (Pelliot 2675) and *Jiujiang mingtang* 灸經明堂 (Stein 5737), as well as several untitled illustrated texts (e.g., Stein 6168, 6262); see Lo and Yoeli-Tlalim, “Travelling Light.” For an insightful analysis of such sources as popular manuals, see Lo and Cullen, *Medieval Chinese Medicine*. An overview of excavated sources that includes comparisons with medical texts surviving in Japan is given in Kosoto, *Chūgoku igaku koten to Nihon*, 589–670.
11. The classic study on *hijiri* is Gorai, *Kōya hijiri*. See also Kleine, “Hermits and Ascetics in Ancient Japan” and Kikuchi, *Kamakura bukkyō*, 47–95.
12. Salguero, *Translating Buddhist Medicine*, 61.
13. *Ishinpō* (1a), 56.
14. *Zhouhou beiji fang*; see fasc. 3:114–115; see also the discussion in Smith, *Forgotten Disease*, 39–41.
15. Lo, “Travelling Light.” I thank Vivienne Lo for kindly sharing a draft version of this paper.
16. *Ishinpō* (1a), 314–317. On these illustrations, see Wilms, “Nurturing the Foetus” and Triplett, “For Mothers and Sisters.” On women’s health and obstetrics in the *Ishinpō*, see Andreeva, “Childbirth in Aristocratic Households,” and Triplett, *Buddhism and Medicine*, 121–127.
17. Tracings of these illustrations can be seen in *Denshibyō kyūji* (T 2508).
18. Leung, *Leprosy in China*, 19.
19. *Essential Notes*, 8.
20. *Essential Notes*, 9.
21. Collcutt, *Five Mountains*, 41–48; Abe, “The Cultural History of *Kanjō*,” 209–210.
22. Goble, *Confluences of Medicine*, 10–12.
23. *Fumon’in kyō ron shō so goroku jusho ra mokuroku*, 491.
24. *Essential Notes*, 13.
25. T 46, 1911:8a27–8a28.
26. T 46, 1911:106a19–111c21.
27. *Essential Notes*, 9–10.
28. Rhodes, *Genshin’s Ōjōyōshū*, 198; *Ōjō yōshū*, 18.
29. Sharf, “Thinking Through Shingon Ritual,” 70–71.
30. T 21, 1201:15b17–15b29.
31. Payne, “Introduction,” 31.
32. T 18, 901:795a08–795a09.
33. T 18, 901:812a29–812b04. This passage is cited in fascicle 16 of the *Gyōrinshō* in a section on the efficacious virtues (*kunō* 功能) of the “Sutra for Benevolent Kings Rite” (Nin’ō gyō hō 仁王經法), attesting to the use of *Dhāraṇī Collection Sutra* to elucidate such powers (T 76, 2409:137e25–138a04).
34. T 18, 901:823a24–823a26.
35. T 18, 901:848a17–848a19.

36. Liu, "Poisonous Medicine in Ancient China," 114–116.
37. T 19, 984:459a01–459a02.
38. T 20, 1097:427a23–427a24.
39. Orzech, "Ritual Subjects," 268–269.
40. NST 7:601–603.
41. *Konjaku monogatari shū*, SNKBT 35:554–557; for an English translation, see Dykstra, *Buddhist Tales*, 354–356.
42. *Uji shūi monogatari*, SNKBT 42:342–344.
43. Tale 20:2 in SNKBT 36:221–226; for an English translation, see Dykstra, *Buddhist Tales*, 499–502. The story is analyzed in Wakabayashi, *The Seven Tengu Scrolls*, 22.
44. This notion appears in other stories as well, such as in the hagiography of the Shin-gon monk Kakuban 覺鑊 (1095–1143), who similarly used the Fire Generating Samādhi to fill a room with fire (and the Water Contemplation to flood a room with water); see the *Daidenpō'in Hongan Shōnin goden* 大伝法院本願聖人御伝 (ZGR no. 215, 8A: 763–764). This image surely inspired the phrase, used in diaries such as the *Diary of Sanuki no Suke*, that monks who pray vigorously will have "smoke pour from their ears"; see Brewster, *Sanuki no suke nikki*, 66, 121.
45. A similar pyrotechnical fascination, likewise derived from esoteric Buddhism, shaped the imagination of Daoist *fashi* rituals in Song China. Edward Davis (*Society and the Supernatural*, 49) notes that one *fashi* is able to "generate [the tantric deity] Nezha's characteristic weapon, the fireball, and then recall it into his own body."
46. Groner, *Ryōgen and Mount Hiei*, 221.
47. Groner, *Ryōgen and Mount Hiei*, 233.
48. Adolphson, *The Teeth and Claws*, 38.
49. McCullough, *The Tale of the Heike*, 56. The monkeys in the dream are the messengers of the Sannō deity, the tutelary god of Mt. Hiei and protector of the Sanmon branch.
50. Historical sources differ on the date and severity of this attack. For a comparison, see Tachi, *Onjōji Kōin no kenkyū*, 231–239. See also Adolphson, "Myōun and the Heike," 209–210.
51. Translation from McCullough, *The Tale of the Heike*, 164, with minor alterations.
52. Other tales focus explicitly on these events. For instance, a series of three such tales appear together in *Kojidan* (483–487). One tale that undoubtedly addressed the Yokei–Ryōgen feud more directly but is no longer extant is tale 20 in *Tales of Times Now Past*, vol. 8, "How High Abbot Ryōgen Became a Spirit, Went to Kannon'in, and Subjugated High Abbot Yokei."
53. *Shōshiki daikongō yasha byaku kima hō*, T 21, 1221:100a12–100a13.
54. *Asabashō*, DNBZ 59:77b.
55. The practice of encoding meaning onto the fingers and hands is more complicated than the example discussed here. For a diagram of one mapping, see Saunders, *Mudrā*, 32–34.



56. Faure, *The Fluid Pantheon*, 150.
57. Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 202.
58. *Shōshiki daikongō yasha byaku kima hō*, T 21, 1221:100c29–101a05.
59. Stone, *Original Enlightenment*.
60. *Shōshiki daikongō yasha byaku kima hō*, T 21, 1221:101b21–101b23.
61. Lomi, “Dharanis, Talismans, and Straw Dolls,” 270–274.
62. T 19, 997:569b18–569b23; translation in Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 237. This text was likely part of the Onjōji library, given the inclusion of Prajñā’s 般若 (734–?) ten-volume translation in Enchin’s catalog (*Chishō Daishi shōrai mokuroku*, T 55, 2173:1104a8).
63. T 21, 1214:4a27–4b02. This is cited in the *Gyōrinshō*, T 76, 2409:379b17–379b21.
64. McCullough, *The Tale of the Heike*, 59.
65. Despeux, “Buddhist Healing Practices,” 131.
66. *Shasekishū*, NKBT 85:323–326.
67. *Zoku honchō ōjoden*, NST 7:571–572.
68. *Shōshiki daikongō yasha byaku kima hō*, T 21, 1221:100a29.
69. *Essential Notes*, 13.
70. Mauss, *A General Theory of Magic*, 80.
71. Kasuya and Yamamoto, *Yamai no sōshi*, 83; Hinrichs, “Picturing Medicine,” 233–248.
72. *Kojidan*, 442–445.
73. *Idanshō*, 146.
74. *Idanshō*, 148.
75. Goble, *Confluences of Medicine*, 69.
76. *Idanshō*, 146.
77. Wilcox, *Moxibustion*, 29.
78. For example, on a regular basis during the last few months of 1230, the *hijiri* Shinjaku-bō 心寂房 visited his patron and patient Fujiwara no Teika to examine his moxa sores for signs of worsening and improvement; *Meigetsuki*, 1230 (Kangi 2), 9/14, 9/16, 9/19, 9/26, 10/1, 10/5, 10/12, 10/19, 10/26, 11/8, 11/14, 12/1, 12/10, 12/27, 3:240–267.
79. *Idanshō*, 146.
80. Teeuwen and van der Veere, *Nakatomi Harae Kunge*, 36.
81. For just a handful of examples, see *Minkeiki*, Kangi 3 (1231), 1/10, 2:173, 3/5, 2:271; 3/20, 2:153.
82. For example, *Gyokuyō*, Kenkyū 3 (1192), 6/6, 13:247.
83. *Inokuma kanpakuki*, Kennin 2 (1202), 4/20, 3/146; Shinmura, *Nihon iryō shakai-shi no kenkyū*, 379.
84. *Tsurezuregusa*, 201; translation with slight modifications from McKinney, *Essays in Idleness and Hōjōki*, 95.
85. *Inokuma kanpakuki*, Kennin 2 (1202), 5/13, 3:151 and 7/8, 3:170; Shinmura, *Nihon iryō shakaishi no kenkyū*, 379.
86. *Kurodani Shōnin gotō roku*, T 83, 2611:232c15–232c19.

87. On mulberry in Yōsai's work, see Macomber, "Milking the Bodhi Tree."
88. *Idanshō*, 148–149.
89. Benn, "Where Text Meets Flesh," 296.
90. Benn, "Where Text Meets Flesh," 303–304.
91. Liu, *Healing with Poisons*, 7–8.
92. *Idanshō*, 156–157.
93. Liu, *Healing with Poisons*, 61–80.
94. Yamada, *The Origins of Moxibustion*, 67.
95. Scarry, *The Body in Pain*, 56.

## Epilogue

1. Iida, *Kōshin shinkō*, 40.
2. Haneda, *Shōmen kongō hō*, *Tenmangū gohonji ku*, 4–49, 60–76.
3. Iida, *Kōshin shinkō*, 45.
4. Kubo, *Kōshin shinkō*, 92.
5. In this and subsequent paragraphs, when referencing Shitennōji, I rely on the entry for “四天王寺” in the *Nihon rekishi chimei taikei*.
6. Murayama, *Nihon onmyōdō shiwa*, 308–309.
7. *Shōshiki daikongō yasha byaku kima hō*; Chisan Denbōin, *Shinpukuji Bunko satsuei mokuroku*, 2:533; see Kissuizō Shōgyō Chōsadan, *Shōren'in Monzeki Kissuizō shōgyō mokuroku*, 431.
8. For a discussion on the designation of karmic illness in two editions, see Goble, *Confluences of Medicine*, 81–82.
9. *Keiranshūyōshū*, T 76, 2410:765c04–767c10.
10. Chisan Denbōin, *Shinpukuji Bunko satsuei mokuroku*, 1:191–192.
11. *Giba gozōkyō*, 102–105.
12. Ueno, *Yume to mononoke*, 285–307.
13. For one variation of such works in the context of equine medicine, see Triplett, *Buddhism and Medicine*, 163–188. For another, focusing on the worms and drug therapy, see Andreeva, “Wondrous Worms and Exotic Drugs.”
14. *Idanshō*, 190–192.

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